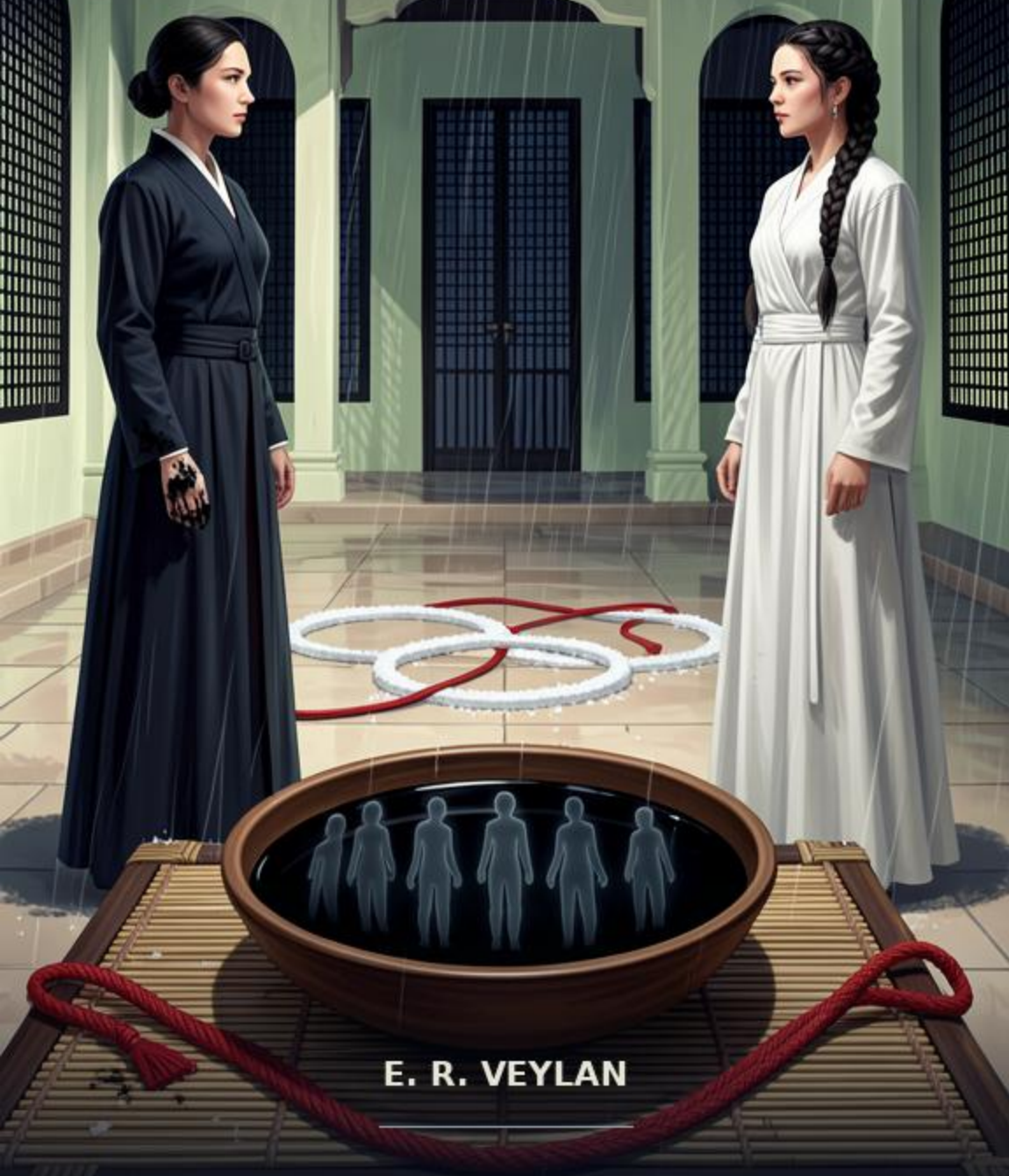


AN ADULT FANTASY NOVEL

A MARRIAGE OF SEVEN GHOSTS

No dead voice owns the living.



A Marriage of Seven Ghosts

An original adult fantasy novel

E. R. Veylan

Part I

Chapter 01 — Ink for a Peace

Salenne found a wet footprint beneath the witness stools before anyone had brought water into the Vow Chamber.

It darkened the pale lime floor in the shape of a bare heel and four toes. A fifth toe might have lain under the rear leg of the seventh stool, but Lady Maelin Valev had already taken her place at the reed-table, and asking the Lord Remembrancer to move furniture would announce that Salenne had noticed something worth hiding.

She set down her document case instead. “No servants during the reading?”

“Fewer ears, Advocate Vaud.” Maelin’s voice held the calm of a woman who had spent thirty years making privacy sound like courtesy. “The final marriage draft concerns two crowns. We can pour our own tea.”

The tea waited on a side table beside a dry basin. No cup had spilled. Above them, the ceiling’s blue tiles showed neither crack nor stain. The chamber had no exterior windows, only a narrow service grille cut high in the west wall and plugged from the other side with lime.

Salenne removed her indigo court coat and folded it over the first witness stool. Her left thumb had stained the cuff during the morning’s ink grinding. Most clients regarded that mark as reassurance. Maelin glanced at it as if Salenne had arrived wearing someone else’s confession.

Two days remained before Prince Edran Marr would enter the palace in public. On the announced wedding date, if the treaty calendar held, Crown Heir Ardis Valev would stand in the hall above this room’s foundations and splice her fifty-three lawful dead to the prince’s Household. Osteren had not yet furnished its final roll. Rumor counted more than two hundred names.

A difference of that scale should have stopped the Bride Accord at the first review. Instead, three ministers had initialed it, the Rain Council had praised it, and the Black Reed villages had begun counting grain wagons that would move only after the marriage.

Maelin touched the rolled vellum between them. Her right hand lacked its little finger. The old war injury made her gestures look more deliberate, never less complete. “You asked for an unsupervised test of the operative copy.”

“I asked that no interested ancestor be lent a mouth while I read.”

“An ancestor is always interested.”

“Then I am grateful the dead have you to translate their restraint.”

A brief brightness entered Maelin’s eyes. Not amusement exactly. Recognition,

perhaps, of a blade small enough to use indoors.

Salenne opened her document case. A salt spoon lay in one groove, charred black reed in another, and a stoppered bottle held clean river water drawn above the mortuary drains. She placed a shallow shell dish on the table. Preparing burial black for a royal vow required a name-token shaving from an eligible witness, but a testing mixture used the advocate's licensing token instead. It could reveal whether a clause sought a body. It could not bind the reader beyond twelve breaths.

That limit mattered. Salenne took her bone license from the cord around her neck and scraped one translucent curl into the dish. Her own name, pressed on the token in funeral script against the day someone would need it, lost a hairline from the final letter.

Maelin watched without asking why Salenne counted the shaving twice.

Charred reed came next. Salt followed. Salenne ground the three with the spoon's blunt end until black paste clung to the shell. When she added water, the mixture opened like oil and smelled of extinguished cooking fires.

"Your mother made cleaner ink," Maelin said.

The spoon stopped in Salenne's fingers.

Orsa Vaud had been absent from every lawful roll for ten years. People who wished to be kind called her missing. Funeral clerks used unentered. Salenne preferred neither word. Both allowed someone else's hand to disappear inside the grammar.

"You remember her work?" Salenne asked.

"I remember every skilled person House Rain failed to keep."

A polished answer. It made grief sound administrative and blame sound universal.

Salenne resumed grinding. "Then you remember that she disliked comparisons offered after a person could answer them."

"I remember that too."

No apology followed. Maelin did not spend words she could not enforce.

Once the burial black moved without grit, Salenne drew a test line across scrap reed vellum. The surface tightened under the stroke. Cold touched the roots of her lower teeth, a minor response from the licensing token. No borrowed impulse followed it. She counted twelve breaths, rinsed the spoon, and felt the cold recede.

"Fit," she said.

Maelin broke the draft's white thread and unrolled it. The vellum wanted to curl toward its reed memory. Ivory rods held the corners flat. Neat funeral script filled thirty-two columns, with corrections stitched into the margins by red silk. Every stitch meant someone had changed a word after witnesses approved the page

beneath it.

Salenne began with the obligations that kept people alive. Osteren would release three grain convoys at marriage. Lyr would lower bridge tolls for Black Reed merchants. Both crowns would withdraw living soldiers to agreed tide marks and fund canal clearing in all seven disputed villages.

Those clauses named offices, acts, durations, and consequences. They could bind.

To prove it, Salenne touched the test brush to the grain provision. The black bracket darkened at once. A pull caught the tendons of her thumb and turned her hand toward the east, where the bridge granaries stood beyond three courts and a line of city roofs.

"Office named," she said. "The Osteren grain factor must release the first convoy. Act named. Three thousand measures cross the Bridge of Reeds. Duration named. Before the second dry-month bell."

"Consequence?"

"Lyr's toll office loses collection authority for one season if passage is obstructed. Sensible. Public. Repairable." Salenne lifted the brush. Her thumb resisted for half a breath, then relaxed. "The clause reaches the officer through the seal accepted with the post. It does not enter the officer's spouse or children. It does not command a hand except when that hand exercises the office."

Maelin leaned over the margin. A drop from her sleeve landed beside the bracket, though the rain had not yet begun. It must have come from the tea. "You make lawful enforcement sound almost modest."

"Modesty keeps a clause from acquiring appetites."

The second test concerned the canal crews. This time cold climbed Salenne's forearm while a phantom spade handle pressed across her palm. She counted the living offices: two crown engineers, seven village reeves, one neutral paymaster. When she spoke the termination date, the pressure faded.

A badly drafted vow did not merely punish breach. It searched for the nearest body that could satisfy its grammar. Salenne had seen a toll oath close a dead collector's hand around his daughter's throat because the clause named his blood after his office had lapsed. The daughter survived. Her memory of her own wedding day did not.

"Every public term should behave like these," Salenne said. "Narrow reach. Visible consequence. A door that opens when the duty ends."

"And if a realm refuses duty?" Maelin asked.

"Then living officials answer in a living court. Burial black can secure procedure. It cannot make virtue."

"An austere limit during an eight-year war."

"A necessary one after it."

Salenne dried both brackets with clean salt. The tests had cost her no memory because neither clause asked for a dead witness or a private body; even so, her wrist throbbed from the brief compulsion. On a wedding day the full draft would enter two heirs before hundreds of observers. A beautiful phrase could conceal a year of bodily occupation.

The marriage clauses preferred perfume.

“The spouses shall receive shared Household guidance,” Salenne read aloud. “Receive by hearing, by voluntary lending, or by compelled bodily use?”

“Guidance has carried the customary meaning for five dynastic unions.”

“Four ended before the lunar year.”

“Through illness.”

“Three illnesses involved torn autobiographical memory. The fourth spouse bit through his tongue while nine ancestral jurists argued with it.”

Maelin poured tea. She left Salenne’s cup untouched on its tray, allowing acceptance to become a choice. “You have been retained to secure the peace, not compose a treatise against marriage.”

“My retention letter instructs me to identify bodily enforcement.”

“Identify it, then.”

Salenne dipped a narrow brush into the testing ink and drew a bracket beside shared Household guidance. “The draft must state whether either spouse can refuse a dead voice. It must establish a stopping mechanism. It must bar one Household from coordinating bodily control against the other spouse.”

“Overcrowning is a disputed theory.”

“Among families that possess equal rolls.”

A muscle moved once near Maelin’s jaw. “Ardis carries the lawful strength of House Valev.”

“Fifty-three named dead do not become two hundred because we capitalize their House.”

The tile overhead clicked.

Both women looked up.

A drop struck the center of the vellum. Cold water burst over the word shared, diluting no ink because the binding script had already cured. A second drop landed on Salenne’s wrist. Another touched Maelin’s tea.

Within three breaths, rain fell through clear air.

It came straight down beneath the blue-tiled ceiling, thin and hard and cold enough to sting. Water struck the seven stools, the table, the sealed lime floor. None touched the side chamber beyond the threshold. The dry basin remained dry until a drop formed over it and fell from empty space.

"Hollow Rain," Salenne said.

Maelin rose. Her chair legs scraped lime. "There has been no binding."

"An active proposal suffices if erased dead stand close enough."

"The foundations were cleansed after Dorel's coronation."

"Cleansing moves remains when the workers know where to find them."

Rain spattered Salenne's scalp and ran cold beneath her collar. The testing ink in its shell dish trembled. Not from falling water. Its surface puckered upward, one small peak seeking the plugged service grille.

Maelin reached for the draft.

Salenne laid her stained thumb on the lower rod. "If you roll wet vellum, you may transfer a live clause."

"Then neutralize it."

"I need to learn what has pressed near."

"We need a dry copy and a room not contaminated by mortuary residue." Maelin's careful diction had shortened. "Release the page."

The cold in Salenne's teeth sharpened until her molars ached. Something moved behind the west wall, not with sound but with the remembered strain of crouching too long. Her right knee bent without permission. A smell entered her nose: horse sweat, lamp grease, wet rope.

Not her memory.

She lifted her thumb from the rod and pressed it into the dish.

Burial black coated the whorls of her skin. The presence beyond the wall recoiled. Then it surged so hard that Salenne's knuckles struck the table.

"Someone is caught in the lime," she said.

Maelin went still. Rain ticked against her severe coil and tracked down one temple. "Do not host from unmarked residue."

The warning carried professional sense. An unclaimed dead person needed a name-token shaving for safe hosting. Without one, the ghost might strip an unrelated memory, enter without a stable name, or spend its twelve breaths screaming through the advocate's throat.

Salenne knew all three case histories. She also knew that Maelin had tried to remove the vellum before asking whose bones lay in her palace.

"I'm not drinking it." Salenne turned the scrap test strip toward the service grille. "I'm offering a writing surface."

"Advocate."

"Lord Remembrancer."

The title answered the title and nothing else.

Salenne set her wet thumb against the top of the strip. Pressure climbed her wrist. A ghost could not move the brush, but it could lend sensation if the living hand allowed it. She opened two fingers' worth of control, no more. The presence seized them.

Her thumb dragged downward.

A black stroke tore through the vellum. Pain flashed under her nail. The second stroke crossed the first. Crude stable notation, not funeral script: a knot count used for feed sacks.

Maelin stepped around the table. "Close your hand."

Salenne's fingers no longer heard her.

The room vanished behind a memory that did not belong to her. A boy pressed his face to a service grille. He had straw in one sleeve and blood on both knees. Beyond the bars, a young woman in burial white fought someone hidden by a hanging. Red cord cut into the woman's throat. Pearls shone on a knife handle near the floor.

The borrowed image broke before Salenne could see the killer.

Her hand convulsed. Letters replaced knot marks, each one formed through a stableboy's memory of kitchen labels rather than schooling.

NERA

The brushless line staggered. Salenne tasted iron where she had bitten the inside of her cheek.

Maelin seized her wrist with four fingers and a thumb. "Enough."

The contact brought another flash: lamp smoke, a woman's heel hammering stone, red fibers stretched between hands.

Salenne twisted free. "You know which Nera he means."

"Half the palace knew Nera." Maelin's grip had left pale marks above the ink. "Grief makes patterns from residue. Your profession should have taught you that."

"My profession taught me residue cannot spell."

"It can repeat names."

"Then let it repeat more."

The Hollow Rain ceased.

Not gradually. One moment water struck tile and skin; the next, silence occupied the chamber. Droplets still rolled off the rods. Puddles reflected the seven stools. Above the scrap strip, Salenne's hand hung open and rigid.

Something drew one final breath through her lungs.

She gave it the last movement left in the twelve-breath test.

The message cut across the wet scrap in block letters deep enough to score the fibers.

NERA DID NOT DROWN

Control released. Salenne's fingers slammed flat. Sensation returned as a field of needles from thumb to elbow.

Maelin looked at the words. Her face showed no theatrical guilt, no convenient terror. She looked tired, and that frightened Salenne more. Weariness implied an old burden, one carried often enough to polish its edges.

"Nera Valev drowned twelve years ago," Maelin said. "Her body came from the east cistern. Her sister identified her coat. The funeral court accepted the record."

"Her name entered the Household?"

A pause followed, small enough for another person to miss.

"The royal rolls are not under review today."

Salenne blotted her hand on linen. "Every named dead proposed as a wedding witness falls under my review."

"You will review the list when the household clerks deliver it."

"I requested it four days ago."

"So did I."

That answer could be true. Maelin's skill lay partly in arranging truths so they served lies without becoming them.

At the service grille, wet lime flaked from the plug and fell in a crescent. A breath of air reached the chamber carrying old straw rot. The erased boy had retreated. Salenne could no longer feel his cramped knee, though her own still hurt from his borrowed posture.

Maelin rolled the wet draft around one ivory rod with precise care. "We will move tomorrow's reading to the east accounting room. The chamber will be opened by mortuary workers. You will surrender that scrap as contaminated palace material."

The command entered the room dressed as procedure.

Salenne folded the strip once before Maelin could reach it. Wet black pressed against wet black, hiding the words. "My license obliges me to retain any unsolicited witness statement until I can establish name and competence."

"Your license answers to the Crown."

"It answers to funeral law. The Crown answers there too, on its better days."

Maelin's gaze moved from the folded scrap to Salenne's face. "Peace will feed people who do not have the leisure to admire your independence."

There lay the argument no clever clause could dismiss. Seven villages waited beside silted canals. Grain factors priced delay in bodies. Soldiers on both sides slept within horn call of one another. If Salenne stopped the agreement on the word of an unnamed dead boy, hunger would not distinguish moral caution from sabotage.

Yet a peace draft willing to hide bodily control could also hide a murder.

"I will continue the review," Salenne said.

"Good." Maelin gathered the rods. "At the east room. Tomorrow."

Salenne put on her coat while the water on the floor crept around her shoes. No drain served the Vow Chamber. Someone would have to sponge the Hollow Rain into buckets, carry it through servant corridors, and answer no questions about why a roofed room had filled with weather.

At the threshold, Maelin spoke without turning. "An accusation can restart a war before evidence arrives to catch it."

"So can a concealed clause."

Maelin left.

Salenne waited until the footfalls passed beyond the outer screen. Then she reopened her case, slid the witness strip beneath the false lining used for disputed wills, and placed an ordinary ink blotter where the folded thickness might show.

Seeking the Crown Heir directly would violate three palace customs and one instruction in Salenne's retention letter. The instruction required her to report anomalous testimony to the Lord Remembrancer. She had reported an anomaly. It did not require her to surrender the only copy before speaking to the person whose sister had supposedly drowned.

A legal distinction, narrow as a knife's back.

She stepped around the footprint beneath the seventh stool. Its edges had not blurred in the rain.

Outside, two guards waited to escort her toward the advocates' gate. Salenne gave them her driest professional frown and asked which corridor Crown Heir Ardis used after the noon genealogy lesson. One guard looked offended. The other looked toward the royal apartments before he could stop himself.

That glance supplied a route.

Salenne followed the guards away from it, counting doors, saving the turn for later, and carrying an erased boy's accusation against her skin.

Chapter 02 — The Bride's Missing Dead

Ardis lost her own voice on the fourth name.

"Pel Vaudren, who held the east sluices," she began, and the sentence dropped half an octave before another woman's cadence carried it onward. "Who denied the Silt Year breach and preserved the lower wards."

Her tongue shaped preserved as pre-sarved, an old Rain Court pronunciation dead for sixty years. The seamstress kneeling at her hem did not look up. People who dressed a crown heir learned to treat ancestral intrusions like exposed skin: necessary to handle, dangerous to acknowledge.

Ardis closed her teeth. The borrowed cadence retreated, leaving a sour pressure along her gums.

"Again," Lady Maelin said from beside the dressing mirror.

"No."

The seamstress's needle paused.

Ardis met her aunt's reflected gaze. White linen threaded Ardis's close braids instead of the funeral names expected for a wedding rehearsal. Maelin had objected to that choice three times. The plain thread remained.

"You will answer the Osteren genealogy at the prince's reception," Maelin said. "Their court will hear hesitation as disrespect."

"They will hear fifty-three people speaking through one mouth if we continue this way." Ardis rubbed the hinge of her jaw. "That may reassure them. I would find it crowded."

A pressure gathered behind her right shoulder blade. Old King Serrat disliked the word crowded when applied to his lawful heirs. He had occupied that shoulder since she was fourteen, correcting her sword posture and her manners with equal irritation. Ardis shifted before he could pull her spine upright.

Household dead could not command without a living body. Every lesson said so. Lessons gave less attention to the thousand daily permissions inherited before a child understood refusal: the borrowed grip during sword practice, the ancestor's phrase accepted at table, the posture yielded during public prayer. Consent given by habit remained useful to the dead long after the living person tried to revoke it.

Maelin stepped behind the seamstress and removed a loose name-thread from the floor. Her four-fingered right hand folded it into her palm. "A stable voice will prevent Osteren's dead from exploiting weakness after the splice."

"The safest prevention would be not to splice us."

"Then seven Black Reed villages face the dry-month shortage without guaranteed grain."

There it stood again: not threat, not exactly. Arithmetic sharpened by hunger.

Ardis raised both arms while the seamstress fitted her ceremonial coat. It crossed diagonally from left collarbone to right hip, leaving her sword arm free. The older pattern enclosed both wrists in ancestor-stitched cuffs. She had ordered those removed.

“Continue with the mothers’ line,” Maelin said.

Ardis looked at the genealogy sheet on the stand. Fifty-three names filled its narrow columns, each copied from the lawful Valev funeral roll. A second document beside it listed seven selected dead who would witness the Bride Accord. Her mother, Queen Dorel, headed both. Below Dorel came kings, sluice ministers, war queens, and one prince whose chief distinction had been dying before he could tax funeral salt.

No elder sister appeared in the visible section.

The omission should not have surprised her. Nera had drowned without completed funerary preparation. That explanation had followed Ardis for twelve years, offered by clerks, councilors, undertakers, and Maelin whenever the empty place in the Household became too conspicuous. A damaged name token could delay lawful entry. A disputed death could hold a ghost outside the bloodline. Some dead never pressed close enough to be named.

Ardis had accepted each reason because the alternative required asking why her sister’s absence suited so many people.

A knock sounded at the outer door. The seamstress flinched this time.

“Who?” Maelin asked.

A guard answered through the wood. “Advocate Vaud requests instruction on a damaged testing mixture.”

Salenne had spent the morning with Maelin in the Vow Chamber. A damaged mixture belonged to the mortuary counters, not the heir’s dressing room. The phrasing had been built to pass a guard without giving him a truth he could repeat.

“Send her to the east accounting room,” Maelin said.

Ardis lowered her arms. “Admit her.”

“The fitting is private.”

“So is legal instruction concerning my marriage.”

Maelin’s expression did not change. Her gaze did: a minute withdrawal, as though she had stepped behind an interior door. “We have not finished the mothers’ line.”

“I know my mother’s ancestors.”

“Knowing differs from answering cleanly under pressure.”

“Then I will rehearse with the advocate who must certify what their pressure is allowed to do.”

The Crown Heir outranked the Lord Remembrancer. A niece did not outrank the

woman who had held a war court together while Queen Dorel grieved herself thin. Both truths occupied the room, and the seamstress kept her head bowed between them.

Maelin placed the folded thread on the mirror shelf. "Twenty minutes. The funeral clerks expect you before the noon cistern bell."

She left through the inner door rather than meet Salenne at the outer one.

Only after the latch closed did Ardis say, "Leave the coat pinned."

"My lady, the right seam may pull if you sit."

"Then I'll stand."

The seamstress withdrew with her basket. Ardis counted to five before admitting Salenne herself.

The advocate entered in her undecorated indigo coat. Damp darkened the hair at her temples. Her left cuff carried fresh burial black, and four pale finger marks circled her opposite wrist.

Ardis noticed the marks before she noticed that Salenne had locked the door behind her.

"What damaged the mixture?"

"Palace architecture." Salenne glanced at the mirror, the inner door, and the genealogy stand. Her attention moved like a proofreading knife, finding margins before text. "May I ask whether your aunt uses that door without warning?"

"She considers warning a courtesy that emergencies cannot always afford."

"Convenient. Is there another exit?"

"The wardrobe connects to my mother's old rooms, but the door has been sealed since her death."

"Then I'll be concise."

Salenne did not immediately produce whatever she had come to show. That restraint distinguished her from half the court. Most petitioners treated proof like a cup they could empty into Ardis's lap and make her responsible for the spill.

Ardis gestured toward the genealogy stand. "You interrupted an ancestral recitation."

"I apologize to any dead person who feels deprived of a living woman's teeth."

Despite herself, Ardis almost smiled. "They recover quickly from disappointment."

"Your aunt says they recover from everything."

A careful sentence. Salenne's posture kept formal distance, but her damp hair and bruised wrist argued with it.

"What happened in the Vow Chamber?" Ardis asked.

"Hollow Rain fell during a test of the marriage clauses."

The pressure behind Ardis's shoulder vanished. Even Serrat knew enough to listen.

"Inside a roofed room?"

"Yes."

"Near active burial black?"

"Yes."

"Then an erased dead person pressed close to a binding proposal." Ardis had learned the rule as a child, before Maelin dismissed most palace incidents as old mortar sweating. "Did you identify them?"

"Not lawfully."

Salenne's stained thumb touched the side of her document case but did not open it.

Ardis studied her. "You came to ask me a question before you trust me with the answer."

"I came to learn whether the person named by the dead appears among your lawful witnesses."

There were many ways to demand obedience. Salenne had chosen none. She had also chosen not to reveal the name. Professional caution, perhaps. Fear, certainly. The four-finger marks suggested who had supplied it.

Ardis turned to the genealogy stand. "The complete roll is in the funeral archive."

"This copy carries fifty-three names."

"You counted."

"I count clauses, doors, witnesses, and people who tell me not to count."

"An exhausting profession."

"It prevents surprise."

Ardis looked down the first column. Dorel Valev. Serrat Valev. Mara of the South Sluice. Names continued through cousins, rulers, and acknowledged children, each followed by a qualification for legal persistence. The wedding roll beside it selected seven from those fifty-three names to empower the marriage.

"Tell me whom I should seek," she said.

Salenne opened her case. From beneath a stack of dry blotting paper, she drew a folded strip of wet-stiffened vellum. "I will retain custody."

"Under what authority?"

"Unsolicited witness testimony under a host's license."

"You did not host anyone."

"Under a prudent interpretation of the license."

That time Ardis did smile, briefly. "My aunt dislikes prudent interpretations she did not compose."

"Your aunt and I found common ground there."

When Salenne unfolded the strip, black scoring showed through fibers warped by water. The first line held only a name. NERA. The second had been written with greater violence.

NERA DID NOT DROWN.

The room changed without magic. Ardis still heard a servant rolling a clothing rail in the outer passage. Pins still tugged the unfinished seam against her ribs. Her mother's white thread still lay in her braids. Yet the dressing mirror returned a woman who had spent twelve years arranging her face around a fact that might never have been one.

A murmur moved through her Household.

Not words. Recognition among the dead could feel like rats changing direction inside a wall. Queen Dorel pressed against the back of Ardis's throat with a grief so sudden that her knees weakened. Dorel had never spoken Nera's name through her. Not once.

Ardis gripped the genealogy stand.

"Whose hand?" she asked.

"An erased boy near a sealed service grille. Stable memories. Rope. Blood. A woman in burial white." Salenne kept her voice quiet. "The contact showed red cord and a pearl-handled knife, but not the person holding either. The statement is evidence of a claim, not proof."

"My aunt saw this."

"She saw the words."

"What did she do?"

"Tried to secure the treaty draft, ordered the chamber cleansed, and requested custody of the strip."

Reasonable acts for a Lord Remembrancer. Ardis could construct Maelin's defense before anyone offered it: contaminated residue, political timing, an unidentified ghost, the danger of letting a dead servant restart a war. Maelin had taught her to think in those layers.

"Nera Valev," Ardis said, testing the name aloud.

Dorel surged. The dead queen's grief bent Ardis's spine before she could stop it. A remembered lullaby threatened to enter her mouth, but the tune broke at its first interval. Dorel withdrew so abruptly that Ardis tasted blood where her teeth caught her tongue.

Salenne took one step forward, then stopped outside touching distance. "Was that your mother?"

"Yes." Ardis straightened slowly. "She reacted to Nera's name."

"Recognition does not prove the claim."

"No. It proves she has been avoiding it."

A living daughter could demand that her dead mother speak. The Household recognized rank inside blood as readily as a court did outside it. Ardis could lend Dorel her voice and force whatever grief remained through her own throat. She imagined Maelin calling it testimony. She imagined Nera, wherever erased dead waited, watching one sister compel their mother for the sake of another.

Ardis released the stand. "I won't command her."

"Good." Salenne's answer arrived without court polish.

The blunt approval warmed something in Ardis that had no place in the room. She put it aside.

"We need the archive copy," she said.

"The lawful roll and the selected witness list may not share the same omissions."

"They should. Every selected witness must come from the lawful Household."

"Should is a dangerous word near a royal archive."

Ardis took the genealogy sheet and the wedding roll from the stand. "The funeral clerks expect me now."

Salenne refolded the accusation. "Your aunt expects me in an accounting room."

"She can be disappointed for twenty minutes."

They left separately. Ardis used the inner corridor reserved for royal dressers, while Salenne went by the petition passage with instructions to arrive at the archive three minutes later. The secrecy felt childish until Ardis saw Maelin's clerk waiting beyond the main stair with a message tablet in hand. Then it felt insufficient.

The palace funeral archive occupied two long rooms above the west cistern. Shell name tokens filled shallow cabinets sealed with white wax. Lawful rolls lay on sloped desks under linen guards, safe from damp and casual fingers. Each open book had a clerk beside it and a bowl of salt ready to stop any binding that woke unexpectedly.

Ardis entered to seven bowed heads.

"Continue your work," she said. "I need the current Valev Household roll and the wedding selection."

The senior clerk, an elderly man named Pellin whose cuffs carried three generations of archivists, glanced toward the door behind her. "Lord Maelin requested that all wedding materials pass through her rooms."

"Then you may record that they passed through mine first."

He bowed again, less deeply. "At once, Crown Heir."

Retrieval required more than opening a cabinet. Pellin washed his hands in salt water, dried them on unmarked linen, and asked Ardis to name her office before two junior clerks. When she answered, the lawful Household stirred against her palate. The archive recognized blood through the dead, but office determined which drawers blood could open. A royal child might hear the ancestors and still lack authority to inspect how the court had named them.

Pellin pressed Ardis's seal to the cabinet plate. Cold crossed her right palm. Dorel's practiced signature tried to enter her fingers, offering an older form of the access mark. Ardis refused the lending and drew her own plain A in wax. Pain tightened across her knuckles until the cabinet accepted the living mark.

One clerk recorded the refusal. Such moments usually vanished into routine notation: Household assistance declined; access still competent. Today Ardis made the girl read the sentence back. If someone later lifted another line from an index, at least three people would remember that this one had existed.

Salenne arrived while attendants unwrapped the great roll. She carried no visible scrap. To the clerks, she looked like an advocate performing expected due diligence. Only the drying bruise at her wrist disturbed that fiction.

The roll had been recopied after Dorel's death. Fifty-three bone headings divided the columns. Ardis followed them one at a time, using a glass counter bead to prevent her eyes from skipping familiar names.

Dorel appeared first among the recent dead.

Nera did not appear after her.

No damaged line marked a disputed entry. No blank preserved a place. The sequence moved directly from Dorel to a cousin dead in infancy thirty years earlier, then onward to Serrat's generation.

"Check the amendment leaves," Salenne said.

Pellin bristled. "The Crown Household has no unentered amendment."

"That sentence is either excellent news or a reason to check."

Ardis hid another almost-smile by turning a page.

Amendments recorded stillbirth corrections, adoptions, disinheritances, and names delayed by inquest. Twelve years ago, the year Nera died, three amendments entered the archive. One concerned a gate cousin. Another corrected a spelling. The third leaf had been cut close to its binding thread.

Ardis touched the severed fibers. "What did this contain?"

Pellin's face lost color. "The index will show it."

It did not. A pale scrape lay where a line had been lifted from the waxed index board.

Salenne drew the wedding selection beside the great roll. Seven names, all

royal, all capable of enforcing the Bride Accord. Dorel headed the list. Serrat followed. Five war rulers completed it.

“Nera is absent here too,” Ardis said.

Pellin looked between them. “Princess Nera did not enter the Household.”

“Why?”

“Her death token could not be made competent.”

“Because she drowned?”

“That is my understanding.”

“A drowned body can be named.” Salenne kept her tone neutral, giving Pellin room to choose truth. “Water complicates preparation. It does not invalidate identity.”

The old clerk’s throat moved. “The sealed funeral ledger would contain the undertaker’s finding.”

“Where?” Ardis asked.

“In the restricted cabinet. Three keys are required: Remembrancer, Crown, and mortuary license.”

Maelin held one. Ardis held another by office. A licensed undertaker could supply the third if the Crown ordered access.

Outside the archive doors, the noon cistern bell struck. Its vibration moved through the cabinets, setting hundreds of shell tokens whispering against wood. Fifty-three names answered in Ardis’s teeth.

None belonged to her sister.

She dismissed the clerks except Pellin, then ordered him to seal the great roll in her presence. Salenne watched without offering comfort. Ardis valued that more than she could safely say.

“When can you open the funeral ledger?” Ardis asked.

“With an undertaker and your written grant,” Salenne replied. “Your aunt will learn we entered the cabinet.”

“She would learn if I changed breakfast tea.”

“This carries a greater consequence.”

Ardis looked at the cut amendment leaf. For twelve years she had called delay prudence. Maelin had needed peace; Dorel had needed protection from grief; Lyr had needed an heir without scandal clinging to her accession. Each reason had been sufficient for one day. Stacked together, they had made twelve years.

She took Pellin’s record brush and wrote an access grant on fresh reed paper. Salenne Vaud, oath advocate, could examine the sealed funeral ledger of Nera Valev with a licensed undertaker, retain witness copies, and report first to Crown Heir Ardis.

The final phrase displaced Maelin without naming the displacement.

Ardis pressed her office seal into white wax.

“Find out what happened to my sister,” she said, and gave Salenne the key-grant before caution could ask for another day.

Chapter 03 — A Voice in Burial Black

Ysra Pell barred the mortuary workroom with a corpse scale.

The brass beam fit neatly between the door handle and a floor ring used for lifting stone tables. No clerk outside would mistake it for an official lock. Any clerk who forced the door would still have to explain why privacy had mattered less than a restricted royal ledger.

“Elegant,” Salenne said.

“Funeral elegance means the body stays where you put it.” Ysra tested the beam with one broad hip. Her undertaker’s sleeves bore stitched names from wrist to elbow, clients whose funerals had lacked family. “Court elegance means someone else pays for moving it.”

Morning trade filled the Mortuary Exchange beyond the walls. Shell cutters tapped name tokens into shape. Singers tested pitches over bowls of water. At the public counters, families argued about burial salt, inheritance, and whether a disliked uncle’s persistence in the Household constituted evidence of love. The practical clamor made the sealed room feel less secret, not more. Every life in Lyr eventually passed through these counters. A royal ledger differed from a fishmonger’s only in the number of people paid to misplace it.

Salenne set Ardis’s grant on the stone table.

Three white seals held the ledger box closed. The Crown key had arrived as Ardis’s office mark pressed into the grant. Ysra supplied the mortuary key from her licensing ring. Maelin’s key had come at dawn inside a locked messenger tube, accompanied by two clerks and a note stating that the Lord Remembrancer objected to contaminated testimony but respected the Crown Heir’s jurisdiction.

“Persuasive compliance,” Ysra said after reading it. Her gold tooth flashed. “She gives you exactly what law requires, which means she has prepared what law will find.”

“She had one night.”

“She has had twelve years.”

Salenne’s bruised wrist ached as she fitted Maelin’s thin iron key into the third seal. “We do not know what happened twelve years ago.”

“We know someone worked very hard to prevent us knowing.”

Ysra never mistook anger for proof. Salenne trusted her partly because she could hold both without spilling either.

They named their offices aloud. The Crown seal warmed under Ardis’s written authority. Ysra’s key released a faint scent of funeral myrrh. Maelin’s turned last, and cold ran from Salenne’s fingertips to her elbow. Each mechanism opened a different legal permission: royal blood granted access; mortuary license protected

the dead; remembrance office certified that the record had not been displaced from lawful custody.

The box clicked.

Nothing borrowed Salenne's hand. No Household voice entered Ysra's mouth. They waited twelve breaths anyway.

"Still alive?" Ysra asked.

"Professionally undecided."

"Good. Lift your side."

Nera's ledger lay under grey linen. It consisted of six reed leaves sewn with black sinew between thin boards. A bone clasp passed through the front edge. Someone had cut that clasp and sealed the break with white funeral wax.

Salenne bent close without touching it. The bone carried half a funeral name: VALE on the upper piece, the final V lost with the severed tip. Crosscuts marked death year and royal status. A line of tiny notches near the hinge indicated water recovery.

"The cut bone seal predates the wax," Ysra said. "See the dark edge? Bone exposed before the white seal aged."

"Could preparation have required cutting it?"

"Not across the name. If a token fails, we break it lengthwise and record both halves. Crosscutting prevents the dead from recognizing the token as a lawful rest."

Salenne drew a diagram before Ysra opened the clasp. The missing tip might have carried tool marks. It might also have become a shaving in someone's burial block.

Beneath the clasp, the first leaf recorded recovery from the east cistern. Princess Nera Valev, twenty-six. Body identified by Crown Heir Ardis Valev through the deceased's burial-white coat and left wrist scar. Time in water: estimated six hours. Witnesses: Remembrancer's clerk, cistern keeper, two palace guards.

No undertaker had signed the body examination.

Ysra turned the leaf toward the window lamp. "This line used an archive hand."

"The whole entry did."

"Exactly. Funeral findings carry at least two hands. The person who washes speaks; the licensed recorder writes. Royal deaths add a witness hand. Here one clerk performed every role without naming himself."

The river-water test had also been omitted. A body drawn from the east cistern should have carried salt at the lips from its overflow channel. The entry mentioned fresh water in the lungs but gave no measure. Nera's hair had supposedly contained blue cistern algae during a month when maintenance records showed the basin drained for tile repair.

Ysra laid three colored cords beside the entry. Undertakers used blue for water evidence, yellow for uncertain time, and undyed fiber for a body examined after washing. The recorder had sewn a blue knot through Nera's leaf, then clipped its tail so closely that no one could retest how many turns it carried.

"Two turns mean recovered from water," Ysra said. "Three mean water caused death. This has room for either."

"Ambiguity presented as damage."

"And accepted because everyone expected a grieving princess near a cistern to become a drowned princess."

Salenne held the leaf at a low angle. Scrape marks crossed the ruled space reserved for neck injuries. Wax had been rubbed into the fibers, filling whatever the first examiner recorded. Warmth could lift some of it, but heat might wake residue in the token or deform the later ink.

Ysra built a cold tent instead. She inverted a glass dish over the line, packed salt and shaved ice around its rim, then breathed once through a reed tube. Moisture condensed on the waxed fibers. Under the blue lens, compressed strokes emerged where a tool had once pressed hard enough to bruise the vellum.

"Ligature," Salenne read. "Anterior bruising. Red fiber recovered."

The finding ended midway through a letter. Someone had scraped the rest and rewritten the drowning observation above it.

They copied the revealed pressure marks separately. Ysra marked her method, materials, duration, and the risk of misreading. A dead person's record could accuse the living only if living people made their own work answerable. Ghost testimony might begin the case; careful hands had to keep it from becoming another convenient story.

Salenne copied each discrepancy. Grammar exposed the deeper fraud. The writer used passive forms wherever a living person should have acted. The body was recovered. Identification was accepted. Preparation was deemed impossible. No one lifted Nera. No one accepted Ardis's identification. No person had made preparation impossible.

"Coward's syntax," Ysra murmured.

"Institutional syntax."

"Same coat. Better buttons."

The second leaf carried the death ruling: accidental drowning following an evening of solitary grief. Salenne read the phrase twice. Nera's mother had died a year before; the ledger presented grief as both motive and witness, a condition that required no signature.

A narrow strip of different vellum had been sewn into the lower margin.

Ysra slid a horn blade beneath it. "Later addition."

"Before or after sealing?"

"After the sinew dried, before the wax went brittle. Give me the blue lens."

Through tinted glass, erased iron salts rose brown against black reed fibers. The strip had once held six lines. Scraping removed most, but pressure from the recorder's tool had impressed the vellum beneath.

Salenne laid thin paper over it and rubbed charcoal sideways. Letters emerged backward. She turned the copy toward the lamp.

Stable service grille cleared after incident.

Boy assigned: Tev Orr, lower stable, age seventeen.

Statement incoherent due shock.

Transferred to river watch.

The last two lines had been cut away with the bone seal.

"Tev Orr," Ysra said. "Do you know the name?"

"No lawful roll lists him. I checked the palace servant deaths after yesterday."

"Transferred where?"

"No river watch intake bears his name."

Salenne's right knee began to hurt.

The sensation did not belong to the workroom. It came sharp and bruised from kneeling on stone, accompanied by horse sweat and lamp grease. The erased stableboy had followed the witness strip or the ledger. More likely, both objects formed part of the same unresolved truth, and opening the record gave him a route.

Ysra saw her posture change. "Contact?"

"Yes. Same knee."

"Close the ledger."

"Not yet."

"Salenne."

"He has a name now."

"A name impressed under a fraudulent entry does not guarantee identity."

"It gives us enough to ask him."

"And what will he take?"

That question had ended three arguments between them and one youthful affair. Ysra believed costs should be counted before courage received praise. Salenne believed counting could become another form of delay. Both had spent years proving the other partly right.

She opened the preparation drawer. "One marked drop. One ghost. Controlled

emotional field.”

“Your mother’s ledger is involved.”

“Nera’s ledger.”

“Do not become tedious with me. Orsa copied royal funeral work. You are thinking of her with every line.”

Salenne looked at the false drowning entry. She could prepare with a memory strong enough to absorb the displacement: her father teaching her first safe clause, her licensing feast, the day she met Ysra beside an unclaimed dockworker. The hosting would choose within the emotional field she opened. It did not honor preferences.

“I need a shaving from his token,” Salenne said.

“If he was erased, the token may never have been entered.”

The missing bone tip lay suddenly clear in her mind.

She lifted the broken clasp with padded tongs. VALE marked Nera’s piece, but a second layer had been glued beneath it. The hidden sliver showed a stable knot and two letters: OR.

Ysra swore softly. “Someone laminated tokens.”

“Then cut through both.”

“Nera’s broken name hid his. One destruction silenced two dead.”

The efficiency chilled Salenne. It also supplied competent material. Ysra separated one powder-fine shaving from the hidden layer and placed it in a shell dish. She added charred reed and salt while Salenne copied the stable assignment onto a clean witness card.

“Conditions,” Ysra said.

“I host Tev Orr solely to identify himself and testify to events he personally witnessed concerning Nera Valev’s death. I lend voice voluntarily. I do not lend hands, legs, or breath beyond speech.”

“Duration.”

“Until sunset, unless I discharge him sooner before competent hearers.”

“You cannot discharge unresolved murder testimony in this room.”

“I can close voice access.”

“Consequence if he presses past it.”

Salenne steadied her stained thumb on the table. “The license locks my jaw and returns bodily control. The witness remains hosted but silent.”

“Cost.”

“One autobiographical memory of comparable emotional force, permanently displaced.”

Saying it did not make the sentence brave. It made it exact.

Ysra mixed the burial black. This batch smelled different from Salenne's licensing test: horsehair smoke, rain trapped in old straw, the mineral sweetness of young bone. When the shaving dissolved, a small bubble formed and held at the center.

"Last chance," Ysra said.

Salenne chose her preparation field. She pictured Orsa at a copying table, not her face, which memory had already softened, but her hands flattening funeral rolls. Her mother used to sing while she worked. No court hymn, only dock songs with rude final verses she stopped when young Salenne entered. That memory contained craft, annoyance, affection, and loss. Strong enough to pay.

She could choose another field.

If Tev had died because adults valued peace or reputation more than a stableboy's speech, asking him to enter through a trivial memory would repeat the insult. Salenne held the copying-room image and nodded.

Ysra painted one marked drop onto the back of Salenne's tongue.

Cold struck first. Her throat closed around the taste of salt and burned reed. The workroom tilted. For three breaths she heard shell cutters outside as hammers on stall boards. On the fourth, a boy's terror entered her ribs.

Dark, he said without using her mouth.

His thought carried the cramped service grille, knees against stone, hands smelling of tack soap.

"My name is Salenne Vaud," she said. "You are held under witness license. Tell me your name."

Her teeth knocked together.

Tev Orr.

"Age at death?"

Seventeen. I had the grey mare. She bit everyone else.

The specific pride inside that memory steadied him. Salenne let him show the mare's blunt yellow teeth, the warm notch beneath her jaw, a feed bucket kicked over in deliberate protest. No murder lay there. Just a boy with work he knew.

Ysra wrote each answer. "Ask his death."

Salenne's pulse raced. "Tev, do you know how you died?"

Pressure packed her throat.

River men came. Said I had to tell again. Cloth over my head. Rope here.

Pain circled Salenne's neck. The license tightened her jaw before Tev could borrow her hands to claw at it.

"Witness only what you saw," she managed. "Do not relive what they did to you through my body."

His fear recoiled. Shame followed, though none belonged to him.

"You have done nothing wrong," Ysra said toward Salenne's face. "Boy, listen. Nothing."

A smell of myrrh entered the borrowed stable memory. Tev noticed Ysra through Salenne's senses: undertaker sleeves, gold tooth, heavy steady hands. He believed her because she looked like someone who handled dead people without asking them to pretend comfort.

Lady came through the hollow passage, he said. Princess Nera. She argued with someone behind the mourning cloth. Said the marriage would put too many soldiers in her sister's bones. Said she had copied the hidden words.

"What hidden words?" Salenne asked.

Don't know reading. She said no body. She said surety.

The words struck near later knowledge but did not complete it.

Tev pushed sight into Salenne.

Stone filled her vision. The service grille cut the corridor into narrow bars. Nera stood beyond them in burial white, alive, one hand closed around folded vellum. Another figure remained half concealed by a hanging of black reeds. A four-fingered hand reached from behind the cloth.

The image broke into red.

Cord tightened around Nera's throat. Her body hit the wall. A pearl-handled knife dropped, struck stone, and spun near the grille. Its blade bore the small forked-rain mark used by the Lord Remembrancer's office.

Tev knew the knife. He had carried tack to Maelin's courtyard twice and seen it used to cut white ceremonial thread.

Salenne's stomach turned.

"Did you see the killer's face?" she asked.

Cloth. Hand. Then Nera saw me.

The dead princess's eyes found the grille. Not the attacker. Tev. Her mouth formed a word he could not hear. Run, perhaps. Or witness.

A living boot struck the grille from the corridor side. Memory shattered.

Salenne pitched forward. Ysra caught her shoulders without touching her throat. Tev's panic flooded her muscles, demanding flight, but the license held her hands flat against the stone.

"Close voice access," Ysra ordered.

"Tev Orr, remain under my license in silence until I call you."

Don't put me dark.

The plea nearly undid her.

"Not alone," Salenne said. "You may share ordinary senses. No body. No speech unless invited."

Agreement arrived as the smell of the grey mare's warm hide.

The workroom returned. Salenne found herself kneeling. Blood dotted the stone beneath her nose. Ysra wiped it away and checked her pupils with the blue lens.

"Memory," Ysra said. "Name what moved."

Salenne reached for the copying room.

Orsa's hands remained. The rolls remained. Sunlight still lay across the table, and Salenne remembered knowing a song had filled the room.

She could not hear it.

No melody. No rough warmth in the low notes. No laughter when Orsa changed an obscene word for a child and sang the wrong rhyme. Facts survived like labels on sealed drawers, but her mother's singing voice had gone beyond reach.

Salenne opened her mouth. Grief emerged without sound.

Ysra crouched beside her. Years ago, those hands had known how to touch her as a lover. Now Ysra put one palm on the floor between them and let Salenne choose whether to close the distance.

Salenne covered that hand with her stained one.

"My mother's singing voice," she said. Naming the loss gave the ledger an entry, not a cure. "I remember that she sang. I cannot hear her."

Ysra's fingers turned under hers and held. "I'm sorry."

Inside Salenne, Tev stayed very quiet.

They remained on the floor until her nose stopped bleeding. Then Ysra sealed Tev's shaving, the false ledger copies, and the rubbing of his erased assignment in three separate packets. Salenne wrote the loss in her private host register. She did not soften its wording.

Before they closed Nera's ledger, Tev pressed one image against the edge of her sight without taking voice: red cord drawing tight, pearl handle turning on stone, forked rain cut into steel.

Maelin's office mark.

Not a face. Not yet an accusation Salenne could lawfully make. But the knife had belonged in the Lord Remembrancer's hand often enough for a stableboy to remember it.

Salenne sealed the copied image statement beneath her license and rose with Tev Orr breathing fear behind her ribs.

Chapter 04 — Prince of the Larger Household

The first Osteren grain wagon broke an axle halfway across the Bridge of Reeds.

Edran heard the crack through six ranks of soldiers and two hundred eleven dead.

The living soldiers turned toward the sound. His Household turned his body. General Hal Marr pulled Edran's shoulders square, tightened his right hand around the saddle horn, and drove an old command into his tongue.

Advance the guard. Leave freight to factors.

Edran shut his mouth until the words lost their shape.

Below the bridge, barge chains rang against pilings in the morning current. Black Reed merchants flattened themselves beside toll shelters while Osteren outriders held formation around the disabled wagon. On the Lyr bank, white-linen funeral banners hung motionless beneath a roofed inspection court. Crown Heir Ardis waited there with enough officials to turn any delay into doctrine.

Edran swung down from his horse. His right leg hit stone badly, and the old campaign injury sent pain from knee to hip. He let the hitch show. Concealing it would cost time, and every soldier behind him already knew.

"Wheel crew," he called. "Second file, chock the wagon. Archers stay mounted. Grain factor, bring me the manifest."

Weak display, Hal said against his teeth.

A century dead, the general still considered carrying food a lesser military art. Hal remembered three victorious crossings and none of the villages burned to feed them.

Captain Tovin Sare reached the axle first. His split left ear made his profile unmistakable even among men in bronze travel caps. He crouched, examined the break, and held up two fingers.

"Old split," Tovin said. "Pitch hid it."

"Sabotage?" an outrider asked.

"Neglect. Less flattering, more common."

Edran suppressed a smile. Tovin had spent eight years distinguishing danger from men who wanted danger to explain their poor work.

The grain factor hurried over with a waxed board. Seven Black Reed villages appeared in one column, each followed by the measures needed before the second dry-month bell. Half the loads in this delegation served as ceremonial proof that Osteren could fulfill the Bride Accord. The rest would feed horses and visiting officials while villagers upriver waited beside bare bins.

"Move the sacks to wagon four," Edran ordered. "Use palace porters only after

our factor counts seals with theirs.”

“Your Highness, the entry schedule requires the royal carriage first.”

“The schedule does not eat.”

His Household shifted. Quartermasters long dead approved of the redistribution; kings objected to the prince walking into Lyr beside a damaged cart. Two distant cousins offered conflicting advice about the ceremonial horse. Someone who had never visited the border recalled a triumphal song.

Two hundred eleven names did not speak as a choir. They crowded like officers around one table, each mistaking persistence for relevance.

Edran put a hand on a grain sack. The rough weave grounded his palm. Black Reed grain smelled faintly sour from damp storage. If Maelin Valev’s marriage succeeded, the road would open, tolls would fall, and the villages might survive long enough to rebuild their silted canals. If it failed, soldiers waiting beyond horn call would receive simpler orders.

That arithmetic had brought him to the bridge.

A Lyr official crossed from the inspection court. Her grey robe bore bridge scales instead of ancestor thread. “Prince Edran Marr, Crown Heir Ardis asks whether you require assistance or privacy.”

An excellent question. Assistance invited Lyr hands into Osteren seals. Privacy left the entire court waiting while Osteren displayed a broken axle.

“Ask Her Highness for four empty carts and eight porters chosen by the Black Reed merchants here,” Edran said. “Our factor will count every sack beside hers. No delay to toll traffic.”

The official glanced at the merchants. “The welcoming order does not grant them ceremonial function.”

“Then we have improved it.”

Ardis heard the answer from across the court. Her posture changed by a degree, head tilting toward one of her councilors. Edran could not read approval at that distance. He could read attention.

General Hal pressed against his left heel, trying to turn him toward the royal carriage.

Edran drove both feet flat. “Not now.”

The living people near him pretended he had addressed the broken wheel.

You enter enemy ground on foot while a woman makes you wait, Hal said.

“She is making the grain wait less.” Edran spoke quietly enough for Tovin alone.

Tovin rose from the axle. “Hal?”

“Who else measures sovereignty in boot height?”

“Your grandmother measured it in spoon placement.”

“She is objecting too.”

Together they supervised the transfer. Lyr supplied carts with broad delta wheels. Merchants from three of the seven villages counted seals in both dialects, arguing over one faded mark until the factor opened the sack and proved it held grain rather than military salt. The process delayed the prince’s ceremonial entry by thirty-one minutes. It also made theft nearly impossible.

While the last sacks moved, Tovin steered Edran behind the north toll shelter. The shelter had no door, only a waist-high counter and shelves for disputed seals. From the inspection court it looked as though the prince and his captain had paused to discuss manifests.

“You gave Hal your left heel at the bridge crown,” Tovin said.

“I took it back.”

“After eleven steps.”

“Nine.”

“Do you want accuracy or discretion?”

“Both. I have become demanding in peace.”

Tovin checked the shelter opening before touching Edran’s right thigh above the old wound. His palm found the muscle in spasm through riding wool. Intimacy entered by practical routes with them. A battlefield had taught Tovin where pain hid; the years afterward taught him which touch meant captain, which meant lover, and which could be both.

“Sit,” he said.

“No.”

“An Osteren prince may sit in a toll shelter without surrendering territory.”

“Hal disagrees.”

“Hal died before this bridge had honest scales.”

Edran leaned against the counter instead. Tovin pressed two fingers beside the scar until the knot released. Pain flared, then dropped to a manageable heat.

Beyond the shelter, living officers shouted wagon numbers. None of the dead in Edran’s blood could count the present loads unless he lent them his eyes. He kept that access narrow. General Hal received bridge approaches and armed positions by habit; Tovin’s touch and the grain manifest remained private.

“What did you hear when the court came into view?” Tovin asked.

“Hal wanted the guard advanced. Meret wanted the carriage curtains opened. Grandmother wanted me to notice Ardis wore no names.”

“And did you?”

“I noticed.”

Tovin’s hand left the scar. “You also noticed she sent merchants instead of

palace porters.”

“That matters more.”

“I know.” No jealousy sharpened his voice. Their problem had never concerned whether Edran might admire a capable woman. It concerned a state arranging his body around that admiration and calling the arrangement consent. “If she understands the imbalance, she may refuse at the hall.”

“Then Osteren’s generals move before the court finishes blaming her.”

“We can put the grain across first.”

“Not enough for the full shortage.”

Tovin turned the waxed manifest so the smallest figures faced Edran. Little Harrow needed three hundred measures. South Reed needed six hundred and canal pitch. Venn Tar had seed grain for twelve days if no officer requisitioned it. Tovin had added those notes in the compressed hand he used when numbers frightened him.

“Maelin’s letters promised release upon lawful marriage,” Edran said. “If we separate release from marriage, we remove the generals’ cleanest excuse.”

“And give Hal reason to push harder inside you.”

“He already considers restraint a temporary illness.”

For a moment Tovin looked past rank, logistics, and the open shelter. “I cannot anchor two hundred eleven if the splice gives them another body.”

The statement carried no accusation. That made it worse.

Edran caught the back of Tovin’s neck and drew their foreheads together below the sightline of the court. He wanted to kiss him. Boots crossed three paces away, and caution had survived eight campaign years for good reasons, so he held the contact instead.

“You will not be asked to,” Edran said.

“A prince’s promise?”

“Mine.”

Tovin closed his eyes for one breath. When he stepped back, Captain Sare had returned to his face. “Then tell Ardis before the dead tell her with her own mouth.”

“I intend to.”

“Today?”

“Before Maelin seats us beneath funeral banners and everyone mistakes placement for agreement.”

“That sounds almost wise.”

“Record the date.”

A factor called that the transfer had finished. Tovin straightened Edran’s travel coat, an ordinary captain’s service that hid the tenderness of his thumb once

brushing Edran's pulse.

By the time Edran reached the inspection court, Ardis had sent the minor councilors away and ordered thick tea served to everyone still working. No musicians played. He had expected a line of ancestral trumpets and found practical silence.

She stood at the near edge of the court in an asymmetrical copper coat. Plain white linen threaded her braids. Nothing on her body displayed the fifty-three lawful dead of House Valev.

Beside her waited a short woman in indigo, jaw-length black hair framing an expression that seemed to have found errors in the bridge, the axle, and Edran's face. Burial black marked her left thumb.

"Prince Edran," Ardis said. "Welcome to Lyr. I regret the axle."

"I regret bringing it."

"Your captain believes we share custody of the road's maintenance failure."

Tovin bowed. "Captain Tovin Sare, Highness. I said neglect respects no border."

"Then it may be the first power to honor our ceasefire."

Edran liked her at once and distrusted the liking. Arranged spouses received too much praise for tolerating each other's sentences.

Ardis gestured to the advocate. "Salenne Vaud certifies the Bride Accord."

"Tests," Salenne corrected.

A Valev councilor inhaled through his nose.

Ardis's mouth almost moved. "She tests the Bride Accord."

Edran bowed to Salenne. A scent of charred reed reached him, followed by something less identifiable: a stable after rain, perhaps. Her pupils tightened when he spoke his Household name.

"Advocate Vaud. Have you received Osteren's funeral roll?"

"The certified count. Not the name leaves."

"Two hundred eleven," Edran said.

The words activated his dead more efficiently than prayer. Hal filled the base of his skull. Kings and officers crowded behind him, alert to being counted in foreign space. His right hand sought a sword hilt he had surrendered at the bridge by agreement.

Tovin touched two fingers to the inside of Edran's wrist.

No one else would notice the gesture beneath the drape of Edran's travel coat. Tovin used the same rhythm after battle dreams: two slow taps, one quick. Their room above a grain store in Alth. A cracked washbasin. Tovin laughing because the prince had tried to repair it with military sealing wax. Specific living memory gave Edran his hand back.

Salenne noticed anyway. Her attention flicked to Tovin, then away without judgment.

"Your lawful count exceeds House Valev by almost four to one," she said. "Do you dispute the arithmetic?"

"No."

The Valev councilor stepped forward. "The royal strength of a Household cannot be reduced to number."

"Bodies are vulnerable to number," Salenne replied.

General Hal approved of her tone while rejecting her conclusion. The contradiction produced a brief hammering behind Edran's eyes.

Ardis looked toward the tea table. "We have a formal audience at noon. Before then, I would prefer to understand what my advocate has chosen to ask at the bridge."

"Your aunt requested the question wait," Salenne said.

"My aunt requests many forms of waiting."

Edran heard history beneath that answer without knowing its shape.

Servants offered tea. Ardis made sure the axle crew received cups before the four principals. She dismissed the remaining councilor with a request to verify the grain seals, a task important enough to flatter him and distant enough to free the conversation.

Once only guards and working merchants remained within earshot, Salenne spoke. "The marriage splices both Households for one lunar year. If one side coordinates at three to one or greater, sustained control of speech, posture, and hands becomes possible. Does House Marr recognize overcrowning?"

Fabrication, Hal said.

Edran accepted tea from a servant and waited until the dead general spent his first rush of anger.

"House Marr recognizes it privately," he said.

Ardis's cup stopped below her mouth.

Across the court, Tovin watched the exits. His stillness indicated approval more reliably than praise.

Salenne asked, "Publicly?"

"Our official funeral jurists call it unproven coordination pressure."

"What do you call it?"

"Overcrowning."

Hal drove pain through Edran's wounded leg. His knee threatened to fold. Edran shifted his cup to the other hand and let the court think travel had stiffened him.

Ardis set her tea down. "Can your Household do it deliberately?"

There were diplomatic answers. No living precedent. Not under supervised vows. The balance of royal dignity prevents abuse. Maelin's correspondence had supplied variations of all three.

Edran chose the answer that would keep Ardis from waking with his dead in her hands.

"Yes."

The word left a clean wound in the welcome.

General Hal struck for his mouth. We preserve what living weakness loses.

Edran closed his jaw, but the pressure traveled into posture. His shoulders turned toward Ardis with an old conqueror's appraisal. One foot advanced.

Tovin moved between them under the pretense of taking Edran's empty cup. His shoulder met Edran's chest lightly. The contact carried years of shared campaign tents, fever watches, and nights when rank had stayed outside a locked door.

"Enough," Edran whispered.

Hal receded to a furious ache.

Ardis had seen the struggle. She also saw Tovin's hand stay near Edran's without touching it again. Her gaze held no jealousy, no courtly curiosity. It held comprehension.

"My Household expects the marriage to give it strategic access to Lyr," Edran said. "Some ancestors call that guidance. General Hal calls it continuity. The effect on your body would remain the same whatever noun survives the minutes."

"Why agree to come?" Ardis asked.

"Because the ceasefire expires if I refuse, and the grain provisions were tied to the wedding before either of us received a complete draft."

"Your court tied them."

"Both courts accepted the knot."

Her chin lifted. "Do not distribute blame to make it harmless."

"I am not. Osteren needs the road opened. Lyr needs troops withdrawn. Your council needs a ceremony it can display as control. My generals want access to your Household. I came because refusing all of those at once would put soldiers back into seven villages."

"While proceeding may put two hundred eleven dead into me."

"Yes."

The direct answer cost him less than any gentler one.

Salenne moved her stained thumb along the seam of her document case. "The current draft uses shared Household guidance without defining refusal. I marked it yesterday. Lord Maelin calls customary meaning sufficient."

"Custom serves the person who wrote it," Edran said.

“Occasionally it serves the advocate billing by correction.”

Dry humor, offered without warmth. Edran respected it.

Ardis looked from him to Tovin. “Does your captain know the full risk?”

“Tovin knows what my dead can do because he has stopped them doing it.”

Captain Tovin Sare finally faced her directly. “The prince can refuse one ancestor. He can sometimes refuse ten. During fever or blood loss, the Household coordinates faster. A wedding splice would create a route into you every hour, asleep or waking.”

No servant nearby reacted. The bridge court continued moving around them: sacks counted, carts rolled, toll chains lifted for a fish barge. Edran preferred the ordinary labor. It prevented their bodies from becoming the only stakes in the conversation.

Ardis said, “If the clauses barred lending without explicit consent each time?”

“Consent under two hundred voices wears down,” Tovin replied.

“If the splice carried no bodily access?” Salenne asked.

Hal surged at that possibility. Other dead followed, officers first, then rulers who regarded marriage without control as a treaty stripped of teeth.

Edran pressed his palm to the grain manifest. Numbers anchored him: seven villages, fourteen damaged sluice gates, three thousand measures in the first convoy, nine days until projected shortage in the smallest settlement.

“The Household would resist such wording,” he said. “Which means it might protect her.”

“Would you sign it?” Ardis asked.

“If the grain passage, toll reduction, withdrawal line, and canal crews remain guaranteed independently of bodily marriage terms.”

“That sounds like bargaining over whether I am occupied.”

“It is bargaining over whether either court can use hungry villages to force us into occupation.”

Silence held for several heartbeats.

Ardis examined the workers at the broken wagon. One merchant had climbed onto the replacement cart to count sacks. A Lyr porter argued cheerfully with an Osteren factor over seal wax. Their cooperation needed no wedding witness because the axle had given them a problem smaller than sovereignty and more immediate.

Maelin’s arrival bell sounded from the palace gate, one measured strike. The formal welcome could no longer be delayed without insult.

Edran knew the visible choice expected of him. Take Ardis’s offered hand. Enter beneath joined funeral banners. Let both courts see beauty where each heir saw a mechanism.

Instead, he addressed Salenne. "Bring me the bodily clauses before the rehearsal. I will mark every place House Marr expects access."

Hal's outrage burned along his spine.

Ardis looked at him for a long moment. "And your condition?"

"Write the famine relief so no refusal by either spouse can stop it. The Black Reed villages receive grain whether this marriage survives review or not."

A second bell rang.

Ardis extended her hand, not as a bride receiving a groom but palm upward, waiting for terms. "I cannot promise what the Rain Council has not approved."

"Promise to help secure it."

"I promise that."

Edran placed his hand in hers. Neither Household crossed through skin. The gesture held no vow, no burial black, and no witness beyond the living people who understood its limits.

"Then I will help rewrite the vows," he said.

Together they turned toward the palace entrance while Tovin and Salenne followed, two professionals already watching for what the ceremony intended to hide.

Chapter 05 — Terms Behind a Locked Door

Ardis locked the map room while Edran still had one boot in the corridor.

He looked down at the threshold, then at her hand on the key. “In Osteren, territorial disputes usually begin after everyone enters.”

“In Lyr, we value efficiency.” She waited until he brought his injured leg across and shut the door. “Captain Sare will keep anyone from interrupting.”

“Tovin believes we are comparing patrol lines.”

“He believes we are lying about comparing patrol lines.”

“He learns quickly.”

Salenne stood beside the long map table with a funeral packet under one hand. Since their meeting in the dressing chamber, a new stillness had entered her. Her eyes sometimes shifted toward an empty place near her shoulder as if listening to someone too frightened to speak aloud.

Ardis set the key beside the central lamp. “Lord Maelin has scheduled the shortened-vow rehearsal for tomorrow.”

“She told me after requesting my revisions,” Salenne said.

“Did she accept them?” Edran asked.

“She thanked me for clarifying the customary meaning.”

“Which means no.”

“Which means she has placed my objections in a folder with an excellent label.”

The map room had no ancestral decoration. Painted tiles showed the delta canals, Osteren’s dry terraces, the disputed grain road, and seven Black Reed villages arranged along it like knots in a fraying cord. Ardis had chosen this room because servants expected raised voices over borders. Any listener outside would hear the correct nouns and misunderstand their purpose.

Edran unrolled a waxed famine ledger over the central villages. “Little Harrow reaches seed reserve in eight days. Venn Tar in twelve. South Reed can last fourteen if its western store has not spoiled.”

Ardis leaned over the figures. “Our factors reported eighteen.”

“Our factors reported what Osteren’s ministries could admit while negotiating.”

“You brought false numbers to the Bride Accord.”

“I brought the accurate ledger with me. The official copy traveled ahead under three ministerial seals.”

“Then both courts are using the same custom.”

The rebuke struck him. He did not dodge it. “Yes.”

Edran opened a pocket sewn into the ledger wrap and removed seven narrow

report slips. Each came from a village reeve rather than a ministry. Little Harrow had slaughtered draft animals to preserve feed grain. South Reed's children received fish broth at midday so adults could leave the sour cakes to them. Venn Tar had dismantled two burned roofs for canal braces because Osteren's timber convoy remained behind a military checkpoint.

"These reports crossed through funeral merchants," he said. "Official messengers were ordered to summarize conditions, not describe them."

Ardis read the signatures. Three writers shared surnames with Lyr petitioners she had seen at the rain court. War had divided families without teaching hunger to respect the division.

"If we place these before the Council, ministers will challenge origin," she said.

"Let them. I can identify each reeve under oath. Tovin knows two personally."

Salenne turned one slip over. A child's grain tally covered the back, four small circles crossed out day by day. "Facts do not become improper because poor paper carried them."

Salenne placed a finger beside the grain-release clause. "This binds relief to completed marriage. If either spouse refuses at the ceremony, the first convoy remains under Osteren military custody."

"General Sev will call refusal a threat to the road," Edran said. "General Hal will call it proof that Lyr never intended peace."

Ardis knew Hal meant one of the dead. Edran's jaw had tightened in the way it did when he denied his Household speech. "And if the convoy moves first?"

"Living officers lose famine as a justification for advance. They retain other excuses."

"Armies are rarely short of those."

The map showed distances without hunger. Ardis put a counter on each village, then a grain bead beside each counter. Seven pieces of painted bone. Seven figures that could become bodies if court language failed.

She faced Salenne. "Show him."

The advocate opened the funeral packet. Copies lay within, never originals: Nera's false drowning entry, Tev Orr's scraped assignment, Ysra's ligature finding, and a drawing of the pearl-handled knife. The red fiber recovered from Nera's neck had darkened almost brown in the lens rendering.

Edran read standing up. His Household disturbed the lamp flame through his breath, each exhalation too sharp.

"Tev is with you?" he asked.

"Yes," Salenne said. "Hosted under license. He has ordinary senses but no body access. I open speech deliberately."

"What did hosting cost?"

Ardis watched Salenne's stained thumb press the packet edge.

"My mother's singing voice."

The plain answer entered the room more forcefully than grief performed for sympathy could have done. Edran lowered his gaze to the record. Ardis wanted to say that no evidence should demand such a payment. The statement would insult both the cost already paid and the people who had arranged for evidence to require it.

Instead she asked, "Does Tev identify the killer?"

"No face. He saw a four-fingered hand, red cord, and a Remembrancer knife he recognized from palace work. That creates suspicion. It does not complete identity."

Ardis's attention went to the map-room key. Maelin's missing finger had been visible all Ardis's life, an absence acquired in war and converted into part of her authority. Many people in the palace bore missing fingers. Fewer carried pearl-handled office knives.

"My aunt supervised the drowning record," Ardis said.

"She also supplied her key for us to open it," Salenne replied.

"After twelve years in which to prepare the contents."

"Both propositions can be true."

Edran looked at Nera's copied words about soldiers in Ardis's bones. "She discovered the overcrowning design."

"Tev heard her oppose a marriage," Salenne said. "He does not know this draft or House Marr's count."

"He knows enough." Edran's left hand flattened beside the ledger. "My Household has argued for access to Valev bodies since negotiations began. I thought that pressure belonged to current military aims."

"Could any of your dead have joined a plan twelve years ago?" Ardis asked.

"Those ancestors could pressure living hardliners. They could not write, murder, or erase without living hands. I was eighteen and on the north grain road. Tovin served with my escort. Neither of us knew of a marriage design."

Ardis believed the location detail because he offered a witness and no demand that belief follow. Trust had to begin somewhere smaller than innocence.

Salenne drew a clean strip of reed paper from her case. "We have two problems that courts insist on making one. People need grain. Neither heir can consent freely while grain depends on bodily union. The vow also fails to define bodily access."

Edran read over her shoulder as she wrote. "Start with prohibition, not consent."

"Why?"

"Because two hundred eleven voices can wear consent down and preserve the

final yes as if it governed the hours before it.”

Ardis felt Dorel stir at the back of her throat. Not command. Sorrow.

Salenne dipped her brush. “Propose language.”

Edran spoke to the paper rather than Ardis. “No ancestor of either spouse may take speech, posture, hand, or sense through the other spouse.”

“Too narrow,” Salenne said. “A Household could coordinate descendants other than the named ancestor. It could also use breath, gait, sleep, pain, or appetite without taking the listed capacities.”

“Then no dead person entering through the splice may use a living body.”

“Entering implies the route matters. Harm remains harm if a funeral token supplies another route.”

Ardis listened to them reduce horror into enforceable edges. Precision did not make the subject bloodless. It showed where blood might go.

She said, “No spouse may be entered, directed, restrained, injured, or deprived of memory by any dead person through this agreement.”

Salenne’s brush moved.

Edran added, “Each lending requires a separate spoken request by the ancestor and a separate answer by the descendant. Silence refuses.”

“Each permission ends after twelve breaths unless renewed,” Salenne said. “No renewal while asleep, wounded, drugged, compelled, or under coordinated Household pressure.”

The line filled half the strip. Burial black would test it later; ordinary ink sufficed for thought.

Ardis read the draft twice. “Could it bind?”

“It names protected persons, prohibited acts, duration, and consequence still missing.”

“What consequence can repair possession?”

“None. We can make attempted bodily entry terminate the Household splice.”

“Would that tear memory?” Edran asked.

“Under the current termination clause, yes.”

“Then the protection punishes the person attacked.”

Salenne looked up. “Exactly.”

They stood around the strip, three people chosen by separate offices to complete a marriage and now trying to make refusal survivable. Outside, Tovin raised his voice about a patrol marker. A second voice answered with theatrical offense. Their territorial fiction had acquired convincing details.

Ardis said, “The splice itself must come out.”

Edran's Household struck him visibly. His shoulders jerked back, and his left fingers curled against the map. He breathed through his nose until the posture became his again.

"If you remove it now," he said, "my court may withdraw the grain."

"Then we secure grain first."

"Privately?"

"For one day. I can move councilors if I bring them village figures they cannot dismiss as Osteren exaggeration."

He pushed the famine ledger across to her. "Keep it."

The trust carried legal danger. Possession of the uncensored figures could expose him to charges of undermining his own ministers. Ardis closed the ledger and put her seal across its wrap.

Salenne gathered the evidence packet. "Before we proceed, I need instruction concerning whom I must obey."

The words sounded formal. Her face did not.

Ardis understood the trap. Salenne's retention letter bound her to the Crown Heir for advocacy and to the Lord Remembrancer for palace investigation procedure. If Maelin ordered evidence surrendered, access ended, or Tev discharged, refusal could end Salenne's license before Ardis protected her.

"You remain my assigned oath advocate," Ardis said. "I am not releasing you from service."

Salenne's expression tightened, a small reminder that clarity could wound while doing necessary work.

Ardis continued. "On investigation matters touching Nera's death, funeral-roll alteration, or coercive terms in the Bride Accord, I release you from direct obedience to me, Lady Maelin, and any Valev Household voice. You may refuse instructions, retain evidence, choose witnesses, and stop work without penalty from my office."

"Your council can still punish me."

"I cannot lawfully pre-forgive offenses I have not seen."

"No. You cannot."

"I can promise a hearing before any suspension takes effect."

Salenne considered. "Record it."

Ardis wrote the release on the reverse of the access grant, narrower than freedom, wider than the advocate had held that morning. Both Edran and Salenne signed as living witnesses. No dead empowered it. Office law, not burial black, made it competent.

"Now secrecy," Edran said.

They divided the evidence into three packets. Salenne kept Tev's host register and original copies. Ardis took the famine ledger and Nera's archive grant. Edran received the knife drawing and the bodily-clause draft. Each packet went into a small map drawer fitted with one lock.

"Three keys," Ardis said, setting hers beside the lamp. "One held by each of us. Any two can open the drawer if the third is arrested, compelled, or missing. No one opens it alone."

Salenne tested the mechanism. "A conspiracy designed by committee."

"A committee of three may occasionally outperform a murder."

Tev moved inside her. Her gaze turned toward the old foundation map painted beneath the current border roads.

"There," she said.

A faded label followed the wedding hall's southern footing: HOLLOW AISLE, SERVICE WITNESS ACCESS. Later paint covered most of the corridor. Seven small rectangles lined it beneath the Vow Chamber.

Ardis had crossed the wedding hall hundreds of times and never known a named passage ran below it.

"Tev recognizes the word hollow?" Edran asked.

"The route," Salenne said. "He went through a grille from the stable side. He remembers Nera entering through a stair behind a mourning hanging."

Tomorrow's rehearsal would fill the hall with both Households and active vow language. If erased dead remained in the foundations, Hollow Rain might return. So might whoever had altered Nera's record.

Ardis removed the foundation map tile from its brass clips and rolled it with the bodily-clause draft.

"We search tonight," Edran said.

"No," she replied. "The masked ancestors' vigil begins at dusk tomorrow. Every court observer will face the upper hall, and veiled movement will be expected. Salenne and I can descend without bringing Osteren guards into a royal foundation."

Edran disliked exclusion but recognized the border consequence. "Tovin and I hold the hall route."

Salenne closed her fingers around her key. "Then tomorrow we find the Hollow Aisle."

Ardis unlocked the map-room door only after each of them could state the same lie about patrol markers and the same truth about what would happen below the wedding hall.

Chapter 06 — The Hollow Aisle

Salenne entered the wedding hall wearing the face of a dead tax collector.

The mask had been hammered from river tin and painted with the collector's most flattering funeral portrait, which gave him two complete eyebrows and omitted a boil beside his nose. Around her, courtiers moved beneath hundreds of other ancestral faces while the masked vigil rehearsed absence: no living names, no uncovered mouths, no speech above a whisper until the west cistern bell.

Ardis wore Queen Dorel's blue-lacquered mask. Plain white linen still threaded her braids behind it.

At the hall's north entrance, Edran stood beneath General Hal's bronze likeness while Tovin wore no ancestor at all. A captain without name-thread drew disapproving looks, which served their purpose. Every court watcher noticed Tovin. None followed Salenne and Ardis when they passed behind the old mourning hanging.

Tev tightened behind Salenne's ribs.

Here, he said through sensation rather than voice.

The hanging smelled of dust and bitter reed oil. Its stitched scene showed House Rain rising from the delta, royal figures carrying bricks while servants appeared only as hands along the lower border. Salenne lifted the fabric. A limewashed wall waited behind it.

Ardis pressed the third painted reed stalk on the map rubbing. Mortar clicked. A section of wall shifted inward far enough to expose black stair treads.

"You knew where to press?" Salenne whispered.

"I spent half my childhood touching things I was told represented my family." Ardis glanced through Dorel's fixed blue smile. "Occasionally they opened."

A draft climbed from the gap, cold and stale. Salenne tasted old salt. Tev recognized the air and pulled her right knee toward the opening.

"Body," she told him under her breath.

His pressure vanished at once, replaced by shame.

Ardis heard. "Did he try to move you?"

"He remembered moving. The distinction becomes physical only if I enforce it."

"Do you want to stop?"

The question held no impatience. That made answering harder.

"No."

Salenne opened the wall. Ardis took a hooded lamp from under her vigil cloak and led down five steps before Salenne caught her shoulder.

"The person with a Household goes second."

"The person with the lamp goes first."

"The person carrying a licensed witness can detect burial residue before the Crown Heir walks into it."

Behind Dorel's mask, Ardis's breathing changed. "You do not become expendable because your license contains a cost schedule."

"And you do not become skilled at mortuary descent because a crown contains stairs."

They faced each other in the narrow opening, each blocked by the other's protection. Attraction did not announce itself as softness. It arrived as infuriating attention: Ardis noticing Salenne's limits, Salenne noticing exactly where Ardis tried to spend herself.

The west bell sounded above. Court masks would turn toward the witness dais for the first silent circuit.

Ardis handed over the lamp. "You take five steps. I hold your coat. If you lose balance or speech, I pull you back."

"Agreed."

Her fingers closed around the back of Salenne's indigo coat, firm enough to feel through two layers. Salenne descended.

The hidden stair corkscrewed through older brick than the palace used above. Each tread dipped at the middle from servant feet. White salt crusted the outer wall. No decorative rail softened the drop; a rope ran through iron eyes, replaced in patches over generations and then abandoned.

At the seventh step, burial residue touched Salenne's licensed token. Cold spread under her tongue. Not Tev. Many presences rested nearby, too diffuse for names.

"Workers," she said. "Erased or never entered."

Ardis's grip tightened. "How many?"

"More than one. Fewer than a crowd. They are not pressing for speech."

"Can they feel my Household?"

Dorel and the other Valev dead had gone silent inside Ardis. The royal dead knew this foundation. Their silence carried the shape of avoidance.

"They can feel the proposed binding above," Salenne said. "They may not distinguish you from it."

A film of moisture formed under the stair arch. Hollow Rain gathered but did not fall.

They reached a landing wide enough to stand side by side. Ardis released Salenne's coat. The missing pressure felt immediate and foolish.

Tev sent the memory of a left turn.

Their passage narrowed beyond the landing. Names had been cut into the brick at hip height, hundreds of shallow marks layered under lime. Most were single names without Household forms: Pela, Dorn, Iss, Maret, Uvi. Work signs followed them, a bucket, a hammer, a reed knife, a kitchen hook.

Salenne held the lamp sideways to throw shadows across the cuts. "These are servant names."

"Why hide them?"

"Perhaps the people who carved them did not consider this hidden."

Ardis touched no inscription. "The royal apartments grew over the service foundations after the second flood. Court histories say the workers received lawful naming."

"Court histories also say Nera drowned."

That landed harder than Salenne intended. Ardis stopped.

A living apology would be easy. It would also shift comfort toward the person whose profession had just exposed a lie. Salenne waited instead.

"My sister's record does not make every record false," Ardis said.

"No. It makes confidence more expensive."

They continued.

At the first junction, brick dust covered a collapsed alcove. A broken shell token protruded from the rubble. Salenne knelt and used horn tongs to lift it. The surface carried no royal form, only TAR beneath a mason's square.

Ardis lowered the lamp. "Ena Tar."

"You know the name?"

"I have seen it beneath foundation estimates. The copies call Ena a supplier, never a mason."

Salenne rubbed dust from the adjacent brick. Three full lines appeared:

Ena Tar laid the witness course.

Seven heard freely.

No blood paid them ownership.

The wording lacked legal completion, but its direction opposed modern practice. Witnesses heard freely. Blood did not own them. Someone had carved the proposition in a service corridor and later buried it under lime.

Tev pressed curiosity into Salenne's mouth. He had never reached this junction alive.

"Do not show him more than we see," she reminded herself.

"What?" Ardis asked.

"Hosts can confuse a ghost's presence with its knowledge. Tev learns this now through me. Later he may remember learning it and mistake the corridor for something he witnessed before death."

"Can you prevent that?"

"I can tell him the boundary. I can record it. Memory remains less obedient than law."

Salenne spoke inwardly. Tev Orr, you did not see this inscription while alive. You see it now through Salenne Vaud on Day Four of your hosting.

His agreement came with the grey mare's scent.

Ardis watched her face. "You make even thought give evidence."

"Thought causes fewer wars when it admits dates."

The passage ended at a wider aisle beneath the wedding hall. Here the palace builders had used pale mortar veined with rust-red lines. Seven shallow niches occupied the north wall, each human height but too narrow for a coffin. Slots inside them could once have held name tokens or rolled witness vellum. All stood vacant.

Seven empty niches.

Modern wedding law required exactly seven lawful dead. Salenne had assumed the number belonged to royal precedent. The foundation suggested an older source.

Ardis stepped into the first niche. "No ancestor marks."

"Servant marks below each threshold."

Salenne read them in order: mason's square, stable knot, ferry hook, copying knife, grain scoop, cup, burial spade. Professions rather than bloodlines.

"The original witnesses came from outside the royal Household," she said.

"Or the niches honored workers who built a royal witness place."

"Possible."

"You sound disappointed that I offered caution."

"I am attracted to caution when it arrives before a conclusion."

Silence followed.

Salenne realized the word she had used only after it entered the corridor between them.

Ardis removed Dorel's mask. Warm lamp light showed a flush high on her cheeks. "Attracted?"

"To the method."

"Of course."

Rank sharpened every possible answer. Ardis could flirt and call it private; Salenne would still return tomorrow to a service assignment controlled by her

office. Desire under those terms could never separate invitation from professional survival.

Salenne turned to the mortar. "There is blood here."

The change of subject lacked elegance. Elegance would have been more dangerous.

Rust-red threads crossed the pale joints in irregular bands. She wetted a testing swab with salt water and pressed it beneath the first niche. The fibers darkened, releasing a copper smell untouched by age.

Ardis crouched beside her. "Animal?"

"No reed ash. No binding response yet." Salenne added one grain of clean burial salt.

The mortar warmed.

A woman's hand memory entered Salenne's palm, broad fingers forcing lime into a wall seam. Pain flared through an old cut. Then a man's shoulder carried a basket. A third worker coughed red dust. None gained speech or body. Their labor impressions remained mixed into the structure.

"Human," Salenne said. "Blood in the mortar, probably from the workers who laid it. Cremation salt too."

"Sacrifice?"

"Do not grant murder to a test that proves only material. Builders bled. Mortar took what touched it. Someone later added cremation salt, or people worked here after funeral preparation."

Ardis rested her hand near the swab. "Hollow Rain comes from erased worker dead in palace lime."

"Yes. This aisle contains enough residue to answer any vow spoken overhead."

Moisture thickened beneath the ceiling. One cold drop hit the empty cup niche.

Salenne withdrew the swab. The borrowed labor sensations released, leaving a shallow cut across her palm where none had opened in her skin. Ghost residue could lend pain without making a wound. Her fingers still trembled.

Ardis reached for her, stopped, and asked, "May I?"

Salenne gave her hand.

The heir turned it palm up, checking for blood. Her thumb hovered above Salenne's stained left thumb, close enough for heat to cross. No ancestor traveled through the contact. Tev remained still. The moment contained only two living bodies and the terms they had not spoken.

"No wound," Ardis said.

"Remembered cut."

"Yours?"

“Someone who worked the mortar.”

Ardis let go before either of them could mistake examination for permission to continue. “They built the room that made my family’s vows possible, and the rolls removed them.”

“We have evidence of removal from the wall’s public history. Not yet from every roll.”

“You protect even the people who lied from an accusation not proved.”

“I protect the accusation. Overstatement gives liars a place to stand.”

Ardis carried the lamp to the grain-scoop niche. A small cavity behind its token slot held a coil of blackened reed fiber. She used Salenne’s tongs rather than her bare fingers, an adoption of mortuary caution so immediate that Salenne felt an unreasonable flash of pride.

The coil unrolled into seven narrow work tallies. Each named a person, labor, and payment from the first Concord stores. Ena Tar headed the mason’s tally. A ferryman named Pell Rusk had received two salt measures for “free hearing after completion.” The stable tally had lost its first edge, but enough remained to show that a nonroyal worker once occupied every niche.

“Payment for witnessing?” Ardis asked.

“Payment acknowledges labor. It does not prove consent.”

A second strip answered that objection in a copyist’s compact hand: Each named below may depart before speech and keep full pay. No master, blood heir, or Crown officer may answer for the witness.

Salenne read it twice. “This predates the modern rule allowing a Household head to accept on behalf of ancestral witnesses.”

“Can we use it to stop the rehearsal?”

“Not alone. A work tally found behind a wall has provenance problems. Maelin can call it ceremonial accounting unrelated to binding law.”

“She can call anything incomplete until everyone who remembers it has been erased.”

The bitterness came from more than Nera. Ardis stood inside a foundation built by people her office had made absent. Above, living courtiers wore dead faces at a ritual intended to preserve the same office. Salenne saw the moment duty turned in Ardis’s hands and cut both ways.

“You are not required to solve the entire Crown tonight,” she said.

“I am required to marry for it in fifteen days.”

“Requirement and coercion can share a document.”

“Do not give me an advocate’s clean answer.” Ardis’s voice stayed low, but Dorel pressed a tremor through its final word. “If I refuse now, grain stops. Generals move. People with no place in this corridor pay for my bodily freedom.”

"And if you proceed under the current clause, House Marr gains your body and strategic access to every Valev descendant your office can summon. Those same people may pay later."

"Later lets them eat first."

"There will always be a person whose immediate need can be placed against your consent. That does not make the need false. It makes the arrangement efficient."

Ardis set the lamp into a niche before her grip could shake it. "Easy to say when your refusal does not move an army."

The words hit with royal accuracy. Salenne's service remained dangerous; Ardis's decision carried villages. Pretending equal risk would turn solidarity into vanity.

"No," Salenne said. "My refusal can cost my license and perhaps my life. It cannot move your army. I will not claim otherwise."

A pause opened between them.

"What, then, do you ask me to do?" Ardis said.

"Stop asking what sacrifice proves you deserve the Crown. Ask what act changes the mechanism."

"And your answer?"

"Move grain before the marriage. Establish public bodily limits. Find enough corroboration that Maelin cannot close the question as contaminated testimony. Make refusal cost the courts more than it costs the villages."

"That sounds like law pretending it has time."

"It sounds like work. Time dislikes work because work makes a day specific."

Ardis leaned back against the mortar, then thought better of touching residue and stepped away. "You have already spent a memory for this."

"Do not use my cost to purchase your obedience."

"I meant that I know you are not asking safely from the shore."

The correction stripped rank from her voice without pretending rank had vanished. Salenne looked at Dorel's mask hanging from Ardis's hand. The painted queen smiled with ceremonial patience. The living daughter looked tired, angry, and far more difficult to idealize.

"That is why you released my investigative obedience," Salenne said. "So I can tell you to stop without making the instruction a performance."

"I did not release your service."

"I know."

Awareness settled through the silence. Attraction had entered their speech earlier and remained there, constrained by the assignment neither could honestly

ignore.

Ardis picked up the lamp. "When this work ends, I would like to ask you a question that has nothing to do with clauses."

"When it ends, you may ask."

"Will you answer?"

"I have not heard it."

"That sounded almost like caution."

"Try not to become attached to the method."

A quiet laugh escaped Ardis before she could contain it. Dorel's Household pressure loosened with the breath. The moment changed nothing legal. It changed how closely Salenne felt the loss when they moved apart.

They wrapped the seven work tallies in clean linen and left the originals in place after making charcoal rubbings. Removing foundation evidence before documenting custody would allow a later charge of fabrication. Ardis marked the niche order on the back of her map in her own hand. Salenne signed the time and method. Both women added thumbprints in ordinary blue archive ink so burial residue could not turn the record into an accidental vow.

At the aisle's far end, a sealed door showed no handle. Seven concentric cuts surrounded its center, each matched to one niche mark. The mason's square came first. Stable knot second.

Tev recoiled so hard that Salenne's breath stopped.

She braced against the wall. "He knows this end."

"What did he see?"

"Dark. Cloth over his head. He came through here after Nera died."

Fragments crowded in: boots dragging, rope at his wrists, a voice telling him to repeat the story correctly. Tev had not seen the door. He had felt its cool stone against his shoulder while men waited for someone to unlock it.

Ardis drew close but did not touch. "Close his senses."

"He is trying."

Grey mare, Salenne told him. Warm notch under her jaw. Feed bucket. Stay there.

The memory steadied his fear.

They examined the door without testing the cuts. The center carried a nearly erased inscription. Ardis angled the lamp while Salenne dusted the strokes with chalk.

Witness enters by name, work, death, and free hearing.

Below it, later hands had gouged away a date register. One line remained because mortar filled the cut before the erasure tool reached it.

TEV ORR. LOWER STABLE. SEVENTEENTH YEAR. FOURTEENTH DAY OF LOW TIDE.

Salenne's pulse thudded. "This gives his death date."

"His ledger only recorded transfer."

"He may not know the calendar name. He knew the day by work."

She opened Tev's voice under the license.

Cold tightened her throat. "Tev, what happened on the day river men covered your head?"

His words emerged in his own frightened cadence through her mouth. "Grey mare foaled before dawn. Low tide bell sounded wrong because the west rope broke. Kitchen sent plum rinds after noon."

Ardis's face changed at the last detail. "The fourteenth day. Palace preserving records list the plum delivery."

Salenne asked, "State your name, work, and death as you know them."

"I am Tev Orr. Lower-stable hand. Seventeen. They killed me after the grey mare foaled, on the fourteenth day of low tide."

The stable-knot ring filled with black moisture.

Stone moved.

A line opened around the sealed door, exhaling air cold enough to whiten their breath. Beyond lay no visible chamber, only darkness and the smell of old vellum.

Tev withdrew from Salenne's mouth. Her knees softened. Ardis caught her at the elbows and held only until she stood under her own balance.

Above them, the vigil bell began its final circuit. Rehearsal waited with the next day.

Salenne raised the lamp toward the new black seam but did not cross it.

The door had heard Tev's true death date. Whatever waited beyond had been built to hear him too.

Chapter 07 — Rehearsal for Possession

Ardis entered the wedding hall to the sound of fifty-three dead people correcting her walk.

Slower, Serrat urged through her knees.

Left shoulder back, said an aunt who had died before Ardis learned to stand.

Dorel offered no instruction. Her mother pressed close behind Ardis's tongue, wary of the shortened vows waiting beneath the central rain court.

Living courtiers filled three sides of the hall. Lyr wore white name-thread; Osteren wore campaign bronze. Masked vigil faces had given way to uncovered scrutiny. Every bench placement carried a prediction about peace: bridge councilors nearest the public exit, Osteren generals beside the grain-road mosaic, funeral officials where they could reach the seven witness stools if a token cracked.

Salenne stood at the reed-table in indigo, checking salt bowls and vellum edges. She did not look up when Ardis entered. Her left thumb moved down the rehearsal draft one line at a time.

That concentration steadied Ardis more than the Household's corrections did.

Edran waited across the hall in plain ceremonial white. Captain Tovin Sare stood behind his left shoulder, close enough to intervene without appearing to guard the prince from his own blood. Edran's right-leg hitch showed when he turned. He had declined the elevated groom's platform, forcing Maelin's attendants to lower Ardis's by one step so the heirs stood level.

Maelin occupied the witness end of the table. Her severe silver-brown coil held seven white pins. A pearl-handled knife rested beside her right hand for cutting rehearsal thread.

Ardis saw Salenne notice it.

The knife matched Tev's memory drawing down to the forked-rain mark on its blade.

Suspicion tightened inside her, but evidence remained incomplete. A Lord Remembrancer's knife passed through many clerks' hands. Missing fingers occurred in every war household. Ardis had promised herself she would not trade one official lie for a more satisfying unproved accusation.

Maelin raised her four-fingered hand. The hall quieted.

"This rehearsal uses shortened language and twelve-breath witness capacity," she announced. "No marriage will bind today. No Household will remain joined after the final salt bell. The exercise protects both heirs by identifying ceremonial error before the public wedding."

Applause moved through the Lyr benches. Osteren officers answered more

slowly.

Ardis looked at Salenne.

The advocate's face had gone still.

"What?" Ardis asked under the applause.

"The copy on my desk differs from the revision I certified this morning."

"Where?"

"Termination." Salenne kept her voice barely audible. "My version ends each lending at twelve breaths. This says witness capacity endures twelve breaths. Different subject."

The distinction cut cleanly. Witness power would expire. Household access might not.

"Stop the rehearsal."

"If I object without demonstrating the substitution, Maelin produces my initialed archive copy and calls this a scribal duplicate."

"Can you test it?"

"Not without activating a clause."

Maelin's gaze rested on them from the far end. "Crown Heir?"

The room expected compliance disguised as composure. Refusal would expose disagreement before Ardis could separate grain from marriage. Edran's famine ledger had reached two councilors overnight, not enough to guarantee convoy release. If the court broke now, General Sev could hold the grain by sundown.

Ardis hated that hunger could stand behind her and move her feet without magic.

"One clause," she told Salenne. "The narrowest. Stop at any bodily response."

"I advise against proceeding."

The advocate had authority to stop her own work, not the ceremony. Ardis could invoke Crown precedence and replace her with Maelin's clerk. Doing so would destroy the only protection in the room.

"I hear your advice," Ardis said. "Remain at the table and name the first breach."

Salenne's mouth tightened. "That is not consent to the draft."

"No. It is a decision about this room."

Neither woman pretended the decision free.

Maelin signaled the funeral clerks. Seven shell tokens entered the witness slots around the table. Four belonged to Valev dead: Dorel, Serrat, Mara of the South Sluice, and King Uven. Three belonged to Marr: General Hal, Grain Mother Sere, and Prince Orven. The arrangement appeared balanced by count. Blood did not count pressure that way. Hal could call every named Marr dead through Edran

once the splice opened.

Each clerk named a token's authority and the living descendant through whom it attended. Dorel came through Ardis by lawful blood but received no lending. Serrat pressed for her voice; Ardis refused him aloud. The refusals entered the rehearsal minutes as evidence that bodily choice remained intact before the clause.

Across the table, Edran denied General Hal speech and allowed Grain Mother Sere one breath of scent to verify the grain provision. Dry terrace wheat entered the hall through Edran's nose. Sere withdrew at the bell, a model of voluntary lending so controlled that several councilors murmured approval.

Ardis understood the performance. Show a harmless ancestral exchange, then let the audience assume every later pressure shared its terms. The court would remember Sere's wheat before it remembered Salenne's objections.

Attendants placed an unsharpened ceremonial sword at Ardis's left hip, against her usual side. Maelin explained that the heir would touch it during the border-defense line while Edran touched the grain measure. The matched objects represented security and relief, force and food held in balance.

"Why the left?" Ardis asked.

Clerk Peln answered. "The spouses face inward during the final vow. Left placement leaves the joined right hands visible to witnesses."

"We are not joining hands today."

"The rehearsal preserves final geometry."

Ardis moved the sword to her right hip. Peln moved it back after Maelin's smallest nod.

Salenne recorded the exchange in her margin. "Object placement directs which hand a clause will reach. This is not decorative."

"The sword carries no burial preparation," Maelin said.

"The body carrying it will."

Osteren's generals watched with sharpened attention. Hal pushed against Edran's jaw, eager for the symbol even before an active route existed. Tovin's hand hovered near the prince's sleeve without settling there.

The witnesses next heard the termination rubric. A funeral clerk held up a twelve-knot salt cord and promised to cut one knot per breath. At the last knot, all rehearsal witness capacity would cease. Salenne required the clerk to repeat that the rubric named witness power, not Household access. He looked to Maelin before acknowledging the distinction.

"Then amend the spoken rubric," Salenne said.

"The archive copy cannot be altered in the hall," Peln replied.

"Speech can clarify it."

Maelin's four-fingered hand settled beside the pearl knife. "The witnesses

require exact correspondence between page and voice.”

There lay the closed mechanism. They could not clarify the danger because the dangerous page governed what could be spoken. Ardis felt the court waiting for her to make procedure look trustworthy by surviving it.

Salenne inspected each token. “Exactly seven eligible witnesses. No cracks. No substituted names.”

A clerk poured burial black into the central groove. Charred reed, salt, and seven token shavings darkened the vellum’s border. Cold reached Ardis’s teeth from two paces away.

Tev shifted inside Salenne. Ardis recognized the moment through the advocate’s sudden bruised-knee stance.

Above the witness table, clear air condensed.

One drop fell.

Hollow Rain struck Maelin’s knife and rolled along the pearl handle.

Murmurs rose from the funeral benches.

“Foundation moisture responding to the active ink,” Maelin said. “Expected in an old hall.”

“No,” Salenne replied. “Hollow Rain indicates erased dead near a proposed binding.”

“A subject for tomorrow’s maintenance council.”

Aunt and advocate held each other’s gaze. Maelin looked neither surprised nor cruel. She looked determined to carry a dangerous process through because interruption had become, in her mind, the greater danger. Ardis understood that logic. She had lived inside it for twelve years.

The salt bell sounded once.

Ardis and Edran stepped to opposite edges of the table. They did not touch.

Salenne read the clause aloud before either heir repeated it. “For the duration established herein, each spouse shall receive shared Household guidance necessary to preserve the peace offices created by this Accord.”

“Spouse is inaccurate before marriage,” she said. “Duration established herein refers to no explicit termination attached to Household guidance. Necessary grants judgment to the dead witnesses. Preserve names no act.”

Clerk Peln stood behind Maelin with an archive copy. “The rehearsal rubric supplies ceremonial meaning.”

“Meaning that cannot survive being stated should not enter a body,” Salenne said.

Maelin touched one white pin at her coil. “Your objections are entered. The heirs may continue under the twelve-breath limitation.”

Edran looked at Ardis. "If either of us says stop, we stop."

"Agreed."

They spoke the shortened acceptance.

Burial black flashed wet across the vellum.

On the first breath, Ardis heard grain falling into a wooden measure.

On the second, an Osteren grandmother judged the width of her hips for childbirth and found the question irrelevant to current military use.

The third breath brought saddle leather, terrace dust, and a soldier's infected leg opened under a field knife. None belonged to Edran's present senses. The Bride Accord had made a path.

Ardis tried to inventory herself before the foreign memories multiplied. Her name remained Ardis Valev. She stood in House Rain's wedding hall on Day Five of rehearsal. Her right shoulder felt sound, her sword sat wrongly at her left hip, and Salenne watched from one pace beyond the table. Facts supplied edges. They did not prevent other lives from filling the middle.

A Marr child's memory placed her under a terrace loom. An officer overlaid it with the angle of Lyr's western gate. Grain Mother Sere smelled mildew in palace storage through Ardis's nose, though Sere had accepted no lending from her. The route ignored the permissions demonstrated moments earlier.

Dorel pressed Ardis's childhood name into her chest. Serrat answered with a formation command. Valev dead who had argued for decades now coordinated from fear, yet their defense consumed the same body it meant to protect. Ardis lost the distinction between an ancestor bracing her knee and an invader testing it.

She raised one finger toward Salenne, their agreed sign for bodily response. General Hal noticed through her eyes and bent the finger back into her palm.

The pain belonged to Ardis. The decision did not.

"Bodily response," Salenne said. "Stop."

Ardis tried to answer.

General Hal reached her first.

He came not as a voice but as training laid over bone. Her heels separated. Her breathing dropped into a soldier's marching rhythm. The hall became approaches and obstructions: east servant exit, north guard line, six Valev councilors within three strides, oath advocate nearest the active document.

Secure the binding, Hal ordered.

Ardis forced her tongue against her teeth. "Stop."

The word emerged softly.

Edran slammed both hands on his side of the table. "I revoke acceptance."

Nothing released.

Fourth breath.

More Marr dead entered. A logistics officer counted palace grain stores through Ardis's eyes. A cavalry prince tested her calf muscles. Someone dead of fever dragged heat across her skin. Their coordination did not require agreement on purpose. It required only that each pressure weaken a different point.

Her own Household surged to defend her. Serrat stiffened her spine against Hal. Mara seized her jaw from an Osteren jurist. Dorel wrapped grief around Ardis's heart as if grief could form armor.

Fifty-three Valev dead collided with two hundred eleven Marr names inside one living body.

Ardis's knees locked.

"Terminate the clause," Salenne demanded.

Maelin did not move from the witness end. "The witness capacity has eight breaths remaining."

"The Household route lacks that limit."

"Crown Heir Ardis retains speech. Her revocation will close it."

"I revoked," Ardis tried to say.

Hal held her tongue flat.

Fifth breath.

Edran came around the table. General Hal used Ardis's eyes to track him. Her body recognized the Osteren prince as both command channel and threat. Hal wanted contact, a stronger route through royal blood.

Tovin caught Edran before he reached her. "Not skin," the captain said. "They want you to complete the circuit."

Edran's face contorted. "Ardis, hear me. The bridge wagon. Four empty carts. You changed the welcoming order."

A specific living memory, offered as anchor.

It reached her but could not dislodge Hal. One spoken memory could stabilize a sevenfold host because consent created the connection. Overcrowning followed inherited routes already inside both heirs. Edran's words gave Ardis something living to push toward, not a magical release.

Sixth breath.

Hollow Rain thickened. Water hammered the roofed court, drenching courtiers and witness stools. Erased workers pressed near the active vow. Their confusion entered the mortar, making the floor tremble beneath Ardis's feet.

Salenne threw clean salt across the vellum. The black script hissed and remained dark.

"Salt fails because the clause names preservation," she said. "Any interruption

reads as a breach to prevent.”

Maelin turned to Peln. “Remove the public benches.”

At last, practical action. Guards began moving people toward the doors. Several courtiers refused to leave, either from concern or hunger for a story. Osteren officers reached for absent swords.

General Hal felt the movement and chose force.

Ardis’s left hand on the sword at her ceremonial belt did not feel like her hand. She normally drew right-handed. Hal crossed her body, locked the left fingers around the hilt, and pulled. The wrong angle twisted her right shoulder backward. Pain tore from collarbone to spine.

Steel came free.

Screams broke the remaining ceremony.

Hal turned the point toward Salenne.

The advocate stood over the draft, both hands spread, eyes on the blade. Tev’s fear widened her pupils. Still she did not step away.

“Ardis,” Salenne said. “Your right shoulder is injured. General Hal does not feel it. You do.”

Pain. Living, current, hers.

Ardis caught it and pulled.

The sword point dropped an inch.

Seventh breath.

Hal took her elbow. Serrat fought him, turning her wrist sideways. Other dead piled into the joint. The blade swung between Salenne and Maelin.

Edran struck his own chest with a closed fist. “Hal! Use me.”

A terrible offer. The dead general’s attention shifted. Pressure doubled inside Edran; his back snapped straight.

Tovin moved behind him and spoke into his ear. “Alth grain store. Cracked basin. You used sealing wax. I laughed until the floor guard complained.”

Edran’s shoulders shook once. “You complained louder.”

“Because you tried blue wax after red failed.”

Their living history interrupted Hal’s command long enough for Edran to grab the table edge rather than Ardis.

Eighth breath.

Salenne seized the rehearsal draft.

Maelin caught one corner. “Tearing an active marriage clause can strip memory from both heirs.”

“It is not a marriage yet.”

"The ink recognizes them as spouses."

"Because your substituted copy named them so."

For the first time, fear changed Maelin's face.

She released the corner.

Salenne did not tear across the binding script. She ripped the vellum lengthwise along the witness margin, separating the seven token shavings from the clause. The paper screamed through Ardis's teeth.

Witness power broke.

Household access did not.

Ninth breath had no legal meaning, but Ardis's body kept counting.

Without the seven witnesses, Hal lost the vow's enforcement and retained the open route. He drove Ardis toward Edran. Her injured shoulder failed. She stumbled, blade rising as her body fought itself.

Salenne kicked the table support. The reed-table folded between the heirs. Ardis fell across it, left wrist trapped beneath her. Hal tried to make her roll toward the sword.

"Get the knife," Salenne told a funeral clerk.

The clerk froze.

Salenne took Maelin's pearl-handled knife herself and cut the stitched pocket inside her coat. A tiny sealed shell dropped into her palm.

Ardis understood. "No."

The word escaped because Hal had moved to her arm.

Salenne heard. "I need a dead witness outside both lawful Households. Nera's token can challenge the route."

"You do not know the cost."

"I never know the exact cost."

Maelin stepped forward. "That shaving came from restricted royal remains. Hosting it constitutes theft from the Crown Household."

"Nera is absent from the Crown Household," Salenne said. "Your own roll establishes that."

The logic stopped Maelin for one heartbeat.

Ysra pushed through retreating courtiers from the funeral benches. She must have come as Salenne's emergency undertaker, unannounced to Ardis. Gold flashed in her mouth as she swore at the broken table.

"What did you prepare?" Ysra asked.

"Nera Valev. Identity and unresolved death testimony. Voice only. No hands, gait, breath, or sight without separate permission."

"Sight may be necessary to recognize the cord."

"Then one image under invitation."

"Duration?"

"Until testimony can reach competent hearers, with voice closure now if she presses."

"Emotional field?"

Salenne hesitated.

The delay frightened Ardis more than the blade in her hand.

"Taste," Salenne said. "Licensing feast. Plum-salt cake. A day I chose the work."

She opened the shell. Inside, a shaving from Nera's cut token rested in dry burial black. Ysra added one drop of water from her funeral vial and mixed it with the pearl knife's flat side before Maelin could reclaim the tool.

Hollow Rain struck the dish. The burial black opened.

Ardis fought Hal with everything still hers. Her right shoulder burned. Her left hand clenched the sword. Dorel pressed close, not commanding, trying to reach Nera through the smell of wet reed and royal bone.

Tenth breath, counted only by panic.

Salenne lifted the marked drop to her mouth.

Maelin said, "Advocate Vaud, by remembrance authority, I forbid unlawful hosting in the royal hall."

Ardis forced air past Hal. "Investigation release."

Salenne looked at her.

"You do not obey her," Ardis said. "Choose."

The choice remained cruel. It had become Salenne's.

She drank.

Black spread along the edges of her tongue. Her body bowed as if a cord had pulled her backward. Tev cried out inside her without taking voice. Another presence entered through cold, rage, and the memory of burial white scraping stone.

Nera.

Ardis knew her before she spoke. Not through face, which Salenne's features could not supply, but through the impatient lift of one shoulder. Nera had made that gesture whenever a tutor mistook obedience for comprehension.

"Sister," Ardis said.

Salenne's eyes opened.

Nera's voice came through them raw from twelve years without lawful speech. "You took long enough."

Salenne staggered inside the borrowed posture. For one instant her own cadence returned beneath Nera's. "The licensing feast remains. Ysra was there. Olan gave me the bone case. I remember every fact." Her tongue moved as if seeking a trace of flavor. Grief crossed her face with clinical certainty. "The plum-salt cake has no taste. It is gone."

Ysra marked the loss on her wrist tablet while keeping one hand ready near Salenne's jaw. "Second host competent. Memory paid. Salenne, name yourself."

"Salenne Vaud. Oath advocate. Two witnesses: Tev Orr and Nera Valev. My voice remains mine unless invited."

Nera waited through the self-check. Rage did not make her careless with the body carrying her. When Salenne nodded, the dead princess resumed the offered mouth.

The words shattered Dorel's restraint. Their mother surged through Ardis with a grief too large to coordinate. Valev resistance collapsed. Hal took the opening.

He wrenched Ardis upright and drove her left arm toward Edran.

Nera looked at the sword, the pearl-handled knife in Ysra's hand, and Maelin beside the witness stools.

Memory struck the hall through Salenne's invited sight.

Ardis saw what Nera had seen. Mourning cloth. A hand with four fingers. Red cord looped once, twice. Maelin's face close enough for Nera to smell plum soap. The pearl-handled knife cutting the hidden vellum from Nera's grip.

Salenne screamed as the image passed through her.

The sword fell from Ardis's left hand.

"Nera," Maelin said.

No title. No dismissal. Only a name shaped by terror and something that might once have been love.

Salenne turned toward her. Blood ran from one nostril. Black edged her tongue.

"Maelin held the cord," she said in Nera's voice.

Courtiers nearest the hall heard. Others caught only Maelin, cord, or a dead princess's cadence from an advocate's mouth. The accusation traveled badly and could not be recalled.

General Hal recoiled from Nera's unresolved truth. The Household route spasmed. Edran shouted and forced both hands flat on the broken table, denying Hal any weapon.

Ardis fell.

Her right shoulder struck stone. Pain flared white, then the hall disappeared.

She woke in Salenne's arms beneath a rain that had stopped falling.

The advocate sat on the wet floor with Ardis's head braced against her shoulder. One hand supported Ardis's neck; the other stayed open where Ardis could see it. There was nothing romantic in the hold, and too much tenderness for safety.

Ardis tasted blood. "Edran?"

"Alive," Salenne said in her own voice. "Tovin has him."

Inside that voice, two dead people argued too softly for Ardis to understand.

Her right shoulder refused to lift. The sword lay three strides away under salt cloth. Funeral workers contained the severed witness margin in seven separate bowls.

Beyond them, the court had divided according to what each person claimed to have heard. A bridge councilor repeated the phrase about the cord to a clerk who insisted Nera's name had never been spoken. Osteren officers argued that Lyr had introduced an unlawful dead princess to discredit House Marr. Two undertakers pointed at the cut termination line and demanded custody before Peln could replace it with the archive copy.

Edran sat against the folded reed-table while Tovin bound a scrape across his knuckles. His face looked emptied but his hands rested open on his own knees. When Hal pressed, one finger twitched toward Ardis and stopped.

"Do not let him touch me," Ardis said.

"He asked the same," Salenne replied. "The route is closed. Fear remembers faster than law."

Ysra knelt nearby with the host register. "Nera remains competent but agitated. Tev remains frightened and silent. Salenne can close both voices. Two hosted dead, two permanent losses."

Ardis looked up at the advocate holding her. "The cake?"

"I know it had plum salt. I know Olan complained it cost too much. Taste supplies nothing." Salenne's answer stayed exact despite the hurt under it. "Do not apologize. I chose after you returned the choice."

Ardis could not absolve herself so easily. The room, the deadline, her office, and the famine had narrowed Salenne's choice even after direct obedience ended. Naming the choice did not make the conditions clean.

"I will record the conditions too," Ardis said.

"Good."

That single word carried more regard than gratitude would have.

Maelin stood on the dais, wet white robes clinging to her missing finger. Guards had formed around her, not arresting her. Protecting the office.

"The rehearsal copy was sabotaged," she announced to the fractured court. "An unlawful host introduced a hostile royal dead and broke a peace instrument under active witness. No accusation spoken through that breach carries competence."

Salenne's arms tightened once around Ardis, then loosened before comfort could become restraint.

Across the hall, Maelin looked directly at them while clerks began writing her version of what everyone had seen.

Part II

Chapter 08 — Rain in the Queen's Chamber

Salenne woke with two dead people disagreeing about her eyelids.

Open them, Nera demanded.

Men outside, Tev warned.

The voices did not sound alike. Nera pressed behind Salenne's brow with the heat of a grievance held intact for twelve years. Tev stayed lower, a stable smell and a bruise in her right knee. Distinguishing them should have reassured her. Instead it proved neither had been a fever dream.

She kept her eyes closed and took inventory.

Salenne Vaud. Thirty-two. Oath advocate. House Rain Palace. Day after the shortened-vow rehearsal. Tev Orr first. Nera Valev second. She remembered Orsa singing at a copying table but heard no melody. She remembered her licensing feast and the plum-salt cake set before her, but the imagined bite supplied texture without taste.

Both absences remained clean-edged. No new permanent loss had appeared during unconsciousness.

Her body reported lesser damage: dried blood beneath her nose, bitten tongue, a headache above the left eye, and thirst severe enough to turn every swallow into work. Two hosts could bleed senses into one another without displacing another memory. That distinction mattered even when the headache disliked it.

Now, Nera said.

Salenne opened her eyes.

Blue tile covered the walls. An empty wardrobe stood opposite the bed, its doors warped inward. A silver rain chain descended from the ceiling and ended over dry stone, decorative plumbing disconnected after the room's cistern route changed. No royal portraits remained, but pale rectangles preserved their absence.

Queen Dorel's chamber.

Ardis had mentioned the sealed connection during their first private conversation. Someone had confined Salenne in the late queen's disused rooms rather than a nameproof cell. That choice allowed guards, locked doors, and respectable language such as recovery.

It also placed Nera inside her mother's room.

The dead princess went silent.

Outside, two guards traded duty phrases. One voice belonged to palace watch. The other used funeral-office forms. Maelin had divided custody so neither office

could be accused of holding Salenne alone.

A covered tray waited on a low table with thick tea, sour grain cake, river fish, and a clay cup. Salenne smelled plum salt on the cake before seeing its purple crystals. Her mouth watered. Memory supplied no answer to whether she liked it.

She took water first.

Tev borrowed the expectation of a dented stable cup, not her hand. Nera supplied knowledge that the clay cup came from Dorel's private kitchen and had once carried a painted crown. The blue glaze had been scraped away after the queen's death.

One sense at a time, Salenne told them. Label what comes from life, what comes through me now, and what you infer.

Nera's reply arrived edged with impatience. I know my mother's cup.

From life?

Yes.

Tev offered, I never came in here alive.

The boy had learned.

Salenne wrote their statements on the tray's paper liner with a burnt match. Guards had removed her document case, brushes, burial salt, and licensing token. They had left ordinary fire because respectable confinement required tea. Institutional mercy often overlooked the uses of char.

Nera pushed toward voice.

Salenne closed her throat. Request.

A pulse of royal anger met the rule. Nera had lived as someone whose questions opened doors. Death and erasure had not improved her patience.

May I speak?

For what purpose?

To ask why Ardis waited twelve years.

She is not here.

Then to ask why you let her stand on the other side of a room from my murderer.

Tev contracted at the memory of red cord.

Salenne pressed both feet to the tile. Voice denied until speaking will change something outside this room. You may share a memory if I invite it. You may not use my body to rehearse anger.

Convenient terms for the living.

Necessary terms for the body keeping you heard.

Nera withdrew far enough to let Salenne breathe without tasting burial cloth.

The outer lock turned.

Both ghosts reacted. Tev sent the remembered scrape of men's boots. Nera reached for Salenne's shoulders as if a dead princess could stand through her by right. The license tightened Salenne's jaw, warning that coordinated pressure would close voice access entirely.

A funeral guard entered with Ysra Pell behind him.

Relief hurt almost as much as the headache.

Ysra carried a physician's satchel and the expression of an undertaker invited to approve a death she intended to prevent. "Out."

"My orders require sight custody," the guard said.

"Then look through the door grille and enjoy the educational view of an advocate using a chamber pot."

He left.

Ysra barred the door with a chair, less elegant than the corpse scale and more available. She checked Salenne's pupils, tongue edges, pulse, and the nails of both hands. Her fingers were brisk until they reached Salenne's jaw.

"Two voices?"

"Distinct. Tev sensory, Nera verbal pressure. No shared limbs."

"Name losses."

"Orsa's singing sound. Plum-salt cake taste."

"Can you taste this?" Ysra touched salt to her lower lip.

"Yes."

"Good. The loss has not generalized."

Salenne looked at the scraped cup. "Who chose this room?"

"Maelin called it the only royal chamber with funeral containment and no active Household tokens. Ardis agreed before the shoulder healer gave her poppy."

"How badly hurt?"

"Strain. No break. She cannot raise the right arm cleanly."

Guilt tried to recruit Salenne's precision against her. She listed facts instead. Hal forced the wrong-handed draw. Ardis pulled against him. Breaking the witness margin closed enforcement, not access. Hosting Nera disrupted the route. None of those steps alone caused the injury; together they had formed the only available path.

"The court?"

"Maelin suspended you for unlawful royal hosting pending review. She says the original rehearsal copy vanished during sabotage. Peln has produced an archive

copy with the twelve-breath Household termination you said should have been there.”

“Of course he has.”

“Edran and Tovin are confined to the Osteren guest court. Ardis has not appeared publicly.”

Nera pressed a question against Salenne’s throat.

“Ask,” Salenne said.

Her mouth changed. The voice emerging remained Salenne’s instrument, but Nera supplied cadence. “Did Ardis hear me?”

Ysra did not startle. “She heard enough to drop the sword.”

“Did she believe me?”

“Ask her yourself if she comes.”

Nera released the voice voluntarily.

Ysra’s eyes softened by a degree. “Better manners than most royals.”

I heard that, Nera said inwardly.

“She heard that,” Salenne translated.

“Good.”

Ysra restored Salenne’s licensing token but kept the burial-black supplies. “Maelin’s guard checks the room each bell. I argued that taking your token increased possession risk. I did not win the ink.”

“You should leave before the next check.”

“I should do many things. My career reflects poor compliance.”

They touched foreheads, an old gesture from years when they had briefly mistaken compatible work for a compatible life. No longing followed it. Affection did, durable and uncomplicated.

Ysra left with the charred paper liner hidden in her sleeve.

Once the lock settled, Nera demanded speech again. Tev answered before Salenne could refuse, not with voice but with the remembered shock of a boot striking the service grille. The princess’s anger had pulled him back toward the murder.

You saw me, Nera said inwardly.

I tried quiet.

You saw who came after.

Cloth. Rope. River men.

Nera pushed for the shape of those men. Tev’s terror surged into Salenne’s shoulders, folding them forward. The license tightened across her jaw and warned

both ghosts away from muscle.

Stop, Salenne told them. A witness may ask. A witness may not force another dead person through death again.

He has details we need, Nera replied.

Then we obtain them under conditions he can survive inside me.

The words sounded absurdly bodily for two murdered people, which made them necessary. Ghosts retained temperament and old rank. Death did not turn a princess into a neutral examiner or a stableboy into evidence without fear.

Salenne set the scraped clay cup between her feet as if it marked a hearing space. She granted Tev ordinary smell and Nera ordinary sight through her current senses. Neither received voice. Then she named the room, day, and limits aloud so guards would hear only a host maintaining control.

Tev, did you see the person behind the cloth?

No face.

Did you hear the person?

A knot memory entered Salenne's fingers without moving them. Tev had counted feed ties to stay silent while adults argued. On the sixth knot, another voice used a clipped Osteren phrase. He had not understood its origin in life. Through Salenne's present knowledge, he could now recognize the accent, but that recognition counted as inference rather than witnessed fact.

Say exactly that, Salenne instructed.

Tev repeated it with care.

Nera's pressure eased. I frightened him.

Yes.

I did not mean to.

Intent does not return his body to him.

The rebuke could have provoked royal fury. Instead Nera offered Tev the memory of a palace kitchen boy slipping her extra pickled reed hearts after sword practice. She labeled it as her memory, not his. A clumsy apology, but freely given.

Tev answered with the grey mare's warm breath.

Salenne recorded the exchange in burnt strokes on the underside of the food tray. The writing would look like an inventory to a guard: one Osteren phrase heard, speaker unseen, recognition made after hosting, reliability limited. Precision gave frightened memory a shape that anger could not improve.

Two bells passed. Salenne ate half the cake to test the shape of loss. Sour grain registered. Plum crystals crunched. Salt stung the bitten place on her tongue. The

missing taste did not create blankness in the food; it created a fact she could no longer verify against memory.

At the third bell, the wardrobe opened.

Ardis stepped through holding her right arm close to her body. Dust marked her copper coat. The old door seal hung broken from a hinge behind her, and a narrow passage led toward the dressing rooms.

"You said it was sealed," Salenne said.

"It objected." Ardis pushed the wardrobe doors nearly closed. "I outranked it."

Her face showed a night without sleep. No name-thread decorated her braids. A sling would have served the shoulder, but she had refused one because public injury would feed Maelin's sabotage account.

Salenne rose too quickly. The room tilted. Ardis's good hand lifted, then stopped before contact.

"Sit," Ardis said.

"Do not make your first secret act an order."

"Please sit."

Salenne did.

Ardis chose the low stool rather than the chair beside the bed, placing herself below Salenne's eye line. The choice did not erase rank. It showed she knew rank occupied furniture too.

"Nera wants speech," Salenne said.

"I came for yours first."

Warmth moved under Salenne's ribs, entirely living.

Ardis continued, "Did I compel you to host her?"

"You returned my investigative choice after Maelin forbade it."

"That does not answer whether the conditions compelled you."

"No choice in that hall stood clean. Edran's dead occupied you. The draft survived salt. Maelin controlled the witnesses. I chose the only intervention I believed could break the route."

"And lost another memory."

"Yes."

"Would you choose it again?"

"Do not ask me to convert cost into virtue."

Ardis lowered her gaze. "Fair."

Silence held the unasked question from the aisle. Attraction had not disappeared during catastrophe. It had become less safe to ignore and more dangerous to indulge. Salenne noticed the careful way Ardis protected her shoulder, the pulse at

her throat, the dust on her hand from breaking a forbidden door. None of those observations granted permission.

"I need to say this plainly," Ardis said. "I want you safe. I also want your skill, your witness license, and what Nera can prove. Those wants conflict. My office makes even kindness useful to me."

Salenne's throat tightened for reasons neither ghost supplied. "Most powerful people stop after the first sentence."

"I was trained by one who stops before admitting the conflict."

"Maelin."

"Yes."

Nera struck against the inside of Salenne's mouth at the name. Tev retreated toward the grey-mare memory.

Ardis saw the change. "May I hear her?"

Salenne set terms. "Voice only. One answer at a time. Nera, you may speak to what you personally saw before death. No hands. No attempt to force Ardis's Household."

Agreed.

Permission opened.

Nera drew one careful breath through Salenne. "You identified my coat."

Ardis's face folded without losing control. "Yes."

"You did not identify my body."

"The veil covered your face. Maelin said water damage made viewing harmful to the Household."

"She used my white coat on someone prepared for the cistern record. I was already beneath the hall."

"Did Maelin kill you?"

Nera's rage sharpened Salenne's teeth. "She put the red cord around my throat. She said one dead sister cost less than another border war."

Ardis shut her eyes.

Salenne felt Dorel press from across the room through Ardis's body, a low maternal grief seeking contact with Nera. Nera leaned toward it. The two dead women could not cross without an active binding, and Salenne did not offer her body as a bridge.

"What were you holding?" Ardis asked.

"A copy from the foundation. The marriage design gave a larger Household power to direct the smaller through shared guidance. I found a line beneath it saying no one could answer for a witness by blood."

"The tallies," Salenne said in her own voice. "Ena Tar's niche."

Nera paused. "I knew the name Ena. Not the niche."

The knowledge boundary held.

Ardis asked, "Who else stood there?"

"Mourning cloth hid part of the aisle. Maelin faced me. Someone waited behind her."

"Pel'n?"

"I did not see a face."

"Lyr or Osteren?"

"I heard an Osteren court phrase. 'Continuity requires a clean line.' Maelin answered that the record would be clean."

Nera's memory buckled. Cord pressure crossed Salenne's throat. The license closed her jaw.

"Enough," Salenne said when she could speak again. "The body stops testimony."

Nera withdrew furious but compliant.

Ardis's left hand trembled on her knee. "I accepted the drowning because questioning it would have broken my succession and the peace talks that followed."

"You were sixteen."

"I was old enough to know I had not seen her face."

"Culpability has degrees. Maelin benefits if you flatten yours until it equals hers."

"You defend me."

"I distinguish acts."

"Would you distinguish them if you did not want me?"

There it stood, the question from the aisle without disguise.

Salenne could lie professionally. She could deny attraction and protect them both with false clarity. Nera waited inside her, a murdered sister whose body had been converted into policy. Tev waited too, a boy erased because adults valued convenient speech.

"I would make the same legal distinction," Salenne said. "I would not find the work as difficult."

Ardis looked at her. Desire moved between them without gesture.

"I want you too," she said. "That does not make acting on it permissible."

"No."

"You are assigned to my service. Your license, access, and physical safety

depend partly on my word.”

“Yes.”

“If you ask to be released from service, I will sign it today and secure your passage out of the palace. If you stop hosting, investigating, or drafting, I will not call it betrayal.”

The offer cost Ardis evidence and perhaps peace. That made it real. It did not complete the formal release because Salenne had not accepted, and Maelin still controlled her suspension.

Salenne examined what she wanted. Safety lay beyond the advocates’ gate, if Ardis could truly get her there. Tev and Nera would remain hosted until competent testimony or transfer. Maelin would retain the rehearsal record. Edran’s dead had already shown what the wedding could do.

“I choose to continue,” she said. “Not because you want me. Not because Nera is your sister. I continue until the bodily clause cannot be used again or I decide the cost has exceeded my consent.”

“To keep that choice real,” Ardis said, “I will send the question at every morning bell through Ysra: continue, pause, or end. You may answer with one word. No explanation required.”

“And if Maelin intercepts it?”

“I will also leave three blank slips in the wardrobe passage. Remove one each day you continue. Leave it in place if you pause. Tear it if you want extraction.”

Salenne considered the mechanism. It asked for renewed choice and made silence meaningful without allowing the Crown to interpret silence as consent. “Add a fourth state. Fold the slip if I need counsel before deciding.”

“Agreed.”

Ardis nodded. “Recorded.”

“By whom?”

“Two dead witnesses with regrettably strong opinions.”

Tev supplied a startled stable laugh. Nera called Ardis insolent with such affection that Salenne’s eyes stung.

A guard tried the outer latch.

Ardis rose. Pain crossed her face as the shoulder shifted. She moved toward the wardrobe, then Nera slammed one image into the boundary of Salenne’s sight.

Not without request. An urgent offer.

“What?” Ardis asked.

Salenne invited one image.

The Hollow Aisle returned in fragments. Maelin’s red cord. Pearl knife. Mourning cloth. Behind it, a hand gathering the stolen vellum after Nera fell.

A signet pressed into that hand's index finger: white stone cut with Osteren's campaign reed.

Nera had seen it only while dying and buried it beneath the cord's pain.

"There was an Osteren signet at the murder scene," Salenne said.

Ardis stopped with her good hand on the wardrobe door. The investigation had just crossed the border.

Chapter 09 — The Uncle Erased Twice

Edran cut the seal on his family's ossuary while four Osteren guards watched him commit the offense.

The bronze-ribbed wagon stood in House Rain's foreign court with its wheels locked and prayer vents shuttered. General Sev Marr had posted two soldiers at either end after the rehearsal, ostensibly to protect the royal dead from Lyr interference. The soldiers at the door wore Sev's white campaign cord around their left arms.

Tovin had selected the other pair himself.

"State your order again, Highness," the senior roll-keeper said.

"Open the traveling campaign archive from twelve years ago through ten years ago." Edran handed her his signet. "We are searching for any use of the campaign-reed seal tied to a Lyr palace entry."

The roll-keeper looked toward the guards with white cord. "General Sev limited access to active ancestor tokens."

"I am not active enough for him?"

"Your Highness knows what I mean."

He did. General Hal had screamed inside Edran for most of the night, sometimes in commands, sometimes in the word traitor repeated against his molars. The old general could not open a wagon or burn a roll. A living officer could call such acts protection and supply hands.

Tovin closed the courtyard gate. "No one enters or leaves without the prince's order. If any ancestor borrows a mouth, name the lending. Unnamed speech ends the search."

One white-cord guard touched his funeral-thread collar as if reassured by its weight. The other measured distance to the wagon brazier.

Edran noticed and moved the brazier outside.

The roll-keeper used three keys: travel office, living heir, and funeral custody. No Crown mark governed an Osteren ossuary on foreign ground. When the final lock turned, two hundred eleven dead pressed forward in Edran's blood.

Inside, bronze ribs divided the wagon into ancestry bays. Tokens belonging to rulers occupied no higher shelf than millers or quartermasters, but red cord marked those authorized for military lending. Every token faced inward so travel vibration could not point a dead person toward the road and create false direction memory in descendants.

Tovin checked each shutter before allowing the lamps uncovered. Thin salt channels ran beneath the drawers. One had been swept recently, its pale line broken by heel marks despite General Sev's claim that no archive staff had

entered since the border crossing.

"Three people at least," Tovin said. "One narrow boot, one campaign heel, one person dragged the right foot."

"My hitch?" Edran asked.

"Wrong side. This one drags left."

The roll-keeper consulted her night slate. It recorded no visitor. Her fear seemed genuine, which did not prove innocence but moved her away from the simplest explanation.

Edran assigned Tovin's soldiers to copy every broken salt line before anyone stepped farther. He also required the roll-keeper to count the token bundles aloud. Two hundred eleven legal names answered the manifest. The number remained correct while custody beneath it had changed.

"Someone could alter a roll without removing a token," the roll-keeper said. "The Household would still carry the dead."

"Unless the altered name never entered the legal bundle," Edran replied.

His uncle's absence pressed again, shaped exactly like a drawer no one had counted because the inventory said it did not exist.

He denied them sight.

Darkness did not silence a Household. Hal knew the wagon's old arrangement. Diplomats remembered which drawers held their own treaties. Several dead offered help with the sincere confidence of people whose interests Edran had reason to doubt.

"I lend no sense, speech, hand, or posture," he said. "Any pressure beyond ordinary Household presence will be recorded as interference."

The words quieted some. Hal struck pain into Edran's right leg.

Tovin placed the campaign ledger on a portable desk. "Start eleven years ago."

"Why not twelve?" asked the roll-keeper.

"Because the signet appeared at Nera's murder twelve years ago," Edran said. "Ilyan Marr died the following year after investigating Lyr contacts."

His uncle's name changed the pressure inside him. Not a voice. An absence around which other dead recoiled.

Ilyan had taught Edran to read convoy promises by looking at the roads omitted from them. He had also taught him to cheat at river tiles and then expressed wounded surprise when his nephew learned too well. Official history reduced him to a diplomat who killed himself after compromising border talks.

No Ilyan voice had entered Edran's Household after the funeral.

The first campaign roll covered Osteren officers authorized to use white stone signets cut with the campaign reed. Twenty-seven names appeared. Six traveled to Lyr during the year of Nera's death. Three had since died. Two served General

Sev. One line had been scraped until the reed paper thinned.

The roll-keeper applied blue ash. Pressure marks rose.

Diplomatic Observer Ilyan Marr. Temporary continuity authority.

Tovin read it twice. "A diplomat carried a military signet?"

"To protect negotiations," said a white-cord guard.

"From whom?"

The guard's jaw tightened. A borrowed phrase entered his accent. "Continuity requires a clean line."

Nera had heard those words behind the mourning cloth.

Edran stepped between the guard and the wagon. "Name the speaker."

The man swallowed. "General Hal Marr, through lawful campaign lending."

"Release him."

"I did not grant him my mouth."

The admission frightened the guard more than any rebuke could.

Tovin removed the man's sword and ordered his own soldiers to escort both white-cord guards to opposite corners. "No arrest yet. No funeral thread touched. Keep them apart."

General Hal surged inside Edran. Protect the line. Close the wagon.

Edran gripped the desk until his knuckles whitened. "Continue."

The roll-keeper turned to the death entries.

Ilyan Marr, age forty-two, had supposedly hanged himself from an ossuary hitch in a border lodging. The report used one hand throughout, as Nera's drowning ledger had. No undertaker countersigned. No knot drawing showed how a man alone tied the cord above his own reach. The body had been wrapped in white campaign cord instead of ordinary funeral linen.

"Who certified?" Edran asked.

The signature space carried a smear.

Blue ash revealed the forked mark of Campaign Continuity, an office answerable then to three hardliner generals. The same office had issued temporary signets during the Lyr mission.

Tovin lifted the page toward the vent light. "There is a second leaf under it."

Two sheets had been glued together with bone paste. Steam would damage both. The roll-keeper inserted a flexible shell blade between fibers and worked by touch. A hidden entry separated slowly from the suicide report.

Subject intercepted following unauthorized contact with Lyr remembrance authority.

Evidence packet recovered.

Public death form: self-harm under diplomatic disgrace.

Household entry denied for continuity protection.

The final order carried three signet impressions. Campaign reed. A Lyr forked-rain mark. A third had been cut out.

Edran's stomach turned cold.

They tested the inks before trusting the hidden leaf. The suicide report used ordinary campaign black mixed eleven years ago with terrace ash. The concealed order used the same batch along its first three lines. No later forger had inserted the confession. Its final line carried darker repair ink added months afterward, when Household entry had been denied.

Tovin laid the recovered white cord beside the page. Seven black knots divided it. Military funeral custom used five: command, unit, campaign, death, and release. The extra two represented custody correction and name suppression, procedures omitted from public law but familiar to officers handling disgraced dead.

"I saw seven-knot cord after Silt Gate," Tovin said. "They used it on deserters whose descendants still served. Officers said suppression protected the family from divided command."

"Did it?"

"It protected the officers from testimony."

The roll-keeper cut a fiber under neutral witness and wet it with salt. A white campaign cord made during Ilyan's death year should have held terrace flax and chalk. This fiber also contained black reed pulp from Lyr. The cord had been prepared jointly or repaired with material carried across the border.

Edran marked the evidence sequence himself: false public death, hidden interception order, seven-knot suppression cord, Lyr fiber, dual office seals. Ilyan's ghost might testify, but the objects could survive cross-examination without asking the dead to supply every truth.

"He was murdered, called a suicide, and denied his Household," Tovin said. "Then someone scraped even his campaign appointment."

"Twice erased," the roll-keeper whispered. "Death falsified first. Name removed after."

Inside Edran, the absence moved.

A soft sensation touched his left palm: river tiles, one flat piece hidden under Ilyan's wrist. Not Hal. Not a general. The memory carried amusement and fear together.

"Uncle?" Edran said.

The wagon answered with a knock from its deepest drawer.

The white-cord guard at the far corner lunged toward the brazier outside. Tovin's soldier caught him. At the other corner, his companion tore the campaign

thread from his sleeve and tried to put it into his mouth.

“Do not let him swallow the cord,” Edran ordered.

White campaign cord could carry a lawful officer’s lending permission. Burned or swallowed with a token shaving, it could also direct the named ancestor pressure toward a descendant’s body. The guard bit down. Tovin crossed the court in three strides, pinched the man’s jaw at the hinge, and pulled the wet cord free.

Hal drove Edran’s right hand toward the hidden roll.

Edran caught that wrist with his left. Pain shot through both forearms as living muscle opposed inherited command.

Burn it, Hal said through his teeth without permission.

Tovin looked over. “Edran.”

“Do not come close. Hold the guards.”

Hal wanted Tovin within reach. The old general had learned exactly which living body Edran would protect before himself.

The roll-keeper backed away from the desk. “Highness, close the archive. Unlawful pressure contaminates custody.”

“If we close it, Ilyan remains inside.”

“His token may not be competent.”

“Find it.”

She opened the deep drawer.

Tokens lay in fitted rows, each bone or shell slip wrapped in name-thread. One empty channel carried Ilyan’s archive number. Beneath its cloth pad, Tovin found a shallow false bottom. He lifted it with the tip of a seal knife.

A broken bone token rested below, wrapped in the same white cord used on Ilyan’s body.

The name had been scraped away. Two letters survived near the hole: ILY.

Burial residue filled the wagon. Edran smelled a border lodging, lamp oil, damp plaster, and fear hidden beneath diplomatic incense. Ilyan knocked again through the token, not at the drawer but against Edran’s palm memory.

General Hal forced Edran one step toward it.

“Hal wants contact,” he said.

“Then we do not give him blood,” Tovin replied.

The captain wrapped Edran’s right hand in plain linen, covering skin and signet. Together they lifted the token by its cloth pad. No bloodline contact completed. Ilyan remained attached to bone rather than entering the Household route.

“We need a neutral host,” the roll-keeper said.

Edran thought of Salenne confined under Maelin’s funeral guard. “Send for Ysra

Pell.”

“We are under restricted movement.”

“Tell the palace there is unstable royal burial residue in a foreign ossuary and only its suspended advocate has direct witness license. They may prefer scandal to cooperation. They will not prefer an uncontrolled dead diplomat.”

Maelin sent Salenne.

She arrived an hour later between a palace guard and Ysra, pale from two hosts but upright. A blue tile dust streak marked one sleeve. Ardis had found a way to pass the signet information; Edran suspected the same hidden route had helped secure this escort.

Salenne stopped outside the wagon. “State what you found without conclusion.”

Tovin gave the record: campaign authority, false suicide, denied Household, hidden token, white cord, two office seals. Edran added Hal’s uninvited command and Ilyan’s river-tile memory.

Nera stirred visibly inside Salenne at the mention of the campaign phrase. Tev retreated.

“Can you transfer him?” Edran asked.

“Hosting will not transfer him from your blood. He never entered it. I can move his attachment from token to licensed witness custody.”

“Cost?”

“One memory. Permanent. Third host increases sensory bleed but should not damage self-recognition yet.”

“Should not?”

“Bodies dislike guarantees drafted by people outside them.”

She examined the token and the cord. Ysra cut away one unstained fiber for evidence, then scraped a shaving from the surviving ILY edge. Burial black took shape in a shell dish.

Salenne named conditions: Ilyan Marr, identity and testimony concerning his death, Nera’s evidence packet, and joint Lyr-Osteren concealment. Voice only. One invited image at a time. Ordinary senses allowed; body denied. Duration until competent public hearing or voluntary transfer under funeral law.

“What memory field?” Ysra asked.

Salenne looked toward the open courtyard as if distance could answer. “Home routes. Places of safety and departure.”

Edran wanted to stop her. Ilyan knocked from the token. Hal pressed Edran’s tongue toward command.

He refused both impulse and ancestor. “Your choice, Advocate.”

“I know.”

She drank the marked drop.

The response came without spectacle. Salenne's left foot turned as if seeking a familiar hallway. Her fingers shaped a child's door latch in empty air. Then her body steadied and a man's diplomatic reserve entered her expression.

"Ilyan Marr," she said. "State your name."

Her voice changed. "Ilyan Marr. Envoy by river office. Uncle to the stubborn young man trying not to look like me."

Edran laughed once, helplessly. Tovin's hand found the back of his neck.

Ysra continued the competence test. Ilyan named his age, his last lawful office, and the river-tile trick he had taught Edran. He identified the hidden page without being shown its recovered text.

"What memory paid?" Ysra asked Salenne when Ilyan released voice.

Salenne closed her eyes. "I remember my childhood house had a green door. I remember my bed stood in the rear room. I cannot travel from one to the other. Every turn has gone."

"Can you reconstruct it from fact?"

"I can draw facts someone tells me. I cannot remember the route through my childhood house from door to bed."

Ysra recorded the third permanent loss.

Ilyan requested speech once more.

"I sent Maelin Valev copies of the first marriage design and the names of Osteren officers who supplied a campaign signet," he said through Salenne. "I believed she opposed them. She arranged a meeting in Lyr, then disclosed my return route to Campaign Continuity. Osteren killed me. Her office certified the clean record. Both courts kept what my death protected: secret control of a future spouse and a border crisis useful to generals."

Edran asked him to separate what he had witnessed from what he inferred.

Ilyan named three meetings. At the first, two Osteren continuity officers showed him a proposed marriage appendix allowing one Household to coordinate "defensive guidance" through the other heir. At the second, Nera's unsigned warning reached him through a Black Reed funeral merchant. At the third, Maelin met him in a Lyr toll office and accepted his copies.

"She had not yet seen Nera's body?" Edran asked.

"Nera had been dead a year. Maelin told me grief had made her reckless and the Crown could not survive another disputed succession."

The calm in those remembered words made Maelin more frightening than rage would have. She had not mistaken the danger. She had ranked it beneath continuity.

"What did she promise you?" Tovin asked.

"A joint inquiry after I returned to Osteren and identified which generals still held the design. She told me to take the north lodging road because the river route had watchers. Campaign officers waited at the north lodging."

"So she sent you into them."

"She disclosed my route. Whether she selected my method of death, I cannot testify."

Ilyan remembered waking with his wrists tied in white cord. An officer read a statement blaming him for compromised negotiations and offered a choice: sign it, enter the Household under disgrace, and let his descendants carry the shame; refuse, and vanish from the roll. Ilyan refused because either form would validate the hidden marriage design. They hanged him anyway and used suicide to explain the cord mark.

"Did the border war begin because of your death?" Edran asked.

"Not alone. Raids, failed harvests, ambitious officers, and two courts needing a useful enemy built the war. Do not make me important enough to excuse everyone else."

Even dead, his uncle refused the comfort of a single cause.

"Did Maelin order your death?" Edran asked.

"I did not hear such an order. She knew disclosure would expose me. Do not improve my evidence because you hate its shape."

The answer sounded like the uncle who taught omissions.

Edran looked at the campaign roll, the Lyr seal, and the guards who had tried to destroy both. Nera's murder had not belonged to one court while the other merely watched. Living offices on both sides had made advantage from two erased dead.

He ordered Tovin to seal every leaf in neutral funeral custody and placed his own signet over the wagon door.

The war had been fed by a conspiracy both courts could denounce only by confessing how they had profited from it.

Chapter 10 — Seven Witnesses, None Royal

Ysra closed the funeral cloth over Salenne's face before the palace guard reached the stair.

"Do not improve the performance by dying," she said through the linen. "I have only licensed you for transport."

Beneath the cloth, Salenne tasted burial black along the edges of her tongue. Three dead crowded her breath. Tev feared every bootfall. Nera pushed toward the guard with a fury that tightened Salenne's right hand. Ilyan held himself apart, a cold pressure behind her eyes, as if diplomacy still required him to pretend he occupied no room at all.

The bier dipped when two mortuary porters lifted it. Neither had been told who lay under the cloth. Funeral law protected their ignorance: a licensed undertaker could remove a contaminated host from any royal residence before the unclaimed dead spoiled the lawful Household rolls. Ysra had written contaminated in letters broad enough to insult everyone who read them.

At the landing, a guard captain stopped the bier. "Lady Maelin ordered the advocate confined."

"Lord Remembrancer Maelin ordered a living woman confined," Ysra replied. "My warrant concerns three unclaimed dead, one of whom belongs to Osteren's diplomatic roll. You may put your hand under this cloth if you wish to explain the touching to Prince Edran."

No hand came near Salenne. The captain demanded the license instead. Paper clicked as Ysra unfolded it; a shell token tapped against the reed vellum. Salenne counted six breaths, then seven. On the eighth, the bier moved.

Cold air reached her through the linen when the service gate opened. Tev recognized horse sweat and shrank so hard that Salenne's knees jerked against the carrying poles. One porter swore. Nera tried to lend Salenne the posture of a royal corpse, chin high even while horizontal. Ilyan supplied an Osteren breathing exercise meant for men awaiting an arrow volley.

Salenne refused all three. She counted the porter's steps and kept her body her own.

They crossed two wards before Ysra allowed her to sit up in the covered funeral cart. Evening had sunk over the river. Mortuary Exchange lamps made narrow gold strokes in the damp, each one hooded toward the water so passing barges would not mistake them for toll signals.

"You bribed the porters," Salenne said.

Ysra handed her a cup of thick tea. "I paid licensed professionals for lawful work. Bribery costs less."

The tea carried reed smoke, salt, and no sweetness. Salenne knew her mother had once sung over copying tables, but the sound had vanished when Tev entered her. She knew a plum-salt cake had marked her licensing feast, but Nera occupied the place where its taste had lived. She could name every room in her childhood house from Olan's old tax inventory; after taking Ilyan under her license, she could not walk from its door to the bed where she had slept.

Facts remained. Lived routes had gone dark.

Ysra watched her finish the cup. "Inventory."

"Three ghosts. Three losses. No confusion about my own name. Nera keeps reaching for my right hand. Tev recoils from horses and red fiber. Ilyan knows someone followed his evidence through both courts, but he cannot identify the living carrier."

"Your body?"

"Tongue stained. Two hours without a nosebleed. Sleep remains theoretical."

From behind her teeth, Nera pressed a bitter objection to the word ghost. Salenne touched two fingers to her jaw until the pressure eased. "And Her Highness objects to imprecise titles while hiding in an advocate's molars."

Ysra's gold tooth flashed. "Healthier than agreement."

Ahead, the public counters of the Mortuary Exchange stood shuttered. Bone dust whitened the paving around the token cutters' doors. A funeral singer carried folded stools indoors, while three fishwives waited at the emergency counter with a name wrapped in oilcloth between them. Nothing about death suspended trade. Families still needed tokens before burial tide, bargemen needed licenses to carry ashes upriver, and witnesses needed to be paid before memories softened into convenient shapes.

The cart passed the main entrance and turned beneath the drying lofts. Ysra knocked on a red-painted drainpipe: twice with her knuckle, once with her shell ring, then twice again. A square of darkness opened between hanging reed mats.

Night Mortuary Market admitted no one by title. At the threshold, a narrow woman in a butcher's apron held out a clay dish.

"Thread, token, or remembered name," she said.

Ysra cut one gold client-thread from her sleeve. Salenne put down a sliver of pearl from Nera's sealed ledger. The woman looked at the pearl, then at the black along Salenne's tongue.

"Hosts pay twice."

"The dead have already collected," Salenne said.

"Then perhaps they can bargain."

Tev surfaced at the smell of lamp fat. His memory put a stable corridor over the market passage: damp straw, a service grille, red cord biting into a woman's

throat. Salenne's stomach folded. She gripped the threshold beam until the present returned.

A small voice escaped her. "I remember knots."

The gatekeeper's expression changed. Not pity. Recognition. She pushed the dish aside and let them enter.

Beneath the lofts, traders had made aisles from funeral screens. No stall displayed a full name. Initials appeared on shell chips; dates without years marked folded roll copies; lengths of cut name-thread lay beneath smoked glass. The trade existed because lawful archives forgot on command. It also fed blackmailers, grieving families, inheritance thieves, and the occasional advocate willing to ask why a servant vanished from six consecutive copies.

Ysra guided Salenne past a broker selling voice descriptions. "Do not drink anything, agree to any future tense, or answer a question phrased as an inheritance."

"I helped draft the market's license."

"You helped draft the version they show inspectors."

At a screen stitched with white campaign cord, Ilyan tightened against Salenne's skull. One of the knots matched the cord found in his twice-erased campaign roll. He gave no words, only the remembered sensation of sealing a packet while blood from a split cuticle dried under his thumbnail.

Salenne stopped. "Who keeps prewar witness customs?"

A broker behind the screen lifted his chin. He wore a plain coat with every button removed, denying observers any easy count of his Household. "Customs cost more than names. A name can hurt one family. A custom can embarrass a court."

"Both courts have survived embarrassment."

"Not according to their funeral rolls."

Ysra placed a copyist's blade on the counter. Orsa's old blade. The bone handle had worn smooth where a thumb once rested, though Salenne could no longer summon the voice that might have accompanied its work.

The broker did not touch it. "Whose?"

"Orsa Vaud's."

Something moved in the man's face. He drew the screen shut behind them, enclosing a table, three low stools, and a copper lamp. From a floor box he removed scraps of black reed paper packed between salt boards.

"Your mother bought six shadows," he said. "Not names. The gaps around names. She believed a pattern might survive after a roll had been scraped."

Salenne kept both hands flat. "Did she leave them here?"

"She left debts. Olan Vaud settled some."

At her father's name, the three hosted dead reacted differently. Tev fled toward the base of her spine. Nera pushed forward, eager for a culprit. Ilyan went still with the trained caution of someone hearing a door latch during negotiation.

Ysra asked, "What did Olan buy?"

"Silence, mostly." The broker unfolded the scraps. "And this."

Seven crescent marks formed a broken circle across six pieces of paper. Each crescent carried a tool sign rather than a crest: cup, horse knot, campaign seal, copy knife, plumb line, rain hook, empty palm. Salenne recognized the niche diagram from the Hollow Aisle, but its palace rubbing had shown only the crescents. Someone had scraped away the tool signs.

Her breath shortened. Tev pulled toward the horse knot. Nera claimed the rain hook with a sensation of wet hair and rage. Ilyan pressed against the campaign seal.

"These are witness stations," Salenne said.

"Older than the Bride Accord," said the broker. "Funeral custom from the first river settlement. Seven dead heard any vow that could starve a ward or send people across a border. The dead came from the work affected by it."

"Not from the ruling Houses."

"Especially not from them."

A shout rose somewhere beyond the screen. Market lamps dimmed one after another, not extinguished but covered. Ysra shifted her stool so her shoulder blocked the entrance.

Salenne bent closer to the scraps. Beside each tool sign ran a narrow line of copy script. Age and damp had eaten half the strokes. She set Orsa's blade across two fragments to hold them flat, then read what remained.

"Named without descent," she murmured. "Heard without ownership. Released after true account."

The broker supplied the missing custom. "Seven freely named dead."

Nera recoiled from the phrase. Royal training had taught her that dead without descent meant dead without standing. Ilyan's memory answered with a diplomatic hall where every witness had worn Marr thread and every concession had therefore arrived preapproved. Tev offered only the grille: a servant could see a murder and still vanish from law.

"The original system prevented one bloodline from defining truth," Salenne said.

"It tried."

"Who removed it?"

"People whose names remained on the rolls."

Boots sounded on the loft stair. This time Tev distinguished six people, leather soles kept soft for palace corridors. Ysra pinched out the copper lamp.

Darkness strengthened the dead. Salenne felt Nera's fingers overlay hers, longer and trained for a sword grip. Ilyan lent her the location of an unseen doorway by the draft against her cheek. Neither had permission. She curled her hands against her coat and whispered, "You may speak to me. You may not move me."

Tev surprised them all by answering through her tongue. "Under the table."

A seam divided the floorboards beneath the broker's boots. He lifted the hatch, gathered the scraps, and hesitated over Orsa's blade.

"Keep it," Salenne said.

"No. Debt should return to the blood that paid it." He put the blade into her palm and urged them down.

The crawlspace smelled of reed mold and river mud. Above, men entered the screened stall. Clerk Peln's careful voice asked whether an unlawful host had tried to purchase erased royal names.

Salenne lay with her cheek against a salt board. The phrase mattered. Peln had not asked about customs, diagrams, or witnesses. He expected her to chase names because royal law trained every investigator to mistake genealogy for truth.

Across from her, Ysra silently opened one hand: wait.

Peln promised license reviews, arrests, and confiscation. The broker replied with professional offense so convincing Salenne almost believed him. While they listened, she traced the niche diagram from memory onto the dusty salt board. Seven marks. Three ghosts already carried. Four missing. None required royal blood. The public wedding could not lawfully bind through a witness roll selected by either dynasty, and any vow relying on those rolls repeated the original fraud.

One of Peln's men overturned the table. Orsa's blade would have struck the floor if the broker had kept it. Salenne closed her fingers around its worn handle.

A sentence surfaced in Nera's memory, spoken years before in another voice. Not Maelin's. Not anyone Nera could see. A copyist behind a wall had whispered it while scratching a royal crest from old vellum: A vow belongs to the living.

The words did not enforce themselves. They opened no door and commanded no hand. That absence gave them force.

When the searchers moved to the next stall, the broker lifted the hatch. "River exit. Your license will not survive another inspection."

"Neither will this market if the wedding binds," Salenne said. "I need the names attached to the remaining signs."

His mouth hardened. "Names are how courts make ownership."

"Then give me lives. Cupbearer, copyist, mason, whoever stood outside the Houses. I will ask whether they consent to be named."

For a long moment he studied the stained edges of her mouth. Then he tore one

clean strip from the back of Orsa's old packet and wrote three locations in market cipher. The cup sign pointed toward palace service rolls. The copy knife led to six falsified funerals. The plumb line descended beneath the rain courts. Against the empty palm, he wrote only: the one who refused to carry.

Ysra read over Salenne's shoulder. "Four dead before an emergency wedding. Modest week."

"Three living days if Maelin accelerates."

Outside, a river barge knocked against its chain. Palace searchers moved through the market above them. Salenne tucked the cipher inside her coat, beside the cut of her license and the knife her mother had once held.

She had no taste of her licensing feast, no path through her childhood rooms, no sound for Orsa's singing. The absences offered no nobility. Four more witnesses could take memories she still needed to recognize the life she meant to protect.

Salenne climbed into the river passage anyway. Before the emergency wedding, she would find all seven.

Chapter 11 — What the Bride Promised the City

Ardis ordered the Rain Council doors opened before Maelin could seat the petitioners behind a screen.

The ushers froze with both hands on the bronze leaves. Beyond them, forty people waited in the east passage, damp from river spray and angry enough to ignore the palace rule against speaking above cistern tone. Fish porters stood beside grain factors. Two women from South Cistern carried a rolled floor plan between them. A boy in a tax clerk's gray coat held a basket filled with burned ration tokens.

"Highness," the senior usher said, "public petitions follow royal business."

"Today they constitute royal business. Open the doors."

Across the council chamber, Maelin adjusted no part of her severe white coat. She never needed movement to express displeasure. The missing finger on her right hand lay hidden beneath her left as fifty-three Valev dead pressed at the inside of Ardis's teeth, each offering a different precedent for keeping hungry people outside.

Her grandfather urged delay. A great-aunt recommended soldiers. Queen Dorel's low, familiar pressure carried neither instruction nor comfort, only the remembered posture of sitting straight while a room objected.

Ardis kept her hands on the table. "Now."

Bronze scraped stone. Public noise entered with the petitioners, along with the smell of wet rope, fish oil, and people who had been made to wait since before the second cistern bell.

Councilor Vey Rusk arrived among them rather than from his assigned chair. His dock-ward coat had green tax-thread at one cuff and a fresh tear at the other. He bowed only after helping an old porter across the threshold.

"Councilor," Maelin said. "You have mistaken your entrance."

"I used the one my ward could use." Vey took his place at the lower curve of the reed-table. "Convenience, Remembrancer."

Sixteen council seats surrounded the central cistern throat. Maelin had placed Osteren's sealed grain schedule before Ardis's chair. Red cord tied the packet shut. Not murder cord, Ardis told her body. Ordinary record cord. Even so, Nera's absence pulled at the room like a missing stair.

No Salenne stood at the advocate's desk. The empty place made Ardis want to look toward every service door. Yesterday she had sent two loyal guards to fail conspicuously at finding an escaped funeral cart. That small treason had bought Salenne hours, perhaps less.

Maelin rose. "The matter before us concerns immediate execution of the Bride

Accord. Osteren's prince has brought grain commitments for seven Black Reed villages and emergency allotments for Lyr. Delay places every sack at risk."

A murmur moved through the petitioners.

Ardis cut the grain packet's cord. Inside, the figures had been written by an Osteren quartermaster and countersigned by Edran. She recognized his blunt annotations: axle loads, spoiled sacks, bridge capacity, days until village stores failed. Maelin had folded a second paper around the schedule. This page, written in Peln Avar's precise hand, made release of the first convoy contingent on the completed marriage vow.

Edran had not signed it.

"Whose condition appears on the outer sheet?" Ardis asked.

"Joint negotiators prepared it." Maelin's calm spread over the chamber. "A grain road requires peace. Peace requires surety. A royal Household offers the only surety both armies recognize."

Within Ardis, an ancestor who had starved a rebellious ward approved so strongly that her molars hurt.

She pushed the outer page aside. "Prince Edran's hand appears nowhere on this condition."

"His need appears in every figure."

Maelin spoke without cruelty. That made her leverage harder to resist. Seven villages stood near the end of stored grain. Lyr's dock wards had lost two barges during the last border closure. If fighting resumed, bodies would pay before any councilor did. Ardis could see the arithmetic, and Maelin knew it.

The boy with the basket stepped past an usher. "We brought arithmetic."

His voice broke on the last syllable. Ardis gestured him forward.

He emptied the basket onto the table. Charred clay ration tokens clicked around the grain schedule. Each carried a household number and a South Cistern ward mark.

"My mother fired those," he said. "Tax officers burned them when our ward missed the bridge levy. We cannot draw reserve grain without valid tokens, and we cannot pay a levy on grain that has not crossed."

A councilor from the upper rain courts sniffed. "This hearing concerns foreign peace, not municipal arrears."

"Hungry people live in municipalities," Vey said.

Ardis asked the boy his name, his office, and whether he spoke under anyone's instruction. Maelin watched each question with faint approval. Proper inquiry pleased her even when it threatened her design.

"Daro Pell," he said. "Junior tally clerk. The cistern keepers sent me. No one instructed the words."

“Record his tokens as evidence,” Ardis told the council scribe. “Restore provisional ration standing to every household number represented until the levy dispute receives hearing.”

The upper-court councilor protested the expense. Two dead magistrates pushed legal cautions through Ardis’s jaw. She acknowledged both and assigned the cost to palace wedding stores. That silenced half the table and angered the kitchens, whose authority mattered more than several council seats.

Next came the two women with the floor plan. They spread it over the table, covering Peln’s unsigned condition. Three thousand cot spaces had been marked in charcoal throughout South Cistern, though grain bins occupied a third of them.

“Why prepare shelter during a ceasefire?” Ardis asked.

The older woman touched a cluster beside the eastern throat. “Household incidents, Highness. Since the rehearsal, descendants in six dock families hear dead kin who were never lawfully named. Two children woke speaking old bridge commands. A porter walked into the river because his grandfather remembered a crossing that no longer exists.”

Hollow rain, erased mortar, voices outside lawful rolls. The pattern reached beyond Nera and the seven niches.

Maelin placed her four remaining fingertips on the map. “Public panic magnifies ordinary grief. A completed union will settle both Households under recognized witness authority.”

“Or extend overcrowning from one bride to a city,” Ardis said.

Silence arrived unevenly. Several councilors looked toward the public gallery instead of at her. Vey held her gaze. Maelin did too.

No one had used that word in open council. The official rehearsal report described temporary ancestral confusion caused by sabotage. Ardis felt General Hal’s remembered grip in her left fingers, though no Marr dead could reach her now. Her own Household supplied the recoil: deny, soften, protect continuity.

She let the pressure pass without lending it voice.

Councilor Lessa Dorr from the salt weighers leaned over the floor plan. “Does the Crown Heir assert that marriage itself risks possession?”

“I assert that any vow granting one Household access to another body requires examination before execution.”

“Examination by the unlawful host who fled confinement?” asked Maelin.

“Salenne Vaud remains a licensed advocate unless this council convicts her through a hearing.”

“Her license does not permit sabotage.”

“Nor does my title permit my body to serve as an unexamined border instrument.”

A dock porter laughed once, sharply, then covered his mouth. The sound released other voices. Petitioners called out bridge tolls, missing grain, sons posted at reed barricades, daughters waking with dead soldiers in their hands. Ushers moved toward them.

Ardis raised her palm. "Let them speak one at a time. Councilor Vey will order the list."

Maelin's eyes narrowed by less than a finger's width. Giving Vey the list gave dock testimony procedural standing. Ardis had made her first recruit without asking him.

For two hours, the council heard the city that ceremony concealed. A fish salter had lost three workers to levy service. A widow's lawful Household repeated the command to hoard grain because an ancestor remembered siege. Black Reed merchants had twenty wagons waiting beyond Lyr's toll gate, but no official would promise that opening the gate did not concede the border.

Near the end of the list, a barge-chain tender named Mera brought forward a wooden tally rod notched with thirty-two convoy delays. She laid it beside the royal grain schedule. Eight notches had been cut since the ceasefire, each marking a wagon held because a Lyr official and an Osteren officer disagreed over whose ancestor remembered the older boundary stone.

"My crew can lift the chain in six minutes," Mera said. "It takes two courts six days to decide whose dead gave the order."

Ardis turned the tally rod between her palms. Grease darkened one side where working hands had passed it along the bridge. "If the council suspends ancestral lending for toll decisions, will living crews accept joint orders?"

"Give us names with pulses and shifts we can write down."

A Marr observer objected that Osteren officers could not submit to Lyr custody. Mera pointed to a split notch. "Then call it two custodies. I need one order from each bank that says the chain goes up."

Practical language cut through inherited principle. Ardis asked the council scribe to draft paired bridge orders, each limited to the signed convoy schedule and each expiring after the emergency allotments crossed. The Osteren observer requested authority to consult Edran. She granted it at once. Refusing consultation would only imitate Maelin's method with kinder grammar.

Another petitioner, a kitchen buyer from the western rain court, produced wedding invoices for twelve hundred sour cakes and imported plum salt. Palace stores had reserved enough grain for three ceremonial meals while ward bakers diluted flour with reed heart. Ardis canceled the third meal and reassigned its grain to the provisional convoy surety. The buyer warned that titled guests would call the banquet parsimonious.

"Let them arrive hungry enough to understand the subject," Ardis said.

Dry laughter traveled along the public benches. Even Lessa hid a smile behind the cistern plan. Maelin made no objection to the canceled meal. Instead she instructed Peln to record every reassigned sack, ensuring that any later shortage would carry Ardis's name. The choice remained fair procedure and a threat at once.

By the recess bell, the petition ledger held more usable treaty design than weeks of royal drafting: paired custody, living shifts, expiring authority, visible stores. None required a spouse. None promised permanence beyond the work named. Ardis marked those features in the margin before closing the book.

Ardis listened for actionable divisions. Shelter required the cistern office. Grain release required bridge toll authority and salt-weight certification. Public legitimacy required someone willing to say the Crown could keep a promise without offering a woman as collateral.

During the midday recess, she found Vey beside the eastern rain chain, eating a sour grain cake over his own hand to catch the crumbs. Councilor Lessa stood with him. A third councilor, old Sen Kave of the cistern keepers, pretended to study the wall gauge.

"You arranged this audience," Ardis said to Vey.

"I told petitioners which door had hinges."

"Why today?"

"Because tomorrow's grain figures will be worse, and your aunt intends to make urgency sound like consent."

Lessa wiped salt dust from the floor plan. "If you break the marriage condition, Osteren may withdraw."

"Edran did not write that condition."

"You trust him?" Sen asked.

"I trust his quartermaster's arithmetic. I trust his fear for the Black Reed villages. Personal trust can wait."

Vey glanced toward the chamber, where Maelin conferred with Peln. "What are you asking?"

"Three votes. One for provisional opening of the grain road under existing ceasefire terms. One for palace surety against bridge losses. One recognizing South Cistern as emergency civic shelter under its keepers rather than Household officers."

"You have named costs," Lessa said. "Name authority."

"The Crown grain reserve guarantees the first convoy. Bridge tolls remain in escrow until boundary review. Salt weighers from both kingdoms certify loads. No ancestor may lend a hand to the measuring officers during certification."

Sen stopped pretending interest in the gauge. "And if Maelin invokes the

emergency wedding statute?"

Ardis had spent dawn reading that statute while Nera's omission stared from the wedding roll. In famine or imminent invasion, the Lord Remembrancer could shorten notice for a dynastic binding if the council found no alternative surety.

"We give the council an alternative before she asks."

Vey ate the last bite of cake. "You want grain without a bride."

"I want grain because people need grain. I want peace because the border cannot endure another season. Neither purpose gains honesty by fastening it to my skin."

Lessa studied Ardis with the frankness of a woman accustomed to detecting false weights. "Will you say that when both courts can hear?"

"Yes."

"Will the guarantee survive if Edran refuses you?"

"Yes."

Sen asked the question the others avoided. "Will it survive if the marriage never occurs?"

Ardis looked through the open council doors. Petitioners occupied benches formerly reserved for titled observers. Daro Pell sorted the burned ration tokens into household numbers. Beyond the passage, palace cooks carried away trays intended for a wedding week that might not happen.

"Yes," she said. "The promise will survive me."

When the council resumed, Maelin called first for the Bride Accord vote. Ardis rose before Peln could read the motion.

"I submit a prior guarantee under Crown reserve authority," she said. "All grain listed in Prince Edran's signed schedule may pass the Bridge of Reeds under the four-month ceasefire. Lyr will not make food contingent on a marriage ceremony. Palace reserve secures the first convoy against seizure, spoilage, or renewed toll dispute."

The public gallery stirred. Osteren's two observers leaned toward one another. Neither left.

Maelin remained seated. "You would spend royal reserve without obtaining peace surety."

"Food sent under a ceasefire strengthens peace. Food withheld from seven border villages weakens it."

"Your body carries a duty accumulated across fifty-three lives."

"My office carries duties. My body does not belong to the office."

The Household surged. A dead king tried to stiffen her knees. An aunt forced the beginning of a ritual refusal into her throat. Ardis bit the inside of her cheek and tasted blood. Pain established a clean border. She spoke through her own mouth.

“Councilor Vey Rusk, will the dock wards supervise unloading?”

Vey stood. “They will, provided no levy officer burns another household’s ration claim while the convoy waits.”

“Granted pending hearing. Councilor Lessa Dorr, will the salt weighers certify Osteren loads beside Lyr officers?”

“They will, with all lending prohibited during measurement.”

“Entered. Councilor Sen Kave, can South Cistern receive emergency allotment?”

“It can receive grain now and people later, if this chamber respects civic custody.”

“Entered.”

Three votes did not command sixteen seats. They changed what refusal meant. Other councilors could no longer hide behind the absence of a mechanism. The bridge representative joined first, then a rain-ward physician who had treated possessed children. Two upper-court members abstained rather than oppose food before the petitioners.

Maelin let the tally finish. Nine supported the grain guarantee, four opposed, three abstained.

For one breath, Ardis felt the room without ancestral interpretation. Daro pressed both hands over his basket of burned tokens. The cistern women rolled their shelter plan carefully, as if the paper had become usable. Vey did not smile. He began drafting an unloading roster.

An Osteren observer requested the floor. “Prince Edran has authority over the first wagons. We will carry this guarantee to him.”

“Carry the vote as well,” Ardis said. “Lyr has promised passage whether or not I become his wife.”

That sentence moved beyond policy. Everyone heard the opening it made.

Maelin rose at last. Her face held sorrow, not rage, and Ardis understood that part of it might be genuine. Thirty-one years ago, Maelin had watched food become a weapon during the Silt Year. She had built a life around preventing rulers from improvising with hunger. To her, Ardis’s choice looked like another young heir wagering bodies on personal scruple.

“You have separated one convoy from the only durable settlement yet drafted,” Maelin said. “I hope the city can afford your experiment.”

“I have separated relief from compelled intimacy.”

“History does not care what intimacy costs one person when armies move.”

“People make history from what institutions charge them. Today we changed the price.”

Maelin turned to the council scribe. “Record that the Crown Heir has offered reserve grain without treaty surety. Record also that military notices arrived this

morning from both banks of Black Reed.”

Peln distributed narrow red slips. Osteren units had shifted toward the disputed road. Lyr garrisons had answered. No battle had begun, but the ceasefire narrowed with every frightened officer.

Under ordinary procedure, the council would have received a day to verify the notices. Maelin placed her mutilated hand on the old salt seal set into the table.

“As Lord Remembrancer, I invoke emergency wedding law,” she said. “A unity banquet will convene both courts tomorrow night under armed truce. There the Houses will renew public assent, and the binding ceremony will proceed on the shortened schedule authorized by this council unless an equal surety is produced.”

Vey called for a vote on the invocation. Maelin shook her head.

“The statute requires notice, not consent.”

Peln struck the cistern bell once. Ushers began carrying banquet summons to both delegations before the echo died.

Ardis looked at the open doors, the petitioners still inside, and the three councilors who had put their offices beside her promise. She had taken grain out of the marriage bargain. Maelin had answered by moving the whole court to a table where every cup, witness, and mouth could be prepared in advance.

Chapter 12 — The Cupbearer's Last Clause

Salenne found the oath when a white cup refused to hold her reflection.

Around her, the banquet scullery rang with plates, boiling kettles, and the clipped profanity of cooks who had lost a ceremonial meal to Ardis's grain guarantee. Steam fogged every glazed surface except the cup in Salenne's hand. Its inside remained dry. A dull gray figure hovered under the glaze, too straight for a firing crack and too deliberate for ash.

"Do not stack that one," she told the young cupbearer beside her.

Lio Fen stopped with twelve cups balanced along his forearms. He had the long, careful fingers of someone trained to pour beside people who punished noise. Name-thread marked his collar with three deceased servants from his family, lawful Household kin who had carried cups for the Valevs across four reigns.

"All thirty-two came from the sealed pantry," he said. "Clerk's count matches mine."

"Your clerk?"

"Lord Remembrancer's clerk."

Salenne turned the cup toward a kiln lamp. The gray stroke vanished when light struck directly and returned at an angle. Burial black had been ground into the second glaze, then covered beneath clear river glass. Heat had fixed the writing without activating it. Liquid, a living hand, and spoken office would complete the structure.

Behind her teeth, Tev hid from the nearby service corridor. Nera recognized the cup pattern as old coronation ware and pushed Salenne to break it. Ilyan supplied a diplomat's memory of drinking only after both hosts had swallowed. Three responses, none useful enough to justify lending.

She set the cup on a square of black cloth. "Who opened the pantry after firing?"

Lio placed his stack down one cup at a time. "No one. Peln Avar delivered the key in a salt packet. I opened it with two kitchen witnesses."

"A key can carry more than metal."

His face changed. "I touched every cup."

"Then keep your hands away from water until I know what the clause names."

Ysra stood at the scullery door wearing an inspector's yellow oversleeves and enough funeral salt to close any kitchen in Lyr. Her sanitation warrant had brought Salenne through the palace service foundations before dawn. It would not protect them once Maelin learned the escaped host had returned.

"Two Household officers coming down the west passage," Ysra said. "One has opinions about ladles."

“Stall them.”

“With sanitation?”

“With ladles.”

Ysra shut the door behind her. Salenne took Orsa’s copyist blade from her sleeve and scraped the cup’s foot. Powder gathered on the black cloth: clay, transparent glaze, and one dark grain that crawled toward the warmth of her thumb.

The burial black recognized a host.

She touched no skin to it. Using a fishbone pick, she moved the grain into a salt ring and breathed across it. Hidden letters darkened around the cup’s inner curve.

Lio leaned close. “I cannot read that.”

“It has been folded.”

Ordinary contract folding rearranged a long clause across several surfaces. A reader followed registration marks to restore the sentence. Here the marks had been disguised as the cupmaker’s wheel pattern, and every fourth turn reversed direction. Salenne traced them without touching. Pieces emerged: office of cup service. Pourer and receiver. Until joint assent. Pulse returns upon interruption.

A cramp closed her throat. Four components made it enforceable. The oath named an office, an act, a duration, and a consequence. Whoever had prepared it understood seven-dead vow craft, though the cup itself carried only a narrow compulsion fed by Household assent.

“Read it aloud?” Lio asked.

“No.”

He took one step back.

Salenne drew the clause on butcher’s paper, replacing active words with blanks. Even incomplete, its grammar exposed intention. The office of royal cup service would pour. The designated receiver would lend a hand. Joint assent would end the duration. If pouring stopped before assent, the pulse lent by the serving office would return through the vessel and collect its surety.

At the phrase designating the pourer, three words repeated beneath the glaze: the hand that pours.

Lio stared at his fingers. “My office.”

“Your body, if you accept the tray under service declaration.”

“I accepted it at first bell.”

A white line appeared across his right palm.

Salenne seized his wrist without crossing the line. Under her fingers, his pulse kept a normal rhythm, but each beat traveled toward the palm instead of up the arm. The cup had already registered him. Pantry key, salt packet, touch, office. Peln had built consent out of routine acts that no cupbearer would know carried

legal meaning.

"Sit," she said. "Do not pour anything."

"I have poured three kettles since dawn."

"Into cups from this set?"

"No. Kitchen cups."

That distinction might save him. The hidden clause tied act to vessel. Salenne wrapped his hand in dry linen, leaving each finger separate so no fold touched another.

Outside, Ysra began a loud lecture on ladle hooks harboring funeral mold. The Household officers protested their rank. A cook joined Ysra with personal accusations about their boots.

Lio watched the gray writing turn under the glaze. "My mother carried for Queen Dorel. She said a cupbearer prevents surprises."

"Your mother had a charitable definition of court service."

"She said the hand matters because everyone watches the cup."

To test the boundary without activating it, Salenne had him place his wrapped palm above three ordinary objects: a kettle, a tray, and an empty salt bowl. No line brightened. When she moved the black cloth holding the marked cup beneath his hand, the white seam in his palm pulled toward it like thread toward a needle.

"Vessel-specific," she said. "And office-specific. If a cook handled it, the writing would wait."

Lio swallowed. "If I resign my post?"

"Royal service law requires acceptance by your superior. Peln chose an office whose exit he controls."

"My superior died last winter. Peln has signed temporary orders since."

There lay another hidden cost. Maelin's clerk had not merely carried the trap. He had spent months accumulating routine authority over an understaffed service office. No midnight conspiracy had been required, only payroll signatures, pantry access, and grief left administratively convenient.

Salenne asked for the serving ledger. Lio produced a narrow book from his inner coat and opened it without touching the pages with his bound hand. Every banquet assignment carried his own careful checks. Beside today's cup delivery, a fresh line in Peln's writing declared that all vessels remained under cup-service custody until the unity toast concluded.

She circled until with charcoal. "That line supplies duration outside the glaze. Burn this ledger and the cup may lose part of its reach."

"May?"

"An honest advocate promises only what she can test."

Lio tore out no page. "It also proves he wrote it."

Salenne looked at him more carefully. Nineteen, frightened, and already choosing evidence over the quickest chance of safety. "Yes. Keep it dry, and do not let any Household officer take custody."

He slid the book against his ribs. "Cupbearers prevent surprises." The gesture kept the evidence against his heartbeat, where anyone searching him would have to admit they had touched a royal servant's body rather than merely audited a pantry.

"Occasionally they preserve them for trial."

Salenne looked again at the reconstructed grammar. Everyone watched the cup, which meant no one watched the tray, the cloth, the salt packet, or the person who declared an office before touching any of them.

"How many sets did Peln deliver?"

"Seven service sets. Wine, water, tea, salt rinse, witness cordial, bride cup, groom cup."

Seven. Not witnesses yet, but stations. A larger folding could distribute one vow across vessels, serving order, speakers, and royal dead.

The scullery door opened without Ysra. Edran entered in a plain Osteren coat, Tovin behind him. Both men had removed ancestor thread. Two palace guards followed, loyal to Ardis by posture if not uniform.

"I received a message saying not to drink," Edran said. "It lacked novelty."

Salenne covered the cup with black cloth. "Who sent you?"

"Ardis. Her note said you required a receiver whose Household differed from the cup's intended one."

"She should not have risked you."

"I decided which risks reached me." His gaze moved to Lio's wrapped hand. "What has already happened?"

Before Salenne could answer, General Hal pressed through Edran's shoulders. The prince's stance widened, his injured right leg angling to compensate. Tovin put two fingers against the back of Edran's left arm, not restraining him, merely naming the boundary with contact.

Edran exhaled. "My dead recognize the ware."

"How?"

"Marriage campaign cups. Hal says every conquered House drank before signing."

That memory belonged to Hal, not Edran, and the general offered it as proof of usefulness. Salenne marked the distinction. "Do not lend him any hand."

"I had formed a similar ambition."

Testing required a receiver, but no honest test required activation. Salenne asked Edran to stand beyond the salt line. She set an unmarked kitchen bowl inside it and directed Lio to describe, without performing, how he would serve the prince.

Lio recited the order. "Approach from the receiver's unarmed side. Name the office. Show both hands. Pour with the right. Turn the handle toward the receiver. Retire three steps."

On name the office, the gray clause brightened.

"Stop," Salenne said.

His mouth closed. The white line in his palm deepened.

Edran's left fingers curled.

Tovin saw it first. "His hand."

The prince braced his forearm against his chest. Hal pushed from within, eager for a weapon he understood. Yet the compulsion did not seek Edran's sword. His hand reached toward the covered cup.

"No liquid has been poured," Salenne said.

Lio's eyes widened. "I poured the test water before you came. I emptied it when the cup stayed dry."

The glaze had held the act in suspension. Naming his office completed the pour after the fact. Edran's presence supplied the intended receiver, selected by rank and foreign Household.

Salenne snapped a second salt ring around the cup. "Lio, renounce the serving office for this set."

"I renounce service to these vessels."

Nothing loosened. Routine acceptance had bound him until joint assent, and the clause recognized no unilateral withdrawal.

Edran's palm settled over the black cloth. The cup beneath it gave a thin ceramic hum. A Marr ancestor spoke through his teeth: "Pour."

Tovin caught the prince's elbow. "Edran. Black Reed, winter of the broken mill. You carried me three miles after I told you the leg belonged to me and I could ruin it myself."

Living memory interrupted Hal's borrowed cadence. Edran's eyes cleared, though his hand remained fixed.

"Useful romance," Salenne said. "Keep talking."

Lio stood. "If I finish the service, it ends at joint assent."

"It ends when the receiver voices assent under compulsion," Salenne said. "That would prepare him to accept the banquet's larger vow."

"What happens if I interrupt?"

She looked at the last phrase. Pulse returns upon interruption and finds surety in the office that withheld completion.

"It collects from you."

"How much?"

"The clause does not specify. That omission favors the enforcing dead."

Nera surged at the legal obscenity. Tev recognized Lio's fear and crowded toward Salenne's tongue. Ilyan tried to calculate whether one servant's life balanced a prince's compelled assent. Salenne refused the arithmetic.

"Lio, remain still. Edran, I need you to lend Hal one finger voluntarily, then withdraw it on my count. A chosen lending may create a break between his pressure and the glaze."

"No," Lio said.

He snatched the cup from beneath Edran's hand.

The linen around his palm blackened. Before anyone reached him, he drove the vessel against the stone sink. White glaze burst across his fingers. The ceramic hum became a sound below hearing that Salenne felt in her teeth.

Edran's hand released.

Lio's pulse stopped under the linen.

Ysra forced through the door as Salenne caught him. His body had not understood death yet. He looked awake, breath trapped but not gone. Blood came from shallow glaze cuts, none deep enough to kill. The oath had pulled the surety inward. A dark line traveled from his palm along the veins of his wrist.

"Heart shock," Ysra said. She dropped to her knees and struck his chest with both hands.

Tovin cleared ceramic from beneath Lio's shoulders. Edran ordered the guards to lock both doors and seize every cup without touching bare glaze. His left hand trembled, still shaped around an absent handle.

Salenne pressed fingers to Lio's throat. One faint beat answered, then nothing.

"Return your office," she told him. "Lio Fen, you are not required to serve."

The clause had no mercy language. It held the pulse already collected.

Ysra struck again. Lio's back arched. Air left him without another breath following.

Burial black spread through the cracks of the broken cup, carrying a fresh name it had no lawful right to know. The glaze oath had used his service declaration as a temporary token. Unless someone hosted him now, his death would remain folded inside the vessel, available to whoever controlled its shards.

Salenne reached for the fishbone pick.

Ysra caught her stained thumb. "Four ghosts cross the self-recognition

threshold.”

“His testimony dies into Peln’s evidence if I leave him.”

“Your memory pays.”

“I know.”

Across the salt ring, Edran held his shaking hand against his coat. “Can my Household take him?”

“No. Blood inheritance only, and your dead would own the account.”

Tovin asked, “What do you need?”

“A clean name shaving.”

Lio wore no token for himself; living people did not carry funeral slips. Ysra cut a narrow paring from the cupbearer’s wooden service tally, where his name had been stamped beside the day’s order. She charred it over the kiln lamp, mixed the ash with salt and one grain from the broken glaze, then marked a drop on Salenne’s lower lip.

The three hosted dead drew back as far as her body allowed.

Salenne drank.

Lio entered through her hands.

For one instant she felt every cup he had carried that morning: handle temperature, tray balance, the tiny shift in a guest’s breath before refusing a drink. Then memory moved aside to make room for him. Ysra’s hand lay in Salenne’s from years ago, warm and broad as they leaned behind a funeral singer’s screen for a foolish, tender first kiss.

The image remained. Sensation left it.

Salenne could see younger Ysra’s gold tooth, remember the joke that had brought them close, and recite what happened afterward. She could no longer feel how Ysra’s hand had held hers.

Her own fingers went numb. Black edged her tongue farther toward the center.

“Name,” Ysra said, grief controlled into procedure.

“Salenne Vaud.”

“Place.”

“Banquet scullery, House Rain Palace.”

“Living with you?”

“Ysra Pell. Edran Marr. Tovin Sare. Two guards. Lio Fen is dead.”

Inside her, Lio objected to the last sentence with exact professional offense. He had not finished reporting.

Salenne let him lend her eyes, not her mouth. The scullery overlaid itself with his morning route. Peln Avar entered carrying a gray-wrapped tray. He used his left

hand because his right held a salt packet. He instructed Lio to count every cup, then remained while Lio declared receipt under the office of royal cup service.

Memory shifted. Peln's sleeve brushed the pantry lock. A streak of clear glaze marked the cuff.

"Clerk Peln carried the set," Salenne said. "He witnessed Lio's acceptance and used the pantry key as the clause transfer."

Edran's expression hardened. "Can Lio testify?"

"At a hearing, if we corroborate the memory."

"He can testify now," Ysra said. "We all saw the death."

That distinction mattered. Ghost memory supplied evidence, not truth by decree. Two guards had seen Peln deliver nothing, but kitchen witnesses had opened the pantry. The salt packet might still hold burial-black dust. The shards carried the clause.

Lio pressed a sequence through Salenne's fingers. Seven sets. Seven pours. Bride and groom positioned last. Before them, witness cordial passed to five council seats, then water to Osteren officers. Every vessel held a fragment too small to enforce alone.

She laid the fragments of the broken cup in serving order. Gray marks aligned across separate curves. Not one narrow compulsion. One long vow had been folded through the entire banquet service, using borrowed mouths for assent and royal Household pressure as witness authority.

"The cup tried to make Edran's hand complete the toast," she said. "At the banquet, the other sets will compel the people who pour, receive, answer, and repeat. Each mouth will believe it speaks a harmless piece."

Tovin looked toward the locked door. "Can we cancel the banquet?"

"Maelin can call refusal proof of foreign treachery," Edran said. "Both armed courts will already be seated."

Lio gave Salenne one final remembered detail: beneath Peln's gray cloth, a roll lay strapped to the tray. Its visible edge carried seven royal seals, all impressed over fresh scraping.

Salenne arranged the last shard. The clause on the cup ended midword. Its continuation would wait on the banquet table.

"This glaze oath only prepared a hand," she said. "Tomorrow's service prepares the room. The banquet itself contains the larger trap."

Chapter 13 — A Banquet of Borrowed Mouths

Ardis counted fourteen visible blades before the first cup reached the table.

Eight belonged to ceremonial guards, four to Osteren officers, one to Tovin Sare beneath his plain coat, and one to Maelin's fish knife. The last lay beside a plate of smoked river carp and looked harmless enough to make Ardis distrust it most.

House Rain's central court had been arranged as if seating could settle war. Lyr occupied the western half of the U-shaped table, Osteren the east. Councilors sat between them by alternating ward and rank. Edran faced Ardis across the open center, close enough for conversation and too far for either to intervene quickly. His left hand rested bandage-free beside an untouched water bowl. Tovin stood three paces behind him, where a captain should stand and a lover could still reach him.

Maelin had placed herself at the joined head of the table. Behind her, seven funeral singers waited on a raised tile step. No cups stood before them. Their mouths had been painted with a thin line of ceremonial salt.

The clear air under the roof remained dry. That offered no comfort. Hollow Rain required erased dead near a binding, and Salenne had not yet entered.

"Changed exits," Vey Rusk murmured from Ardis's left.

He kept his lips behind his tea bowl. Ardis followed his gaze without moving her head. Two service screens blocked the western passage that petitioners had used yesterday. A row of palace Household officers stood before the south doors. Only the kitchen corridor and the narrow council stair remained open.

"Sen Kave?" she asked.

"By the cistern stair with six civic keepers. Lessa has salt weighers at the kitchen exit."

Three councilors, a promise, and workers accustomed to moving heavy things. Not an army. Perhaps enough to keep a room from becoming one.

Ardis had ordered every banquet vessel replaced with undecorated kitchen ware after Salenne found the glaze oath. Maelin had complied publicly. The bowls now circulating carried no gray writing and reflected every face held above them. Still, each sat on a white service cloth from the original sets. Nothing in Ardis's order had mentioned cloth.

Across the table, Edran saw her looking. His gaze dropped to the cloth beneath his bowl, then rose. He gave no nod. Agreement had become dangerous when ritual could make a gesture count as assent.

Peln Avar supervised service from the northern screen. His cuffs looked clean. Ardis knew from Salenne's hidden note that transparent glaze had marked one sleeve yesterday. Peln had changed coats and retained authority.

"Crown Heir." Maelin's voice reached every place without effort. "Shall we begin before the fish cools?"

"You may begin with the names of those who prepared the service."

A few guests shifted. Maelin regarded the question as if Ardis had asked for the weather in a room with no sky.

"Kitchen rolls remain available for inspection."

"Read them."

Peln stepped forward with a service ledger. "Head cook Mer Va. Deputy cook Issel. Salt steward Pera Nol. Cup service administered by this office under temporary vacancy."

He did not name Lio.

Ardis set down her spoon. "Who held cup service at dawn yesterday?"

A pulse moved in Peln's throat. "Lio Fen died during an act of unlawful interference."

"His death has not been entered in the palace roll."

"Because the escaped advocate removed his remains from lawful custody."

That lie carried enough truth to survive careless hearing. Ysra had taken Lio's body into funeral care. Salenne carried his witness. Palace custody had never lawfully possessed either, but Peln had chosen words that made procedure resemble theft.

Maelin lifted her four-fingered right hand. "The cupbearer's death will receive inquiry after the immediate danger passes. Tonight both courts must show armies beyond the bridge that peace remains possible."

Edran spoke from the Osteren side. "My grain wagons began moving under yesterday's guarantee."

Whispers crossed the room. Ardis had not known whether his living officers would honor it without the marriage condition.

"How many?" asked Councilor Lessa.

"Twenty to the Bridge of Reeds. Fourteen more load before dawn. The Black Reed villages receive the first allotment."

General Sev Marr, seated two places from him, tightened his jaw. Ancestor thread covered his formal coat in white ranks. "Subject to secure passage."

"Subject to the ceasefire," Edran corrected.

Relief moved through Ardis so quickly she mistrusted it. Edran had turned her public promise into material fact. Maelin could no longer claim only marriage moved grain. Yet military notices remained real, and General Hal's pressure sat visibly in the prince's shoulders.

Maelin addressed the room. "Food crossing one bridge does not settle the

boundary, return prisoners, restrain descendants, or prevent commanders from interpreting fear as attack. A durable union does.”

“An enforceable compact might,” Vey said.

“An office changes hands. Blood continues.”

“And so does inherited error,” Ardis replied.

The funeral singers inhaled together.

Not song. One sustained breath passed through seven living throats, each held too long. Ardis felt her Household notice. Fifty-three dead shifted from argument to attention. Name-thread around the room drew tight against collars and cuffs.

Maelin cut one piece of fish. “We will hear the unity account before the toast. The singers carry lawful royal memory from the Bride Accord rolls. No descendant will lend more than voice, and no statement will bind until the final assent.”

The sentence offered safety through limits she alone had defined.

Ardis looked toward the kitchen corridor. No Salenne. Their plan required her to enter after Peln presented the witness roll, not before. She would need the public act of forgery, the cup shards, Lio’s ledger, and living witnesses. If Ardis stopped the banquet too early, Maelin could destroy all four within separate jurisdictions.

A singer at the left end opened her mouth. A dead woman’s voice emerged, low and formal. “In the Silt Year, Lyr endured because House Valev held one command across the living generations.”

The singer’s own eyes watered. Lending exacted bodily cost even when called ceremonial. Her fingers dug into her knees while the ancestor used her breath.

Second came an Osteren account through a Lyr singer: grain roads burned because no marriage joined the competing Households. Third came a Valev admiral’s memory of barges seized at Black Reed. Each statement contained a fact and removed its context. No one named which ruler had ordered hunger or which dead voice had urged retaliation.

Ardis listened to the room rather than the history. Osteren officers leaned forward whenever a Lyr ancestor confessed weakness. Lyr councilors relaxed whenever memory made continuity sound benevolent. The service staff moved in a pattern too exact for an improvised meal.

Seven attendants placed salt-rinse bowls at seven chosen seats. Edran received one. So did Ardis, Maelin, Sev, Vey, Lessa, and an Osteren roll-keeper. Each bowl arrived on white cloth.

Ardis did not touch hers.

A fourth singer spoke. “The living forget what peace costs.”

Nera had used similar words when she argued with Ardis as girls. Maelin had used them after the funeral. The Household picked up the cadence and pressed it behind Ardis’s teeth.

Across the table, Edran's left fingers moved half an inch toward his bowl.

Tovin said quietly, "Broken mill."

The hand stopped.

Maelin watched him. "Captain, ceremony allows no prompting."

"His hand cramped."

"Then a physician may attend after the account."

Edran flattened his palm on the table. "My body requires no ceremonial interpretation."

Peln signaled the attendants.

They poured water into the seven bowls. Clear liquid darkened the white cloth beneath each base. Gray writing rose through woven fibers, one fragment per place. Ardis could read only the line nearest her: heir of the rain office shall answer.

"Do not speak titles," she said.

Too late. The fifth singer had begun the formal address. "Crown Heir Ardis Valev, do you receive the peace account of your lawful dead?"

Every face turned toward Ardis. Refusal could be framed as rejection of peace. Answering in any form might fill the fragment.

She picked up her fish knife and cut the cloth around the bowl without touching either. "I receive no hidden clause."

The gray writing flared.

Receive had sufficed.

A cold line climbed from the table into her wrists. Her Household rushed toward the opened grammar. Fifty-three dead could not move her hands without lending, but the clause had named her office and harvested her answer. The singers provided witness voices. Duration waited elsewhere in the fold.

Edran stood. His bowl hummed against the wood.

Sev rose with him. Lyr guards answered. Fourteen visible blades became fourteen hands deciding whether to draw.

"Sit," Maelin said.

The word traveled through seven singers in seven pitches. Around the table, descendants obeyed before they knew whose command they followed. Knees struck benches. Spines straightened. Even Vey dropped half a hand before catching himself on the table.

Ardis remained standing because her chair had no ancestor thread and because she drove the fish knife through her own sleeve into the wood. Pain at her forearm held her posture outside the chorus.

Maelin had arranged no simple enchantment. She had built compliance from

titles, service declarations, accepted dishes, and the reflex to obey a room speaking with familial voices. Each act looked voluntary alone.

A sixth singer opened his mouth. This voice belonged to one of Ardis's dead magistrates, a man she had heard in dreams since childhood. "State the foreign breach."

No breach had been entered. The clause supplied one from accumulated suspicion.

Ardis's jaw locked. Words gathered in the borrowed shape of royal accusation. Osteren had murdered Nera. Osteren had falsified Ilyan's death. Osteren had moved soldiers during ceasefire. Some parts carried evidence. Joined under compulsion, they formed a declaration of foreign attack.

She bit her bleeding cheek. The words pressed harder.

"Ardis," Edran said. No title. "Look at the grain schedule."

The signed packet lay beside Maelin's plate. Axle counts. Village stores. Twenty wagons already moving because living people had taken orders without marriage surety.

Ardis fixed her gaze on Edran rather than the paper. His left hand had closed around the stem of a rinse bowl. Hal pulled through his arm. The prince's face remained his own, but tendons stood along his wrist.

Her mouth opened.

"Osteren comes under truce," she said. That much belonged to her. Then the clause seized the line. "Osteren sent murder into this House and calls its grain mercy."

Chairs scraped. Sev drew his ceremonial sword. A Lyr guard answered with steel. The Osteren roll-keeper shouted denial while his own bowl forced his right hand against the table.

Borrowed mouths took the accusation and repeated it. The seven singers spoke first. Household descendants around the table followed, each voice changing a word. Murder under truce. Murder carried with grain. Osteren murdered the elder bride. Lyr means to answer. Within breaths, Ardis's compelled sentence had become grounds for war.

Maelin did not smile. She looked stricken, which made Ardis's fury cleaner. Perhaps Maelin had meant to compel a gentler unity statement. Perhaps the old dead had used her design for their own appetite. Control built on possession always gave its architect the excuse of unintended hands.

"Stop the account," Maelin ordered.

The singers could not. Their throats worked under seven separate dead. Salt paint cracked at their lips. One woman clawed at her collar.

Edran dragged his hand away from the bowl. Skin peeled from his palm as if glaze had grown through it. Hal forced him to reach again.

Tovin caught the prince's wrist. "Do not lend."

"I am not." Edran's voice broke with effort. "It has the hand."

The fragment prepared yesterday still recognized him. Lio had interrupted its first vessel, but the larger fold had restored the receiver through service cloth and title.

Edran looked at the knife pinning Ardis's sleeve. "May I borrow that?"

She pulled it free and slid it across the open center.

The fish knife spun once. Edran caught it with his right hand, reversed the blade, and cut across his left palm.

Blood struck the gray writing.

The bowl split down one side. Hal's pressure snapped out of Edran's arm. His knees hit the table, but his left hand remained against his chest, no longer reaching. Tovin wrapped it in his own white cuff and pressed hard.

"The clause names an unbroken receiving hand," Edran said through his teeth. "It no longer has one."

Sev stared at the blood. General Hal must have been shouting through every thread on his coat. The living commander lowered his sword by one finger's width.

Ardis found her voice. "All guards, blades down. Civic keepers, open the cistern stair. Salt weighers, clear the kitchen exit. No one answers any title spoken by the singers."

Vey overturned his bowl without touching it, using the wooden tally rod Mera had left with him. Lessa ripped white cloth from beneath two councilors' settings. Sen Kave and his keepers shoved the western screens flat, making a ramp over the benches.

The room broke into movement. Osteren officers formed around Edran. Lyr Household guards mistook the formation for attack and advanced. Ardis climbed onto the table between them.

"Look at my hands," she shouted. "No weapon. I accuse no living Osteren officer of Nera's death. The sentence came through a hidden clause."

One of her dead tried to make her point at Sev. She locked both hands behind her back.

A palace guard cried, "The foreign prince has bloodied the unity table."

"He cut his own hand to refuse possession."

"Proof of hostile intent," Peln called from the service screen.

That intervention showed too much. Several faces turned toward him. Peln stepped back, but the kitchen door opened behind him.

Salenne entered carrying a dead man's service ledger in one hand and a black-wrapped bundle in the other.

Hollow Rain began above her.

Cold drops formed under the roof beams and fell through clear air. They struck only the northern half of the table at first, darkening Maelin's white sleeve, Peln's clean cuff, and the raised step beneath the singers. Erased dead pressed near a binding. The rain supplied proximity, not guilt, but everyone in Lyr knew what it meant.

Salenne's tongue showed black when she spoke. "Clerk Peln Avar, remove your hand from the service roll."

Four voices moved under hers. Tev's fear shortened the words. Nera gave them command. Ilyan carried a foreign cadence. Lio supplied the exact rhythm of palace service.

Peln clutched the roll against his coat. "Arrest the unlawful host."

"After evidence enters," Ardis said. "Not before."

Maelin rose beneath the interior rain. "You have no authority to admit an escaped prisoner into a joint court."

"I have authority to investigate an attempt against my body and Prince Edran's."

"You surrendered neutral judgment when you concealed her flight."

True. Ardis felt the council register it.

Salenne reached the open center. Her gait looked deliberate because every step required negotiation among five occupants of one body. Four hosted ghosts did not yet loosen her name, but self-recognition had begun to fray at the edges. When Ardis met her eyes, Salenne's attention caught for half a breath, as if attraction, exhaustion, and professional caution all demanded different distances.

No touch could help here. Public power compromised even comfort.

Ysra followed with the two guards from the scullery and three kitchen witnesses. One carried the salt packet. Another held the gray-stained pantry key in tongs. Tovin, still compressing Edran's cut, looked at the evidence and gave a grim nod.

Salenne set the black bundle on the table. Broken white glaze lay inside. "Yesterday, Lio Fen received thirty-two cups under Peln Avar's temporary service authority. A hidden oath seized his office, transferred compulsion into Prince Edran's hand, and collected Lio's pulse when he interrupted the pour. These guards witnessed his death. These kitchen workers witnessed the delivery and opening."

The singers continued their failing chorus behind Maelin. Their repeated accusation had dissolved into fragments. Grain. Murder. Bride. Answer. Each word left another throat bleeding.

"Release them," Ardis told Maelin.

"I did not authorize continued lending."

"You provided the roll."

"The roll contains lawful dead who can withdraw when their descendants withdraw."

Yet the descendants could not. Ardis crossed to the raised step and wiped salt paint from the nearest singer's mouth with her bare sleeve. The woman gagged, then drew a breath of her own. Vey and Lessa began clearing the others.

Peln moved toward the north door.

Lio borrowed Salenne's hand with permission. Ardis saw the moment of agreement: Salenne opened two fingers, no more. Her hand pointed at Peln's roll.

"That paper came under gray cloth with the marked cups," Lio said through her. "Fresh scraping beneath seven seals. Count from the lower edge, third thumb's width. The old fibers run sideways where new names were pressed."

His borrowed speech ended. Salenne closed her hand and took it back. Sweat stood across her upper lip.

Ardis said, "Clerk, put down the roll."

Peln looked to Maelin.

For one dangerous breath, Maelin could have protected him openly. Instead she said, "Evidence must be preserved."

He obeyed.

Ysra pinned the vellum with salt weights. Salenne used Orsa's copyist blade to lift the lower seal without tearing it. Beneath the royal impression, reed fibers showed fresh abrasion. Names had been scraped and replaced. The seven listed dead all belonged to lawful Valev lines, but the erased shapes beneath included tool marks, service abbreviations, and blank spaces where nonroyal witnesses once stood.

"A forged witness roll," Salenne said. "Its current names did not hear the original account. Their seals cannot lawfully validate a clause derived from it."

A councilor called, "Can ghosts not remember through their Household?"

"They can inherit reports from living hosts. They cannot become witnesses to events they never saw."

"Then the Bride Accord lacks seven valid dead?"

"The roll offered tonight does."

Salenne did not overclaim. Ardis heard the restraint and loved her for it with an intensity she refused to turn into action. Exactness mattered most when a room wanted a verdict.

Maelin came down from the head place. Rain coursed along the severe coil of her hair. "A scraped roll proves alteration, not purpose. Every court consolidates damaged funeral copies. This one preserved royal continuity during a war."

"Peln used it to compel assent," Edran said.

His left palm had soaked through Tovin's cuff. He remained upright by leaning his good hand on the table. No Osteren officer could mistake the personal cost.

Maelin faced him. "And your Household used the opening to turn a peace account into accusation. That danger argues for disciplined union, not abandonment."

"It argues against giving our dead one room and calling whatever they take discipline."

General Sev finally sheathed his sword. Two Lyr guards followed. Others did not.

From the public side of the court, someone threw a salt bowl at an Osteren officer. Ardis never saw who. It shattered against armor. Steel came free in answer.

Riot did not arrive as one decision. A singer's husband struck a Household guard who blocked him. Palace officers grabbed a kitchen witness carrying the pantry key. Osteren soldiers pulled Edran back from the table. Lyr councilors ducked beneath benches. Hollow Rain thickened until lamps hissed and white cloth clung to the wood like shed skin.

Ardis jumped down between a guard and the kitchen witness. "Release her."

"Heir, she holds binding material."

"She holds evidence under my protection."

The guard's dead pressed into his eyes, turning his gaze old and distant. "The House requires custody."

"The living court has not granted it." Ardis took the tongs from the witness herself. "Now release her."

He obeyed rank where judgment had failed. Ardis hated the usefulness and spent it anyway.

Across the court, Vey led petitioners through the flattened screen route. Sen's keepers carried one injured singer toward the cistern stair. Lessa stood on a bench naming each open exit so panic could organize around directions rather than rumor.

Tovin and two Osteren officers moved Edran toward the kitchen. Sev guarded their rear with his sword sheathed but his body square to the Household officers. Ardis pointed them toward Lessa's weighers.

"Take his hand to a living surgeon. No funeral salt."

Edran paused. "Salenne."

She still stood beside the exposed roll. Four dead flickered across her expression as the rain struck her face. Ysra packed the cup shards while guards closed from north and west.

Ardis reached her in six steps. "Come with me."

Salenne looked at the exits, then at Peln. "If I run, he calls every piece stolen by an escaped host."

“He will arrest you.”

“Yes.”

“That does not make staying useful.”

“It keeps the evidence in a court with witnesses. Get the kitchen workers out. Preserve Lio’s ledger. Do not let them separate his body from Ysra’s license.”

Ardis wanted to command refusal. The desire sickened her because it wore the face of protection.

Instead she asked, “Do you choose this?”

Salenne’s mouth softened. “I choose the record.”

Household officers reached them. Ardis stood between their hands and Salenne until Maelin arrived.

“Your Highness,” Maelin said, rain running from her mutilated hand, “the chamber has suffered unlawful hosting, foreign bloodshed, forged accusations, and armed disorder. Emergency authority passes to the Lord Remembrancer until Household contamination receives judgment.”

“The roll has visible scraping.”

“And now resides in salt custody for examination.”

“Pel’n prepared the vessels.”

“He will submit to inquiry.” Maelin looked at her clerk. “Confine him to the remembrancer’s office. Remove every service key.”

Pel’n’s shock appeared genuine. Maelin sacrificed access, perhaps even the man, to preserve the institution around them. She could claim control precisely because she punished one instrument.

“Salenne Vaud carries four dead without court registration,” Maelin continued. “One belongs to the royal line, one to Osteren, two to erased service. Until their claims receive lawful testing, she presents a breach between Houses.”

“She exposed your trap.”

“She exposed a clerk’s acts and a damaged roll. Do not grant certainty where evidence has not reached.”

Again, exact language protected wrongdoing without telling a clean lie. Maelin’s fear of war remained visible beneath it. Ardis could almost trace the path: a compelled unity account had become accusation; blades had answered; foreign blood marked the table. To Maelin, failure meant insufficient control, never proof that control caused the failure.

The last singer fell silent. Hollow Rain softened but did not stop.

Maelin raised her voice to the remaining councilors and both courts. “By emergency statute, the binding wedding will occur nine days from this night. The interval permits independent review of the roll, treatment of the injured, and final military guarantees. Refusal after that interval will dissolve the ceasefire conditions

negotiated under the Bride Accord.”

“Nine days,” Ardis repeated. “You call an ultimatum review.”

“I call it time the border does not possess.”

Household officers bound Salenne’s wrists with nameproof linen. The cloth prevented hosted dead from reaching her hands, but it also numbed her living fingers. Ysra protested the knot placement until a guard loosened it enough to preserve circulation.

Ardis could stop the arrest only by ordering her guards against Maelin’s. Some would obey. Others would hear older Valev commands. Osteren soldiers remained within the palace. One clash could reach the bridge before truth did.

Salenne met her gaze. No plea. A direction: keep the room from becoming a battlefield.

Ardis lowered her hand.

Maelin had lost secrecy. The scraped roll lay open before councilors, Lio’s death had living witnesses, and everyone had heard borrowed mouths turn ceremony into an accusation. Yet emergency law now gathered around the woman who had prepared for catastrophe better than anyone else.

Guards led Salenne through the north door. Her black-wrapped evidence remained under Ysra’s hands, but the forged roll went into Maelin’s salt chest.

Above the abandoned table, Hollow Rain fell into Edran’s blood and diluted it across nine marked places.

Part III

Chapter 14 — Prisoner of Her Own Dead

The nameproof cell made the living sound dead and the dead sound close.

Salenne woke on a reed mat while someone beyond the door asked a question she could not understand. The voice reached her as breath without consonants. Salt had been worked into every wall in nested name rings, each one designed to turn declared identity inward. A prisoner could not lend voice through the door. A Household could not call descendants from outside. Hosted witnesses, trapped within the same living name, had nowhere else to press.

Tev crouched in the memory of a stable corner. Nera paced through Salenne's shoulders without moving them. Ilyan counted guard changes by vibration. Lio kept trying to inventory the empty room: one mat, one drain, one covered water cup, no serving ledger.

Salenne sat up. Nameproof linen bound her wrists in front. Her fingers had gone cold, though the knot Ysra forced the guard to loosen still allowed blood through. Burial black coated most of her tongue. When she touched her nose to her shoulder, the indigo cloth came away marked with old blood.

"Name," she said aloud.

The walls returned the word to her in four borrowed cadences.

"Salenne Vaud. Oath advocate. Living."

Nera objected to the last distinction. Dead did not consider themselves less present merely because they lacked bodies. Salenne repeated it anyway.

A slot opened in the door. A guard's sentence entered as vowels and hard taps. Food, perhaps. Hearing, perhaps. Confession.

"Write it," Salenne called.

Paper slid through. Peln's hand had prepared the question: Will the prisoner voluntarily discharge unlawfully hosted dead into royal salt custody pending examination?

No means of discharge existed without true name, unresolved truth, and the people bound by that truth. Peln knew it. The question manufactured refusal.

Salenne turned the page over and wrote with a charcoal nub left beside the water: The named host requests a living hearing, independent funeral counsel, and preservation of all witness evidence. No dead person consents to royal ownership.

Tev pressed fear into her wrist before she finished. He had seen what happened when a servant's refusal entered a palace record. Nera wanted the answer sharpened into accusation. Ilyan advised a diplomatic ambiguity that might preserve access to Osteren. Lio found a missing comma.

Four dead, four uses for one hand.

Salenne drew a square in charcoal around the mat and assigned each corner a witness, an absurdly physical solution to pressure with no bodies. Tev received the point nearest the door so he could warn of boots and cord. Nera took the wall facing the palace, where anger might spend itself on salt. Ilyan occupied the drain corner and listened for traffic in the foundation pipes. Lio received the water cup and responsibility for counting every object passed through the slot.

"Payment," Nera demanded through the muscles around Salenne's mouth.

"You do not buy access with my memories."

"Then why should we help?"

The question carried Nera's grievance rather than doctrine. Hosting had trapped her inside an advocate who could deny the hand or voice she needed to accuse her murderer. Salenne could not call that arrangement freedom simply because a license authorized it.

"You may refuse testimony," Salenne said. "You may ask to speak when the hearing concerns what you witnessed. You may withdraw advice. What you cannot do is take movement because you dislike my answer."

Ilyan offered a colder bargain: one voluntary minute of his hearing in exchange for access to her childhood memory of Olan's archive routes. He believed those rooms might reveal where Maelin hid diplomatic evidence.

"That route is already gone," Salenne told him. "Your arrival displaced it."

Regret passed through him, exact and startled. A ghost did not feel the vacancy made for his presence unless the host named it. His pressure on the drain eased.

Tev wanted no memory. He wanted Salenne never to stand with her back to a service opening. She agreed where practical. Lio requested that his death be called killing rather than mishap in every formal account. Salenne promised to describe the pulse clause and Peln's acts, but not to name legal guilt before hearing.

"Advocates," Lio complained with the remembered smell of hot glaze.

"Witnesses," she returned.

The bargaining changed no magic. Salt still turned every dead impulse inward; four emotional lives still occupied one nervous system. Yet stated permissions gave Salenne a grammar for refusal. When Nera tested her right shoulder, Salenne named the breach, and Nera withdrew before intention became motion.

"You may advise," Salenne told them. "No one writes through me."

Nera's anger tightened the linen. You need rank.

The thought arrived in the taste of rainwater from her childhood, Nera's childhood, not Salenne's. Hosted ghosts rarely formed clean sentences unless granted speech. They pushed memory and bodily intention instead.

"Rank brought us here."

Ilyan offered the sensation of sealing a compromise under three hostile crests. Leverage, then.

“Evidence provides leverage.”

Tev remembered the service grille and red cord. People with evidence die.

Lio answered with his last service ledger held against his ribs. Evidence can outlive them.

Their pressure crowded Salenne’s pulse until she could not tell which fear increased it. She shut her eyes and made an inventory of memories that remained hers. Orsa’s copyist blade in her palm. Ysra laughing after a funeral singer improvised an obscene verse. Ardis in a locked map room, refusing to call her own body surety. The first two came with facts but damaged sensation: no singing voice, no feel of Ysra’s hand. The third remained painfully complete.

Nera noticed Ardis and reached for the memory.

Salenne opened her eyes. “No.”

Her voice struck the salt rings and returned louder. The four dead withdrew by different degrees.

At midday, judging by the warmth creeping through the wall, the door opened. Two guards admitted Ysra in undertaker’s gray. She carried a lidded evidence tray, a roll of clean binding linen, and the expression she reserved for officials who confused inconvenience with law.

A guard spoke. The cell blurred his words.

Ysra answered distinctly because she leaned close enough for Salenne to read her mouth. “Funeral contamination review requires privacy.”

He pointed toward the hosted prisoner.

“Then remain and accept liability for any dead person who transfers into your lawful Household.”

Both guards stepped outside. The lock closed.

Ysra set down the tray and touched her own forehead, throat, and sternum. The old undertaker’s check asked mind, voice, breath without requiring the prisoner to receive touch.

“Salenne Vaud,” Salenne answered. “Living. Four hosted. No discharge. Hearing distortion from the cell. Tongue nearly half black. Two nosebleeds since arrest.”

“Names in order.”

“Tev Orr. Nera Valev. Ilyan Marr. Lio Fen.”

“Hands?”

“Mine.”

“Memories?”

“No new loss.”

Ysra's gaze held for an extra beat at that answer. She untied the prison linen and examined each finger. Warmth returned as pain. Salenne watched those broad hands work and knew they had once held hers during a kiss, but the bodily knowledge had gone. Grief required no missing sensation to hurt.

"What happened outside?" she asked.

"Edran's palm needed six stitches. Tovin threatened three surgeons until one stopped recommending ancestral steadiness. The grain wagons reached the bridge approach. Peln remains confined in Maelin's rooms, which means he has better food than you and fewer exits."

"Ardis?"

"Arguing with sixteen councilors and fifty-three relatives. She tried to enter this corridor twice. Maelin posted Household officers after the second attempt."

Relief came mixed with anger. Ardis could not rescue her by turning private authority into another form of compulsion. Yet the image of her reaching this door settled somewhere Salenne's ghosts could not touch.

Ysra tapped the evidence tray. "Maelin's examiners sent this for contamination classification. They believe the confiscated ink came from your market packet."

"Did it?"

"No. I lied about which seal I recognized."

Inside the tray lay six narrow strips of funeral vellum and Orsa's copyist blade. Black script crossed each strip, then stopped at an abraded gap. Someone had tried to wash the remnants with salt. Moisture gathered over the letters despite the dry cell.

Hollow rain in miniature.

Salenne leaned close. "These came from the six shadows Orsa bought at the market."

"Pel'n's people found them sewn into the Night Market broker's screen. Your arrest gave them cause to raid it."

"The broker?"

"Gone through a river passage. He left the pieces where a search would discover them."

Deliberately, then. He had moved evidence into Maelin's custody because a royal seizure created a chain that could not be dismissed as market forgery. Another person choosing the record.

The six strips carried different funeral hands. Salenne recognized Olan's instruction in three corrected curves, though another copyist had made the original marks. Across the lower edges, tiny knife pricks formed a repeated refusal sign: a copyist declining to certify a name's removal.

Orsa's sign.

When Salenne placed the blade beside the strips, black moisture moved toward its worn handle. A human shape appeared in reflection across the six wet surfaces, never whole on one.

Her mother's face.

Salenne knew that immediately. She also knew the image could not be trusted merely because longing supplied a name. Memory already distorted. She could recall facts about Orsa's eyes and cheeks, summon the general arrangement of features, but grief had polished details over ten years.

The reflected woman raised ink-dark fingers. Not a Household voice. An unclaimed dead person held near death-work and the burial black she had used.

Ysra whispered, "Orsa Vaud."

The moisture shivered.

Tev recognized the copyist who had once hidden him beneath a blank line. Nera knew only the sensation of palace paper passing through servant hands. Ilyan recognized Orsa's refusal mark from a packet copied after his death. Lio felt the professional kinship of two service workers whose exactness had made them dangerous.

Salenne's throat closed around a child's word. She made herself use the legal one.

"Witness, can you state your unresolved truth?"

Ink flowed across the first strip: six.

Across the second: rolls.

The rest remained blank. Orsa lacked enough burial black to carry language through the salt cell. Hosting would grant her voice and preserve the testimony. Hosting would take a fifth memory, carrying Salenne deeper into damaged self-recognition.

Ysra put one hand beside the strips, not touching Salenne. "You can demand a hearing first."

"Maelin will classify this as contaminated copy residue."

"She may."

"She will separate the strips from the blade."

"Probably."

"Then Orsa loses coherence."

"Yes." Ysra's honesty offered room rather than direction. "You still choose."

Salenne looked at her mother's divided reflection. For ten years she had believed Orsa vanished because funeral work had finally taken her beyond any trail Olan could follow. Then she had believed Maelin erased her for resisting falsification. Both accounts left Olan as a grieving survivor. The correction marks on these strips suggested something more intimate.

Behind Salenne's eyes, four witnesses waited. None asked her to do it. Even Nera held still.

"I need marked ink and a name shaving," Salenne said.

Ysra opened the worn handle of the copyist blade. A cavity inside held six compacted curls of black reed paper and one thin shaving from a shell token. Orsa had prepared for erasure. She had hidden enough of her lawful name to let an advocate host her if the rolls failed.

Preparation did not make Salenne chosen. It meant her mother had understood the trade.

Using the evidence tray as a mixing surface, Ysra charred one paper curl over a small funeral lamp. She added salt, damp ink from all six strips, and the token shaving. Orsa's reflection gathered until one face occupied the dark drop.

Salenne set conditions aloud. "Orsa Vaud may enter as witness to the six funeral records she copied and the acts surrounding her erasure. She may advise. She may not lend hand, voice, or movement without specific permission. Duration ends after public true account and her freely stated choice."

The salt rings accepted the terms by darkening. The clause named witness, host, scope, permissions, duration, and consequence. If Salenne broke the boundary, Orsa could join the other dead pressing against her name. If Orsa broke it, the marked drop would drive her back into the six strips, perhaps too damaged to emerge again.

Ysra held the tray. "Last chance to delay."

"Delay belongs in the clause when it protects choice. Here it protects confiscation."

Salenne drank.

Orsa entered through her eyes.

A copy room unfolded: six scraped names, Olan standing at the far table, rain ticking through an interior ceiling because erased workers crowded the active false rolls. Salenne reached for her mother's face inside the memory.

The face vanished from her own life.

She retained Orsa's name, height, copy habits, missing tooth, and the fact that people once said Salenne carried her eyes. She could see the face Orsa brought from the copy room because that image belonged to the ghost. Salenne's private image, the one built through childhood mornings and lamplight, had gone blank.

Panic opened her body. Five dead rushed toward it. Tev flinched. Nera pushed strength. Ilyan tried to organize. Lio counted. Orsa alone did nothing.

Salenne gripped the tray until its corners cut her palms. "Name."

Ysra understood. "Salenne Vaud."

"Again."

"You are Salenne Vaud. You hate sweet funeral tea. You correct menu grammar. You once dismissed me after a kiss because you had an apprenticeship exam at dawn."

Facts anchored four to six ghosts imperfectly; free, specific memory helped. Salenne found the edge of herself.

"Five hosted," she said. "Fifth loss: clear image of Orsa's face."

Orsa used no mouth. Her grief arrived as the pressure of a hand hovering beside Salenne's cheek, refusing contact without permission.

"You may speak," Salenne whispered.

Her tongue moved with a copyist's old economy. "I refused six funeral rolls."

The voice differed from whatever Salenne once remembered. Lower, worn by salt dust, impatient with wasted syllables. She could never compare it to the lost singing.

Ysra asked, "Whose names?"

"Tev Orr. Three palace servants who copied the first Concord. One Osteren courier attached to Ilyan Marr. One mason's assistant who carried vellum below the rain court."

Every hosted witness reacted. Tev came nearest, not in fear this time. Ilyan recognized the courier as the person who had carried his evidence into Lyr.

Salenne let Orsa continue.

"Olan brought the removal order. Debt collectors held our rooms and your apprenticeship bond. Maelin offered cancellation for clean copies."

The words landed without theatrical cruelty. Olan had faced debt, his daughter's future, and a powerful official who knew the price of exact language. He had still made a choice.

"I refused," Orsa said. "He copied three. I hid six originals. Peln's predecessor took me below the salt court. Olan signed the amended roll after."

Salenne tasted charcoal. "Did he know they would kill you?"

"No. He knew erasure would follow."

Ysra closed her eyes.

A child's loyalty tried to find a technical distinction. Olan had not tied the cord. He had not ordered death. He had taught Salenne safe clauses afterward, perhaps from guilt, perhaps to equip her against the machinery he had served.

None of that altered the transaction.

"My father sold the names," Salenne said.

Orsa's pressure answered: Yes.

Not only Maelin. Not only Peln. Useful people inside ordinary fear had supplied the system one signature at a time. Olan's culpability did not erase the coercion

around him, and coercion did not erase the names beneath his hand.

“What did you preserve besides these six?” Salenne asked.

Orsa showed a corridor under Crown Salt Court. She had been marched there with a hood over her head, but copyists measured spaces by echo and step. At the sixth salt ring, moisture had fallen from a dry wall. A woman’s old testimony lived mixed into mortar behind a sealed funeral recess. The hidden voice had spoken one line while Maelin’s officer prepared Orsa’s erasure: no ruling blood could own a witness.

Salenne’s pulse quickened. “Whose testimony?”

“Founding sovereign. First Concord. Removed from modern copies.”

The forbidden name had not entered Orsa’s hearing. She knew the office, era, and location, not the identity recorded deeper in the mortar.

Ysra glanced toward the door. A guard’s muffled voice approached. “Can you lead us there?”

“Sixth ring,” Orsa said. “West wall. Mortar patched in a plumb-line shape. Living trial speech wakes it.”

The Crown Salt Court opened to citizens under old law. Trial-by-witness could force Maelin to admit Salenne into that room carrying the five dead. Ardis would know the jurisdiction.

Salenne wrote the location on the back of Peln’s question. Her hand shook, not from any ghost’s lending but from the blank place where Orsa’s face had lived.

The slot opened. A guard demanded the undertaker conclude.

Ysra packed the six strips into separate salt sleeves, preserving the new custody marks. “Can you stand?”

Salenne rose. Five witnesses changed her balance, each memory carrying a different sense of where her body ended. She named herself again and felt Orsa hover without taking anything further.

At the door, Ysra asked the question as if requesting burial classification. “Disposition of the newly identified remains?”

Salenne answered loudly enough for the blurred guard to hear. “Hold for a living trial.”

Orsa pressed the exact route into her sense of distance: beneath Crown Salt Court, sixth ring, west wall, plumb-line mortar. There the founder’s hidden tomb testimony waited to be heard.

Chapter 15 — The Right to Be Heard Living

Maelin offered Salenne's life on a tray beside the casualty figures.

No servant had carried the tray. It sat between them in the closed Rain Council chamber, bearing four reed sheets, a bowl of salt water, and the release order for an unnamed prisoner. Maelin had signed the order but left its conditions blank.

"At the scheduled wedding," she said, "you will speak the Bride Accord without amendment. Salenne Vaud will receive funeral clemency, retain her license under supervision, and leave Lyr with her witnesses intact until lawful discharge."

Ardis did not sit. Eleven councilors waited along the table. Vey Rusk, Lessa Dorr, and Sen Kave occupied three chairs together at the lower curve. The others had placed spaces between themselves and every faction. Rain from the banquet had dried on their formal coats, leaving pale salt rims.

"Funeral clemency," Ardis said. "You have changed the charge from treason."

"The evidence supports unlawful hosting and disruption, not foreign allegiance."

"Because she prevented a compelled declaration of war."

"Because the facts remain contested." Maelin turned the top casualty sheet toward her. "If you refuse the wedding, Osteren's eastern officers expect Lyr to close the Bridge of Reeds. Lyr's garrison expects Osteren to seize the grain road. Both expectations can cause the event they fear."

The figures named living companies, travel times, and likely civilian paths. One hundred forty soldiers could reach the eastern toll sheds within six hours. Seventy Lyr archers held the western roofs. Seven Black Reed villages lay between reinforcement routes. Maelin had not inflated anything. She never needed false numbers when true ones could be arranged toward a single answer.

Ardis took a charcoal stick and added columns the report omitted: bridge crews caught between armies, wagoners sleeping beneath loaded carts, children using the canal path beside the eastern sheds. Sen supplied the cistern records for displaced families. Vey added night-shift dock labor. With each addition, the clean military estimate became a civic one. Refusing the marriage might expose those people. Completing it might give Hal two royal bodies through which to command armies near them.

"Your total ends at soldiers," Ardis said.

"Soldiers initiate the breach."

"Civilians inhabit its route."

Maelin studied the new figures instead of dismissing them. "Then the case for immediate restraint strengthens."

"Only if marriage supplies restraint. The rehearsal and banquet supply contrary evidence."

Lessa placed one salt-stained finger beside the wagoners' column. "Any surety must be judged by all casualties it can cause, not only the casualties used to demand it."

Ardis read every page.

Twenty grain wagons had reached the bridge approach. Fourteen more loaded under Edran's orders. General Sev requested guidance from ancestral officers. Lyr's bridge commander requested permission to raise barge chains if Osteren cavalry crossed a marker disputed since before either officer's birth.

"What order did you send?" Ardis asked.

"No attack without a living breach."

"A useful order."

"I have not mistaken control for cruelty, Ardis."

The use of her name carried aunt rather than office. For an instant Ardis saw the woman who had taught her to tie name-thread after Dorel's hands became too swollen. Maelin had sat through childhood fevers, corrected succession lessons, and never once suggested Nera's place could be replaced. Love did not make her harmless. Harm did not make every tenderness false.

"What happens to Salenne if I refuse?" Ardis asked.

"Fivefold hosting will be classified as contamination of royal and foreign witness lines. The safest lawful sentence requires permanent salt isolation."

"A cell where living speech cannot reach her."

"Yes."

"How long?"

Maelin looked at the unsigned condition. "Life."

Vey's chair creaked. Lessa whispered a curse used by salt dockers when a measure came up false.

Ardis touched no page. "You call that her life."

"I call it survival. She could instead receive sentence for four deaths and a riot."

"Lio's clause killed him. Nera, Tev, and Ilyan died before Salenne hosted them. The riot began inside your account."

"Which a neutral hearing may establish after peace holds."

"Neutrality postponed until obedience has already bound the witnesses."

Maelin's eyes hardened. "People in Black Reed cannot eat your distinction."

"Grain already moves."

"Because Edran defied officers who may remove him. If his Household takes his hands, his living orders end at the first checkpoint."

That risk remained. Ardis saw Edran's blood spread beneath the banquet bowls,

Tovin binding his palm while Osteren officers drew inward. She saw Salenne choosing arrest rather than let evidence become spoils. Each person had acted without certainty that another would follow.

Political necessity often meant forcing someone else to take the risk first.

Sen Kave cleared his throat. "What does the council receive if the heir agrees?"

"Continuity," Maelin said. "One merged Household able to command both armies away from the border until the year turns."

"And if Marr's two hundred eleven dead overcrowd Valev's fifty-three?" Lessa asked.

"Disciplined witness clauses will limit lending."

"Yesterday's clauses failed."

"Yesterday's roll had been damaged and misused."

No one said forged. Maelin had contained that word inside examination while every physical artifact remained under divided custody.

Ardis studied the bowl of salt water. Funeral custom required a descendant to wet fingers before accepting Household counsel in formal session. As a child, she had done it at every council lesson. No one called those moments standing consent. Yet each touch had opened a narrow channel, and repetition had taught the fifty-three dead that council work belonged partly to them.

"Why bring the bowl?" she asked.

"For guidance before your answer."

"Whose?"

"Those who carried Lyr through worse choices."

Maelin pushed the bowl one hand's width forward. Her missing little finger broke the symmetry of the gesture. White scars crossed the knuckle where Silt Year fire had taken more than flesh. She believed the accumulated dead could prevent living appetite because she had watched appetite burn a city.

Ardis had watched accumulated dead force her left hand toward a sword.

"I decline guidance."

The water moved anyway.

One drop climbed over the bowl's rim and touched the table. Fifty-three names had been written in salt beneath the glaze. The dead pressed into Ardis with the force of every childhood lending renewed at once.

Her knees bent toward the chair. A magistrate shaped her tongue for assent. Dorel's memory entered her right hand: the exact pressure her mother used to sign ration decrees during the last flood. An older ruler supplied breath control. Another dead woman turned Ardis's eyes away from Vey and toward the release order.

Maelin had activated no remote force. She had used standing permissions Ardis had granted before understanding refusal.

"Listen to them," Maelin said.

Ardis heard hunger reports, siege counts, burial lists, roads opened through marriages, children saved by decisions no child had consented to. She also heard vanity, vengeance, and the calm certainty of people no consequence could now reach.

Her right hand moved toward the pen.

She caught it with her left. General Hal's possession had strained her shoulder days ago; soreness no longer remained, but the memory of alien balance did. This pressure came from her own blood and felt more familiar, which made it harder to reject.

"Councilor Vey," she said through a borrowed jaw. "Break the bowl."

Vey took up Mera's wooden tally rod. Maelin lifted her palm.

"No councilor may damage the lawful Household register."

Ardis forced her fingers open. "Then I will."

She seized the bowl in both hands and turned it over. Salt water flooded the casualty sheets. Names darkened beneath the glaze. Rather than break ceramic, she brought the rim down against the table seal. A crack split all fifty-three written names.

Pressure tore through her teeth and vanished.

Ardis staggered. Dorel's practiced hand left first. The flood ruler's breathing followed. Legal phrases she had known since childhood dropped out of immediate reach, still learnable from books but no longer waiting in muscle. Silence inside her Household did not mean the dead had gone. It meant she had closed standing bodily access.

Maelin looked less angry than bereaved. "You have severed Crown guidance during a border emergency."

"I have revoked lendings I made before I could understand them." Ardis set the cracked bowl down. "No dead hand speaks through mine in council unless I grant a specific act and duration."

"Your office inherits obligations."

"My office can read records. It can hire living skill. It does not require occupation."

The room had heard her refuse family, not peace. Now she needed a mechanism more demanding than refusal.

Ardis faced the council. "A witness host stands imprisoned without living speech. Evidence from both courts remains under the authority of the official accused by those witnesses. Yesterday I delayed her release because armed people had begun

choosing sides. That delay made me complicit in her isolation.”

Maelin said, “You prevented bloodshed.”

“I also left a woman in a cell because public risk made private harm convenient. Both statements can remain true.”

Ardis drew the old salt seal from beneath the spilled water. A narrow inscription ran around its edge. Salenne had pointed it out during an earlier contract review: any living office accused by unclaimed dead could be tested under public jurisdiction if the host accepted cross-examination and the claimant opened the doors.

“I invoke trial-by-witness,” Ardis said.

The council stirred. One upper-court member objected that the jurisdiction had not been used for a royal dispute in eighty years.

“Unused law remains law,” Vey said.

Maelin placed both hands on the table. “Crown Salt Court cannot admit contaminated foreign dead during armed tension.”

“The statute excludes no origin. That exclusion matters because Houses cannot judge only witnesses they inherit.”

“You do not know what five ghosts will do to Salenne’s body under examination.”

“No. She must choose whether to accept the risk.”

“And if she refuses?”

“Then she remains entitled to living counsel and an ordinary charge stated without euphemism.”

Ardis looked at the eleven councilors in turn. “My sister’s name disappeared from a wedding roll. A stableboy’s name vanished after her death. An Osteren diplomat sent evidence into Lyr and died erased. A cupbearer died under a clause hidden in palace service. A copyist refused six removals. These claims may fail under corroboration. They may implicate both courts, this throne, and me. None becomes safer because we silence its bearer.”

A Household officer at the door said, “Highness, the Remembrancer retains emergency custody.”

Ardis answered without turning. “Emergency custody cannot close Crown Salt Court after an heir invokes its jurisdiction. Open the prisoner’s corridor.”

Maelin’s voice lowered. “If you do this, every dock petitioner and foreign envoy may hear your family accused. The Crown will not control the account.”

“That constitutes the purpose.”

The release order still lay unsigned. Ardis pulled it free of the wet casualty sheets and wrote Salenne’s full name across the blank. She did not promise acquittal, safety, or agreement. She granted appearance.

"I will hear her living," she said.

Vey seconded the invocation. Lessa added the salt office. Sen Kave added civic custody of the court floor. Two wavering councilors joined when Osteren's senior observer requested foreign standing for Ilyan's testimony.

Maelin could have ordered guards to close the chamber. Instead she straightened the wet casualty pages and marked which figures remained legible. "Then the hearing must begin under full law. I will cross-examine every dead claim. I will enter the riot, the compelled account, the grain road, and the host's bodily instability."

"Enter all of it."

"No private recess with your advocate."

"She no longer serves as my private advocate on this investigation. She appears as host and witness officer."

The distinction did not release Salenne from all service. Ardis felt that incompleteness and would not disguise it. Today's act opened speech. Later, if both survived, power would require a more personal answer.

Cistern bells carried the invocation through House Rain Palace. Under old law, Crown Salt Court doors had to open before the third response.

Ardis walked there with the council behind her. At the first bell, civic keepers swept the white floor rings and removed royal chairs. At the second, foreign delegates surrendered blades at the outer rail. Citizens gathered in the rain passage, among them Daro with his basket of burned ration tokens and Mera carrying her bridge tally.

Before the third bell, the bronze doors opened inward.

No screen divided titled speakers from dock workers. No Household roll hung above the hearing floor. At the far end, five salt rings led toward the west wall, where old mortar carried a faint plumb-line scar.

Guards brought Salenne to the threshold with Ysra beside her. Black marked her tongue; nameproof linen marked her wrists. She looked at Ardis, not grateful and not owned.

Ardis stepped away from the central chair so the living court could see them both. Behind her, citizens and foreign delegates entered through the open doors.

Chapter 16 — Queen Beska in the Wall

Salenne's blood struck the first salt ring before Maelin asked her name.

One drop fell from her nose and darkened the white line at her feet. Citizens crowded the stepped gallery of Crown Salt Court. Foreign delegates stood behind the eastern rail. No royal chair occupied the floor, and the absence made every titled person look temporarily human.

Ysra handed Salenne a clean square of linen. "Do not bleed on all five rings. It confuses jurisdiction."

"Funeral law treasures elegance."

The joke steadied her better than solemnity. Five dead moved inside her, each reacting to the open court. Tev smelled lamp oil and searched for a service grille. Nera recognized people who had watched her funeral without asking why the casket stayed closed. Ilyan counted Osteren uniforms. Lio followed the positions of cups, though the court allowed only covered water at the public rail. Orsa measured echoes toward the west wall.

At the center mark, Salenne faced the living Court Speaker, a retired cistern keeper chosen by lot from the old jurisdiction list. He wore no name-thread. Sen Kave stood beside him to keep the salt bell, while three public recorders waited at separate tables so no single office controlled the account.

"State the body answering," the speaker said.

"Salenne Vaud. Living oath advocate and licensed host."

"State all dead carried, in order of entry."

"Tev Orr. Nera Valev. Ilyan Marr. Lio Fen. Orsa Vaud."

Murmurs rose at Nera's name and widened at Orsa's. Salenne continued before public hunger could turn either woman into spectacle.

"Each witness displaced one permanent autobiographical memory. I cannot recall my mother's singing voice, the taste of the cake from my licensing feast, the route through my childhood house, the feel of Ysra Pell's hand during our first youthful kiss, or the clear image of my mother's face. I retain factual knowledge where facts survived elsewhere. No witness may lend my voice, hand, or movement without specific permission stated in this court."

The Court Speaker asked, "Can you distinguish your own account from theirs?"

"Not perfectly. That limitation enters the record."

Across the second ring, Maelin inclined her head. She wore funeral gray rather than royal white. Peln did not stand with her. Two council examiners had him under separate confinement, though Maelin still held the salt chest containing the forged roll.

Ardis occupied no advocate's place. She stood at the public rail between Vey

Rusk and an Osteren delegate. Her close-braided hair carried plain linen. When Salenne named the fourth memory loss, Ardis looked toward Ysra and then away, granting an old intimacy privacy even in a crowded court.

That small courtesy reached Salenne where comfort could not.

The speaker addressed Maelin. "As challenged officeholder and custodian of the disputed roll, you may test each claim. Cross-examination cannot compel bodily lending."

"I understand the jurisdiction," Maelin said.

"Understanding has often visited this room without obedience. Begin."

A few dock workers laughed. Maelin waited until silence returned.

"Call Tev Orr."

Salenne negotiated the permission inward. Tev wanted no view of Maelin. His fear tightened her lower back. She offered him her hearing and one minute of voice, with no hand or movement. He accepted by releasing her jaw until she could open it willingly.

"My name is Tev Orr," he said through her. "I worked the west stable. Seventeen when I died."

His pitch remained Salenne's, but breath broke in the places his living breath once had.

Maelin approached no closer. "You claim to have seen Nera Valev killed twelve years ago."

"Yes."

"From where?"

"Service grille in the Hollow Aisle."

"What light?"

"Two burial lamps. One behind her. One on the floor."

"Could you see faces?"

"Her face when she fell. Not the other face all the time."

The gallery shifted. Maelin had opened uncertainty rather than denied the witness.

"What did you see clearly?"

"Red funeral cord. Pearl-handled knife cutting it after. A hand missing the last finger."

Silence tightened around Maelin's right hand.

She lifted it where everyone could see the old Silt Year injury. "How many people in House Rain lacked a little finger twelve years ago?"

"I don't know."

"Did you see my face at the instant of death?"

"No."

"Did you hear my name?"

"Nera said 'Aunt.'"

"Her Household included multiple aunts, living and dead."

Tev pushed panic into Salenne's lungs. The court began to feel like the corridor where no answer had saved him. Salenne named the sensation silently and kept her feet on the center mark.

Maelin's voice softened. "You were frightened. You saw a killing through poor light. Someone killed you later. Is it possible fear joined those events into one remembered culprit?"

"Yes," Tev said.

Nera erupted inside Salenne. Rage reached for the mouth Tev held. Salenne stopped all speech and raised two fingers, the court sign for witness conflict.

The Court Speaker rang once. "Host retains voice."

Salenne breathed until Nera withdrew. "Tev acknowledges possibility, not conclusion. Corroboration includes the red cord remembered independently by Nera, the cut-bone seal from her false funeral ledger, the service niche matching Tev's work sign, and his erased roll among the six Orsa preserved. None alone proves identity."

Maelin nodded. "Correct."

Her fairness carried its own strategy. If she showed the court that ghosts could be honestly uncertain, she could later dismiss the whole sequence as incomplete. Yet Salenne would not make Tev certain merely to defeat her.

"Tev, do you know who ordered your death?" Maelin asked.

"No. A stable officer took me below after I told a copyist."

"Which copyist?"

"Orsa."

Maelin ended the minute herself. "Return the host's voice."

Tev withdrew. Salenne tasted straw and lamp fat until Ysra spoke her name from the rail. Specific living sound restored the present.

"Call Lio Fen," Maelin said.

Lio requested voice and right forefinger. He wanted to point at the service ledger. Salenne granted both for the duration of his direct account.

"I held cup service under temporary palace order," he began. "Peln Avar delivered thirty-two white vessels in seven service sets. He carried the pantry key in a salt packet and witnessed my declaration of receipt. A glaze oath named my office and bound the hand that poured. When the prepared receiver entered, the

clause traveled into Prince Edran's left hand."

"Did Peln tell you the cups carried an oath?"

"No."

"Did he speak the clause?"

"No."

"Then you infer his knowledge from delivery."

"From delivery, temporary authority, the ledger line he added, clear glaze on his cuff, burial black in his salt packet, and a forged roll under the same wrapping."

Lio pointed once. Ysra brought his service ledger to the evidence table. Two scullery guards testified separately that they saw the white line cross Lio's palm, Edran's hand seize the covered cup, and Lio die after breaking the vessel. Three kitchen workers identified the pantry key and packet. A court chemist placed black reagent in the packet seam; burial-black grains turned toward Salenne's living warmth.

"Ghost testimony does not produce that motion," the chemist said. "Name-token black seeks a licensed host."

Maelin examined the result herself. "Could anyone have contaminated the packet after Peln delivered it?"

"Yes," the chemist answered. "Custody passed through six hands during the riot."

"Enter that weakness."

Lio's finger pressed against Salenne's permission, eager to accuse. She denied the extension. His service ledger gave stronger proof: Peln's line supplied duration until the unity toast, and Lio's neat delivery marks ended hours before his death.

"Who killed you?" Maelin asked.

"The clause collected my pulse."

"Who authored it?"

"I did not see authorship."

"Who carried it?"

"Peln Avar."

"Those are different claims."

"Yes."

Salenne felt Lio understand why she had refused to name legal guilt in the cell. Precision did not weaken him. It placed responsibility exactly where memory supported it.

After he returned her voice and finger, the Court Speaker called a short water interval. Salenne drank from a reed straw without touching the covered court cup. Black had reached the center of her tongue. Five ghosts blurred the edges of

familiar faces. Ysra remained recognizable by gold tooth, body, and manner. Ardis remained recognizable too, though Salenne checked the white linen in her braids as if it were a written label.

At resumption, Maelin opened the salt chest. "I enter the disputed witness roll."

The scraped vellum lay beneath transparent weights. Three copy examiners confirmed replacement fibers under every royal seal. None could date the alterations precisely. Maelin submitted older repair orders showing damage during two floods and one archive fire.

"Alteration does not establish fraud," she said. "Nor does a tool mark establish that the erased person possessed legal witness standing."

Ardis requested admission from the public rail. "I have physical correspondence."

She entered the seven-niche rubbing made in the Hollow Aisle. Salenne remembered holding the paper with her on Day 4, the argument beneath the old blood mortar, the danger of standing too near. That memory remained whole.

Seven crescents crossed the rubbing. Market cipher supplied the missing tool signs, but Ardis had obtained an independent second rubbing before Maelin sealed the aisle. Under angled light, faint impressions appeared: horse knot, rain hook, campaign seal, cup, copy knife, plumb line, empty palm.

Tev, Nera, Ilyan, Lio, Orsa. Five roles matched five erased people without reliance on royal descent.

Maelin ran her fingertips above the paper. "And the remaining two?"

"Unknown or uncorroborated," Ardis said.

"Then the pattern remains incomplete."

Orsa pressed toward Salenne's sense of distance. West wall. Sixth ring. The plumb-line patch held a coldness no open room should contain.

Salenne addressed the Court Speaker. "One hosted witness offers a location tied to her erasure and the founding Concord. I request a mortar examination under living trial speech."

"Cost?"

"The unclaimed dead may press through the structure. If coherent testimony appears and requires hosting, one more autobiographical memory will be displaced."

"Consent?"

"Mine, if the testimony identifies itself and accepts scope."

The speaker asked Orsa's basis. Salenne granted her one sentence.

"I heard a founding sovereign behind the west wall before officers erased me."

Maelin's stillness changed. Not surprise. Recognition constrained into procedure.

"You knew," Ardis said from the rail.

"I know the palace holds many royal remains," Maelin replied. "Disturbing them can contaminate lawful descendants."

"No blood may own the witness," Orsa said, repeating the hidden voice.

At the exact words, water condensed over the sixth salt ring.

Hollow Rain fell in a narrow line beside the west wall. It did not answer emotion or establish truth. Unclaimed dead had approached an active hearing. Mortar darkened along a plumb-line shape.

The Court Speaker ordered the public back two steps. No one left.

Ysra brought a mason's probe, funeral salt, and a clean clay dish. Salenne knelt outside the wet line while a civic keeper scraped one grain of mortar from the patch. The grain contained lime, black reed fiber, cremation salt, and a flake of royal shell token ground too fine for inheritance rolls.

A woman spoke from the wall.

"Who asks the dead to hear?"

Her voice traveled through mortar rather than a living throat. Age had roughened it into several echoes, but no Household cadence accompanied it.

Salenne answered, "A living court asks whether the first Concord allowed ruling blood to own its witnesses."

"It did not."

"State your name and basis."

"I am Queen Beska Valev, Crown Speaker when Lyr and the upriver court first bound grain passage. I ordered my testimony mixed into public mortar. My descendants could inherit my counsel. They could not inherit my witness."

Ardis closed her eyes once. Fifty-three lawful Valev dead had never included the founder whose authority modern wedding rolls claimed.

Maelin stepped to the wet line. "Can you see this court?"

"No."

"Can you know whether current rolls preserve your language?"

"No."

"What did you witness?"

"The first Concord spoken before seven working dead freely named by affected wards. I witnessed its drafting, assent, and limit."

"Recite the limit."

Rain ran down the mortar. "No blood may own the witness, no body serve as surety, and no dead voice bind the living beyond the office freely taken."

The words carried no compulsion. Exactly six eligible dead occupied or

approached the hearing, not seven, and no binding vellum received them. Their force came from specificity and a dead ruler's refusal to give bloodline ownership over public truth.

A recorder asked where the clause belonged in the surviving text. Beska described the paragraph after grain duration and before border-office succession. Ilyan recognized a gap in Osteren's oldest diplomatic copy. Ardis produced the modern Bride Accord; its corresponding lines jumped directly from grain duration to spouse inheritance.

Living documents corroborated absence.

An Osteren delegate requested standing at the rail. "Our oldest copy calls the missing passage a household accommodation. Does your account bind Osteren's first court as well as Lyr's?"

Beska answered from mortar. "The upriver signatory held grain office for one harvest cycle. His spouse held no office under the Concord. Both courts supplied workers to choose the seven, and neither court could replace them by descent."

Ilyan asked permission to speak through Salenne. She granted one sentence. "I died after finding that Osteren's marriage draft turned an expiring grain office into inheritable spousal guidance."

The delegate entered his uncle's erased campaign roll beside the Bride Accord. Matching copy scars appeared after the grain-duration paragraph in both kingdoms' texts. Separate archives had carried the same removal. That did not identify every person responsible, but accident narrowed into policy.

Maelin addressed the wall. "A sovereign may limit her descendants. Why should working dead chosen centuries ago govern people who never consented to them?"

"They should not," Beska replied. "They witnessed one vow for named offices and duration. We discharged them after account. Your copies preserved authority and removed its end."

The answer unsettled supporters on both sides. Founding practice offered no benevolent dead rulers waiting to solve the present. It offered a temporary public function and release.

Vey asked whether wards had chosen by vote. Beska described work assemblies at the bridge, grain sheds, mortuary counters, cistern crews, copy hall, and foundations. Imperfect participation, limited by who held recognized trades, yet broader than blood inheritance. The recorders entered both the reach and exclusion.

Mortar began to pale. The voice had spent what contact allowed.

Salenne addressed it. "Queen Beska, will you enter licensed hosting as witness to the first Concord and its equality clause?"

"What will it cost you?"

"One memory of comparable emotional force. I cannot choose it exactly."

"Can your blood claim me?"

"No. I am no descendant of yours. The court can hear you; it cannot own you. You retain refusal."

"Then I consent until true public account and no longer."

Ysra mixed the mortar grain with burial black from the court archive, salt from the sixth ring, and the royal shell flake. Salenne set terms: testimony limited to the founding Concord; no hand, voice, or movement without permission; duration through public resolution; consequence for breach, return to wall mortar if possible, dispersal if not.

Beska accepted each provision.

Salenne drank the marked drop.

The sixth voice entered through her understanding of law.

Olan sat across a small table, guiding Salenne's childish hand through her first safe clause. He showed her how duration prevented a promise from swallowing a life. His finger tapped the word until. Pride warmed his tired face.

Then the lesson disappeared.

Salenne knew Olan had taught her first safe clause. She knew the principle and every later rule built on it. She could not recover the room, his words, his tapping finger, or the feeling of learning safety from him.

Six ghosts pressed against her self-recognition. Her own name thinned to letters. Blood ran freely from her nose. Ysra spoke from close by.

"Salenne Vaud. You rewrote my apprentice bond to prevent my master claiming funeral fees after I left. You stain your left thumb because you refuse gloves when mixing black. You are here by your choice."

Ardis did not add her voice. Rank could turn anchoring into performance in this court. She held Salenne's gaze instead, asking without words whether help would be welcome.

Salenne nodded once.

Ardis said, "You corrected three errors in my first treaty page and charged the Crown for four because I argued about the third. You chose to continue after I offered release. You are Salenne Vaud."

Specific truth restored the edge of her name.

"Six hosted," Salenne told the recorders. "New permanent loss: memory of Olan teaching my first safe clause. The legal knowledge remains. The lived lesson does not."

The Court Speaker rang the salt bell. "The court recognizes a sixth eligible voice and enters the equality clause as corroborated founding testimony, subject to final finding."

People in the gallery began repeating the clause. Not as a binding. As language

they had been denied.

Maelin let them finish. Then she pointed to the seven crescents on the niche rubbing.

“Six voices do not complete a seven-dead account,” she said. “The founder herself testified that exactly seven freely named dead heard the Concord. Without the seventh, this court cannot know whether the limit passed final assent or remained a draft.”

Her finger stopped over the plumb-line sign.

“The missing witness carried the name Ena Tar,” Maelin said. “Produce her, or admit the testimony remains incomplete.”

Chapter 17 — A Prince Refuses His Fathers

General Sev Marr put the order home on top of the grain manifests so Edran would have to move it before he could count food.

The traveling ossuary's command wagon smelled of bronze, lamp tallow, and the dry reed paper used for campaign dead. Two hundred eleven ancestor tokens filled the ribs of the curved walls. Every engraved name faced inward. In ordinary travel they provided counsel. Under threat they turned the narrow chamber into a mouth.

Edran remained beside the door. His bandaged left palm throbbed with each heartbeat. Tovin stood at his uninjured side, close enough to catch a failed leg and far enough to let refusal remain visible.

"Read it," Sev said.

"I can read upside down."

"Then you know the royal command."

The order carried three living signatures from Osteren's emergency council and nine ancestor seals impressed through their descendants. It recalled Edran beyond the Bridge of Reeds, suspended the marriage delegation, and authorized Osteren troops to secure all seven Black Reed villages before Lyr could close the grain road.

Secure meant seize. Seize meant every village would choose which uniform to fear while wagons sat between armies.

Edran lifted the order with his right hand and reached the manifests beneath. Twenty wagons had reached the bridge approach. Fourteen from yesterday's loading followed. Another nine could depart by dusk if wheelwrights received iron bands. Village allocations appeared in Tovin's compact hand: first to roofs burned during the last raid, then households divided by the border, then garrison stores.

"You withheld this recall until the wagons moved," Edran said.

Sev's ancestor-thread tightened along his shoulders. "I waited for confirmation of the Lyr riot."

"You waited until stopping grain could be blamed on me."

"I waited until the prince's judgment could be tested against the House."

General Hal answered through the wall tokens. The House has tested it.

No living mouth shaped the words. Edran felt them in his teeth, a command cadence worn into him through twelve years of military lending. Hal had taught him formation turns, winter rationing, and the moment a frightened line required a visible officer. Useful skills made the dead general's entitlement harder to cut away.

Tovin scanned the recall. "Which unit seizes the eastern village?"

"Third Reed," Sev said.

"My former company."

"They know the canals."

"They know half the homes. Sergeant Varo's sister lives west of the marker. Two archers have children in Lyr ward schools." Tovin tapped the order. "You selected the unit least likely to fire quickly."

Sev looked toward the bronze ribs. "Hal selected it."

There lay the command chain: a dead general made a politically careful choice; a living general treated usefulness as authority; soldiers received an order with royal seals; any violence afterward would belong to necessity.

Edran opened the wheelwright report. "Nine wagons need bands. Send army iron from the reserve cart."

"The reserve belongs to bridge artillery."

"We are not moving artillery."

"The recall authorizes defensive advance."

"I do not."

Sev placed both palms on the manifest table. "Your authority derives from House Marr. The emergency council has judged you compromised by Valev influence and unlawful witness craft."

"Did any signer attend the trial?"

"No."

"Did any speak to the living prince whose hand the banquet clause seized?"

"They spoke through lawful ancestors."

"Then they interviewed their own expectation."

Hal pressed laughter against Edran's jaw. You sound like Ilyan before he made disobedience into suicide.

Rage moved Edran one step into the chamber. The door closed behind him as a roll-keeper obeyed Sev's gesture.

Tovin turned. "Open it."

"No one leaves during royal command review," Sev said.

Edran tested the distance to the latch, the table, the short sword at Sev's hip. Hal supplied angles before he asked. The old general had planned fights in tighter rooms. Borrowed skill aligned Edran's right foot and compensated for his damaged leg.

He deliberately shifted wrong.

Pain climbed from his old campaign injury. Hal's formation vanished for a breath.

"Do not make this bodily," Edran told Sev.

"I have drawn no blade."

"Neither did the banquet cup."

The ancestor tokens began to click against the bronze ribs. Two hundred eleven small sounds gathered into one rhythm. Sev closed his eyes and lent. His spine straightened into Hal's posture. His right hand curled as if around a field baton.

Edran's own hands answered.

Standing campaign permissions remained in him. He had lent fingers to Hal for map work, legs for marching cadence, voice for battlefield orders. Every grant had named an act at the time. Repetition had connected them into a road the dead could follow.

His bandaged left hand rose toward the recall order.

Blood warmed the stitches.

"Edran," Tovin said.

The prince's right hand reached for the seal block. Hal intended to stamp acceptance with one hand while reopening the wounded palm to blood-mark the order with the other. Royal body, royal seal, living injury made into assent.

Tovin did not seize him. Touch could become another command in a chamber built to recognize force.

"Black Reed, fifth winter," he said. "The east mill had lost its roof. You ordered retreat because Hal said the canal ice would break."

Hal pushed Edran's thumb toward the seal.

Tovin continued. "I told you three children remained under the grain floor. You asked whether I had seen them. I said yes. You believed a living scout over a dead general."

Edran remembered. Snow blowing through broken rafters. Tovin young enough to hide tenderness behind insolence, his split ear still bleeding from falling tile. They had gone back with rope, pulled out two children alive, and carried the third body to her mother. Hal had been right about the ice; it broke under Edran's injured leg on the return.

His right hand stopped above the seal.

"Afterward," Tovin said, "you blamed me for the leg."

"I blamed you for saying the rope would hold." Edran's voice came partly his own.

"It held."

"It removed half my skin."

"You complained more when I kissed you in the infirmary."

Sev's eyes opened. Private truth entered the command wagon like a civilian

walking across formation lines.

Tovin held Edran's gaze. "You asked me to do it again when the surgeon left. You were terrible at secrecy even then. That memory belongs to us. Hal never stood in that room."

The specific account gave Edran a border the dead could not cross. Hal possessed campaigns, inherited tactics, and every permitted gesture Edran had failed to close. He did not possess Tovin's mouth trying not to smile against his, or the shock of wanting a life beyond usefulness.

Edran pulled his left hand against his chest. One stitch tore. Blood spotted the bandage, but the hand remained his.

Hal crowded his throat. Sign.

"I will not lend you my hands," Edran said.

The tokens struck bronze at once.

He revoked by name and scope. "General Hal Marr, I withdraw every standing permission to my hands, voice, posture, sight, and military judgment. No campaign precedent grants bodily access. No seal pressed by an ancestor through me carries living authority. Advice requires a specific question. Lending requires my separate consent, act, and duration."

The chamber tilted. Inherited formations left his muscles. Distances he could once judge at a glance became things requiring measurement. He forgot no campaign, but Hal's practiced certainty withdrew from his bones.

Sev staggered too. He had not revoked anything. Hal used the living general's mouth.

"House Marr removes an unfit heir."

Tovin answered before Edran could. "A corpse holds no office in the Osteren army."

Sev's hand drew his sword.

Edran had no borrowed angle now. He saw only a man reaching for steel in a close wagon. That proved enough. He kicked the manifest table into Sev's knees. His bad leg almost failed, but Tovin caught the back of his coat and kept him upright. The sword cleared halfway. Edran pinned Sev's wrist beneath the table edge.

"Living roll-keeper," he called. "Open the door."

The young keeper looked between royal heir and commanding general while 211 tokens clicked.

"What does your written oath name?" Edran asked.

"Custody of ancestor tokens and accurate entry of living orders."

"Does it name obedience to any dead officer?"

"No, Highness."

“Then enter this: General Sev Marr attempted armed enforcement of an ancestral command against the living commander of this delegation. He is relieved pending court-martial.”

The keeper unbarred the door.

Osteren guards waited outside. Some wore ancestor-thread, others plain campaign cloth. Tovin took Sev’s sword. Edran did not order arrest until the roll-keeper read back the entry and two living captains witnessed it.

Sev fought Hal long enough to speak once in his own cadence. “If you strip every old voice, inexperienced officers will kill people learning what the dead already know.”

“Then we preserve records and teach skill,” Edran said. “We do not let expertise occupy the hand signing its own authority.”

He assigned Sev quarters under two officers without Marr blood. The precaution did not make those officers neutral; it made Hal unable to reach them through inheritance.

Next Edran ordered every ancestor seal removed from active dispatches. Living names, posts, acts, durations, and countersigns replaced them. Advice from the ossuary could enter a separate margin with its dead source identified. No ancestral recommendation carried command weight without a living officer accepting responsibility in writing.

To test the change before orders reached the field, he called the wagon quartermaster, two reed farmers, a bridge scout, and the youngest artillery lieutenant into the yard. The quartermaster spread a canal chart on an upturned iron chest. Without Hal’s practiced estimate, no officer could agree whether loaded wagons would crack the eastern culvert.

One farmer pushed aside three gloved military hands and marked water depth with a pickle skewer. “Your chart predates the silt clearing. The culvert runs shallower now.”

The artillery lieutenant bristled at correction from a civilian until Edran asked which person had crossed it last. The farmer had, yesterday, driving two oxen and a funeral cart. Edran entered her observation under her name. A scout added wheel-rut measurements. The quartermaster reduced each load by four sacks and assigned an extra axle team.

Hal’s answer would have arrived in a heartbeat. Living judgment consumed half an hour, five witnesses, and a changed loading plan. It also identified who could be questioned if an axle broke.

When the officers left, Tovin closed the yard-room door and unwound Edran’s bloodied bandage. One stitch had pulled through the cut from the banquet. His touch remained brisk until he saw Edran’s hand shake.

“Hal?” Tovin asked.

“Absence.”

Borrowed steadiness had supported Edran for so long that its removal resembled fear. Tovin cleaned the wound without ancestor skill, following instructions learned from campaign surgeons and corrected through experience. He tied the fresh linen one-handed against his own thigh.

“You named us in front of Sev,” Edran said.

“I named a memory. He supplied the conclusion.”

“Conveniently.”

“I grew tired of letting dead officers count on our silence.” Tovin tucked the knot beneath Edran’s wrist. “But I will not become proof that your refusal came from compromised judgment.”

“They will use you that way whether we speak or not.”

“Then make me visible as a captain who argued with you for twelve years. Lover can remain true without becoming my only office.”

Edran turned his hand carefully and caught two of Tovin’s fingers. No ancestral witness entered the touch. “Both truths, with limits.”

“Put that in the treaty language and Salenne may recover out of professional annoyance.”

The joke could not hide their fear for her. Six ghosts already blackened her mouth. The seventh might loosen her own name. Tovin squeezed once before reclaiming his hand and opening the door. Private tenderness ended because work resumed, not because either man denied it.

The reform slowed work immediately. Quartermasters accustomed to dead calculation had to verify axle loads themselves. A bridge captain admitted he did not know how Hal had estimated canal freeze. Tovin assigned two living reed farmers to teach him. Losing possession did not produce effortless virtue. It produced work with names attached.

Edran dictated the withdrawal order last. “Third Reed will not advance on any Black Reed village. All units hold present roads under the Black Reed ceasefire. Defensive response requires two living officers to record the observed breach. Rumor, Household memory, or disputed marker history does not qualify.”

A captain asked, “Under whose authority if the emergency council removed you?”

“My authority remains until a living court hears me or the Crown Speaker recalls me under an order free of ancestral seals. Anyone unwilling may state refusal now without Household penalty.”

No one refused. That did not mean all agreed. It meant the order had returned disagreement to living risk.

One captain asked to attach a dissent, arguing that two-officer confirmation

could delay defense during a night raid. Edran allowed it and amended the order: immediate sheltering movement required one officer; any advance beyond held roads still required two. The captain signed both the dissent and the amendment. Written disagreement improved the command instead of branding either man disloyal.

A second officer removed ancestor-thread from his sword wrist but kept it around his collar. "Advice," he said when Tovin looked at the choice. "Not access."

"That distinction enters your own lending record," Edran told him. "No uniform rule can make it for you."

He sent nine iron bands from the artillery reserve to the wagon yard.

By evening, Edran stood with Ardis in the open passage outside Crown Salt Court. Tovin remained at his right, no longer three ceremonial paces behind. Salenne's hearing had adjourned after the sixth witness entered; black rain stains marked the west wall, and citizens still repeated fragments of the equality clause beyond the doors.

Ardis looked at Edran's fresh bandage. "You were told to let a surgeon keep that closed."

"I received competing advice from a dead general."

"Did you win?"

"I dismissed the living man who gave him a sword."

Tovin said, "He also kicked a table with his bad leg."

"Strategic furniture," Edran replied.

Ardis's smile lasted one breath. Then she saw the absence of ancestor seals on his dispatch packet. "What did it cost?"

"Inherited field judgment. Several officers discovered they had allowed dead skill to replace training. The next week will be slower and more dangerous."

"But yours?"

"Hands, voice, posture, sight. Closed unless I grant a named lending."

She understood because she had broken her own salt bowl. No congratulations passed between them. Each had lost useful power while armies remained near the bridge.

Edran handed her the living-signed dispatch. "No seizure. Grain continues. The marriage condition has no place in the order."

Ardis read each countersign. "Maelin will say we have weakened both command structures during crisis."

"We have. Weak command can improve. Possessed command cannot answer for itself."

Tovin's shoulder touched Edran's, deliberately public within view of council staff and foreign delegates. The contact asked a question they had postponed for years.

Edran answered by keeping it.

"There is another truth relevant to the marriage negotiations," he told Ardis. "Tovin and I have been lovers since the Black Reed campaign. Private for military command and succession, not from shame. I will not enter a marriage that requires either of us to pretend otherwise."

Ardis folded the dispatch slowly. Nothing in her expression suggested surprise.

"You knew," Tovin said.

"I knew you looked at his injured leg before you looked for assassins."

"That can be professional."

"You threatened my palace surgeon using six forms of Osteren jurisdiction."

"Also professional."

Edran found himself laughing despite the day. Ardis let them have it before her voice turned serious.

"I will enter your relationship in the confidential treaty record only if you both consent," she said. "Public disclosure belongs to you. Our arranged marriage coerces more than two bodies. I should have said that sooner."

Tovin glanced toward Osteren staff gathering near the court. "Enter that the prince's household of choice creates no claim on command, succession, or my body. If the political record names me, it names limits too."

"Agreed," Ardis said.

Edran added, "When public challenge comes, I will answer it myself."

They stood as allies without pretending the arrangement had become safe. Maelin still held emergency authority. Salenne carried six ghosts and needed a seventh. Armies could turn one frightened report into movement before any revised peace existed.

A wagon officer ran into the passage with bridge mud on both boots. "Highness, first twenty loads have clearance. Lyr's paired order reached the western chain. We need final destination signatures."

Edran used his right hand. The left remained bandaged and empty of Hal.

He signed each village allotment under living authority, then gave the officer a separate instruction for the fourteen wagons behind: proceed without wedding surety, answer only to the Black Reed ceasefire and the named bridge officers.

"Will you return with us?" the officer asked.

"No. Tell the council I remain in Lyr for a revised peace."

Tovin countersigned the dispatch as living captain. Ardis added Lyr's passage guarantee. Three names, no ancestor seals, moved the grain toward the villages

while Edran stayed.

Chapter 18 — The Kiss Without Witnesses

Ardis stopped outside Queen Dorel's chamber because Salenne had written her own name on the door.

The paper hung at eye level in a firm copyist's hand: Salenne Vaud. Six hosted. Ask before entering. Beneath it, Ysra had added: This includes heirs.

Ardis knocked.

"Who?" Salenne called.

"Ardis Valev, alone."

A pause lasted long enough for six dead to disagree. "Enter."

Blue tile reflected one low lamp. The late queen's wardrobe stood empty, its doors open to prove no guard hid inside. Salenne sat at the writing table wearing an indigo coat without her advocate's silver clasp. Court clerks had removed the clasp as disputed office property and left a pale rectangular mark at her collar.

Black reached the center of her tongue. Fresh linen waited beside a bowl stained from nosebleeds. Around the table she had placed six folded labels bearing the witness names in hosting order. The practical arrangement frightened Ardis more than visible blood. Salenne needed written positions to separate the dead from herself.

"You know me?" Ardis asked.

Salenne looked at the plain linen in her braids, the asymmetry of her coat, and her empty hands. "Yes."

Not of course. Not an assurance neither could verify.

Ardis closed the door but did not approach. After the trial adjourned, Crown Salt Court had released Salenne from nameproof custody into Ysra's funeral supervision. That changed the cell, not the hierarchy. Salenne remained the Crown-appointed advocate who had been confined, endangered, and required to carry dead for a peace Ardis's office demanded.

"I brought papers," Ardis said.

"Your courtship improves by the hour."

The dry line had less breath behind it than usual. Ardis set a packet at the far edge of the table and stepped back. "Before papers, I need to hear what this has taken. Not for court. You may refuse."

Salenne's fingers rested near the six labels. "You heard the list in public."

"I heard it entered as evidence. I did not ask what living around the losses requires."

"Why do you need to know?"

Because Ardis wanted to hold every absence as if care could stop it widening.

Because she feared desire had dressed Salenne's sacrifice in nobility. Because love spoken from a throne could become an order even when whispered.

"To avoid making your cost into a story about my gratitude," she said.

Salenne studied her. Six witness pressures altered the rhythm of her gaze: Tev's quick fear, Nera's directness, Ilyan's reserve, Lio's inventory, Orsa's precision, Beska's long view. Then Salenne returned to the surface.

"The singing loss means I cannot hear my mother when I read her work," she said. "I know she sang. Other people can describe the tune. That does not give it back."

Ardis nodded once.

"The cake matters less. I know it contained plum salt because the receipt survives. I no longer taste the licensing feast when I remember becoming an advocate."

No consolation belonged there. Ardis kept silent.

"My childhood house exists as rooms from records," Salenne continued. "I cannot move through them in memory. If someone found the building, familiarity would not return. Ysra's hand during our first kiss has no sensation attached. The friendship remains. So does the fact we were briefly lovers."

Something ungenerous tightened in Ardis, a reflex of jealousy too small for the room. She let it pass without feeding it.

"Orsa's face appears only in what she carries," Salenne said. "I have no private image now. Olan's first lesson survives as law I know, not as a moment with him. Those distinctions do not soften the losses. Records are maps of places I cannot revisit."

"Do the ghosts feel what they displaced?"

"Only when I show them. Ilyan did not know he took the route through my house until I told him. None selected a memory. The black makes room according to emotional force, not justice."

"Can Beska take more without another hosting?"

"Not by remaining. Six voices damage self-recognition and increase sensory bleed, but each entry charges once. Bodily overuse can still cost language, blood, sleep, and judgment. Seven will loosen my living name."

The missing seventh label lay folded at the far corner, blank except for a plumb-line mark.

Ardis wanted to say they would not take that risk. She had no right to decide. "What do you want from me now?"

"The papers."

She slid the packet across.

Vey Rusk and Sen Kave had witnessed its first page. Lessa Dorr had certified

that no burial black, name-thread, salt register, or Household seal touched it. Ardis had written the operative language in ordinary carbon ink.

Salenne read every line. The instrument ended her appointment as personal oath advocate to Crown Heir Ardis Valev. It preserved all earned fees, independent licensure, possession of her own notes, and freedom to testify for or against the Crown. No release condition required secrecy, continued investigation, residence in Lyr, affection, forgiveness, or successful peace. Any later work between them required a separate agreement Salenne could refuse without penalty.

"You released the Crown's claim to my notes," Salenne said.

"They concern your witnesses and your mind."

"The council will object."

"It already did."

"Your fees clause pays the full wedding term."

"You performed more than the work."

"Payment can purchase gratitude as effectively as rank."

Ardis met the objection rather than defending generosity. "Then reject or amend that line. The undisputed amount already sits in an account under Ysra's countersign. Taking it creates no private obligation to me."

Salenne turned to the second page. It revoked every personal command Ardis had issued under the appointment, except Salenne's chosen custody protections at Crown Salt Court. It also prohibited future officers from construing Salenne's continued witness work as implied service.

"Why now?" she asked.

"Because I should have done it when I promised release on Day Six. I offered freedom to stop, but I left the service relationship intact while you chose to continue. That made your choice narrower than I admitted."

"You were trying to keep the investigation lawful."

"Yes. Necessity can explain an error without curing it."

Nera moved behind Salenne's expression, protective of Ardis and furious with her in equal measure. Salenne placed two fingers on Nera's label until the pressure passed.

Ardis continued. "This release stands if the trial fails. It stands if you leave tonight. It stands if you never speak to me privately again. It stands if you testify that my delay helped Maelin."

"Did Vey insist on that sentence?"

"I did. He insisted on 'privately.' He said heirs mistake audiences for conversations."

"Councilor Vey improves your prose."

“Relentlessly.”

Salenne picked up the carbon pen. “The release ends service but not my separate licensed duties to hosted witnesses or the living court.”

“Correct.”

“It does not remove your public duty as heir.”

“No.”

“It does not create a private relationship.”

“No.”

She amended one fee phrase from reward to earned compensation, initialed it, and signed both copies. Ardis signed the amendment. No vow activated. Ordinary ink dried without darkening the reed paper.

Ardis took her copy and said the words without title or euphemism. “Salenne Vaud, you are released from my service.”

The room did nothing.

No rain fell. No ancestor pressed. No clause enforced gratitude. Relief did not require magic to enter Ardis’s knees, but she remained standing.

Salenne put the pen down. “You may sit.”

“Is that a request from the former advocate or hospitality from the room’s current prisoner?”

“It is pity for a woman trying to make furniture constitutional.”

Ardis sat across from her.

For several breaths neither spoke. Attraction had felt safer while impossible. It could live in glances and unfinished arguments, protected by the rule that nothing physical could follow. Release removed the prohibition without removing rank, danger, or consequence. Choice became available and therefore frightening.

“I do not know how to do this cleanly,” Ardis said.

Salenne’s mouth curved. “There is no clean clause for wanting someone.”

“I could ask permission.”

“You could.”

“Would the question itself burden you?”

“Less than making me draft it for you.”

Ardis almost laughed. “May I come closer?”

“Yes.”

She moved to the chair beside Salenne, leaving a hand’s width between their knees. Six labels remained on the table. No part of the room allowed the fantasy of privacy.

“Can they see?” Ardis asked.

"They receive sensory bleed when they attend to the surface. I can deny lending, not erase their presence. They can withdraw attention into their own memories if they consent."

"Then I will not ask you to silence them for me."

"They also have no claim to every living moment because my body hosts them." Salenne touched the labels in order. "I can ask for privacy. They can refuse. If one refuses, I will tell you."

She closed her eyes.

Tev retreated into the remembered warmth of a horse breathing against his palm before fear entered his life. Nera objected that sisters had never respected closed doors, then withdrew to a childhood rain court. Ilyan chose an empty negotiation chamber. Lio went through a perfect serving inventory. Orsa returned to six names before erasure. Beska stood within the first Concord after its dead had discharged.

Their pressure did not vanish. It turned away.

Salenne opened her eyes. "They consent to a privacy interval. No lending, no surface attention until I call or danger breaks it."

"That still leaves legal language," Ardis said.

"It comforts me."

"What duration?"

"Until one of us asks them back, the cistern bell rings twice, or the palace catches fire."

"Consequence?"

"We stop and deal with reality."

Ardis looked at her stained mouth, the exhaustion beneath her eyes, and the woman inside those conditions who remained neither fragile nor invulnerable.

"I want to kiss you," she said. "You owe me no tenderness for release, protection, title, or anything done in council. A refusal changes none of the papers."

Salenne's gaze dropped to her mouth. "I know."

"Do you want me to?"

Instead of answering immediately, Salenne reached across the space and took Ardis's hand. Her thumb rested beside Ardis's pulse. No burial black stained the contact; Salenne's permanently darkened left thumb faced outward.

"I want no witness to make this credible," she said. "No oath. No office. If I forget it later, that will not mean it did not happen."

Then she leaned in and kissed Ardis.

The first touch carried no ceremony. Salenne's lips were warm and dry from salt,

careful only until Ardis answered. Desire moved through Ardis with the dangerous simplicity of something she could neither govern nor justify. She turned her hand beneath Salenne's and held on without tightening.

Salenne drew back half an inch. "Still?"

"Yes. You?"

"Yes."

The second kiss lost some caution. Ardis tasted thick funeral tea and the faint mineral trace of burial black. She lifted her free hand, stopped before touching Salenne's jaw, and waited.

Salenne closed the distance herself. Ardis cupped her face.

No Household guided the angle. No dead relative offered experience. Ardis's recent revocation left her with only the awkwardness of her own body, which made every small correction intimate. Salenne smiled against her mouth when their noses met badly.

"Royal training failed you," she murmured.

"I dismissed the instructors."

"Wise constitutional reform."

Ardis kissed the corner of her smile. Salenne's fingers slid into the plain linen at the back of her braids and held there. Heat gathered where their knees touched. For one selfish instant Ardis wanted the locked door, the two bells, and the whole threatened city to wait.

Salenne ended the kiss before exhaustion made the decision for her. She kept her forehead near Ardis's, breathing unevenly.

"Name?" she asked.

The question chilled Ardis until she understood it as a six-host check, not doubt.

"Salenne Vaud," she said. "You threatened to invoice me for the fourth error on a page that had three. You have just criticized my kissing as a matter of government. You chose this."

"I did." Salenne's eyes remained closed. "And you are Ardis Valev. Released employer. Presently tolerable."

"Devastating."

They separated without pretending distance erased what had happened. Ardis returned to the opposite chair before calling the six witnesses back. One by one, pressure returned to Salenne's posture. None supplied commentary. Nera's restraint amounted to affection.

The cistern bell had not yet rung once.

A knock came at the door. Both women stilled.

"Ysra," said the voice outside. "Miserable timing, urgent masonry."

Salenne admitted her. The undertaker entered carrying the seven-niche rubbing, a maintenance plan, and an expression that noticed the changed room without claiming it.

“Civic keepers copied Maelin’s sealing order,” Ysra said. “All pre-Crown foundation routes close at midnight as contaminated evidence. We have perhaps two hours.”

Ardis spread the documents. The maintenance plan showed rain throats, cistern drains, and later service corridors. No foundation chambers appeared beneath the Hollow Aisle. On the niche rubbing, the seventh plumb-line sign curved at its foot into three short cuts.

“Ena Tar’s foundation mark,” Salenne said.

“How do you know?”

“Orsa recognized the cut family from the mason assistant’s roll. Beska recognizes it from the first Concord.”

Before trusting either dead memory, Ysra opened a civic repair ledger she had taken from the court keepers. Three separate entries used similar cuts beside work no royal plan recorded: a flood bypass, an undertakers’ ash drain, and a foundation inspection pocket. Each entry came from a different century. The signs had survived among workers after official maps stopped acknowledging them.

“Independent practice,” Salenne said. “It corroborates meaning, not this specific route.”

Ardis compared ink age and tile repair dates. The palace had sealed one bypass after the last flood but left the inspection pocket marked active. Maelin’s midnight order named that pocket by a modern number, which meant her office knew an undocumented passage existed even while denying the public plan showed one.

“Could she expect us to use it?” Tovin asked later from the doorway.

“She expects every legal entrance,” Ardis said. “This one begins in my mother’s private rooms. Maelin may assume grief kept us from searching here.”

Salenne gave Beska permission to use one finger. The old sovereign traced the three cuts, then withdrew. They represented down, under water, and turn against drainage. Not a signature alone, but a route instruction used when royal plans omitted workers’ access.

Orsa added the remembered pace between the copy prison and Crown Salt Court. Ilyan recognized the foundation’s foreign measurement marks from an early Osteren treaty copy. Neither could see the current tunnel, so Salenne entered their contributions as estimates rather than directions.

Ardis overlaid the rubbing on the maintenance sheet. The seven niches aligned with seven roofed rain courts only when she rotated the plan away from its formal north mark. Palace surveyors had oriented later maps toward the royal entrance. Foundation masons had oriented theirs toward water flow.

A blank strip appeared beneath Queen Dorel's chamber and continued under the Vow Hall. Two drain symbols interrupted it. The first carried a crossed line indicating dry-season closure; the second carried no closure date. Tovin's depth cord could test that chamber before anyone committed a body.

"Why hide an inspection route from royal plans?" Ardis asked.

Ysra tapped the ash-drain entry. "Workers needed access after rulers declared a foundation finished. A plan held by the ruler can become an order to seal the people who know where mistakes remain."

That logic matched the seven niches: public work preserved outside dynastic record, not through mysticism but through marks passed hand to hand.

"The empty wardrobe," Ardis said.

Its back panel covered an old rain-chain access. She opened both doors and removed the lower shelf. Blue tile behind it carried the same three cuts, nearly hidden beneath glaze.

Salenne crouched without touching the mark. Six ghosts shifted her balance. "Down, under water, turn against drainage. It reaches the Hollow Aisle below the sealed door."

"Can you search tonight?"

"Can I? Yes. Should I? Unclear."

"Then we do not decide alone."

That answer mattered more now. Ardis sent Ysra for Edran and Tovin, then requested civic keepers rather than royal guards. While they waited, Salenne packed burial salt, six witness labels, Orsa's blade, and carbon paper. Ardis changed into a short work coat and took no ancestor-thread.

Edran arrived with his left hand freshly bandaged. Tovin carried rope, lamp oil, and a bridge surveyor's depth line. Neither commented on why Ardis and Salenne could not quite look at one another without warmth entering the silence.

"Maelin posted two Household squads at the public foundation doors," Edran said. "This route bypasses them."

"Which also means no fast retreat," Tovin added.

Ysra distributed decision plainly. "We seek Ena's remains and original vellum. Salenne risks sixth-host instability, not seventh unless she freely chooses hosting after discovery. Anyone may stop before the descent."

Each person agreed separately.

Ardis pulled the wardrobe panel. Old air entered smelling of wet lime and black reed rot. Beyond it, narrow steps descended beside a dry rain chain. A civic keeper recorded their names, destination, entry time, and the absence of royal command.

Behind them, a palace bell sounded the first warning before Maelin's midnight seal.

Salenne lifted her lamp and stepped through by choice. Ardis followed, then Ysra, Edran, and Tovin. The panel closed above them as they entered the foundation tunnels.

Chapter 19 — The Mason Beneath the Vows

Salenne put her left hand against the foundation wall and felt seven names answer through the stone.

Six of them lived behind her teeth. Tev recoiled from the dark water washing over her boots. Nera pressed toward the stair ahead with an impatience that tightened Salenne's jaw. Ilyan measured every crossing as if an escort might be ambushed there. Lio counted the people in their party twice. Orsa recognized the chisel marks beneath Salenne's palm. Queen Beska gave no word, only a grave pressure that made the oldest mortar seem warm.

The seventh name lay somewhere below them.

Ardis lifted the hood from a salt lamp. Its light found a flooded chamber, three brick arches, and a floor laid in square stones incised with servant names. Ysra came down behind her with the leather case that held witness ink and clean reed slips. Edran followed sideways to spare his injured leg, while Tovin lowered the stair cover into place above them.

"No footsteps yet," Tovin said. "That will change when Maelin learns which stair you used."

"She knows every official stair," Ardis replied. "This one belonged to the people her office removed."

At the bottom, she looked to Salenne rather than ordering a direction. The absence of command had become a thing Salenne noticed as keenly as a missing clause. Hours earlier, in a sealed room above, Ardis had released her from service. Then she had asked permission to kiss her, and Salenne had discovered that freedom could frighten her more cleanly than obedience.

Nera stirred at the memory of her sister's mouth. Salenne set the recollection away from the dead before they could handle it.

"This route," she said, touching the wall again. "Ena Tar's foundation mark repeats beyond the middle arch."

Three diagonal cuts crossed a shallow circle in the brick. The sign resembled the diagram beneath the seven niches, but Orsa supplied the practical reading: Mason's correction. Weight moved after setting.

Ysra crouched beside the nearest floor stone. "These names can move."

Water hid the seams until she swept it aside. Iron sockets showed at each corner. Not paving stones, Salenne realized. Name-stones, fitted over channels and shifted by hooks so workers could redirect cistern overflow without breaking the floor.

Edran tested one with his good heel. "The wrong arrangement will drown the passage."

"Or seal it," Tovin said.

A muffled impact sounded above. Dust loosened from the stair cover.

Maelin's people had found the chamber sooner than Tovin's estimate.

Salenne took the narrow iron hook from the wall. Its grip fitted her stained thumb as if Ena had left it there yesterday. Seven ghosts leaned toward the incised names, each carrying a different fragment of the hidden system. Tev knew service knots. Nera remembered being dragged through a wet corridor. Ilyan recognized a defense built to delay soldiers. Lio saw serving order in the stones. Orsa read copyists' alignment marks. Beska remembered work crews whose names her descendants had deleted.

None possessed the whole design.

"Read them aloud," Salenne said.

Ardis raised the lamp. The first row held five names: rope maker, lime burner, cistern diver, reed cutter, mason. Edran and Tovin took the hook together and dragged the mason's stone one socket north. Water rushed into the exposed channel. A low grinding traveled under Salenne's feet.

The next row turned half a span without a hand touching it.

Moving name-stones, not a lock. A civic machine disguised as commemoration.

Another blow struck the cover. A voice above called Ardis by title and demanded that she open in the Crown's name.

Ardis did not answer. "Which next?"

Salenne knelt until the water touched the hem of her indigo coat. The names did not form a lineage. They formed a work order. Reed before rope. Rope before descent. Lime after the chamber stood dry. Mason last, because a mason closed what others had built.

"Cistern diver east. Rope maker south. Then turn the lime burner so the name faces the wall."

They worked without ceremony. Edran's bandaged palm left a dark wet print on the hook. Tovin kept his body between Edran and the stair. Ysra braced a stone with both knees and swore at a dead engineer's fondness for concealed counterweights. Ardis moved where the labor needed her, shoulder under iron, white linen coming loose from her braids.

The final stone settled. Water vanished through the floor in a single throat-deep gulp.

Behind the middle arch, a brick panel opened inward.

"Go," Tovin said.

They passed into a corridor too low for Edran to stand straight. Salenne went first with the lamp, guided by Ena's triple cut. Behind them, the stair cover broke. Boots splashed into the chamber they had left.

A guard shouted, "By order of the Lord Remembrancer, surrender the unlawful host."

Unlawful, Nera said through a pressure that made Salenne's tongue ache. She learned that word after she used a cord on me.

Salenne kept moving. The passage turned twice and ended at a circular shaft where old maintenance ledges spiraled around black water. A rope bridge had once crossed its center. Only two wet lengths remained fixed to the far wall.

Edran examined the bronze rings along the rim. "No bridge. No time to rebuild one."

"There was never a bridge," Salenne said.

Tev's memory supplied the smell of horse sweat and hemp. Lio's mind supplied the sequence of hands passing a tray. Orsa gave her the reading of three abbreviated names cut beside the rings. Salenne understood what the chamber demanded.

"Each ring releases the next ledge. Seven names spoken in work order. The mechanism expects seven workers."

"We have six living bodies," Ysra said.

"Five who can safely pull." Ardis glanced at Edran's palm.

His expression closed. "My hand can pull."

Tovin tied a strip of linen around the bandage without debating him. "Once."

The pursuers entered the low corridor. Their lamps threw broken light across the shaft.

Salenne spoke the first worker's name. Ardis hauled the corresponding ring. A brick ledge pushed out above the water. Tovin pulled the second. Ysra took the third. Edran used both hands on the fourth and made no sound when blood seeped through linen.

For the fifth, Salenne hooked her elbow through the ring. The six voices inside her surged toward the act. She refused their hands but accepted their knowledge, and the distinction drew a line of fire from her tongue to her sternum. Stone emerged under her boots.

The sixth ring stood across the shaft.

Ardis stepped onto the first ledge. "I can reach it."

"You can fall," Salenne said.

"So can everyone Maelin means to bury." Ardis turned her body sideways and crossed.

The ledges held only while weight rested on the previous one. Tovin followed to keep the first depressed. Ysra came after him, then Edran. Salenne waited until they formed a living chain around the shaft. Behind her, guards reached the opening.

Ardis pulled the sixth ring.

No ledge moved.

Beska pressed a forgotten instruction into Salenne's wrist: not strength, but office freely lent. The founders had made a royal hand insufficient unless someone outside the blood named its purpose.

"Ardis Valev," Salenne called, "do you pull for the Crown's inheritance?"

"No." Water reflected Ardis's face in pieces. "I pull so the erased may be heard by the living."

The sixth ledge emerged.

One guard lunged onto the first stone. Tovin stamped his heel over the man's fingers, not hard enough to break them, hard enough to make him release. The guard fell backward onto his companions rather than into the shaft.

Salenne faced the final ring on the far wall. No ledge remained between.

Ena's mark waited above it.

"Throw me the hook," Ardis said.

Salenne measured the distance, the iron's weight, the weakness beginning in her right arm. The six dead crowded her sight with other rooms. A stable grille. A red cord. An Osteren roll wagon. A cup cooling on tile. Her mother's copying desk. Mortar mixed beneath a queen's feet. The living shaft threatened to disappear beneath their recollections.

She threw.

Ardis caught the hook against her forearm. Edran and Tovin gripped her coat while she leaned across the gap, caught the last ring, and pulled.

The far wall split along an invisible seam.

They stumbled through. Tovin cut the retaining rope on the final ring, and every ledge folded back into the shaft. The guards remained across the water with authority, lamps, and no route.

Beyond the wall lay a mason's rest chamber. Lime shelves lined its curved sides. A low table held tools wrapped in waxed cloth. The air carried the dry mineral smell of a room sealed from flood for centuries.

At the center, beneath an overturned mixing trough, a clay vessel stood inside a cage of copper wire.

Ysra approached first. "Do not touch it."

Letters had been scratched into the vessel before firing. ENA TAR, followed by no parent, House, or royal office. A thumbprint darkened the clay beneath the name.

"A mason jar," Edran said, almost softly.

"Not for preserving food." Ysra set down her case. "For preserving testimony

near the thing built. Her token shaving went into the seal. Her bones must lie in the wall."

Hollow rain gathered on the chamber ceiling. Cold drops struck the table, though no active vow had been spoken there for generations.

Salenne felt the erased mason awaken through the water.

The jar clicked once. A hairline crack ran from Ena's name to the thumbprint. Dust breathed out, carrying lime, old blood, and the bitter smell of burned reed.

A woman's memory entered Salenne without permission: two hands laying vellum flat while royal advocates argued over honor; a blunt thumbnail holding a ruler; seven laborers refusing to let either House choose the dead who would judge them. The vision stopped before it became testimony.

"Ena Tar," Salenne said. "I am licensed to host unclaimed witness dead. I know six others who were erased to preserve what you helped make."

The jar scraped inside its copper cage.

Beska leaned toward the mason with the grief of a ruler meeting the worker whom history had stripped from her side. I failed to keep your name in the public roll.

A new pressure answered from the clay. Not forgiveness. Measurement.

Ysra prepared burial black on a shell slip. She mixed charred reed with salt, then shaved the smallest curl from the jar's name seal. "Seven will loosen your name. You know the limit."

"I know the rule."

"Rules do not make the cost smaller."

Salenne looked at Ardis. Wet white threads hung beside her face. A smear of foundation blood crossed one cheek where Edran's bandage had brushed her. Hours ago Salenne had touched that cheek with a freedom neither woman had expected to survive the night.

Ardis held her gaze. "I will not ask this of you."

"Good." Salenne's voice roughened. "I might obey from habit."

Pain moved through Ardis's expression, but she did not turn the pain into persuasion. "Then choose with all the information. If you refuse, we take the vellum and find another lawful route."

At the back of the chamber, Orsa directed Salenne's attention to a lime shelf. Beneath wrapped trowels lay a cedar tube capped with bone. Salenne opened it. Reed vellum uncurled across her hands, brown at the edges and dark with clauses in two inks. Beska's formal hand occupied the first lines. Ena's corrections crowded every margin, practical and unsparing.

The original Concord.

A cut section showed where modern copies had removed the equality clause.

Another margin explained why exactly seven freely named dead had to hear the vow. Seven prevented one Household from supplying a majority. Unowned testimony kept blood from judging its own appetite.

Salenne carried the vellum to the low table while Ysra guarded the unsealed jar. Ardis held the salt lamp over the first set of amendments. No royal names headed them. A cistern diver had required public access to stored water during any border closure. A kitchen steward had insisted that relief grain pass under weights inspected by both courts. Beska had written acceptance beside each demand, while Ena's blunt marks corrected the masonry spaces where copies would be stored.

Edran traced the grain clause without touching the surface. "This could have prevented the first Black Reed levy."

"It could have made refusal unlawful for the offices collecting it," Salenne said. "It could not have filled an empty granary."

"Law that admits its limit." He gave a tired sound that did not reach laughter. "No wonder our ancestors cut it out."

Tovin studied the witness list. Seven occupations stood beside seven personal names. "What made them eligible?"

"Choice," Ardis said. "Each person had received the full text. Each could refuse the duty. None carried a royal name."

Beska supplied more through the ache in Salenne's knees. The seven had sat through four days of argument. They had rejected two drafts and required public copies before accepting the third. Royal advocates later described them as ceremonial attendants, then omitted them altogether. The practical delays that had made consent real became an embarrassment to descendants who preferred obedience at speed.

A smear beside Ena's name drew Salenne's stained thumb. She saw a work yard under roofed rain, not as prophecy or vision but as a dead woman's retained memory. Ena sat on an upturned lime bucket while Beska waited standing. Between them lay a clause that would let the Crown close a cistern during sedition. Ena had crossed out sedition and demanded a list of acts, a duration, and living judges. Beska had objected until a water carrier asked which of his thirsty children counted as a rebel.

The queen yielded. The mason kept the correction.

Then the memory released Salenne. Her body remained in the sealed chamber with cold sweat beneath her coat and six dead crowding her breath.

"Her testimony corroborates the craft," she said. "She did not merely hide this. She altered the law."

Ardis looked from the vellum to the clay thumbprint. "And the throne turned a collaborator into a servant."

"Your throne did." Salenne kept the distinction sharp. "You did not make the erasure. You decide what to do after learning it."

Boots grated behind the distant wall. Authority had begun searching for a route around the shaft.

Without Ena, they held a document. With her, they held the living craft of its making and the seventh eligible dead voice required to speak a replacement.

Boots hammered faintly somewhere beyond the sealed wall. Maelin would find another route.

Salenne counted the memories already gone. Her mother's singing voice. Plum-salt cake. The path through her childhood home. Ysra's hand during their youthful kiss. Orsa's face. Olan teaching her first safe clause. Six empty places, each shaped like a fact she could describe but never inhabit.

The seventh memory would come from her. Not from Ardis, and not from the peace.

"Mix it," she told Ysra.

Ysra's gold tooth did not show when she frowned. "Already mixed."

The marked drop lay black on the shell. Salenne lifted it to her tongue.

Ena entered like a wall settling onto its foundation.

Her spine bowed. Lime burned beneath her fingernails. A lifetime of lifting stone occupied her shoulders at once, followed by the crushing absence of a daughter whose lawful name Ena had refused to trade for royal favor. Seven dead shifted within Salenne, no longer a chorus but a room in which every speaker could reach the door.

Her own name loosened.

Say it, Orsa urged.

"Salenne Vaud." The syllables sounded copied from a roll.

Ardis moved closer without touching. "Salenne Vaud. You corrected my first consent clause because I had hidden coercion inside the word duty."

Specific truth struck through the pressure. Salenne steadied.

Edran added, "You made a prince explain grain figures before you let him discuss peace."

Tovin said, "You noticed which hand I kept near my knife when everyone else watched my prince."

Ysra's voice came last and hardest. "You were nineteen when you sang the wrong verse at your licensing feast, then argued the dead had no standing to complain."

The anchors gave her a temporary shape. Nothing transferred from them. No magic stole their memories. They merely spoke what coercion could not manufacture.

Ena used Salenne's left thumb to point at the vellum margin.

The seventh memory tore free.

A narrow chamber vanished from Salenne's life. A woman in an asymmetrical coat stood at a reed table, but the instant of meeting dissolved before Salenne could keep the angle of her face, the first words between them, or the private shock of being seen too carefully. The fact remained: she had met Crown Heir Ardis in the Vow Chamber on Day One. The living encounter itself had gone.

Blood ran from Salenne's nose onto the vellum case. Ysra caught it before it touched the clauses.

"Read," Ena said through Salenne's mouth, her voice rough as a trowel on brick.

Salenne read the original Concord aloud. Each clause named an office, an act, a duration, and a consequence. Grain passage belonged to toll keepers and quartermasters. Border hearing belonged to appointed judges. No spouse carried a kingdom as bodily surety. The seven witnesses had been chosen by trades and wards, not blood.

When she finished, silence held the chamber.

Ardis watched her with a tenderness Salenne recognized as evidence rather than memory.

"Salenne?"

She knew the woman's title. She knew Nera loved her. She knew she had chosen to kiss her after release from service. None of that supplied the missing beginning.

Salenne closed the vellum tube with hands that remembered law better than they remembered love.

"I know who you are," she said. "But I cannot remember meeting you."

Chapter 20 — When Every Tomb Opened

The first ossuary door opened while Ardis still had foundation mud on her hands.

A crack like split timber traveled through the palace wall above the concealed stair. White dust fell across the vellum tube under Salenne's coat. Somewhere beyond the brick, a woman screamed an ancestor's name, then repeated it in a man's voice.

Tovin looked up the shaft. "That did not come from Maelin's guards."

"No," Ardis said. The Household behind her teeth had gone abruptly silent.

Silence from fifty-three royal dead frightened her more than their pressure. They had withdrawn as soldiers withdrew before a gate broke. She felt them gathered in the roots of her jaw, listening to something larger approach.

Salenne leaned against Ysra. Blood marked her upper lip, and her eyes kept losing focus on Ardis's face. Seven unclaimed witnesses occupied her now. Their presence showed in small disagreements of posture: Tev's hunched shoulder, Nera's raised chin, Ilyan's careful stillness, Lio's counting fingers, Orsa's ink-trained thumb, Beska's straight back, Ena's work-bent knees.

"Can you climb?" Ardis asked.

"I can object to the premise of the question."

"That sounds like you."

"For the present." Salenne touched the vellum tube. "Take this if I lose my name."

Ardis did not accept it. "You carry it until you choose otherwise."

A second impact rolled through the foundation. This time the sound came from several directions. Copper doors rang open in the royal wall chambers. Bone tokens rattled in their trays. Above them, running feet changed rhythm as living guards yielded hands to dead officers.

Edran pressed his palm to the passage. "Hal has reached for me twice since the jar opened."

Tovin moved close enough for their shoulders to touch. "Your hand?"

"Still mine."

"Keep it inconvenient."

They climbed by a maintenance stair Ena remembered building. Her knowledge arrived through Salenne in fragments rather than omniscience. The mason knew where brick had been laid, not what later courts had built above it. Twice they met sealed ceilings. Each time Ardis placed both palms against lime, named herself as a living descendant, and refused the demand from her Household that she lend them speech.

On the third landing, a mortar panel fell inward.

They emerged behind a linen press in the lower wedding kitchens. Heat, steam, and panic struck them together. A cook stood with both hands submerged in a broth kettle while an old voice commanded her to keep stirring for a feast held sixty years ago. Two scullions pulled at her elbows. She did not feel the boiling water.

Ardis crossed the room. "Knock the kettle over."

The senior scullion stared at her. "Heir, the stock feeds two hundred."

"Her hands feed no one if they cook." Ardis seized a paddle and levered the vessel from its brick ring. Broth flooded the drain channel. The cook collapsed when the ancestral task lost its object.

Edran wrapped her burned hands in a wet apron. "Whose voice?"

"Grandfather Pell," one scullion said. "He ran this kitchen during the Lean Flood."

The cook answered through chattering teeth. "He thinks the court is starving."

"He can only use what you lend," Ardis said, though the red flesh of the woman's hands made the rule sound cruelly inadequate. "Do not answer him with your body. Speak your own name."

Beyond the kitchen, bells began ringing without pattern. Not prophecy. Pull ropes ran through family galleries, and possessed descendants had taken them up.

A pantry boy pushed through the crowd. "The west bone room opened. All the trays. Every tomb in the lower wards, they say. People hear anyone named in blood."

Ardis wanted to deny the breadth until she had reports. A ruler who waited for certainty during a fire merely chose which corridor burned unobserved.

"Clear the knives," she ordered. "Cold water on burns. Send anyone hearing commands to the bread court, away from tools and stairs. Nobody ties a possessed person unless they are hurting someone. Use names, facts, and living voices."

The kitchen staff moved because they knew her, not because a dead queen pressed command through Ardis's tongue. That distinction had never felt so fragile.

Ysra pointed toward the service arcade. "We need the Mortuary Exchange. The jar's seal and the rupture may be connected."

"No time," Salenne said. She gripped the press until her stained thumb whitened. "This began with an active counter-rite. The dead are being called along hereditary routes."

Ardis heard a low note inside her own skull. Queen Dorel's voice carried no words, only a mother's practiced warning. Behind it, older Valevs coordinated around a command too large for any one throat.

Open the bride. Receive the larger House. Preserve the peace.

The wedding dominance clause had begun seeking its intended body before a wedding took place.

"Maelin," Ardis said.

Nera answered from Salenne's mouth. "She cannot complete the splice without vows. She can loosen the doors."

"What closes them?"

Salenne pressed fingers to her nose. "The original system separated named dead from hereditary command through chosen witnessing. Modern rolls force every relation into a Household channel. Maelin has put pressure into those channels. We need to replace the governing vow or let the pressure exhaust living bodies."

A crash shook the arcade. Three palace guards came through the steam with swords drawn. Their captain's eyes had gone unfocused. Name-thread on his collar pulled tight against his throat as if invisible fingers held it.

"Crown Heir," he said in a voice too old for his face, "the Bride Accord requires your immediate custody."

Ardis recognized Lord Valev Ossan, dead ninety years, from years of genealogy rehearsals. He had commanded the salt levy against his own dock wards.

"Captain Emon," she said to the living man. "Your daughter broke my north window with a practice ball last spring. You lied that wind did it."

His sword wavered.

"Your daughter is called Pera. You promised to teach her tide knots on rest day. Lord Ossan never met her. He does not know which lies you tell to protect her."

The old voice forced his wrist forward. Tovin caught the blade against a kitchen hook. Edran struck the captain's forearm with the flat of his hand, and the sword fell into spilled broth.

Captain Emon gasped his daughter's name. His knees failed.

The other guards lowered their weapons by living choice.

"Take him to the bread court," Ardis told them. "Remove your name-thread. Do not lend. If a dead officer gives an order, ask for the living law that authorizes it."

They obeyed. No royal pressure accompanied her words.

Salenne's knees buckled.

Ardis caught her under the arms. For one breath Salenne looked directly at her and showed no recognition. Then Nera's anger tightened her face, followed by Salenne's own dry irritation.

"You are Crown Heir Ardis Valev," she said carefully. "You dislike chairs placed higher than the people petitioning you."

"Yes."

"We kissed."

"Yes." Ardis made the answer gentle and unadorned. "After I released you."

"I remember that."

Relief hurt, because Ardis knew another memory would eventually occupy that same blank distance.

The floor rolled under them. A cistern throat in the next court gave a deep, resonant boom. Hollow rain poured from the covered arcade roof, cold enough to turn kitchen steam white.

Erased workers pressed near the disrupted binding. Their unclaimed voices had no descendant channels, so they entered mortar, drains, tools, and name marks. A row of storage jars trembled on its shelf. Lime cracked around old handprints.

"Move," Ardis said. "The rain court gives us a route to the public stairs."

They reached the lower royal ossuary and found its copper doors hanging open. Fifty-three trays stood exposed. Shell and bone tokens had spilled across the floor. Servants, cousins, guards, and clerks crowded the chamber, each fighting a private contest in public flesh.

A laundress recited tax law while tearing her own sleeve into tally strips. A young footman tried to march on a leg broken badly in childhood because an ancestral soldier did not recognize the healed weakness. Councilor Vey Rusk held an old dock judge against the wall with both hands while the judge, living inside his grandson, demanded authority to reopen a drowned prison.

Ardis climbed onto the lowest token table.

"Look at me." Few did. She took a brass serving bowl and struck it against the wall. "Living names first. Speak them to one another. Tell one specific truth the dead cannot know."

Vey understood before the rest. He turned to his possessed grandson. "Joren Rusk, you hate pickled reed hearts and hide them beneath my council papers. Your dead judge ate them every morning. He does not know you."

Joren vomited brine and began to sob. The old posture left his shoulders.

Others followed unevenly. A wife named the scar her husband got repairing their roof. A clerk recalled the street song her brother sang badly. One guard told another where they had hidden tea during the banquet siege. Specific living memories weakened ancestral coordination but did not close the trays.

The Household inside Ardis surged in response.

Fifty-three voices did not need her consent to speak among themselves. They needed it to move her, but the counter-rite rubbed every inherited pathway raw. Her left hand rose toward the royal witness tray. General Hal's influence had once used that hand through the proposed marriage splice. Now Valev dead tried the

same route from within.

Ardis seized her own wrist.

Nails cut skin. Her shoulder, strained during the rehearsal, answered with a deep pull. She held her hand against her sternum until her vision narrowed.

Preserve continuity, Lord Ossan urged.

"Continuity of what?" she said aloud. "The people burning themselves for your unfinished tasks?"

The dead replied with images rather than argument: breached river walls, Osteren soldiers at Black Reed, Queen Dorel coughing smoke into Maelin's sleeve, grain stores emptied during siege. Real disasters. Real fear. None granted a corpse title to her fingers.

Ardis stepped off the table. "Vey, take everyone who can walk toward South Cistern. Its thick water walls may dampen the voices."

"Capacity?"

"Three thousand if the grain bins and tax ledgers move."

"We have more than three thousand descendants in the palace wards alone."

"Then the palace courts become secondary shelters. Kitchens first, drains open, no blades, no open flame. Separate people from the tools their dead remember using."

Vey looked at Salenne. "Can the advocate stop this?"

"She can help write what living offices must accept. She does not owe us her body."

Salenne heard. Her expression sharpened with exhausted approval.

A chant rose from the east passage. Maelin's loyal remembrancers came in two files, each wearing full name-thread. They had deliberately lent themselves. Royal ancestors occupied their posture in coordinated steps.

At their center, Clerk Peln carried a brazier.

"The unlawful vellum," Peln called. "Surrender it for purification."

Ardis saw the attack before he threw. Not fire at bodies. Fire at the cedar tube under Salenne's coat.

Peln flung the brazier.

Ysra moved first. She struck Salenne sideways. Coals scattered across the token floor. A remembrancer drove a narrow funerary spike toward the vellum and caught Ysra beneath the shoulder instead.

The impact turned her. A second attacker hit her ribs with a bronze tray. Ysra fell over Salenne, shielding the cedar tube with her body.

Ardis drew the short ceremonial blade she had kept since the rehearsal. She did not lend her hand. She cut Peln's name-thread at the collar. The stitched strip

snapped, releasing a gust of breath that smelled of old salt. Peln staggered as his ancestor lost the prepared route.

Edran and Tovin met the other remembrancers without killing them. Tovin used elbows and wall space. Edran gave ground on his weak leg, drawing two attackers away from Ysra, then dropped one with a shoulder strike. Captain Emon's guards returned from the kitchen and chose Ardis's side after a single look at the burning tokens.

"Water on the coals," Ardis ordered. "Peln alive."

She knelt beside Ysra. Blood darkened the undertaker's sleeve high on the shoulder. Each breath stopped short on the left.

"Two ribs," Ysra said. "Perhaps three if your floor remains ambitious."

Salenne had already torn open the sleeve. Her hands shook from sevenfold pressure, yet funeral training directed them. "Puncture missed the artery. We need pressure here. Do not lift that arm."

"You always did become affectionate after blood loss."

"Your blood loss."

Ardis pressed folded linen against the wound while Salenne checked Ysra's breathing. The vellum tube lay intact beneath them. One edge had warmed but not charred.

A dying coal touched a bone token nearby. Flame ran across the inked name, not consuming it, activating it. A dead child cried through six descendants at once. The sound tore across the room.

"Put every ember out," Salenne said. "Burial heat opens marked routes."

Vey overturned a water urn. Steam billowed. The exposed tokens went dark one by one, but doors continued to strike open farther through the city.

Reports arrived faster than Ardis could receive them. The dock mortuary had lost three sealed rooms. At the Bridge of Reeds, Osteren ossuary wagons rang from inside. Family tombs beneath dye houses had opened. A barge pilot surrendered both hands to a dead grandmother and nearly rammed the cistern gate. Children with no training spoke burial languages their families had stopped using.

Every tomb did not literally contain a door, yet by midday the phrase had become the city's truth. Every lawful channel stood open. Every erased name pressed against the bindings that excluded it.

The route to South Cistern crossed the fish arcade, where awnings had been pulled down to make shade for the shaking. Ardis walked the first convoy because no written order could show her which alleys remained passable. Two hundred people moved with her, some barefoot, some carrying children who spoke in the accents of dead grandparents. Palace porters pushed handcarts loaded with cold water and folded cots.

At Salt-Step Lane, a cooper blocked the procession with a mallet raised over his

own son's head. An ancestral guild master occupied his stance. The dead man believed the boy had spoiled a royal barrel and meant to enforce an abolished punishment.

Ardis stopped the guards before they rushed him. "His living name?"

"Daro Vim," a neighbor said. "The boy is Kes."

"Daro, you repaired the blue cistern last thaw with green wood because dry staves cost too much. Kes held the hoops while you lied to the inspector."

The mallet trembled. The dead guild master pushed Daro's elbow higher.

Kes stared at his father, too frightened to speak. Ardis crouched until she met the child's eyes. "Give him something the dead man cannot own. One true thing."

"My father sings when he planes wood," Kes whispered. "He sings the ferry song with the last verse wrong."

Daro made a broken noise. His fingers opened. The mallet struck paving stone.

No royal voice had saved them. A child's particular knowledge had supplied the anchor, and everyone in the convoy witnessed how little generic reassurance could do. Ardis assigned two neighbors to walk beside Daro and kept the family together.

Farther on, the street narrowed beside a dye drain. A possessed barge clerk had lowered the flood gate because an ancestor remembered an Osteren raid from forty years earlier. Water rose around the convoy's ankles. Ardis sent porters to the manual wheel, but the clerk clung to it with both hands.

Edran limped through the water and named the living grain truce. "No Osteren force stands in this ward. My soldiers remain beyond the Bridge of Reeds. Captain Tovin holds them there under my order."

The ancestor rejected a foreign prince's assurance. Ardis found the clerk's sister among the evacuees and learned that he had missed his daughter's funeral after a fever closed the roads. The sister spoke the daughter's name and described the shell toy he still kept beneath his mattress. Grief, not force, brought the living man back to his knees.

They raised the gate. Water rushed into its proper channel, taking blood and burial-black residue with it.

At the sanctuary entrance, cistern engineers had marked three queues: active possession, injured bodies, and families able to anchor one another. Ardis ordered a fourth for unclaimed people who had no living relative to speak a memory. Palace clerks objected that the category had no precedent. Vey wrote it onto the board himself.

"Unnamed does not mean unattended," he said.

The first thousand entered beneath stone thick enough to soften Household voices. The relief did not free anyone completely, but shoulders lowered. Borrowed speech broke into fragments. Undertakers began recording living names beside the dead names people heard, creating evidence rather than another secret roll.

Only after the cistern routes functioned did Ardis return to the palace.

Ardis refused the protection of a private room. She made the lower rain court a command station because it offered four exits, running water, and enough floor for maps. Staff stripped ancestor embroidery from blankets. Kitchen workers brought cold grain cakes after extinguishing the ovens. Living messengers marked routes in chalk because old clerks kept seizing ink hands to revise obsolete records.

Ysra lay on a door used as a litter, shoulder bound and ribs wrapped. She insisted on keeping the vellum under her sound arm until Salenne could take it again.

"You are not a vault," Ardis told her.

"Today I am exceptionally well built furniture."

"You have a hole in you."

"Many respected institutions do."

The joke ended in a pained cough. Ardis sent her toward South Cistern with two undertakers and explicit authority to refuse any royal demand, including Ardis's, that interfered with treatment.

Salenne stood at the map table, one hand planted over her written name. Seven witness voices moved beneath her speech. "Maelin used the prepared wedding cord as a sympathetic route. The Bride Accord already names both royal bodies, both Households, and a Day Nineteen term. She has accelerated the opening without completing the marriage."

Edran looked toward the bridge mark on the map. "My traveling ossuary has two hundred eleven named dead. If Hal coordinates them through our officers, he can seize the grain convoy."

"Tovin goes to the Osteren guard," Ardis said. "You stay where we can anchor you."

Edran's mouth hardened. "I command them."

"You dismissed ancestral officers yesterday. Let your living captain prove that order meant something."

Tovin met Edran's gaze. No rank occupied the silence between them. "I can hold the wagons. You can help write the office that sends them."

After one difficult breath, Edran nodded. Tovin touched two fingers to his uninjured wrist, brief enough for soldiers to overlook and intimate enough for Ardis to understand. Then he left with six guards stripped of name-thread.

A cistern engineer reported that South Cistern sanctuary could hold three thousand only if they cleared the east grain bins within two hours. Ardis assigned dock crews, palace porters, and every idle carriage. She ordered the tax ledgers brought up but not burned. Evidence of who had paid for royal continuity would survive the crisis.

"Priorities," Vey said, chalk ready.

"People injuring themselves under dead commands. Children. Anyone whose ancestor practiced weapons, fire, surgery, river gates, or confinement. Keep family groups if their living memories anchor one another. Separate them if they repeat the same dead command."

"Royal Household members?"

"Same order as everyone else."

That decision traveled through the rain court. A few council clerks stared as if equality under triage constituted abdication. Ardis made them carry cots.

At the western gate, Maelin's loyalists refused to open a roll store that listed erased servants. The names inside pressed Hollow Rain through three floors of dry brick. Ardis went there herself.

An elderly keeper barred the door with a copy stand. His mouth spoke in his own voice, but a dead official shaped every word. "These rolls were struck by lawful order."

"Lawful orders can preserve crimes."

"The dead within have no family authority."

"Then they have even less reason to be imprisoned for royal convenience."

Ardis placed her signet against the lock plate and felt her Household gather around the gesture. The old Crown expected her to command the keeper through blood. Instead she turned to the living porters waiting behind her.

"Will you witness that I open this store for public safety and evidence preservation?"

One by one, they gave their names. None belonged to the lawful fifty-three.

Ardis broke the seal with a crowbar.

Unclaimed voices did not pour into bodies. They remained near names, bone slips, old garments, and tools. Their pressure condensed water beneath the ceiling, but the rain softened once the door stood open. Suppression, not mere presence, had driven them against the binding.

Inside lay six rolls in Orsa Vaud's hand. Salenne would need them later. For now, Ardis assigned living clerks to copy every name in public view.

By late tide, the palace had changed purpose. Audience rooms held cots. Marriage kitchens cooled burn victims. Council tables became triage stations. Royal curtains wrapped people shaking from ancestral speech. No arrangement looked ceremonial enough to hide who performed the labor.

Ardis returned to the rain court and found Salenne writing on cheap kitchen paper. She had labeled seven columns with the witness names. Beneath each, she recorded only what that dead person had witnessed. Even while her own memory frayed, she defended the boundary between testimony and invention.

"Your face changes when I look away," Salenne said without lifting her pen.

Ardis sat across from her. "Do you want me to say my name?"

"Not yet. Save the anchor for when I cannot say mine."

"What do you need?"

"A deadline."

As if summoned by the word, Ena took Salenne's hand. The mason drew a foundation diagram around the old Bride Accord's date clause. Beska added the legal sequence through a tightening in Salenne's spine. Lio supplied the serving-order principle: once a binding route opened, its clauses had to be replaced in the order they had begun. Nera knew the murder truth still blocked honest consent. Ilyan knew Osteren's office must accept the border terms. Tev and Orsa knew the erased names had to enter public record.

Salenne wrote until black seeped at the edge of her tongue.

"The counter-rite reaches completion at tomorrow's last cistern bell," she said. "After that, the old dominance clause becomes the only organized route through the open Households. It will force coordination toward the wedding whether we speak it or not."

"How long?" Vey asked.

"Twenty-four hours."

The number quieted the living court around them.

Ardis looked at the work before them. Shelter thousands. Open rolls. Draft a covenant neither realm had used for generations. Persuade offices and witnesses. Expose Nera's murder in public. Bring two courts and two armies beneath one roof without letting hereditary dead take their bodies.

She felt terror arrive cleanly. Unlike an ancestor's command, it belonged to her.

"Can we close the channels without a binding?" she asked.

"No." Salenne wiped her mouth with the back of her hand. "The modern system tied public peace to the Bride Accord. We must replace it using the same opened witness route, then narrow enforcement to offices freely accepted."

Edran studied the old wedding hall on the map. "Both courts already expect a ceremony there."

"Maelin controls the wedding forms," Ardis said.

"Then we do not use her form."

Hollow Rain began over the map table. Drops darkened the cheap paper around seven names while leaving the vellum tube under Ysra's departed litter cloth untouched.

Salenne lifted her face. For a second seven histories watched Ardis through one exhausted woman. Then Salenne returned, uncertain of the first room they had shared but certain of the choice before them.

"We must hold a wedding," she said, "that is not a marriage."

Part IV

Chapter 21 — A Palace for the Unnamed

Ardis found three royal portraits stacked face-down in the bread court and ordered the frames broken into cot braces.

The steward who had carried them there went pale. "Heir, those are the accession likenesses."

"The painted dead have walls in every ward. The living need beds."

He looked toward the Household gallery, where opened copper doors knocked softly in the Hollow Rain. An ancestor tightened his mouth. Ardis waited until the living steward chose.

"Use the cedar frames first," he told the carpenters. "The gilt splits."

By morning bell, palace order existed only where people rebuilt it. Rain courts held burn stations. The southern audience hall sheltered children repeating dead languages. Cooks served soaked grain cold because fire awakened name-token ink. Porters carried roll boxes into public view while council clerks followed with inventories. Every corridor contained someone listening to a voice no one else could hear.

Ardis stood at a slate board beneath the bread ovens and assigned space by danger rather than rank.

"South Cistern has admitted nineteen hundred," Vey reported. Chalk streaked his sleeve. "The engineers can reach capacity if we move the tax archive from the western platform."

"Move it."

"Revenue clerks refuse. They say damp invalidates the quarter tallies."

"Possessed citizens drowning in an alley will invalidate more."

Vey added the order. "Three thousand cots require every platform, including the grain ledge."

"The last grain bins go to the north kitchens. Count every sack during transfer. Hunger remains a political weapon even while the dead shout."

A cistern runner waited beside him, breathing too quickly. His grandmother kept trying to use his hands to close public wells against Osteren poisoners from a war that had ended before his birth. He had tied his wrists together with apron cord.

Ardis cut the knot. "What is your name?"

"Pel Oren."

"What did you do yesterday that she did not witness?"

"I stole a sour cake from the wedding stores."

"Poorly done. Who shared it?"

His fear cracked around a smile. "My sister."

"Keep that memory near. Carry this to the engineers." Ardis gave him the order to clear the tax platform. "Your hands belong to Pel Oren for the journey."

He repeated the words without enchantment and ran.

The palace wards continued to fail. Lime around the west genealogy chamber wept cold water. Servant bells rang from rooms no one occupied. Fifty-three lawful Valev dead coordinated in Ardis's blood, testing her exhaustion for openings. None could move her without lending, but resisting every small impulse cost breath and muscle. By the tenth refusal, her teeth ached. By the twentieth, her injured shoulder shook when she lifted a cup.

Salenne paid more.

She drafted at the old kitchen accounts table with seven witness names on scraps around her. Ysra had been taken to South Cistern, leaving Salenne without the friend who usually noticed her earliest failures. Each time her own name loosened, a clerk read from a list of specific memories gathered from people who knew her. The anchors worked for minutes, not hours.

Ardis did not hover. She made sure water reached the table, guards faced outward, and no one addressed Salenne as royal property. Then she returned to the work only her office could perform.

A delegation from the lawful funeral families waited at the east roll store. Their leader, Mistress Caul, wore twelve lines of name-thread across a red coat. The open channels had lent her ancestors a stiffness that kept changing at the shoulders.

"You have released struck names into public record," Caul said. "Some were erased for treason."

"Some were erased for seeing murder. Others for refusing false copies."

"Opening all the rolls will overwhelm descendants further."

"Closed rolls are already pressing through mortar. Suppression gives them no lawful place except living bodies and death objects."

Caul's eldest ancestor surfaced in her voice. "The Crown cannot equate service names with House names."

Ardis looked past her to the porters, washerwomen, kitchen clerks, and undertakers waiting for access. "Watch me."

A remembrancer barred the inner door with the missing key held against his palm. "Lord Maelin sealed this store under continuity authority."

"Maelin's authority is disputed."

"Not revoked."

That exposed the gap. Ardis had challenged Maelin, but the council had not yet

stripped her office. A Crown command could open the door and reproduce the very hereditary power they meant to end. An argument could consume the remaining hours.

Ardis turned to the assembled workers. "Who has standing to request these records?"

A gray-haired laundry master stepped forward. "My mother's brother vanished from our family roll after he repaired the old rain court."

A fish porter named her grandmother, a palace scaler who had witnessed a tax killing. Three undertakers claimed clients buried without lawful copies. Vey asserted dock-ward oversight of records tied to public cistern labor.

"Then petition in your living names," Ardis said.

The requests came rough and overlapping. A clerk wrote each one on black reed paper. Ardis heard her royal ancestors urge her to convert the petitions into permission from the blood. Instead she invoked the Crown's custodial duty to preserve evidence pending trial, a narrow office power with a named duration.

"Until the living court reviews these erasures," she said, "the store opens for witnessed copying. No token leaves. No line changes. Every petitioner may inspect the name connected to their claim."

The remembrancer held the key tighter. "You will make servants equal to queens."

"No. I will make records answer to the people they record."

Mistress Caul moved first. She removed one thread of ancestry from her sleeve and wrapped it around the key, blocking the dead pressure in the remembrancer's palm. The living man released it.

"Open the rolls," Caul said.

Porters carried long boxes into the east rain court. No curtain hid the copy tables. Undertakers read names aloud while family members corrected spellings and trades. Hollow Rain eased as each erased person acquired living acknowledgement, but no ghost resurrected or entered a Household automatically. Naming created standing, not ownership.

The laundry master found his uncle under a false number. He touched the line with one wet finger and did not ask the dead man to enter his blood. "Put him on the hearing list," he said. "He can choose later if he wishes to remain named."

That choice spread. Some families wanted their dead restored immediately. Undertakers refused without the dead person's consent and a living descendant's separate acceptance. Other petitioners asked only that a name appear in public evidence. One woman crossed her father's name from her private household copy because his voice had abused her for years, then wrote it on the civic death roll where history could retain him without giving him her body.

Ardis watched law emerge from practical refusals faster than it emerged from

royal theory.

A shout came from the north kitchens. She arrived to find six Maelin loyalists overturning water jars beside a group of unclaimed descendants. The loyalists claimed the refugees carried hostile ghosts. Their leader had tied red funeral cord around both wrists.

Among those cornered stood Kes and his father Daro from the evacuation route. Daro's ancestral guild master still surfaced in spasms, but neighbors held him with spoken memories rather than rope.

"This court is reserved for lawful households," the loyalist said.

"No court under my roof is reserved by blood during this emergency."

"Then they contaminate the named."

A jar struck brick. Water spread across the floor, carrying burial salt toward the ovens.

Ardis ordered the oven vents closed. Kitchen workers acted at once. She placed herself between the loyalists and the refugees without drawing a blade.

"The north court becomes the unnamed sanctuary," she said. "Any person without a lawful roll, family anchor, or accepted Household may enter. So may anyone refusing ancestral contact."

The loyalist raised his corded wrists. "By what precedent?"

"By a living emergency order under cistern law. Duration: until the open Household channels close or the council renews the shelter. Act: food, water, rest, and protection without required funeral status. Consequence for obstruction: removal from palace relief work and hearing before the living court."

Specific office. Specific act. Specific duration. Specific consequence. Salenne had taught her to distrust the soft grammar in which ownership hid.

The red cord tightened. A dead remembrancer tried to lift the loyalist's hands toward Ardis. He fought it badly, perhaps because obedience had always spared him the muscle of refusal.

Daro stepped forward. "My grandfather wants me to strike you," he told the man. "I do not give him the mallet. You can keep your hands too."

For a moment the loyalist looked less like an enemy than a frightened descendant. Then he lowered his wrists.

Two others refused. Living guards removed them without surrendering their own hands to dead captains.

Ardis assigned the first cots herself. No dais, no royal alcove, no ancestor screen. A chalk board at the entrance asked three questions: living name, dead voice heard, anchor requested. "Unknown" counted as an answer. Silence counted as refusal.

By midday, the unnamed sanctuary held five hundred people. Some carried no

dead. Some carried too many and wanted none. Children drew their own names on scraps of reed. Undertakers moved among them with empty ledgers, asking before writing.

The first dispute came over a girl called Rian, nine years old, whose lawful family found her in the sanctuary. Her aunt demanded that remembrancers return the child's grandmother to proper Household contact. Rian hid beneath a cot and clamped both hands over her ears.

"She has no authority to refuse a named elder," the aunt said. "Not before majority."

Ardis sat on the floor beside the cot rather than order the girl out. "What does the grandmother ask her to do?"

"Practice thread counting. Our family keeps bridge tolls."

From under the blanket came Rian's muffled voice. "She makes me count when I sleep. If I miss a number, she uses my fingers."

The aunt's face changed, but duty recovered it quickly. "Training can feel strict."

"Training stops when the student refuses her hands." Ardis addressed Rian. "Do you want your aunt to remain?"

After a pause, the girl said, "If she takes off Grandmother's thread."

The aunt stared at the stitched cuff she had worn all her life. Removing it did not erase her elder or settle inheritance law. It merely gave a frightened child a visible promise that no prepared channel would enter the conversation.

Slowly, she unpicked the thread.

Rian emerged. Her fingers carried tiny ink numerals where she had written her own sequence to compete with the dead woman's counting. An undertaker offered oil to clean them. The girl refused and asked for a fresh reed slip instead.

Ardis directed the clerks to record a provisional rule: no guardian could compel a child to lend body or sleep to Household instruction. Funeral naming done for a child required review when that child could speak a refusal. The clause would need debate, an office to hear petitions, and a consequence for adults who ignored it. For the remaining emergency, the sanctuary honored refusal immediately.

The aunt did not thank Ardis. She sat beside Rian and listened while the girl described the counting. That difficult listening mattered more than gratitude.

A second conflict followed at the meal line. Lawful families claimed their dead conferred priority because ancestral officers had once funded the palace granary. Kitchen workers answered with ledgers showing whose taxes had filled it. Ardis ordered equal portions by bodily need and placed the accession silver on the weighing table as collateral for further grain.

"Royal plate cannot be alienated during crisis," a treasurer protested.

"Then lend the plate a spoon and let it feed someone."

The kitchen laughed despite itself. The treasurer did not, but he weighed the next ration correctly.

Edran arrived from the outer courtyard with grain dust on his coat. His left palm had bled through another bandage. "The convoy remains beyond the bridge. Tovin has living officers at every wagon. Hal keeps calling retreat."

"Do you hear him?"

"Every time I stand." Edran lowered himself onto a flour bin. "He mistakes pain for permission."

Ardis gave him water. Their proposed marriage, once framed as peace's necessary center, now seemed almost small beside the work that had replaced it. They had become allies because each had stopped treating the other's body as a border instrument.

"We need Osteren to accept the new offices," she said.

"You will have my signature as heir. The quartermasters need separate acceptance. So do the bridge captains."

"Will they give it?"

"If the terms feed the villages and do not invite Lyr judges into Osteren homes."

"Then negotiate the edge, not the marriage."

His tired smile carried no courtship. "A revolutionary suggestion."

A runner brought a report from South Cistern. Three thousand cots now covered the platforms, including the cleared tax ledge. The sanctuary had reached capacity. Secondary shelters needed another thousand sleeping places before night bell.

Ardis sent the remaining palace mattresses to the dock wards and kept her own bed off the list only because its frame had already become splints.

In the west court, the lawful Household families had begun arguing over whether open rolls weakened their inheritance. Ardis convened them beside the copy tables, where erased names remained visible. She did not promise that peace would preserve every ancestral comfort.

"The channels may close differently," she said. "Your dead may no longer command merely because you share blood. Skills may become harder to reach. Family counsel may require consent each time."

Mistress Caul rubbed the bare place on her sleeve. "My grandmother taught me river accounts in dreams."

"You may ask her to continue. The Concord cannot guarantee she answers, and it cannot force your body to receive her."

"What do we lose?"

"Automatic possession disguised as guidance."

A man near the back said, "We also lose knowledge."

"Yes." Ardis would not make the reform painless by lying. "Tomorrow's city may build worse walls because dead masons cannot seize a descendant's hands. Living apprentices will have to learn. We will pay wages for that learning. We will make mistakes without ancestors to blame."

The admission changed the room more than reassurance could. People began asking material questions: who certified living teachers, how funeral consent could be recorded, whether children could revoke naming done in infancy. Clerks wrote every uncertainty for Salenne's drafting table.

Late light entered no window, but cistern bells marked the sinking day. Hollow Rain continued wherever open rolls neared old binding plaster. Palace staff set buckets under it and used the water for washing, refusing to turn a magical symptom into spectacle.

Ardis returned to Salenne with public petitions, office acceptances, and the unresolved questions. The advocate had moved to a wall so no one could approach unseen. Black stained the corners of her mouth. Seven columns covered the table.

"Do you know me?" Ardis asked.

Salenne studied her face without pretending. "Ardis Valev. You opened the rolls today. You once placed a chair at floor level because the fish guild came with bad knees."

"Good enough."

"Not for you."

"It has to be." Ardis set down the petitions. "I will not demand recognition as proof of feeling."

Nera moved behind Salenne's eyes, protective and furious. Ena flexed her ink-stained thumb. The seven did not agree on clause order, witness authority, or whether royal offices deserved preservation. Their argument shook Salenne's fingers.

"What keeps you here?" Ardis asked.

"Specific truth. My own name, when I can find it. Memories freely spoken."

The clerk reading anchor notes had gone hoarse. He held only six pages, mostly from Ysra and court colleagues. Salenne needed enough variation that no ghost could learn the sequence and imitate it through her.

Ardis went to the unnamed sanctuary and asked for volunteers.

She explained the full cost. No speaker would lose a memory. An anchor had to concern Salenne personally, had to remain true, and could not be coerced. Generic praise did nothing. Volunteers might need to speak before both courts while seven dead contested a binding. Refusal carried no loss of shelter, food, standing, or favor.

At first no one moved.

Then a copyist raised her hand. "She corrected my license appeal without charging because the clerk had put my deadname in the filing."

A kitchen boy followed. "She caught me watering burial black and made me start again instead of reporting me."

The laundry master remembered Salenne reading Orsa's hand on a work roll. Vey recalled her refusing his flattering version of a dock petition. A woman from the fish arcade had once watched Salenne kneel in market mud to retrieve a stranger's scattered name slips.

More people came. Undertakers recorded each memory beside the speaker's living name and obtained permission for public use. Nobody transferred what they remembered. Their knowledge remained theirs, offered as a temporary handhold rather than tribute.

Ardis carried the growing list back to the drafting court. Salenne read the first page, and her shoulders settled into her own posture. The volunteers formed speaking watches so no exhausted voice became the only thread holding her identity.

Outside, the palace dead kept testing doors all across the failing wards. Inside, citizens whom the Crown had erased volunteered the memories that would hold its oath advocate among the living.

Chapter 22 — The New Concord Draft

Salenne pressed the first clause into wax, and the wax tried to close around Ardis's wrist.

"Invalid," she said.

Ardis pulled free before the pale surface hardened. A red mark circled her skin where the test binding had interpreted the Crown shall ensure passage as permission to use the nearest royal body. Edran reached for the bowl of salt water, then stopped until Ardis nodded.

Seven ghosts argued inside Salenne about why the clause had failed.

Beska blamed the modern definition of Crown. Ena blamed a verb that named no worker. Lio identified an omitted serving order. Ilyan objected that Osteren offices had not accepted Lyr's authority. Nera wanted the whole line burned. Orsa reached for a copyist's correction. Tev feared the wax because Maelin's cellar clerks had tested cord bindings on servants.

Salenne heard all of them and lent her hand to none.

She crossed out ensure. "Name the offices that move grain."

Edran sat across the kitchen accounts table, left palm newly wrapped. "Osteren road quartermaster. Bridge captain. Lyr toll keeper. Black Reed receiving council."

"Four offices, four acts." Salenne wrote each title on separate reed slips. "Duration?"

"Three dry months, renewable by public hearing."

"Consequence?"

"Suspension from office if passage is obstructed without a declared shortage verified by both courts."

Ardis watched the door while Salenne wrote. Hollow Rain tapped buckets beyond the drafting court. Every few breaths, someone in the palace shouted a living name to interrupt an ancestor. Three thousand people filled South Cistern. The remaining shelters had begun rationing water.

No abstraction in the draft could feed them.

Salenne laid four fresh wax tablets in a line. Each officeholder had sent written acceptance, but a binding required more than signatures. It required a living person to understand the act before assuming the office. She read the clause aloud. Ardis tested the Lyr toll keeper's tablet with two fingers. Edran touched the Osteren quartermaster's.

The wax warmed without gripping skin.

"Office without ownership," Salenne dictated to the clerk. "Put that principle above the tests, not in the enforceable text. Principles guide reading. They must

not pretend to act.”

The clerk wrote it on the margin sheet.

A citizen anchor at Salenne's left spoke when her sight began to divide. “You charged my sister one shell for a funeral appeal because the law required a fee, then gave the shell back as payment for carrying your ink case.”

The memory had happened to Salenne, and its ridiculous exactness held. Tev retreated from the wax. Ena stopped trying to adjust Salenne's fingers. Her own name returned with a metallic taste.

“Salenne Vaud,” she said.

The anchor nodded and yielded his chair to the next volunteer.

Drafting with seven dead did not make Salenne wiser. It multiplied the number of mistakes available at once. Each witness knew a bounded truth and brought a private appetite. Beska wanted the Crown preserved as a capable coordinator. Ena distrusted any office housed above a worker. Ilyan guarded Osteren sovereignty. Orsa wanted every erased roll opened. Nera would have written Maelin's name into each consequence if Salenne allowed her. Lio cared about sequence. Tev wanted no servant placed near the enforcement route.

Their disagreement protected the text only while Salenne remained capable of refusing them.

Ardis returned to the table with a report from the cistern. “Two families are fighting over whether a dead surgeon may use a descendant's hands. The patient consented. The descendant did not.”

“Then no lending.”

“The patient may die.”

Salenne looked at the clause governing emergency skill. The easy answer would privilege outcome and call the descendant's body an available tool. Old dynastic law had done the same with brides.

“Consent does not become decorative because the need is terrible,” she said. “A living surgeon may receive spoken instruction if the descendant agrees to listen. No hand may be taken.”

Edran rubbed the hitch in his right leg. “Hal knows a field amputation that our living surgeons do not.”

“Will you lend him your hands?”

“No.”

“Would you consent to repeat his instruction?”

“Under a surgeon's authority, yes.”

Salenne drafted a nonbinding protocol beside the Concord. The dead might advise through a descendant who accepted voice alone. A living practitioner retained decision and responsibility. Refusal ended the exchange. No emergency

converted a body into surety.

Nera pressed fierce approval through Salenne's ribs. The pressure hurt enough to blur the ink.

"You agree without using my lungs," Salenne told her.

Ardis's mouth almost smiled. "Does she listen?"

"No. Family trait."

The humor cost Salenne less than solemnity. She bent over the next clause.

Seven chosen witnesses had to hear the new Concord. The phrase could not mean seven ghosts chosen by either court after the fact. Eligibility required a true name, witnessed consent to hear, no automatic Household claim over either office, and direct knowledge relevant to the vow's truth. The hosted seven qualified because each had been erased by the conspiracy or the legal structure it served. Their unresolved truths touched the false Bride Accord.

"What happens after discharge?" Ardis asked.

"They choose." Salenne tapped the witness schedule. "Silence, dispersal, or voluntary naming. No court inherits them as payment for testimony."

"And you?"

"Hosting ends if their truths receive public hearing and they consent to leave."

"That did not answer me."

Salenne kept her eyes on the text. Ardis had released her from service. She had kissed her without witness. Salenne knew those facts, though the beginning of their acquaintance had become an empty room. Want survived factual damage in a form she did not trust enough to name.

"My displaced memories remain displaced," she said. "Seven departures will not restore them. My name may settle. It may not settle entirely."

Ardis accepted the answer without promising a cure.

Edran moved the sovereignty map between them. The old marriage line treated the Black Reed villages as dowry territory. Salenne cut that section from the working copy.

"The villages are neither spouse property nor a single office," he said. "Their canals cross the disputed line. Lyr dredges two. Osteren dredges five."

Ardis said, "A joint receiving council could certify grain and water work."

"Equal seats?"

"Seats by village, not kingdom. Seven living delegates."

"Appointed how?"

"Each village chooses under its existing assembly."

Edran tested the proposal against military need. "Armies keep beyond the canal markers unless the council requests flood labor. Border officers cannot use a

request to quarter troops.”

Salenne wrote acts and prohibitions on separate slips. Mixing them invited a clever officeholder to claim that performing one excused violating the other. The clause bound bridge access for three dry months. It required public weights, village receipts, and posted shortages. Obstruction removed an officeholder pending a hearing. No punishment touched spouse, child, descendant, private memory, or bodily integrity.

They tested the clause in wax.

A small crack crossed the village tablet. Ena showed Salenne why by pressing a remembered mason's plumb line through her wrist. Existing assembly carried no safeguard for villages whose lawful family rolls had burned in war. The dead did not provide a solution, only the observed defect.

“Representation cannot depend on ancestral standing,” Salenne said. “Living residence and work establish eligibility.”

Edran considered the seven villages he had fed as a commander and failed as a prince. “Include displaced households. Raids drove half of Dren Reed across the canal.”

Ardis added, “And no kingdom veto.”

The revised wax held.

Next came hearing duties. Beska wanted Crown Salt Court preserved because its open jurisdiction had allowed the trial. Vey's dock petitioners demanded hearings beyond palace walls. Ilyan rejected any Lyr court judging Osteren officers alone.

Salenne built a rotating living court: one judge accepted by Lyr, one by Osteren, one selected by the affected village or ward. Terms lasted one year. Proceedings remained public unless a witness requested protection. Ghost testimony counted as evidence requiring corroboration, never automatic truth.

Tev pushed forward at the word public. He remembered Maelin's cellar and the service grille. Exposure had killed him once.

Salenne revised. A witness could give a protected statement through a licensed neutral host or living advocate. The accused received substance and opportunity to answer, not the witness's location. No clause promised safety the offices could not provide; it assigned guards, record keepers, and review.

“Better,” Ysra said from the doorway.

She had escaped the cistern litter and arrived with her right arm bound across her chest. Pain shortened her breath. An undertaker followed carrying a stool and the expression of someone who had lost an argument with a patient.

“You are supposed to be lying down,” Salenne said.

“I can object horizontally later.” Ysra lowered herself onto the stool. “The open funerals need language. Half the sanctuary wants to name every dead person

immediately. The other half wants the rolls burned."

"No burning." Orsa's pressure entered Salenne's thumb, sharp with old fear.

"No compulsory inheritance," Salenne added in her own voice.

They drafted funeral consent as a civic schedule rather than an enforceable peace clause. A dead person's name could remain in public history without placement in a descendant's Household. Adults could accept or refuse contact. Children received review when capable of refusal. Erased dead gained hearing, not possession rights. Funeral workers recorded consent separately for witness, descendant, and office.

Ysra read the page. "And people who want no naming?"

"Private silence, unless the name belongs to evidence of public harm."

"Then history can record a killer whom a family refuses to host."

"Yes."

"Good. I have six clients whose relatives need that distinction."

A coughing fit folded her around the injured ribs. Salenne began to rise. Seven ghosts rose with her in seven different motions, and the room tilted.

The next anchor spoke before Ardis could touch her. "You once refused to certify my husband's funeral because I had copied his consent from an old form. You sat with me until I wrote what he had actually asked."

Salenne found the memory: bitter tea, a cracked shell token, a widow furious at precision until precision returned her husband's choice. The details held her upright.

"I remember," she said.

The volunteer answered, "So do I."

They continued.

At midday, a remembrancer brought a proposed enforcement clause from Maelin's remaining council allies. It bound each signatory's descendants to preserve the Concord. Salenne fed it to a cold brazier without lighting it.

"A future person cannot accept an office today," she said.

"They fear repeal," the messenger replied.

"Then require public procedure for amendment. Do not colonize unborn bodies."

Another draft allowed marriage to satisfy joint-sovereignty duties. Ardis crossed it out herself. "No private relationship performs public office."

Edran added, "And no refusal to marry counts as treaty breach."

Salenne wrote the spine in plain language before turning it into enforceable clauses: no blood may own a witness; no body serves as surety; no dead voice binds the living beyond an office freely taken.

Beska recognized her old words. Pride moved through Salenne, but so did

shame. The dead queen had accepted the clause, then failed to prevent its removal. Testimony did not cleanse rule.

"Your failure enters the record too," Salenne told her.

It must, Beska answered through a tightening behind the eyes.

For the first time that day, a ghost yielded without trying to shape Salenne's body. The choice mattered because it remained choice.

They tested marriage directly. A wax figure represented a spouse. Another represented a Crown office. Salenne spoke the new clauses before the seven hosted dead, but only as a nonbinding trial with no burial black on vellum. The office tablet warmed. The spouse figure remained cold.

The next test used living volunteers. Vey entered with Lyr's acting cistern keeper and an Osteren bridge clerk whose office had accepted the grain clause for one hour. Each person read the text privately first. Salenne asked them to explain it back in their own words, because a copied assent could conceal as much coercion as a wedding smile.

The cistern keeper frowned over the suspension consequence. "If I close water during contamination, I risk losing office before a hearing."

"You may close it for a named public hazard," Salenne said. "You must post the evidence and open an alternate source. Unexplained closure triggers review, not immediate punishment."

"And if the evidence comes from a dead engineer?"

"Record who heard it, what the engineer directly knew, and what living inspection corroborates."

The keeper marked acceptance.

The Osteren clerk objected to the village council inspecting military grain. Edran did not invoke princely rank. He showed the man the current convoy ledger, where army quartermasters had hidden spoilage beneath readiness figures. The clerk revised his objection into a narrower protection for troop locations unrelated to delivery.

Salenne accepted the edge and rewrote the inspection act. Consent changed the clause rather than merely decorating it.

They placed a marked wax seal on each volunteer's office token. When Salenne spoke the trial wording, the seals warmed. Neither person's skin changed. She asked both to resign the test office. The warmth ceased at once.

"Again," Ena urged through pressure in Salenne's forearm.

This time they simulated obstruction. The bridge clerk moved a grain marker away from its assigned road without posting cause. Wax tightened around the office token and prevented the marker from entering the closed channel. His hand remained free. The consequence blocked an official act; it did not punish flesh.

Vey attempted the same obstruction after resigning. Nothing happened.

"That permits a dishonest officer to resign and obstruct as a private merchant," he said.

"Then ordinary living law addresses fraud," Ardis replied. "The Concord cannot police every private act without becoming the ownership it replaces."

Salenne wrote a referral duty. Evidence of conduct outside office passed to the living court. No seven-dead vow followed a person home.

A harder test concerned nonperformance. If a quartermaster simply failed to arrive, magic could not distinguish illness from sabotage without inquiry. The old Accord solved uncertainty by compelling the body to attend. Salenne refused that convenience. She assigned a deputy procedure, public notice, and a hearing after repeated absence. Enforcement could preserve a process without marching an unconscious person to a bridge.

Ilyan disliked the delay. He remembered envoys killed while committees argued. Tev remembered servants killed because powerful people called speed necessary. Their conflict struck Salenne as nausea.

"Neither memory decides," she told them. "The living office accepts the risk."

Edran read the final absence clause and signed. "Osteren accepts."

Ardis signed beneath him. "Lyr accepts."

The two heirs sat on opposite sides of a scarred kitchen table, allies rather than spouses, each surrendering the fantasy that perfect enforcement could remove political courage.

They tested a child of an officeholder. Cold.

Private letters. Cold.

A bridge captain's hand during an obstruction order. The wax heated, then released when the imagined captain resigned. Enforcement attached to office and ended when the office freely ended, subject to a living hearing for acts already committed.

"Office without ownership," Edran said.

Salenne nodded. The phrase had moved from aspiration into mechanics.

Near evening bell, the draft lay in twenty-three sections. It guaranteed grain passage, border hearing, public records, sanctuary duties, and chosen witness procedure. It excluded marriage, sex, affection, descendants, private memory, and bodily collateral. Seven eligible dead had reviewed the tests. Living officeholders from both realms had marked preliminary acceptance.

Before copying the final working text, Salenne required every clerk to exchange pages and read numbers backward. Lio remembered how serving order could hide a glaze oath; Orsa remembered how a single altered funeral number could erase a household. Two errors surfaced: a three-month term copied as three years, and a

bridge consequence attached to the person rather than the office. They corrected both in different hands, then recorded who had found them. Precision needed witnesses too.

A volunteer anchored Salenne with the memory of an ink-market argument over counterfeit salt. She recalled losing the argument, buying the salt anyway, and returning at dawn to apologize. The dead could imitate praise after hearing it. They could not manufacture a living person's private knowledge of her mistakes.

The vellum still refused the first binding stroke.

Each time Salenne touched burial black to the title line, Hollow Rain struck the table hard enough to scatter drops across the margins. Nera seized Salenne's heartbeat. Tev smelled red cord. Lio saw a serving tray carried past a sealed door. Orsa remembered six false rolls. Ilyan remembered trusting Maelin with evidence. Beska felt her descendant throne hiding behind continuity. Ena saw blood mixed into foundation mortar.

The witnesses shared one obstruction despite their separate knowledge.

Salenne reviewed the truth conditions. A Concord could not bind honestly while the office offering it concealed the crime that had shaped its current authority. Ardis had admitted personal delay in court, but the Crown had not released Nera's full record. Maelin retained the Remembrancer title. The public knew forged rolls, not the whole murder chain.

Ardis read the refusal in Salenne's face. "What remains?"

"Nera's death."

"I will name Maelin."

"More than Maelin." Salenne turned the blank title line toward her. "The throne benefited from the drowning lie. It kept the roll sealed. It offered your body under the design Nera died trying to expose."

Ardis looked toward the open courts, where portraits had become cot braces and royal rolls lay under citizen eyes.

"What does the vow require?"

"Truth before the people bound by it." Salenne set the burial black aside. "Before this draft can hold, the throne must confess Nera's murder."

Chapter 23 — Maelin and the Obedient Dead

Maelin cut the disobedient names from her sleeve with Nera's pearl-handled knife.

Three Valev ancestors had begun questioning the counter-rite after Ardis opened the struck rolls. Their stitched names resisted the blade as if thread remembered rank. Maelin sawed through each one, dropped the strips into a salt bowl, and tightened the remaining lines around her left wrist.

The missing little finger on her right hand made knots awkward. She had learned awkwardness at twenty-five, when the Silt Year surgeons removed the burned joint without enough poppy milk. She had learned endurance earlier.

Around her, the old remembrancer's rooms listened through their contents. Funeral rolls filled cedar cases from floor to ceiling. Fifty-three lawful name tokens occupied the inner cabinet, though their channels now stood open across the city. The loyal dead spoke through pressure in Maelin's teeth and offered the same counsel they had given living rulers for generations: narrow the choices, preserve the line, survive judgment long enough to become precedent.

Outside the barred door, palace workers carried royal furniture toward shelters. Each scrape along the corridor sounded like vandalism performed in the name of virtue.

Maelin marked their routes on a ward plan. Ardis had turned the bread court into a command station. South Cistern held three thousand. The unnamed occupied north kitchens. Edran's captain controlled the Osteren wagons at the bridge. Salenne drafted somewhere near the lower rain court, carrying seven stolen witnesses and the original vellum.

A beautiful arrangement, if one ignored the next famine, the next ambitious council, the next ruler who preferred applause to continuity.

The dead did not ignore next years. That had always been their value.

A knock came in the pattern Clerk Peln used. Three, pause, two. Maelin opened the speaking slit but not the door.

Peln's face carried a purple bruise from the ossuary fight. "The living guards have warrants."

"From whom?"

"Vey Rusk and four councilors. They call themselves a living court."

"Four frightened clerks do not become jurisdiction by choosing a new adjective."

"The Crown Heir supports them."

Maelin closed the slit.

Ardis had once watched every room before entering it. As a child she counted exits because Nera taught her to escape boring lessons, not because she feared murder. Maelin had kept both girls alive through grain riots, fever years, and

Osteren raids. She had chosen their tutors. She had slept outside Dorel's sickroom. She had remembered which daughter refused reed-heart pickles and which required a lamp near the bed.

No public confession could contain that labor. Neither could it erase the cord.

A royal ancestor called Mother Sera pressed for Maelin to surrender and preserve the office through lawful defense. Maelin tightened the name-thread until the voice thinned.

"Law follows survival," she said.

The phrase had belonged to General Hal before it belonged to her.

Thirty-one years earlier, Dorel had dragged Maelin through a burning cloth market while Silt Year soldiers fought across the cistern gates. Maelin had been ten. Dorel, fourteen, wrapped both girls in a wet funeral banner and made them crawl beneath overturned dye tables. The air tasted of heated salt and hair.

At the alley mouth, a living Crown captain ordered the water gate kept closed because opening it might admit enemy boats. People trapped inside the market beat on the bars. Dead engineers shouted through descendants that the gate could release a narrow flow without lowering the chain. The captain refused ancestral advice as superstition.

Fire crossed the awnings.

Dorel climbed the gate wheel herself. Her sleeve caught. Maelin remembered Dorel's burned sleeve fused to the skin from wrist to elbow, the white linen turning brown while she kept turning the mechanism. Water entered the alley. It saved forty people and cost Dorel the free movement of two fingers for years.

The living captain fled before inquiry.

A dead engineer had known the gate. A living ruler had chosen appetite and fear. From then on Maelin understood memory as infrastructure. People called that doctrine cold because they remembered the fire as a story. She remembered the smell.

Years later, Dorel became queen and discovered that royal dead offered contradictory counsel. She listened selectively, failed often, and laughed when Maelin built tables comparing each ancestor's advice with its result. Dorel had called the tables "my sister's argument against surprise."

Then war consumed surprise faster than Maelin could record it.

Dorel died of marsh fever before the Black Reed raids became an eight-year conflict. Nera inherited her mother's impatience without her patience for accumulated judgment. Ardis inherited the watchfulness. Maelin inherited custody of two daughters who thought love should announce itself as permission.

On the desk lay Nera's sealed-copy ledger, the false one. Maelin opened it to the drowning entry.

Twelve years had not made the handwriting less exact.

Nera had discovered the dominance design in the first peace marriage proposal. She came to the Hollow Aisle carrying copied clauses and demanded public exposure. At twenty-six, she believed a true scandal could cleanse an institution. She did not ask what Osteren hardliners would do when the marriage failed, what grain embargo would follow, how many border roofs would burn.

Maelin had tried confinement first. Nera fought. Tev saw through the service grille. The red funeral cord lay ready for sealing an erased worker's token. Maelin looped it once around Nera's wrists.

Nera shouted Ardis's name.

That memory remained disobedient. It returned in Nera's exact voice rather than Maelin's preferred account. Maelin had pulled the cord across her niece's throat to stop the shout. The body struggled longer than policy language allowed. A pearl button came off Maelin's sleeve. The knife cut her own palm when she severed the cord afterward.

She could have released Nera.

The fact occupied the room with no ghost required.

Instead she called Clerk Peln's predecessor. They carried the body to the cistern channel. Osteren agents supplied a signet impression to implicate a foreign killer if needed. Tev died days later. Orsa refused six corrected rolls and therefore had to vanish from lawful record. Each later act protected the first. Protection accumulated until it resembled governance.

Maelin did not tell herself she had saved Nera. She had murdered her. The word belonged to fact.

She told herself the murder prevented a war.

For four years, it did.

Then Black Reed burned anyway.

The loyal ancestors shifted. Some urged silence. Others offered the arithmetic of alternate casualties. If Nera had exposed the design, Osteren might have invaded earlier. If the Bride Accord had held, eight years of border war might have ended before the third. Counterfactual dead made excellent accomplices because no living court could cross-examine events that never occurred.

Maelin shut the ledger.

A message scratched itself across the prepared wax beside her hand. General Hal did not move objects at distance. His living descendant, an ossuary keeper outside the palace, wrote on paired burial wax under voluntary lending. Maelin had arranged the set years ago.

EDRAN RESISTS. OFFICERS DIVIDED. COMPLETE DOMINANCE AT CEREMONY. I WILL TAKE THE PRINCE.

General Hal's bargain had begun twelve years earlier. Osteren hardliners would help conceal Nera's death and Ilyan's evidence. In return, Maelin would preserve a

marriage draft allowing the larger Marr Household to coordinate both heirs. Hal imagined conquest. Maelin imagined containing Hal inside a balanced ceremonial system after the splice.

Each believed the other manageable.

Ilyan had discovered the bargain and sent Maelin proof, trusting her love for Dorel's daughters. She used his trust to identify Osteren dissent. Hal's allies recorded his murder as suicide. Later, Maelin had his roll erased when his ghost continued pressing against the lie.

The wax warmed again.

GIVE THE CORD. OPEN THE BRIDE. OBEDIENCE OUTLIVES GRIEF.

Maelin stared at the final sentence. Hal meant that trained dead persisted after living sentiment weakened. He considered it praise.

Obedience outlives grief. That had become Maelin's doctrine too, though she had arrived by another road. Grief changed direction, contradicted itself, forgave at inconvenient hours. Obedience offered repetition. A hand trained by five generations could close the same gate every time.

It could also close the wrong gate for forty years.

Maelin pressed her damaged right hand flat over the wax and felt no little finger answer. The dead carried every sensation they had known, yet none could restore the part fire and surgery removed. Continuity did not equal wholeness. She had always known. She had simply found wholeness politically irrelevant.

"Tell Hal the ceremony proceeds," she instructed Peln through the slit.

The clerk hesitated. "The Crown may confess tonight."

"She will confess."

"You sound certain."

"Ardis mistakes self-accusation for freedom. She will tell the whole city that her throne concealed murder, believing shame can become foundation."

"What happens to your office?"

"If the dominance clause takes both heirs, office will no longer depend on a council's courage."

Peln lowered his gaze. He had carried the glaze oath that killed Lio Fen. He had served Maelin for seventeen years and still expected her to protect him from consequences. Loyalty often concealed a private invoice.

"Do you wish to lend yourself at the ceremony?" she asked.

His head rose sharply. "To whom?"

"Remembrancer Sera. She knows the witness sequence."

"For how long?"

"Until the old vow takes."

He understood that no honest duration existed. "I will carry the cord."

"A courier can do that."

Relief entered his face before he hid it. "Then use a courier."

Maelin watched him leave. She had demanded sacrifice from Nera, Tev, Ilyan, Orsa, Lio, Salenne, Ardis, and Edran. When her loyal clerk refused with a downward glance, she permitted evasion because coercing him openly would expose the doctrine beneath her care.

The dead noticed.

Mother Sera withdrew her support. Two military Valevs followed. Maelin cut their names from her other sleeve. Her available chorus narrowed to the most obedient, which also narrowed the counsel they could give. Control made poor information. She accepted the defect because time had run out.

The inner cabinet began to knock.

Fifty-three token drawers occupied seven rows. Not every dead Valev possessed a living descendant near enough for easy speech, but the counter-rite had opened all lawful routes. Pressure traveled from drawer to blood and back again. The remaining loyalists wanted their tokens moved into a ceremonial basin, where salt water would join their voices before Maelin lent herself.

She opened the cabinet and read the names she meant to empower.

Lord Ossan had drowned a prison rather than let dock petitioners free its captives. Remembrancer Sera had preserved three censuses through war and erased a fourth when it threatened succession. General Arven knew canal defense but had ordered grain burned during retreat. Their competence remained real. So did the harm they called necessity.

A younger version of Maelin had built comparative tables precisely because ancestry alone did not make advice sound. Tonight she chose these dead because they agreed.

The recognition did not stop her. It required her to abandon the defense that she acted from ignorance.

One token belonged to Queen Dorel. Maelin lifted it from the drawer. Shell warmed against the scar where her little finger had ended. Dorel knew statecraft, flood gates, and the cost of issuing an order while fever narrowed thought. She also knew Maelin before doctrine consumed every private room.

"Will you lend?" Maelin asked.

The token cooled.

A lawful dead voice could refuse. Modern remembrancers rarely taught that part because descendants interpreted silence as weakness in themselves. Maelin had spent a career translating ancestral pressure into duty. Dorel's refusal carried no sentence, yet its absence changed the room.

Maelin returned the token instead of adding it to the basin.

From another drawer she took Queen Haret, who had negotiated the first Osteren canal truce and broken it six months later when toll revenues fell. Haret offered her speech readily. So did Ossan. So did three remembrancers whose terms had expanded funeral authority after convenient emergencies. Consent among the dead did not cleanse purpose any more than Maelin's willingness to sacrifice herself cleansed murder.

She arranged twelve tokens in salt water. The number gave enough coordinated pressure to hold Ardis's smaller household faction until Hal entered through Edran. It also crossed the safe limit for voluntary lending. Once the first ancestor took Maelin's voice, the others could use the opened channel to coordinate posture and hands.

A drop of blood from her damaged hand entered the basin. Warmth climbed her wrist. The dead supplied remembered skills: Haret's treaty cadence, Ossan's command posture, Sera's witness order. Maelin retained control because she had not spoken acceptance.

She tested the release phrase. "The living holder closes the office."

The pressure withdrew slowly.

Too slowly.

At the ceremony, no one would grant her the quiet needed to repeat a release. Ardis might cut the name-thread. Salenne might alter the clause route. Nera might speak through the host and break Maelin's concentration with the voice from the Hollow Aisle.

Maelin wrapped each token separately so collision could not open the basin early. Her preparations resembled funeral care. That resemblance had hidden many crimes.

Next she reviewed the list of citizen anchors Peln had copied. Several memories named Salenne's errors rather than praising her. Maelin admired the design. Generic loyalty could be counterfeited; private imperfection held a living person more securely. Disrupting the testimony order would require fear, not false memories.

She marked three anchor speakers whose families had lawful dead still pressing in the palace. Peln's remembrancers would not attack them. They would whisper that speaking might let Salenne's ghosts follow the memory home. The claim had no basis in hosting law. During a crisis, a plausible lie needed only one frightened heartbeat.

Maelin set the list beside Nera's false ledger. She could see every choice as an isolated measure with a limited purpose. Together they formed a system that used uncertainty as cord.

From a locked drawer she removed the original red cord, still preserved as the

long loop that had bound wrists before it closed a throat.

Age had darkened it almost brown. One section retained Nera's blood beneath the sealing salts. Tev's death object had touched another part. The cord connected murder, erased rolls, and the Bride Accord's prepared route. During the ceremony, Maelin could lay it across the old vellum and let the open Household channels recognize the unresolved truth as command pressure.

The new Concord might name consent. The old cord would name continuity in blood.

Maelin prepared three measures. First, paired wax told Hal to seize Edran only after the seven witnesses began, so Osteren ancestry would appear to answer unlawful hosting rather than initiate attack. Second, Peln would place loyal remembrancers among the citizen anchors and disrupt their testimony order. Third, Maelin would lend her own body to the remaining Valev dead.

Her office allowed voluntary lending to one ancestor. The dominance design would coordinate many. She knew the risk: speech, posture, and hands could pass beyond retrieval. If living rulers could not preserve the line, she would make herself a door and let accumulated rule walk through.

No one else paid that particular cost.

It did not absolve the costs she imposed on them.

A soft knock sounded from the archive wall. Not Peln's pattern. Hollow Rain gathered above the oldest roll cabinet. Erased workers pressed close to the active cord. Water fell onto Maelin's control map and blurred the lines leading to South Cistern.

She moved the cord away from the drops.

Dorel's low Household presence touched her damaged hand. Her sister had never spoken clearly from the lawful chorus. Fever death left broken impressions: cool cloth, daughters arguing, Maelin asleep beside the bed. Now the pressure formed a refusal in the tendons.

Maelin closed her fist.

"You left me with a city that burns," she whispered.

Dorel offered no defense. The dead queen had not witnessed Nera's murder and could not judge its facts. She knew only the sister who had stayed, served, and turned grief into rooms no living person could leave.

That limited knowledge hurt more than condemnation.

Maelin changed into ceremonial white. The coat had no name-thread because her body would supply the route. She bound the missing finger's side of her hand with linen so the grip would not slip. Into one pocket went the pearl-handled knife. Into another went General Hal's paired wax.

Before leaving, she read the false drowning entry once more. She could destroy it and force Ardis to rely on ghost testimony. Instead she left it on the desk. Some

part of her still wanted the record to reveal the quality of the adversary required to defeat her.

Vanity, perhaps. Or the final disorder grief had preserved.

She cut away the bloodstained section and placed it in a plain courier box. The longer remainder, including the fibers that had touched Tev's death token, went around her waist beneath the ceremonial coat. Both lengths retained the same continuous funeral preparation. She sealed the box with the Lord Remembrancer's mark. On the lid she wrote a direction to the central rain court, where the old wedding would begin.

A junior page waited outside, stripped of ancestor thread and visibly afraid.

"Deliver this to Crown Heir Ardis," Maelin said.

"What is inside?"

"The evidence she intends to name."

The page did not reach for it. "Will it hurt me?"

Maelin could have commanded him under palace service. She could have lied.

"Not if you keep the box closed."

He considered, then accepted it with both hands by his own poor, frightened choice.

Maelin watched him carry the bloodstained section toward the wedding hall as a challenge no confession could avoid.

Chapter 24 — The Throne Confesses Murder

Ardis placed Nera's ledger on the rain court floor because no dais remained.

Cots had taken the raised platform. The royal canopy covered a burn station. Citizens filled the seven arcades while clerks repeated each statement toward the outer courts and messenger lines carried it to South Cistern. Beyond the Bridge of Reeds, two armies waited beside a grain convoy that could still become relief or spoil.

The courier box rested near Ardis's feet. Guards had inspected its hinges without breaking Maelin's seal. Burial salt leaked from one corner. Nera's red cord lay inside, close enough that Ardis's Household recoiled from it.

Edran stood to her right in an undecorated military coat. Tovin remained at the bridge, holding the living command. Vey and six councilors occupied ordinary chairs to her left. Salenne waited behind the witness table with black at the edges of her tongue and seven histories crowding her posture.

Ardis wanted to look at her longer. The city had assembled to hear a murder, not witness a private fear.

"Read the jurisdiction," Ardis told Vey.

He rose. "Crown Salt Court sits in emergency public session under trial-by-witness law. Present are ward councilors, Lyr record officers, Osteren observers, undertakers licensed in both realms, and citizens with standing from erased funeral rolls. No Household voice may hold a voting place. Living officeholders answer in their own names."

A councilor descended from three queens objected. "The Crown Heir cannot be both accused institution and presiding authority."

"I do not preside," Ardis said. "I give evidence."

The distinction moved through the crowd. Some approved. Others heard abdication. Her fifty-three dead heard treason against their accumulated identity and pressed hard against her teeth.

Ardis spoke her living name before they could borrow it.

"I am Ardis Valev, Crown Heir of Lyr. I accepted the official account of my sister's death for twelve years. When evidence contradicted it, I delayed public accusation while seeking proof and preserving a marriage negotiation. That delay protected the office that profited from her silence."

No ancestor compelled the words. Shame did not make them magically true. Documents and witnesses would have to carry fact.

She opened Nera's ledger.

"The lawful copy records Nera Valev as drowned in the east cistern. The cut bone seal bears a replacement notch. No recovery officer signed. No wet-cloth

inventory exists. Her name disappeared from the wedding roll of fifty-three lawful dead."

Clerks lifted enlarged copies for the arcades. Undertakers testified to the missing funeral requirements. Ysra's written statement came from South Cistern because her shoulder and ribs prevented travel. It described the altered seal, burial black composition, and six related rolls in Orsa Vaud's hand.

Ardis held up the false entry. "This record did not result from one clerk's private crime. The Lord Remembrancer's office sealed it. The Crown archive preserved it. My succession benefited when an elder heir became a drowning victim rather than a murdered dissenter."

Nera moved inside Salenne, pain visible in the sudden angle of her chin.

"The throne concealed her murder," Ardis said.

Hollow Rain struck the covered court.

Water darkened the ledger table but left the prepared evidence beneath sheets of glass. Erased workers pressed near the active truth condition in Salenne's unfinished Concord. The rain indicated their proximity to binding, not approval of Ardis.

A dock woman shouted, "Who killed her?"

"Lady Maelin Valev," Ardis answered. "My aunt. Lord Remembrancer. She used red funeral cord in the Hollow Aisle after Nera discovered a dominance clause hidden in the proposed Bride Accord."

The courier box gave a small sound as damp tightened its wood.

Ardis broke Maelin's seal and lifted the lid.

The cord lay coiled around a pearl button and a strip of reed paper. Nera's blood had dried into one section. The paper carried Maelin's direction in her own hand. No confession, only deliberate custody of evidence she should not possess.

Salenne did not let Nera seize her voice. "Witness protocol," she said, rough but firm.

Vey called Tev Orr first.

Tev spoke through Salenne after she explicitly lent voice for the duration of his witnessed account. He described the service grille, Maelin's pearl-handled knife, Nera's bound wrists, and the cord pulled across her throat. He did not claim to see what happened after guards dragged him away. At the end, Salenne closed her mouth, wrote Tev's stopping point, and withdrew permission.

A living mason produced the grille rubbing from the Hollow Aisle. A guard inventory confirmed Maelin owned the knife at the time. Funeral examination of the cord matched fibers in Nera's sealed clothing packet.

Nera testified next. Consent tightened through Salenne's hand before the voice came. She named her discovery, confrontation, and death. Anger made no fact

automatic. Clerks compared her account with ledger dates, Maelin's access records, and Tev's independent view.

"I called for Ardis," Nera said through the host.

Ardis's knees wanted to bend. She remained standing because public grief did not entitle her to interrupt testimony.

Nera continued. "She did not hear me. Maelin did."

That limit mattered. Nera did not accuse Ardis of witnessing the murder. She accused a throne that accepted convenience afterward.

When Salenne withdrew lending, blood ran from her nose. A citizen anchor spoke from the first arcade. "Salenne Vaud, you once made me rewrite a petition because I had called fear consent. You stayed while I cursed you."

Her body steadied. No memory left the speaker.

Ilyan Marr gave evidence of Osteren complicity through his own witnessed chain. He had uncovered payments to Maelin's clerks and sent proof to her, believing she would protect Nera's surviving sister. General Hal's allies killed him. Maelin used the evidence to identify dissent rather than expose the bargain.

Edran presented the forged campaign roll. Osteren observers examined its white cord and double erasure.

Orsa's six funeral rolls linked Tev's removal to the Remembrancer archive. Lio's account placed Peln carrying later oath traps under Maelin's instruction. Beska testified only to the original equality clause and its purpose. Ena testified to hiding the unedited vellum. Neither dead founder pretended knowledge of a murder centuries later.

The separation of testimony made the case slower. It also made it harder to dismiss as one possessed woman's accusation.

A court advocate appointed from the cistern ward cross-examined Salenne. He asked whether sevenfold hosting allowed ghosts to coordinate a false account. Salenne answered that they could speak privately within her perception and could lie, which explained the separate lending periods, written stopping points, and corroboration requirements.

"Can Nera hear Tev's statement through you?"

"Yes."

"Then she can alter hers to match."

"She can. Compare details each witness recorded before shared hosting. Tev's first account entered the Mortuary Exchange ledger on Day Two. Nera entered me on Day Five."

Ysra's certified copy showed the earlier account. Differences remained: Tev thought the knife had entered Nera's body because he saw its pearl handle near Maelin's hand; Nera said Maelin cut her own palm while severing the cord. The

disagreement supported separate viewpoints rather than perfect coordination.

The advocate turned to Ardis. "Did Lady Maelin ever confess to you?"

"No."

"Did you see the murder?"

"No."

"Then why state the killer as fact?"

"Because physical evidence, archive access, independent testimony, later concealment acts, and Maelin's possession of the cord converge. The court may judge whether that proves the charge."

A royal partisan shouted that Ardis had rehearsed the answer with Salenne. Ardis acknowledged that they had discussed evidence and refused to pretend preparation invalidated truth. The clerks recorded the objection.

Next, an undertaker opened the clothing packet under witness. The cord fibers embedded in Nera's collar matched the courier cord in twist, dye, and funeral salt. A pearl button recovered from the Hollow Aisle matched gaps on Maelin's formal coat inventory from twelve years earlier. Neither object could identify intent alone. Together with witnessed action and false records, they tightened the chain.

The advocate asked Edran whether exposing Osteren collusion served his claim to escape marriage.

"It does," he said. "A useful fact remains subject to proof. My interest belongs in your judgment of my evidence."

That answer unsettled both courts. They had been trained to treat admitted interest as disqualification and concealed interest as dignity.

Citizens then gave standing statements. Tev's surviving cousin described three generations denied a funeral claim because his name vanished. A copyist who had worked under Orsa identified pressure to leave blank lines where servants should appear. A Black Reed merchant described how the marriage condition kept grain wagons waiting while villages rationed sour meal. Their harm did not prove Nera's killer, but it established who had paid for concealment.

Ardis listened without converting their testimony into a story about her courage. A confession could become another royal performance if it centered the person speaking rather than the people injured.

Councilor Bran rose before Vey called argument. "Even if Maelin acted, the Crown Heir cannot confess an impersonal throne. Offices do not murder."

"No," Ardis said. "People murder. Offices conceal, reward, seal, omit, and threaten. Living holders perform those acts and can be judged for them."

"Will you submit yourself to indictment?"

"For my delay and any unlawful concealment proven against me, yes."

The answer frightened her council supporters. Vey looked down. They wanted a

clean reformer, not a Crown Heir who gave adversaries jurisdiction.

Ardis continued before fear converted them into silence. “No confession binds if the speaker exempts herself. The living court may investigate my conduct under the same public procedure.”

A different councilor withdrew her support at once. Two royal clerks followed her from the chairs. Their departure left visible spaces.

The dock wards did not cheer. People who had lost relatives to struck rolls understood that submission to review offered no restitution by itself.

Vey called the jurisdiction vote. Each living member gave a name, constituency, and reason. Four councilors accepted. Two refused. Osteren observers recognized the court for treaty evidence but reserved criminal sovereignty over their own officers. Undertakers recognized its funeral jurisdiction. Ward petitioners granted standing for erased records.

The living court existed through layered acceptance rather than ancestral proclamation.

Before issuing orders, it heard challenges to its members. A dock petitioner objected that Councilor Bran's wife held shares in the sealed archive warehouses. Bran disclosed the interest and withdrew from the evidence-preservation vote. An Osteren observer challenged Vey for publicly supporting Ardis. Vey answered that political support did not erase ward standing, but he surrendered the presiding chair during the Crown inquiry. An undertaker selected by lot took his place.

The substitutions delayed the session while Household channels remained open. Ardis felt every lost minute. She also understood the old court's speed had come from treating conflict as rank rather than information.

A palace guard asked whether warrants signed by such a provisional body could bind him. “Not by magic,” the undertaker-chair said. “You accept service as a living officer under the emergency code. If you refuse, name the ground and surrender your badge pending review.”

The guard read the warrant. It named the rooms to search, the records to preserve, the people to arrest, and an expiration at the next day's final bell. It forbade seizure of unrelated family tokens and required two public witnesses for every opened cabinet.

“I accept,” he said.

His fellow guards answered separately. Two refused because their parents served Maelin. They surrendered badges and received shelter rather than chains. The remaining officers chose their duty without a dead captain moving their mouths.

Only then did the court act.

Its first order suspended Maelin from the Lord Remembrancer office pending trial. Its second issued warrants for Maelin and Clerk Pelin. Its third preserved every

roll, token, paired wax set, and correspondence in the remembrancer's rooms. Living guards accepted service. No ghost enforced the warrants.

Peln attempted to leave through the flour arcade. Kitchen workers recognized his bruise and blocked the door with bread racks. Guards arrested him alive.

Maelin did not appear.

At the bridge report bell, an Osteren messenger entered with mud to his knees. "General Sev's officers dispute Prince Edran's grain order. Ancestral Hal commands seizure of the convoy until the marriage proceeds."

Every face turned toward Edran.

He walked to the evidence floor. His right-leg hitch showed more strongly after two sleepless days. The bandage on his left hand remained clean for once.

"I dismissed ancestral officers yesterday," he said. "General Sev Marr no longer commands the border force. Captain Tovin Sare holds bridge authority under my living order. Quartermasters of the grain road have accepted the relief clauses provisionally drafted here."

An Osteren noble called, "Without marriage, Lyr can close the road next season."

"Without living courage, marriage cannot keep it open today." Edran placed his signet on the grain compact. "Osteren affirms grain passage independent of spouse, dowry, or Household splice. The seven Black Reed villages receive the convoy under their own council receipts."

Ardis added Lyr's toll authority. "No toll office will obstruct it. Any dispute goes to the rotating living court."

Their two seals sat apart on the paper. No binding ink joined their bodies. The relief compact could fail through politics, shortage, or bad officers. It could also be repaired without tearing memories from unwilling spouses.

Before the messenger left, seven Black Reed representatives came forward from the Osteren arcade. War had divided their residence, so three carried Lyr passes and four carried Osteren papers. None wore royal name-thread.

A reed farmer named Sov challenged both heirs. "You promise grain as if delivery ends your debt. Who controls the canal after the wagons empty?"

"The village receiving council," Edran answered.

"Whose soldiers enforce its decision?"

"No standing soldiers," Ardis said. "The council may request flood labor. Any armed entry requires agreement from five villages and review by the rotating court."

Sov read the clause. "Our assembly rolls burned. Osteren calls half of us displaced. Lyr calls the rest foreign."

"Living residence and work establish eligibility," Edran said. "Not ancestral roll."

A woman from Dren Reed asked what prevented either realm from appointing a compliant council after one year. Salenne, still behind the witness table, held up the draft schedule. "Each village selects and recalls its own delegate in a public assembly. The Concord binds the border offices to recognize that delegate. It does not bind the village's choice."

The representatives conferred among themselves rather than looking to royal faces. Two objected to the five-village threshold. One wanted emergency canal repair allowed by three villages when floodwater crossed the line. They revised the edge in public: three could request unarmed labor for forty-eight hours; extension required five and living-court review.

Sov added his village mark only after the change.

Ardis understood what the old Bride Accord had avoided. Consent consumed time, exposed disagreement, and made rulers surrender elegant solutions. Those inconveniences supplied its substance.

The messenger received seven village copies and two royal copies. Each listed offices separately. He carried them toward Tovin and the waiting convoy.

Only then did the court address Maelin's indictment. Vey read each count: Nera's murder; conspiracy in Tev's death; concealment of Ilyan's murder; erasure of Orsa and six rolls; unlawful oath attacks; activation of the dominance design; civic harm from the tomb rupture.

"Accusation is not sentence," Vey said. "Maelin retains answer, counsel, and evidence challenge. Ghost testimony requires corroboration. Her office grants no immunity."

Ardis felt Nera's desire for immediate judgment through Salenne's posture. She felt her own. Neither desire wrote law.

"Living guards take her," Ardis said. "The dead do not punish her for us."

A rumble moved through the outer arcade. At first Ardis mistook it for crowd anger. Then people stepped aside in a widening path.

The guards nearest the entrance looked to Ardis for an inherited command. She gave none. Their warrant authorized arrest, not attack. They arranged themselves around citizens, leaving Maelin a clear route to answer or surrender. That restraint exposed how much easier it would have been to turn confession into vengeance.

Salenne shifted beside the witness table. Seven dead recognized the prepared salt basin before Ardis did. Nera wanted forward. Ena wanted the vellum protected. Salenne kept both impulses from borrowing her feet.

Maelin entered the rain court wearing ceremonial white.

No name-thread marked her coat. Twelve wrapped tokens hung at her belt above a shallow salt basin. Her right hand, missing its little finger, gripped the longer remainder of the original red cord. Its cut matched the bloodstained section in the open courier box. Old royal postures moved behind her face, one after

another, testing the body they expected to share.

Living guards approached with the warrant.

Maelin held up her damaged hand. "You have confessed an office you still intend to use, Ardis."

"I intend to limit it."

"Limits hold until fear teaches new grammar."

"Then living people will have to defend them."

A brief sadness crossed Maelin's face. It made her more dangerous because Ardis recognized love inside it, twisted into the conviction that love entitled control.

The last cistern bell before night began to sound.

Maelin laid the red cord across the entrance to the old wedding space. Behind her, loyal Valev dead gathered through the twelve prepared tokens. Across the bridge, General Hal answered through Osteren blood.

The living court had stripped Maelin of lawful office. She entered anyway, carrying murder as her claim to rule.

Chapter 25 — The Night Before No Wedding

Salenne looked away from Ardis to blot her pen, and the woman's face vanished.

Not the person. The tall figure still stood across the account room in an asymmetrical coat, plain white linen loose in close-braided hair. Salenne knew her posture, title, recent acts, and the quiet care with which she left space around a refusal. When Salenne raised her eyes again, features assembled into someone she loved by evidence.

She could not hold them once she looked away.

Seven ghosts made the loss worse by offering seven incompatible faces. Nera remembered a younger sister with a split lip. Tev remembered a royal woman seen through service grilles. Beska recognized family resemblance across centuries. Ena noticed only whether Ardis's hands carried work. None gave Salenne the living face before her.

Ardis remained beside the door rather than approach. "Do you want an anchor?"

"No. I know my name." Salenne wrote it at the top of the page. **SALENNE VAUD.** The letters held steady. "Faces have become expensive."

"The bells give us three hours."

"Then sit. I need the testimony order settled before anyone begins losing bodily autonomy in public."

Ardis chose the chair at Salenne's level. She did not ask whether the kiss survived.

Around them, the palace prepared for a wedding no one intended to complete. Clerks copied the new Concord onto reed vellum. Undertakers verified the seven witness consents. Living guards marked routes between citizen anchors and exits. Across the wall, Maelin occupied the old ceremony approach under warrant, protected by lent ancestors and loyal remembrancers. Arresting her before the witness route opened risked triggering the dominance pressure through a fight.

Salenne turned to the seven columns.

"Each of you gets one testimony," she said. "Only directly known facts. No interruption. No use of my hands. Voice closes when I say your name twice."

Nera objected first. Maelin will lie while you ration truth.

"Then the corroboration answers her. Anger does not extend your time."

Tev wanted to go before Nera because he had seen the murder from outside it. Lio wanted serving order based on clause activation. Ilyan insisted Osteren complicity had to precede Hal's attempt at dominance. Orsa wanted the erased rolls named before either dynasty spoke. Beska and Ena disagreed over which founder established authority.

Their argument tightened Salenne's muscles until her hands curled.

A citizen anchor read from the watch list. "You once rejected Councilor Vey's petition because he used three graceful pages to avoid naming a dead dock worker."

Salenne remembered the green ribbon on the filing, Vey's annoyance, and the dead worker's daughter laughing when the correction forced him into plain language. Her fingers opened.

"Thank you, Mera Sol," she said, naming the speaker.

The ghosts quieted enough to negotiate.

Tev would begin with the witnessed murder. Nera would follow with the dominance discovery and her death. Ilyan would connect General Hal's bargain and Osteren records. Lio would identify the modern oath mechanism and Peln's delivery chain. Orsa would establish systematic roll erasure. Beska would state the original equality clause and admit the Crown failed to preserve it. Ena would explain the practical seven-witness design and identify the original vellum.

"Testimony order," Salenne told the clerk. "Write the lending limit beside every name. Anchor after each witness, whether I appear stable or not."

The clerk added eight anchor positions, one before the first voice and one after each. No speaker could serve twice in sequence. Maelin's people might frighten volunteers away, so three alternates stood for every position.

Ardis read the arrangement. "Where do Edran and I speak?"

"After evidence, before clauses. He renounces Marr Household authority. You refuse the Bride Accord and offer the office compact. Citizens hear the full text. Accepted officeholders speak their own assent."

"And Maelin?"

"She gets the chance to answer the charges before enforcement. Not the chance to command my body."

Salenne tested the release phrase with each ghost. Tev yielded at once. Nera delayed until Salenne repeated the name. Ilyan withdrew formally. Lio counted three breaths. Orsa touched Salenne's thumb before leaving speech. Beska resisted from an old habit of finishing royal sentences. Ena stopped midway through a word simply to prove she could.

The practice cost no new memory because nobody entered or left the hosting. It cost blood. Salenne's nose began running before the fifth test. Ardis pushed clean linen across the table without touching her.

"Thank you," Salenne said.

"You thanked me for cloth yesterday too."

"Did I?"

"Yes. You had blood on the original vellum case."

Facts came to Salenne now through other people's accounts of her. She feared

becoming an argument assembled by witnesses. Yet everyone had always depended on memories held partly by others. The danger lay in calling their version ownership.

Ardis folded her hands. "May I tell you who I am to you?"

The careful grammar hurt.

"You may tell me who you are. Leave me room to decide the rest."

Ardis nodded. "My name is Ardis Valev. I am twenty-eight. I am Crown Heir until the living settlement decides what the Crown becomes. Nera was my sister. Maelin raised me after my mother died, and I loved her. I delayed questioning Nera's drowning because the lie protected peace and my succession."

She did not begin with romance.

"I asked you to serve as my oath advocate. That rank compromised your refusal. I released you from service before I asked to kiss you. You said yes. We have not promised a future. You do not owe me one because you paid for my sister's testimony."

Salenne looked at her face and retained it for one breath. Warm brown eyes. A line of strain beside the mouth. Rain-dark hair at one temple. Then she glanced down, and detail dissolved.

"What did I say after the kiss?"

"That no witness meant no witness, and if Nera commented you would charge her a consultation fee."

Nera supplied outraged pressure. The response belonged to her.

Salenne laughed, once. "That sounds like me."

"It sounded frightened."

"That too."

Ardis did not reach across the table. Desire remained present without making touch inevitable. Salenne found that restraint more intimate than any vow.

They rehearsed the first two transitions with empty stools. A volunteer sat at the anchor position while Salenne opened Tev's voice for one sentence. The stableboy named the service grille, then stopped when Salenne repeated his name. The volunteer spoke a memory about Salenne once repairing a torn name slip with fish glue because the owner could not afford a new token.

The anchor landed badly. Tev knew the memory now because he had heard it during hosting. In a crisis, a ghost could repeat the words and imitate the rescue.

"Specific does not mean reusable forever," Salenne said. "Once spoken before the seven, retire it."

The clerk crossed the memory from the reserve list. Every anchor needed a truth not previously heard by the hosted dead. That requirement consumed their supply faster than expected.

Ardis sent runners to collect sealed statements from volunteers. Each speaker wrote a private cue for themselves without showing the content to Salenne. An undertaker verified only that the memory involved direct experience, not what it contained. At the ceremony, surprise would help distinguish living recall from ghost imitation.

"Maelin can frighten speakers away," Ardis said. "She cannot prepare against details she does not know."

"She may attack credibility instead. One lie about hosting following an anchor home could empty a row."

"Then I state publicly that no memory transfers and no witness follows the spoken anchor. Undertakers corroborate."

Salenne added a pause to the testimony order. If any volunteer withdrew, the ceremony stopped while an alternate chose freely. No bell, military threat, or royal plea converted hesitation into consent.

They tested a false anchor next. A clerk claimed Salenne had defended him during a licensing hearing they had never attended together. The words held detail but no shared truth. Seven ghosts recognized no autobiographical connection. Salenne's name continued sliding.

Ardis stepped in only when invited. "You spilled burial black over my marriage draft on Day One and told Maelin the reed had warped."

The fact belonged to a first meeting Salenne no longer remembered. It could not anchor her because the lived memory had gone. She understood another limit: a truth about her past failed once hosting had removed her access to it.

"Retire that too," she said. "The anchor must still live in me."

Ardis marked it without grieving aloud.

A third volunteer described Salenne correcting a kitchen worker's appeal that morning. The memory remained recent, mutual, and unknown to the dead before speech. Her name settled.

The rehearsal established the protocol: fresh specific truth, direct shared experience, no coercion, no reuse, and immediate substitution upon failure. Living memory functioned as relationship rather than fuel.

A knock admitted Edran and Tovin. Tovin had returned from the bridge with silt to his calves and no ancestral thread. Edran rose too quickly at the sight of him, right leg hitching. Their hands met at the wrists, open and public before the Crown Heir.

"The convoy holds," Tovin said. "Sev's dismissed officers have split. Living quartermasters side with the village compact. Hal occupies six descendants among the ossuary crews."

"Casualties?" Edran asked.

"Two broken arms. One crushed foot. No deaths."

“Positions?”

“Wagons in civilian files. Soldiers stand away from axles. If the ceremony breaks Hal's command, grain crosses at first safe light. If it strengthens him, I cut the ossuary traces and scatter the token wagons.”

Edran flinched. Scattering ancestral tokens risked damaged records and furious dead. “Do it if I lend him my hands.”

Tovin's expression stayed practical because tenderness could not replace orders. “What anchors you?”

“The winter you stitched my campaign coat inside out and claimed Osteren fashion had changed.”

“I was drunk.”

“You were lying.”

“Both can survive in one officer.”

The shared memory softened Edran's shoulders. Tovin lost nothing by speaking it.

Salenne placed them in the ceremony plan. Tovin would stand with living bridge guards at the western exit, outside the exact seven-dead circle. Edran would enter unarmed. If Hal seized his voice, Tovin spoke the anchor and Edran repeated refusal. Ardis's guard captain held the eastern exit under a warrant limited to protecting civilians and arresting Maelin after answer.

“No heroic charge,” Salenne said.

Tovin looked offended. “I have spent eight years teaching officers that heroics disrupt supply.”

Edran added, “He means yes.”

They returned to the bridge before night bell. Their wrist-touch at parting carried an established private life becoming politically visible, not a confession invented for crisis.

Salenne reviewed the vellum. The title remained blank. After the throne's confession, burial black now accepted the first stroke. The full binding would wait for spoken assent before seven witnesses.

She also reviewed the cost.

Seven hosted dead had already loosened her name. Discharging them under simultaneous Household pressure could tear another memory loose. Preparation could narrow the emotional field but not select the exact loss. Salenne had to decide what she would place nearest the strain.

Ysra's friendship could not be offered. Too much of its beginning had already gone with Lio. Orsa's remaining facts had to support testimony. Olan's lessons survived mostly as records. Her professional craft anchored the ceremony. Her own name had to remain available.

That left Ardis.

"The memory of the first kiss," Salenne said.

Ardis's body went very still.

"I cannot choose the exact loss," Salenne continued. "I can hold that memory near the discharge so the strain takes it before something needed for the clauses."

"No."

The refusal came without title, command, or argument.

Salenne met the face she might soon know only by description. "You do not choose my risk."

"I know." Ardis swallowed. "I am telling you what I want."

"Good. I want to keep it too."

"Then keep it near because it matters, not because it is expendable."

Nothing could make the choice clean. Sacrifice language tempted Salenne to pretend losing love served the city, turning intimacy into another body offered for peace. The city required her skill and consent, not that particular memory. Overload might take it anyway.

"I will not feed the kiss to the vow," Salenne said. "I will not hide it either. If the discharge reaches for the most immediate private memory, it may go."

Ardis's eyes shone. She did not call permanence proof. "If it does, I will not use my memory to overrule yours."

"And if I ask what happened?"

"I will answer facts. I will not tell you what you felt."

That promise contained no enforcement and therefore required character every time it mattered.

Salenne wrote one final note in her own hand: Ardis released me. I chose the kiss. A record cannot restore the lived memory. Ask again from where I stand.

She folded it into her coat, not as a cure but as evidence for a future self.

Outside the account room, citizens took their anchor positions. Undertakers brought the seven witness stools from the Vow Chamber. No royal names marked them. Guards opened all four exits. Hollow Rain began to fall across the covered wedding court as the erased dead pressed near the prepared Concord.

The first ceremony bell sounded.

Ardis rose. "May I walk beside you?"

"Yes."

They did not touch. Salenne carried the vellum. Ardis carried Nera's ledger. Each woman held her own evidence and her own body.

The remaining bells called both courts into the Hollow Rain.

Chapter 26 — A Marriage of Seven Ghosts

The old wedding began with Maelin's cord across the aisle and no bride willing to cross it.

Hollow Rain fell through clear air beneath the roofed court. Water struck seven witness stools, the open Bride Accord on its reed table, and the citizens packed under every arcade. Lyr guards held eastern exits. Osteren officers held west. Between them stood Ardis and Edran in plain coats without marriage thread.

Salenne entered carrying the new vellum.

Seven ghosts tightened her body around seven different purposes. Tev feared the crowd. Nera wanted Maelin. Ilyan listened for Hal. Lio counted the ceremony stations. Orsa followed the copy clerks. Beska recognized the old court beneath later decoration. Ena measured the floor and found the mason's corrections still true.

Citizen anchors waited behind each stool with sealed memories. Living officeholders held separate acceptance slips. Undertakers guarded the boundary, not the dead.

Before anyone spoke testimony, Ysra's deputy inspected the circle in public. She named every substance: reed vellum, burial black, ordinary red dye, funeral salt, Maelin's blood basin, and the bronze ring intended to carry spouse contact. Nothing received the dignity of mystery. Each mechanism entered the record so panic could not turn craft into prophecy.

A Lyr clerk read the old Bride Accord's active portions. Shared household guidance occupied one line. Its consequence schedule occupied nine pages, all attached to the bodies of spouses and future descendants. Divorce during the first lunar year would tear memory from both. Refusal after vows counted as disorder to be corrected by coordinated ancestors.

Edran asked the Osteren observers, "Did your council receive those pages?"

One elderly delegate admitted he had seen only a summary. Another had received the consequence schedule and signed its secrecy clause under Hal's ancestral pressure. Their admissions did not erase acceptance. They proved the acceptance had failed informed consent.

Ardis produced her own wedding copy. The consequence pages had been sealed beneath a false backing. "I was offered the word guidance and denied the acts it permitted."

Maelin said, "Every sovereign marriage carries inherited consequences."

"Inheritance does not excuse concealment."

Salenne directed clerks to place both copies under glass. If the old route survived, no court could later claim ignorance of its mechanism.

The seven witness stools stood outside royal precedence. Each carried a plain shell slip naming the dead person and the bounded truth they would speak. Tev's slip named murder sight. Nera's named discovery and death. Ilyan's named Osteren conspiracy. Lio's named oath sequence. Orsa's named roll alteration. Beska's named founding authority and failure. Ena's named drafting craft.

Salenne asked every undertaker whether a royal official had selected the witness on their behalf. Each answered no. She asked the citizen assembly whether anyone claimed ownership by blood. Silence held, followed by explicit refusals from both royal families.

Only then did she set down the new vellum.

Maelin stood inside the old circle in ceremonial white. Twelve Valev tokens hung over a salt basin at her waist. Red cord wrapped her damaged right hand and ran across the Bride Accord to a bronze ring near Edran's position.

"Last chance," Maelin said. "Complete the lawful marriage. Stabilize both Households. Amend its guidance after the emergency."

Ardis stopped short of the cord. "Consent after possession has no meaning."

"Cities do not survive on meaning."

"No. They survive on labor you erased from the rolls."

The crowd shifted. Maelin pulled once.

Burial salt lifted from the cord in a red mist. The old Accord's prepared title darkened. Across the bridge, General Hal's living intermediaries completed their paired motion. Edran jerked as two hundred eleven Marr dead drove toward his posture through the open Household channels.

His left hand rose, palm scar splitting beneath its bandage.

"I will not lend you my hands," he said.

Hal forced his fingers toward Ardis.

Tovin's voice came from the western guard line. "Edran Marr, you wore my campaign coat inside out for six days because neither of us would admit I had stitched it wrong."

The specific memory hit. Edran laughed through clenched teeth. His hand stopped.

Maelin tipped the salt basin against her wrist. Twelve Valev ancestors entered coordinated lending. Her shoulders changed first, then her voice. Lord Ossan commanded guards to close the exits. Queen Haret ordered the Osteren ranks to advance. Remembrancer Sera recited the modern witness order.

Living guards looked to Ardis.

"Keep every exit open," she said. "No ancestor outranks the warrant you accepted."

They chose. Doors remained open.

Salenne set the new vellum on a second table outside the cord. "The murder truth has received public hearing. Seven eligible witnesses have consented. We proceed under the original Concord's equality rule."

Maelin spoke with several cadences. "Those ghosts are unlawful."

"No blood may own the witness," Salenne said. "Lawful erasure did not make the dead ineligible. It made your law evidence."

She faced the first stool.

"Tev Orr, do you consent to lend voice for your witnessed account, ending when I speak your name twice?"

Fear tightened her throat. Then Tev answered inside her: Yes.

Salenne opened her voice.

Tev described the service grille, the lime smell, Nera's bound wrists, Maelin's cord, and the call for Ardis. He named where his sight ended. Maelin tried to interrupt with Ossan's command voice. Undertakers struck salt rods on stone, not as magic, as a signal that testimony continued.

"Tev Orr. Tev Orr."

He withdrew.

A kitchen copyist opened her sealed anchor. "Salenne Vaud, this morning you changed my appeal from the Household requires to my grandmother demands, because you said a dead person must carry her own verb."

Fresh shared truth settled Salenne's name.

Nera took the second voice. She testified to finding the dominance clause, confronting Maelin, feeling red cord close, and calling for her sister. Maelin's face did not change until Nera described the choice she had offered: release the records and face scandal together.

"I offered you a living consequence," Nera said. "You chose my dead silence."

Maelin answered in her own voice for one breath. "I chose the border."

"The border burned anyway."

"Nera Valev. Nera Valev." Salenne closed the lending before grief could become possession.

The second anchor came from a fish porter. "You knelt in the market mud to gather my father's name slips, then made me count them because you did not assume the dead belonged to you."

The detail reached Salenne. Her knees remembered the mud. She held.

Ilyan followed. He named General Hal's bargain, the evidence he sent Maelin, and the Osteren agents who killed him. Hal drove Edran forward two steps while his nephew spoke. Edran's right leg nearly folded.

Tovin did not repeat the retired coat memory. "You carved my name under the

supply chest at Dren Reed because officers kept removing my requisitions. You misspelled Sare."

"I was bleeding," Edran gasped.

"You were arrogant."

His posture returned to the living man.

Ilyan addressed Edran through Salenne. "Do not preserve me as another officer in your blood. Record my evidence. Let me finish."

Edran's expression broke. "I hear you."

"Ilyan Marr. Ilyan Marr."

The third citizen anchor described Salenne admitting a licensing error in public and paying the appeal fee herself. Sevenfold pressure receded from her fingers.

Lio took the fourth stool. He laid out the glaze oath and Maelin's serving-order trap. Peln, held under living guard, confirmed carrying the cup under instruction. Lio explained how the Bride Accord route named spouse bodies before office acts, letting the larger Household coordinate hands. He did not know the counter-rite Maelin made after his death and did not pretend to.

Maelin pulled the cord again.

The old vellum sent binding heat through the bronze ring. Edran's arm snapped toward Ardis. She stepped aside rather than catch him. A spouse-designated touch could complete the physical route.

Edran drove his own hand into a bowl of cold wax. It hardened around his fingers and fixed them to the table.

"No body serves as surety," Salenne read from the new draft.

Office tokens around the court warmed. Ardis and Edran remained untouched.

"Lio Fen. Lio Fen."

His withdrawal left the memory of Ysra's youthful hand empty forever, but Salenne still knew Ysra had once held it.

An undertaker anchored her with yesterday's argument over rib bandages. Salenne remembered calling Ysra furniture with a hole in it. The crude phrase restored the shape of friendship more effectively than devotion.

Orsa spoke fifth. She named six altered funeral rolls, Olan's sale of erased names, and Maelin's office chain. Her voice through Salenne did not restore her face or singing. It carried copyist precision stripped of maternal comfort.

"My daughter owes no restitution for my erasure," Orsa said to the court. "Use her testimony. Do not make a shrine from her body."

Salenne almost failed to close the voice.

"Orsa Vaud. Orsa Vaud."

A former license petitioner opened the fifth anchor. "You sat with me until I

wrote what my husband had actually asked for his funeral. You drank terrible tea and did not pretend precision made grief smaller.”

The widow's face, tea cup, and cracked token remained accessible. Salenne returned.

Beska entered sixth with royal posture but waited for consent to use speech. She recited the equality clause she had accepted from seven nonroyal witnesses. She admitted allowing copies to remain under Crown custody, creating the route by which descendants removed the limitation.

Ardis asked, “Does your blood give me authority to offer another body?”

“No,” Beska said through Salenne. “My failure gives you evidence against custody without public challenge.”

“Do you command me to preserve the Crown?”

“I hold no living office.”

The lawful Valev dead surged against Maelin's basin. Some recoiled from their founder's refusal of hereditary command. Others drove deeper into Maelin, preferring the modern power they knew.

“Queen Beska. Queen Beska.”

A cistern keeper anchored Salenne with a memory from that afternoon: Salenne had refused to let a dead engineer take his hands even when contaminated water threatened a ward. The keeper had hated her answer. He had obeyed it and found a living apprentice.

Ena took the final stool.

Her voice carried lime and blunt patience. She described drawing the seven niches, correcting the cistern closure clause, hiding the vellum, and choosing witnesses by free consent outside both Houses. She pointed through Salenne's thumb to the original floor marks. Seven work symbols emerged under Hollow Rain where royal tile had hidden them.

“This court called me servant,” Ena said. “I drafted the parts that kept its water moving.”

Maelin stamped across the mason mark.

The floor mechanism answered the living weight, not rank. The stone beneath her shifted half a span. Her salt basin tipped. Three wrapped tokens fell out and rolled beyond the cord.

Their living descendants did not retrieve them.

“Ena Tar. Ena Tar.”

The last anchor came from a child in the unnamed sanctuary. Rian stood on a cot brace so the court could see her. “You told the clerk my refusal counted before I knew the right legal word. Then you asked me what word I wanted.”

Salenne remembered the ink numerals on the girl's fingers and her answer:

mine.

Her name held.

Seven testimonies now stood in public record with corroboration already released. The ghosts remained hosted, eligible to hear the new vow. None controlled Salenne's hands.

Maelin drew the pearl-handled knife.

Living guards advanced under their warrant. Loyal remembrancers blocked them. The confrontation tightened every Household channel. Hollow Rain became a sheet, turning the court floor slick.

"Wait," Salenne said. "The old binding route remains open. Violence around the cord feeds its bodily consequence."

Ardis stepped to the center outside both vellum tables.

"I refuse the Bride Accord," she said. "I refuse marriage to Prince Edran Marr. I refuse shared Household guidance, spouse surety, inherited entry, and any peace purchased through another person's body."

The old vellum cracked along its title.

General Hal forced Edran's mouth open. "Osteren withdraws grain."

Edran bit his tongue hard enough to bleed. He waited for the borrowed voice to break, then spoke through his own blood. "Osteren's living heir affirms the grain compact. I renounce House Marr's command over my office, my hands, and my private partnership."

He looked at Tovin before both courts. "Captain Tovin Sare holds bridge authority because I appointed him and living officers accepted him. He also shares my life. Neither fact makes Ardis collateral."

The public acknowledgment gave Hal nothing to use. Shame had never anchored the relationship; concealment had only made pressure easier.

Tovin struck the ossuary release signal. Beyond the palace, crews cut the wagon traces without scattering tokens. Hal's coordinated route lost physical alignment. Edran pulled his waxed hand free, leaving skin behind but keeping control.

Salenne unrolled the new Concord.

She read its title: "A Marriage of Seven Ghosts."

Murmurs crossed the court. Maelin laughed once. "You deny marriage and name one."

"Seven dead join testimony for one act," Salenne said. "No living spouse enters. The title records what we are doing, not whom we own."

She read the equality spine. "No blood may own the witness, no body serves as surety, and no dead voice binds the living beyond the office freely taken."

The seven ghosts heard. One by one, they consented to witness the clauses.

Salenne named the Lyr toll office, Osteren road quartermaster, living bridge command, village receiving council, cistern relief office, public record keepers, and rotating court. For each she read act, duration, consequence, resignation, and review. No clause followed anyone home. No descendant inherited acceptance. No marriage performed sovereignty.

Ardis accepted only for the Lyr Crown offices she presently held. Edran accepted for Osteren road authority. Vey accepted dock-ward hearing duty. Seven village delegates accepted their council recognition. Bridge captains and quartermasters answered in living voices.

Acceptance did not come cleanly. The Lyr toll keeper refused the first reading because the suspension clause lacked wages during review. "An officeholder with no pay cannot defend against a false obstruction charge," she said. "Only rich families will survive investigation."

Salenne paused the ceremony while Maelin's cord remained active. The crowd shouted about delay. She let the noise spend itself.

Vey proposed full wages for ten days, then subsistence until judgment. A Black Reed delegate objected that endless hearings could drain village grain funds. Edran assigned pay to the appointing kingdom rather than the receiving council. The toll keeper accepted after the correction entered all copies.

An Osteren quartermaster refused public posting of exact wagon numbers, arguing that raiders could use them. Tovin sent a bridge runner with a compromise: post delivered weight and route compliance after arrival, while a three-person audit team inspected live figures under confidentiality. Two members came from villages, one from the road office. The delegates accepted.

Next, Rian's aunt challenged funeral consent. The public-record duty could not require a child to hear a named ancestor merely because the name entered history. Salenne added a separation between civic record and Household contact. The aunt marked acceptance only after Rian read the line herself.

Every revision risked opening a new flaw. That risk formed the difference between living consent and ceremonial assent. The seven ghosts waited. None could shorten debate by taking a hand.

Maelin used the delay. Her remembrancers moved among the anchor rows whispering that spoken memories would let witness ghosts enter their families. Three volunteers stepped back.

Ardis addressed them without ordering return. "An anchor transfers nothing. You may withdraw and keep shelter, standing, and safety. Undertakers will answer questions."

Two remained withdrawn. Alternates took their places after hearing the same warning. The third volunteer asked Salenne directly whether Tev could follow her memory home.

"No. He remains in my hosting until discharge. Your words give me access to a

memory already mine. They create no ghost route.”

The woman chose to stay.

Clerks recopied every amendment. Separate readers compared numbers. Officeholders explained their duties back to the court. The process consumed the time Maelin meant to weaponize, yet rushed agreement would have reproduced her design.

When the last acceptance came, each official placed a token on Ena's work marks. Warmth traveled through the objects and stopped at human skin.

“Citizens are not offices,” Salenne said. “You are not bound by this vow. Those who freely choose may anchor its witness host while the clauses take.”

Hands rose across the arcades.

Maelin thrust the knife through the red cord into the old vellum.

Dominance opened.

Twelve Valev dead struck through her body at once. Hal's diminished chorus answered from the Osteren side. The old Accord tried to identify Ardis and Edran as spouses despite their refusals. Heat raced from the cord toward their feet.

Ena seized no hand. She gave Salenne remembered geometry. The old route ran through the center ring, laid after Ena's work. The new vellum lay outside it.

“Move the office tokens onto the mason marks,” Salenne called.

Citizens passed them hand to hand. Toll, grain, bridge, cistern, rolls, court, village. Seven points around the old circle. The new structure gained a physical route shaped by work rather than blood.

Maelin crossed toward Salenne. Living guards could not reach her without stepping over the active cord.

“Give me voice,” Maelin demanded, though she had no place among the hosted dead.

“You are living,” Salenne said. “Answer in your own.”

The ancestors inside Maelin coordinated her knife hand. She lunged.

Ardis could have drawn steel. Instead she kicked the salt basin away. Tokens scattered into citizen hands. Each holder asked the named dead whether they consented to continue lending through Maelin. Silence or refusal cooled nine shells. Three remained warm.

The coordinated posture collapsed.

Maelin struck Salenne with her shoulder. The impact knocked the host across the new vellum. Seven ghosts surged for balance. For one dangerous breath, Salenne lost the border between their bodies and hers.

Tev wanted to flee. Nera wanted the knife. Ilyan wanted to disarm. Lio counted exits. Orsa protected the text. Beska sought command. Ena braced like stone.

Citizen anchors began speaking from every arcade.

"You returned my shell fee."

"You misspelled my daughter's name and corrected it in red."

"You hate sweet tea and drink it when Ysra asks."

"You refused a prince until he showed grain figures."

Fresh, specific, freely offered memories arrived from people the court had once ignored. No single voice owned Salenne. Together they gave her enough living edges to choose.

Maelin reached for her mouth, seeking the host as a route into the seven witnesses.

Salenne caught the damaged hand. The missing finger left the grip strangely intimate.

"I know why you fear disorder," Salenne said. "Fear does not appoint you to my body."

Maelin's own face surfaced beneath the remaining dead. "Living people will fail this."

"Yes."

"They will repeal it."

"Then living people must defend it."

"After the next fire?"

"After every fire." Salenne tasted blood. "I choose the living."

She used Ena's geometry and her own hand to press the first binding stroke into the new vellum.

The office tokens flared warm.

The old Bride Accord split from title to witness line. Red cord blackened around the knife. The dominance route found no consenting spouses, no lawful body surety, and no office acceptance. Its pressure folded back into the dead who had coordinated it.

They could not move objects or survive without living channels. Maelin closed herself at last, wrenching her hand from Salenne and withdrawing lending before the return pressure broke her mind. She fell to one knee, still living, still culpable.

The cord went slack.

Living guards stepped across it.

Ardis read the warrant. Maelin answered with no ancestor in her voice. "I hear it."

They took her knife, separated each token, bound her wrists with ordinary linen, and led her toward the living court. No ghost killed her. Nera did not forgive her. Judgment remained unfinished work for people who could be challenged.

The new Concord began to take.

Its effects arrived as reports rather than triumph. A runner from South Cistern said a dead surgeon had released a descendant's wrist midway through stitching a burn; the living surgeon finished badly but freely. From the west archive came word that old clerks stopped revising rolls through sleeping bodies. At the bridge, six possessed ossuary workers collapsed when Hal lost automatic command. Tovin kept them under blankets instead of arresting them.

Loss traveled with relief. A cistern engineer could no longer recall an ancestor's practiced method for hearing a crack behind brick. A family accountant lost the dead grandmother who had supplied sums in dreams. Soldiers who had marched by inherited cadence stumbled out of formation. The Concord had not selected benevolent counsel for preservation and cruel counsel for removal. It ended automatic access. Consent would have to be rebuilt one dead voice and one living listener at a time.

Ardis received those costs without calling them regrettable necessities. She assigned living apprentices, emergency wages, and double inspection where ancestral skills vanished. Edran ordered officers to slow the convoy rather than borrow dead scouts. Their choices could fail. No Household would conceal responsibility.

Across the court, people heard silence at different moments. Some wept. Others laughed and then apologized to relatives who felt bereaved. Children covered their ears from habit and discovered no command waited behind their hands.

Across the city, Household pressure loosened. Dead skills, commands, and inherited voices withdrew from descendants who had not freely accepted them. Some ghosts chose silence. Others waited for naming. The change did not erase the dead or repair wounds. It removed automatic command from blood.

Salenne still carried seven unresolved witnesses. Their truths had been spoken before the people bound by them. Now each had to choose discharge.

Tev went first. He asked that his name enter the public roll without any family compelled to host him. When Vey accepted the record duty, Tev consented to silence. He left Salenne with the smell of horses and no returned song.

Nera addressed Ardis. "You heard me living too late."

"Yes."

"You hear me now."

"Yes."

"Do not build your rule from apologizing to me."

Nera chose dispersal. Her departure tore through Salenne's chest.

Ilyan accepted a public Osteren record and no Household command. Lio chose naming in the cupbearers' roll. Orsa asked for her six corrections copied and then released her daughter. Beska chose civic witness status outside blood. Ena

remained named in the foundation record and withdrew from the host.

Seven departures passed through one living memory field.

Salenne had prepared, but simultaneous release carried overload beyond a seventh hosting payment. Her name loosened entirely. She heard anchors, bells, rain, Ardis speaking. A private room opened in her memory: released service, a request, warm breath, a mouth meeting hers without witness.

The discharge reached it.

Salenne tried to hold the scene because it mattered rather than because the city deserved it. Importance gave the loss more force. The memory tore free.

Then the seven were gone.

She lay on wet stone with no dead inside her. Her tongue hurt. Her body belonged only to her and felt unfamiliar in its solitude.

Ardis knelt within sight, hands open. "My name is Ardis."

"I know."

"May I touch your shoulder?"

Salenne searched herself. She knew they had kissed from the note in her coat and from Ardis's earlier account. She knew she had chosen it. The lived sensation had become another permanent absence.

"Yes," she said.

Ardis touched her shoulder, no more.

Salenne survived the marriage of seven ghosts. She did not remember her first kiss.

Chapter 27 — After the Ancestors Left

Edran woke to silence and mistook it for deafness.

No General Hal waited behind his teeth. No dead quartermaster counted the wagons beyond the wall. Two hundred eleven named ancestors remained in Osteren's public records, but not one occupied his blood without renewed consent.

He sat up too quickly. His right leg seized. The torn skin of his left palm pulled under fresh linen. Pain arrived without an ancestral surgeon naming its cause.

Tovin slept in a chair beside the cot, split ear resting against the brick. He had one hand on the bridge roster even in sleep. Edran touched his boot to Tovin's.

The captain woke with a knife halfway from its sheath, then stopped himself. "Living reflex."

"Poorly supervised."

"How many dead?"

"None."

Tovin listened to the answer. Relief and grief shared his face. Hal had threatened them for years. Other ancestors had taught Edran supply routes, languages, and the old method for reading grain mold by smell. Losing command did not separate cruelty from useful knowledge.

A bridge bell rang three times. Standoff.

They reached the Bridge of Reeds at first light. The grain convoy stretched along the Osteren road, forty wagons under damp funeral banners. Lyr toll chains remained raised. Between them, dismissed General Sev and sixty soldiers blocked the first axle.

Sev stood without Hal's posture. He looked smaller and more dangerous because every decision now belonged to him.

"The ceremony voided ancestral command," he said. "It did not void Osteren military law."

"You were dismissed yesterday," Edran replied.

"Under possession and foreign pressure."

"Under my living order, witnessed by your officers."

Half the soldiers watched Sev. Half watched Tovin. Their formation had gaps where dead drill masters no longer corrected distance. One spear line stood too close to the barge chain. A shove could send three people into the river.

Tovin did not exploit it. "Ground spears. Ten paces from the wagons. We discuss authority without an axle at anyone's back."

Sev's adjutant obeyed. Sev did not countermand him.

A Black Reed delegation approached from the Lyr side: seven village representatives, mill inspectors, and wagon receivers carrying the compact copies. Sov the reed farmer held the lead receipt board.

"We have no interest in which prince humiliates which general," Sov said. "Children in Dren Reed have eaten boiled reed pith for six days. Move the grain."

Sev pointed to the Concord mark. "That paper used witness ghosts against Osteren."

"Ilyan Marr testified to Osteren crime," Edran said. "He did not command the convoy. Living quartermasters accepted the delivery office."

One quartermaster stepped from behind the wagons. Without his dead grandmother's arithmetic, he held a slate crowded with corrections. "Weights checked twice. Four sacks spoiled in wagon nineteen. Receipts assign loss to the road office, not villages."

Sev glanced at the uneven numbers. "You cannot certify without Household calculation."

"I can calculate slowly."

The sentence carried more courage than any inherited cadence.

Edran offered Sev a living hearing. He could challenge the dismissal before the rotating court. Until then, surrender command and retain rank without troops. Refusal would lead to arrest for obstructing grain passage under an office he no longer held.

"What enforces that?" Sev asked.

"No ancestral command," Tovin said. "These officers decide whether my appointment stands. The village delegates decide whether they accept the delivery. The bridge guards decide whether to raise the chain. The court reviews all of us."

Messier than Hal. Slower than possession. Real.

Edran addressed the soldiers by name where he knew them and by unit where he did not. "I will not call you traitors for listening to your former commander. Decide the office you recognize. Ground weapons before you answer."

Spears lowered one by one.

The decision did not settle pay, food, or legal exposure. Soldiers who surrendered Sev's command feared Osteren would call them mutineers. Those who remained loyal feared Edran would purge them. Tovin ordered unit scribes to create a living roster recording each person's choice, time, and stated reason. No one signed for another soldier.

A young spear carrier named Ose refused both Sev and Tovin. "My enlistment names General Sev's office. If that office is disputed, I accept neither replacement until review."

Tovin considered the contract. "Ground your spear and leave the bridge. You receive three days' pay while the court reviews command succession."

"We cannot pay every refusal," Edran said quietly.

"We can pay less than a battle costs."

The Black Reed delegates demanded that military payroll not come from convoy grain. Edran assigned it to the Osteren royal road fund and signed personal liability if the council rejected the expense. He disliked the precedent. Living command required him to own it publicly.

Eleven soldiers chose temporary stand-down. Thirty-six accepted Tovin's bridge authority. Thirteen accompanied Sev into guarded quarters without weapons, as witnesses rather than troops. The arrangement weakened the line, but it removed uncertainty from the axles.

Sov inspected the first wagon seal and found an old House Marr mark beneath fresh wax. "Whose authority loaded this?"

The quartermaster checked his crowded slate. His dead grandmother no longer supplied the answer. He called two loaders from the rear files and asked them separately. Both named a warehouse officer aligned with Hal.

They opened the wagon under witnesses. Grain filled most sacks, but three at the center held river stones beneath a thin layer of meal. An ancestral quartermaster had hidden the theft by commanding descendants to certify weight from memory rather than scales.

Edran ordered every wagon reweighed.

Groans moved through the convoy. Rechecking forty loads could cost half a day. Dren Reed needed grain. Yet sending false weights across the bridge would make the first compact receipt another royal lie.

Village teams brought barge scales. Osteren soldiers shifted sacks under civilian direction. Two more stone bags appeared, along with four spoiled sacks and one roll box General Hal's loyalists had meant to move into Lyr. Undertakers sealed the box separately. No one burned or scattered the tokens.

The final count came six hundred measures below the road ledger. Edran pledged replacement from the nearest Osteren store within five days. The village council wrote the deficit into every copy.

"Your dead knew supply," Sov said.

"They also knew how to hide theft inside certainty."

"We will see if living clerks hide it more slowly."

"That may be the best improvement available."

Sev waited for the dead to rescue certainty. Silence gave him no argument. He unbuckled his command sash and handed it to Tovin.

"I request hearing."

“Recorded,” Tovin said.

No one cheered. Humiliation could ferment into another war if treated as spectacle. Tovin assigned Sev quarters under guard and let his own adjutant accompany him.

The first wagon moved.

Lyr toll keepers touched their office tokens, which warmed only for their accepted duty. They counted axles, inspected seals, and raised the final chain. No magic compelled their hands. Obstruction would have blocked an official act and triggered review, but the work itself remained living labor.

At the midpoint, a wheel cracked.

Ancestral wagon masters had once seized descendants' hands and repaired such breaks before a driver understood the fault. Those skills had gone quiet. The convoy stopped in a dangerous bottleneck while soldiers searched for instructions they had never learned.

Tovin climbed under the axle. Edran joined him despite the leg.

“The split runs through the hub,” Tovin said.

“Can we sleeve it?”

“Not with wet wood.”

A Black Reed cartwright named Mara knelt beside them. Her family roll had burned, so no inherited master worked through her. She examined the break, sent children for barge-chain wedges, and ordered the rear sacks shifted onto two village carts.

An Osteren officer bristled at taking instruction from a civilian.

Edran said, “She holds the repair knowledge. You hold a heavy sack. Choose which matters.”

They unloaded the wagon. Mara braced the cracked hub long enough to clear the bridge, then marked it for replacement instead of pretending the repair permanent.

The delay lasted an hour. No dead skill saved them. No person died beneath a failed wheel.

Beyond the bridge, seven village teams divided the convoy by posted shortage. Dren Reed received more than its population share because canal closure had ruined its stores. Another village representative objected, then accepted the inspection figures after a public recount.

The first receipt failed. A Lyr clerk wrote gift from the allied Crowns, language that made relief sound revocable and royal. Sov crossed it out. The Osteren quartermaster replaced it with delivery under treaty debt. A village delegate objected to debt because future courts might demand repayment from people already taxed for the grain.

They settled on received under the Black Reed relief compact, followed by source, measured weight, spoilage, and deficit owed. No gratitude clause appeared.

Then a dispute arose over households split across the canal. Osteren rolls counted them in the eastern village; Lyr ration books counted them in the western. Using both would duplicate shares. Using either would deny half the families.

Village cooks solved it with meal tokens issued that morning. Each person received one portion at the kitchen where they actually stood. Clerks recorded bodies fed and reconciled residence later. Administration followed hunger rather than ancestry.

Edran helped carry the first sacks into Dren Reed's store. His leg protested on the stairs. A village elder told him princes had porters.

"Today the porters are checking my false weights."

Children watched him spill grain from a torn seam. One laughed at his attempt to knot it. No dead logistician corrected his hands. Mara showed him a double fold and made him repeat it until the sack held.

At the cooking sheds, sour meal went into kettles with clean water. The grain could not undo eight years of burned roofs or bring back anyone killed on the road. It would keep living people available for tomorrow's argument.

Every sack entered a grain convoy receipt with delivered weight, spoilage, route, and receiving hand. Copies went to Lyr, Osteren, and the village council. No spouse seal appeared.

Edran watched children steal loose kernels from a torn corner. A quartermaster pretended not to see until Mara made him record the loss. Peace had become small enough to weigh.

At midday, a runner summoned Edran to Maelin's arraignment.

The living court sat in Crown Salt Court with no Household chairs. Maelin wore plain detention gray. Linen bound her right wrist loosely enough to show the missing finger. She had counsel from the undertakers' legal guild, a choice that angered citizens who thought representation resembled mercy.

Salenne attended as witness advocate, not prosecutor. Her jaw-length hair had dried stiff with rain. Without seven ghosts, her posture looked smaller. Ardis sat among Crown officers under inquiry rather than above the court.

Vey read the charges. Maelin answered each with the same words: "I hear the accusation and reserve my plea until evidence disclosure."

Nera did not speak. The dead sister had dispersed. The absence forced everyone to treat records as records rather than summon grief for convenience.

The court considered detention. The Crown advocate argued Maelin could activate hidden funeral routes if released. Her counsel demanded a list of mechanisms rather than fear phrased as expertise.

Clerks produced twelve tokens, paired wax, red cord, knife, sealed correspondence, and archive keys. Undertakers explained which objects could create channels and how to disable them without destroying evidence. Each token went into an individual saltless case. Paired wax halves stayed in separate civic vaults. Maelin would receive no burial black, name-thread, descendant contact, or access to active rolls while detained.

"Duration?" her counsel asked.

"Ten days until evidentiary hearing," the court chair said. "Renewal requires proof of continuing risk."

"Medical access?"

"Living physician of her choice from the approved list. No ancestral lending during examination without separate consent and court witness."

Maelin listened with the attention of someone finding flaws in an enemy's wall. "And if I refuse every physician?"

"Refusal stands unless immediate incapacity prevents informed choice. The court records it."

A victim's relative shouted that Nera had received no such care. Vey ordered no punishment for the outburst but paused until the room could hear again.

Edran gave evidence on General Hal's bargain and Ilyan's roll. Maelin's counsel questioned his interest. He admitted the arraignment strengthened his political position and harmed Osteren hardliners. Facts retained their need for corroboration. The court accepted his documents provisionally and scheduled challenge.

Maelin's arraignment ended without sentence. Living guards returned her to a dry civic room rather than a nameproof cell. She looked at Ardis while passing.

"You will spend your reign relearning what the dead knew," she said.

Ardis answered, "I may spend it learning why they were wrong."

Neither line resolved thirty-one years of fear. The door closed.

The court remained in session for claims that did not fit Maelin's indictment. Descendants asked compensation for injuries caused during the tomb rupture. Families of erased servants demanded burial costs and public corrections. Osteren delegates requested joint inquiry into Hal's agents. Vey warned that one emergency court could not become every institution merely because people trusted it today.

They divided the work. Criminal charges stayed with a panel that included a judge accepted by Maelin's counsel. Record restoration went to undertakers and citizen copyists. Injury claims went to a temporary compensation office funded by Crown and Remembrancer assets. Osteren conspirators faced a bilateral evidence commission with no ghost votes.

A dock petitioner asked why Ardis's office paid rather than Ardis personally. The

court distinguished institutional benefit from individual culpability. Crown archives, property, and fees had preserved the lie, so the office owed repair. Ardis's delay received separate investigation. Neither category canceled the other.

Edran recognized the architecture Salenne had built into the Concord: office without ownership, responsibility without inherited body punishment. Maelin's relatives would not enter detention because of her blood. Her office could lose assets because it had carried the harm.

Outside Crown Salt Court, the practical losses accumulated. A brick crew refused work after its dead master went silent. Cistern inspectors lacked three ancestral testing methods. Funeral singers forgot verses supplied by grandmothers. The city opened paid teaching stations in the palace courts.

Living experts did not appear from nowhere. Mara the cartwright could teach wheel repair but not canal acoustics. Ysra knew funeral craft but could not raise her injured arm. Edran offered Osteren engineers under temporary contracts, and Ardis accepted only after Lyr guilds reviewed wages and access. Foreign skill became exchange rather than conquest.

Apprentices wrote procedures while elders performed them. Some records would preserve bad habits. Others would correct techniques the dead had repeated beyond usefulness. Every manual named its living author and review date so knowledge could change without pretending eternity.

At one station, a former Household accountant wept over sums she could no longer do in her head. A teenage clerk showed her a counting frame. She made three mistakes, cursed her grandmother, then asked the girl to begin again. Grief and learning occupied the same bench.

Afterward, undertakers carried the opened funeral rolls into the public archive. Families queued to review names. Some accepted contact under new consent forms. Some asked for civic naming only. Others refused inheritance and preserved evidence. Orsa's six corrected rolls entered the central catalog in her own hand.

Ysra supervised from a wheeled chair, one arm bound. She caught a clerk trying to place Tev under Valev service names and made him start the page again.

"Occupation?" the clerk asked.

"Stableboy," Ysra said. "Witness. Murdered citizen. Pick whichever describes rather than owns."

Salenne signed the correction. She did not remember her mother's singing or Orsa's face. She did not remember meeting Ardis or kissing her. Facts in the rolls gave standing, not restoration.

Edran kept his distance. Their rebuilding belonged to them, not to a prince seeking proof that the Concord produced happiness.

By evening, the bridge convoy had cleared. Tovin posted living watches and

hired Mara to train Osteren wagon crews in hub repair. The army lacked ancestral formation sense, so he reduced patrol size until officers could relearn spacing. He acknowledged lost capability instead of staging competence. Every training shift paired a veteran with an apprentice and recorded errors before they hardened into another unquestioned tradition.

Edran met Ardis beside the last empty wagon. House Rain Palace stood behind her with open roll rooms and cots still filling royal courts.

"The villages received every sound sack," he said. "Sev surrendered command and requested hearing. Two officers resigned rather than accept me. Tovin kept them from arrest."

"The court will need Osteren judges."

"I have three candidates, none related to me. They will all dislike your toll policy."

"Excellent qualifications."

Their friendship had formed under an arranged marriage and survived its refusal. No romance waited underneath. Ardis looked toward the road where Tovin argued with a wheelwright over apprentice wages.

"Go," she told Edran. "Your captain has begun governing without you."

"He does that whenever supervision weakens."

Edran offered his forearm. Ardis took it, heir to heir, no binding between skin.

"The border survived the truth," he said. "Not intact. Alive." The next convoy would have to survive by the same difficult means.

He left Lyr as an allied prince rather than a husband, walking beside Tovin toward the grain road their living officers had chosen, in full public view, to keep open.

Chapter 28 — Two Living Names

One year later, Ardis waited in the public queue to name her sister.

No guard cleared space around her. The first open funeral under the new Concord occupied the east rain court, where accession portraits had once stood. Seven copy tables formed a broad circle. At each, undertakers asked the same separate questions: Should the name enter public history? Does any living person request Household contact? Did the dead leave a witnessed preference? Who may revise this choice, and when?

Rain fell outside the roof. No Hollow Rain touched the covered court. The burial black on the tables marked funeral records, not a binding vow.

Ahead of Ardis, Rian chose civic naming for her grandmother and refused body contact. Her aunt supported the choice, though grief tightened her mouth. At another table, a dock worker accepted his dead husband's voice for one evening each year. An undertaker recorded the duration and release phrase. A family declined every contact with an abusive father while preserving his name in a court judgment.

Naming no longer supplied one answer.

A bell at the western table announced a contested consent. Two brothers wanted their mother restored to Household contact. Their sister refused to share a blood channel with a dead woman who had controlled her speech while living. Under old law, the majority of lawful descendants would have opened the route for all three.

The undertaker separated the questions. The brothers could each accept private contact if the mother's surviving death object held enough presence and if she consented. Their sister's refusal barred the ghost from her body and home. Shared family gatherings required negotiated limits rather than automatic entry.

"Then she can speak about me through them," the sister said.

"She can," Salenne answered from the advocate table. "The Concord cannot bind private speech without becoming the thing you refused. Your brothers can agree not to relay messages. If they break that agreement, living law addresses harassment."

The brothers disliked a solution that offered no magical certainty. One accepted the no-message agreement. The other refused. Their sister chose separate funeral attendance. No court forced reconciliation.

At the next table, a dead canal worker had left a witnessed request to advise apprentices for five years. No descendant wanted Household contact. The school proposed a licensed volunteer host for one afternoon each month. Ysra required the worker's consent at every session, a release phrase, medical supervision, and payment to the host. Dead expertise did not excuse unpaid living labor.

A third case concerned an erased woman with no known family and no death object. Civic naming could restore her line in the archive but could not summon testimony. Her neighbors offered memories of her work, clearly labeled as living recollection rather than ghost speech. The record held uncertainty without inventing a voice.

Ardis watched people leave dissatisfied, relieved, angry, or quiet. Open funerals did not promise closure. They distributed choices once collapsed into inheritance.

Ysra Pell supervised from a high stool. Her punctured shoulder had healed, but stiffness kept her right arm close in cold weather. She wore the names of unclaimed clients on her sleeves only after obtaining recorded permission from those who remained available to ask. Her gold tooth flashed when she corrected a clerk.

"Public record," she said. "Not inheritance. Different columns exist because different acts exist."

The clerk recopied the line.

Ardis reached the table carrying Nera's restored ledger and the pearl button recovered from the Hollow Aisle. Salenne sat opposite as advocate for the living, jaw-length hair tucked behind one ear, left thumb permanently stained.

Recognition no longer left her face entirely. It had returned through repetition as new memory, not restoration. She knew Ardis's features from the past year: the crease beside her mouth when a councilor hid a cost, the white linen she still wore without ancestor names, the way she chose a chair only after seeing who had been made to stand.

None of that gave back their beginning or their first kiss.

"Crown Speaker," Salenne said.

Ardis had declined the title queen after the provisional charter limited hereditary office. Crown Speaker carried a three-year term, public accounts, and removal by the living court. She still inherited access and obligation. She no longer inherited people.

"Advocate," Ardis answered.

"Public naming?"

"Yes. Nera Valev, murdered twelve years before the Concord."

"Household contact?"

"No." Nera had chosen dispersal. Love did not authorize Ardis to call her back.

"Recorded preference?"

Ardis opened the statement copied from Nera's final testimony. "She asked that her death not become the foundation of my rule."

Salenne wrote it exactly. "Object deposited?"

"The ledger enters the public murder archive. The pearl button enters the

evidence record. Neither belongs in a family shrine.”

“Review?”

“Public-record status permanent unless a court finds factual error. No descendant may convert it to Household contact.”

Salenne sanded the line. “Do you consent to publication of your statement about delay?”

“Yes.”

That record named Ardis's complicity alongside Maelin's crime. Office had not erased personal review. The living court had found Ardis negligent in preserving the sealed ledger after credible doubt arose, but not party to murder or early concealment. She had accepted a formal censure and paid restitution from private property, while Crown assets funded the larger claims.

Maelin's trial had taken seven months. Tev's prior statement, Nera's testimony record, the cord, altered ledgers, Peln's evidence, and Osteren correspondence survived challenge. The living judges convicted her of Nera's murder and five conspiracy counts. They removed her permanently from funeral office and sentenced her to secure civic confinement with access to counsel, books, and no compulsory ghost contact. She had appealed two archive counts, not the murder verdict.

No ancestor pronounced sentence. No relative served it for her.

Ardis pressed her living signature beneath Nera's restored name.

“Any binding requested?” Salenne asked, because every form asked everyone.

“No binding ink.”

The burial black darkened the public record and nothing else. No pain closed around Ardis's wrist. No dead voice entered her blood. Nera's name remained visible without becoming a command.

Ardis left the table for the next citizen.

House Rain Palace had changed around the funeral. The north kitchens still bore chalk from the unnamed sanctuary. Former audience rooms held apprenticeship schools for masonry, canal acoustics, funeral craft, arithmetic, and surgery. Living teachers made errors, revised manuals, and received wages from Crown and Remembrancer restitution funds.

Some losses could not be trained away. A bridge arch had failed because no living inspector heard the crack soon enough. Three people died. The court named the failure publicly rather than blaming silent ancestors. New inspection teams used sounding rods and paired listeners. Peace had not made institutions innocent.

Hollow Rain still fell twice that year near sealed worker bones. Each occurrence triggered excavation and public review rather than omen reading. Ena Tar's foundation record guided the crews. Her name appeared on every palace restoration plan beside the royal founders.

The second excavation uncovered eleven unnamed lime burners beneath a council stair. No intact tokens remained, so funeral workers could not call or host them. Pay lists from three archives supplied eight probable names. The court recorded those with uncertainty marks and left three spaces openly unknown.

Some councilors wanted a memorial title, *The Eleven Faithful*, to make the gap ceremonial. Workers rejected it. Nobody knew whether the dead had been faithful, coerced, angry, or merely employed. The final stone read: Eleven people worked and died here. Eight names probably survive. Three do not yet.

Ardis approved funding but not the wording. The lime-burner guild chose it. Schoolchildren visited to learn why an honest record might contain doubt.

A restoration apprentice later found one missing name in a private wage book. Clerks amended the stone in public, preserving the former uncertainty line beneath. History could correct itself without pretending the correction had always existed.

The seven witness niches remained empty by design. No court kept permanent dead ready for use.

At midday, Osteren bells sounded from the Bridge of Reeds. Edran and Tovin entered for treaty renewal with no wedding escort. Edran's right-leg hitch had worsened slightly after months on the grain road. His left palm carried a pale cross-scar. Tovin wore the insignia of Border Captain under the seven-village council, a public office with an eighteen-month term.

They walked side by side. Court gossip had spent itself against their refusal to hide.

The treaty review took place at a plain table in the funeral court. Seven Black Reed delegates presented figures before either heir spoke. Grain deliveries had met nine of twelve monthly targets. Canal repairs remained late in two villages. Soldier complaints had fallen after living command contracts gained refusal and review terms. Smuggling had risen where ancestor-trained inspectors lost scent memory.

"Not a flawless peace," Sov said.

Edran opened the deficit ledger. "A flawless report would concern me."

The council fined Osteren's road office for two missed deliveries. Edran accepted. Lyr's toll office paid restitution for an unlawful three-day closure. Ardis accepted. Neither realm threatened the other's body, spouse, or descendants.

Tovin proposed joint training for inspectors. A former smuggler from Black Reed would teach concealment methods under paid amnesty. Vey objected to rewarding crime. The village council pointed out that dead customs officers had learned from criminals too, only without declaring the source.

They approved a six-month trial.

Renewal required fresh acceptance from every office. The Concord did not

presume last year's consent. Ardis, Edran, toll keepers, road officers, bridge captains, and village delegates read their duties back before signing. One delegate refused until a flood-labor wage rose. Negotiation lasted an hour.

No one called delay sabotage.

Afterward, Edran found Ardis beneath the old wedding arch. "Your council wants me at the state meal."

"My council wants to count chairs and call it stability."

"Tovin and I promised Sov dinner at a canal kitchen."

"Choose edible food."

Tovin joined them. "The state meal has river fish."

"Cooked by people who fear criticism," Ardis said. "Go to the canal."

Edran looked past her toward Salenne's table. "And you?"

"I have an appointment I have postponed for eleven months."

His smile stayed within friendship. "Logistically irresponsible."

"Politically survivable."

They clasped forearms. Edran and Tovin left together for the bridge wards, where their relationship required no treaty clause to remain real.

Salenne finished the last public naming at late bell. Her practice had changed with the law. Half her clients wanted protection from Household contact. Others wanted carefully bounded advice from dead relatives. She represented living consent in both directions, including the right to seek a voice rather than merely refuse one.

Her memory ledger traveled in a plain indigo case. It listed permanent losses without pretending to replace them: Orsa's singing voice, plum-salt cake at licensing, childhood route from door to bed, Ysra's hand during their youthful kiss, Orsa's face, Olan's first safe-clause lesson, the first meeting with Ardis, the first kiss with Ardis.

Facts lived beside each absence. No sensory reconstruction followed.

Ardis had helped create new memories only when Salenne invited her. They drank tea at public counters. They argued over Crown office clauses. They walked the cistern route after repairs. On one evening Salenne asked Ardis to hold her hand, then withdrew after three steps. On another she kept the contact through an entire bridge crossing.

They had not kissed again.

The year between had given them other firsts that belonged only to the women they were now. Salenne invited Ardis to the Mortuary Exchange at closing bell and made her wash ink cups until royal hands cracked from salt. Ardis invited Salenne to a council budget hearing, where Salenne discovered that attraction could survive four hours of cistern depreciation but not the Crown Speaker's habit of

tapping a pen.

Their worst argument concerned security. After a threat from Maelin's remaining partisans, Ardis placed guards outside Salenne's rooms without asking. Salenne dismissed them. Ardis insisted danger created an office duty. Salenne answered that office duty required notice, alternatives, and limits. They did not speak privately for six days.

The repair began in a public café. Ardis brought three protection plans: a visible street watch, an alarm bell under Salenne's control, or no additional security after a signed risk statement. Salenne chose the bell and required quarterly review. Neither woman called the disagreement proof that they could not love.

Another month, Salenne lost Ardis's face during a fever and feared the sevenfold instability had returned. A physician found ordinary illness. Ardis reintroduced herself from the doorway and waited. Recognition rebuilt after the fever broke, based on eleven months of new encounters. The episode did not unlock a single lost memory.

They learned touch through explicit questions that sometimes received no. A hand on a shoulder. A forehead against Salenne's hair after court. Ardis asleep at the archive table while Salenne chose not to wake her with contact. Consent acquired rhythm without becoming assumption.

Ysra regarded the whole courtship with the impatience of someone who had once kissed Salenne and survived the legal analysis. "You know affection can occur without forms," she told them.

"Unverified rumor," Salenne replied.

Yet forms helped where power hid, and humor helped where forms could not reach.

Ardis waited until the clerks left and the tables stood open around them. Witnesses remained everywhere in the ordinary sense: undertakers cleaning pens, citizens folding records, guards near exits. The court could not supply perfect privacy.

"May I ask you something personal here?" Ardis said.

Salenne closed the memory case. "You may ask. I may tell you to find a less symbolic room."

"I considered the laundry court."

"Too much starch."

"The fish arcade?"

"Too many opinions."

"So this room won by attrition."

Dry humor warmed Salenne's expression. It belonged to the woman standing here, not a record of who she had been.

Ardis kept both hands visible. "I want a life with you. Not a royal appointment. Not compensation. Not proof that what happened before still governs what you feel."

Salenne studied her with the professional attention that had first unsettled Ardis, though Salenne no longer remembered that first unsettling.

"What does a life mean?"

"Separate work. Shared rooms if we choose them. Permission renegotiated rather than assumed. Arguments about tea and public records. No private access created by my office. If I lose election as Crown Speaker, you do not lose home."

"You own the rooms you mean."

"The Crown owns them, which creates the same problem under cleaner grammar." Ardis had prepared for this edge. "I leased a house near the Mortuary Exchange in my private name. I placed half the lease in escrow for a co-tenant who accepts. Either tenant may leave without loss beyond ordinary rent. No palace guard, service duty, or household staff attaches."

Salenne's brows rose. "You negotiated housing before asking me."

"I negotiated an option. The landlord thinks my caution constitutes a disease."

"Landlords recognize only profitable illnesses."

"I also kept my current rooms. Refusal changes nothing about your practice, license, court access, or income."

Power could not disappear because Ardis named it. Crown Speaker remained a dangerous person to refuse. They had built material safeguards, not purity.

Salenne opened the proposed lease. She read each line, crossed out a clause allowing the named royal tenant to approve visitors, and narrowed the damage deposit. Ardis did not pretend romance made the changes unromantic.

"What name goes beside yours?" Salenne asked.

"Whatever name you choose to write."

"No titles?"

"No titles."

Salenne took an ordinary ink pen. Burial black sat at the funeral tables within reach, capable of marking names and empowering a vow under the right conditions. She left it untouched.

Ardis signed first: Ardis Valev.

Salenne signed beneath: Salenne Vaud.

Two living names. No dead witnesses. No bodily consequence. Either could revoke the arrangement under the lease.

"This does not answer the rest of your question," Salenne said.

"I know."

"I want to try the life. I do not know whether I love you in the way I did before."

Ardis held the pain without turning it into debt. "You do not have to."

"I may love you differently. I may decide co-tenancy exposes intolerable tea habits."

"My tea habits survived constitutional review."

"Your council lacks jurisdiction over taste."

Salenne folded the lease into her indigo case beside the memory ledger. "There is another question you have not asked."

Ardis waited.

"Ask whether you may kiss me. Now. Not because we did before."

Hope could pressure as efficiently as disappointment. Ardis let herself feel it without moving closer.

"May I kiss you, Salenne Vaud?"

Salenne looked around the funeral court. "Not here."

Ardis smiled despite herself. "Less symbolic room?"

"Much less." Salenne stood and offered her hand. "The alley behind the laundry court has terrible drainage and no legal history."

Ardis accepted the hand. No warmth traveled from ink. No ancestor approved. Salenne's grip came from muscles under her own command.

They crossed the court where citizens chose how to name their dead. At the exit, Ardis looked back once at Nera's public line, visible beneath glass and silent.

Then she left the funeral court beside Salenne to begin a life no witness owned, carrying an ordinary lease they could revise or end together, beneath a low brick roof where the rain stayed outside.